A WORLD BOOK

The Turning

Kind, Condition, and the reach of the Tree

Living world book · Cut-year 387

Chapters keep their numbers · a grey box is still unwritten

Using This Book

This is the world book of **the Turning**, written for people who will play here. It explains the place in ordinary language. A line in quotation marks is something a person in the world might say, and the text says who says it. A habit people will not explain is described as what they do. The way the world works is stated as fact. Open questions the world itself has not settled stay open in the text.

Chapters keep their numbers and titles. When more of the world is written, it goes into the chapter that already exists. A grey box that begins **Not yet written** is an intentional hole. Filling one means replacing that box inside its chapter. The hole that remains is two claimants on one green in Other Places. The climate chapter does not catalog every plant.

Books I–IX are what a player reads.

Book X is for the person running the game. It holds the sound-system behind the names, and material the table does not start knowing. How to name a person, make a new name, and glue two old words into a hall-name stays in **Language and Naming**. Continent names are given in **The Four Continents**.

Rules for Daggerheart sit inside the Condition and Kind entries: Transformation cards and ancestry features, using the game's own terms (Hope, Stress, Hit Points, Fear, range bands). Folklore and in-world papers are quoted as they are told.

The working notes remain the record this book is drawn from. This book is the copy you read, and it is filled as the world grows.

Print the PDF with a wide right margin, or annotate it in any PDF reader. The HTML is the same book: searchable, with a clickable contents. Open the HTML in a word processor if you want comments in the margin.

Book I

What This World Is

The World in Brief

Vampires, werewolves, and their kin exist in the Turning. Society accepts them, employs them, and needs them. They live openly, and the people around them know what they are. Each has changed, and is a neighbour with a job and a cost. That is a becoming.

Every person carries two layers, and both are true at once.

Kind is what you are born: Human, Elf, Kitsune, Selkie, Tengu, Yumboe, and the rest. A Kind is ordinary. Nobody blinks at a fox-tail in a market or wings on a ridge. The place you live in raises you. A Kind does not keep a country of its own.

Condition is what you become. Roughly three in four people acquire one over a lifetime. People manage a Condition through law, guild, medicine, and work attached to it. Society is built around what people with a Condition can do, and around helping them live with the cost.

Two paths lead to a becoming. At a child's tenth-year solstice, families gather at their town's **Turning Tree**. A coloured leaf falls, and a Condition is **Given**. If the leaves hug with no colour, the child is kept whole, and wanted in their own right. That child is one of **the Kept**. Later, some people cross a threshold alone (a drowning, an oath, a death) and are **Struck**, with no leaf and no ceremony. Over a lifetime the split runs about sixty Given, fifteen Struck, twenty-five Kept for life.

Every Condition carries a **Tithe**. You meet that upkeep to live well with the becoming. Meet it, and you are a valued citizen. Fall behind, and a small, real edge shows. The will stays one's own. No Condition can compel another person.

Some hold that the **Leaf-Mother** blessed the world with these gifts, and that the Trees are her hands. Skeptics say it is simply what the Trees do. The practice is binding. Belief is argued about. The Motherfaith holds her. It is one faith among several.

There is one origin Tree, the **Awakening Tree**, called Thaeloren, on Maiethorn. Someone takes a cutting of the Awakening Tree and plants it in new ground. That is a living graft, and every town Tree is one. The map of the world follows that wood's **reach**. That is how far the grafts have spread. The origin is sacred and dense. The middle lives by trade. The frontier is thin. A storm-walled isle lies beyond the Trees entirely.

Ordinary life is late-medieval. Towns are chartered, and people keep guild halls, markets, letters of credit, mills, and universities. No printing press. No gunpowder. The one step past that life comes from

Condition-labor, paid for by Tithes, concentrated where those Conditions live.

It is the **Years of Hands**, **Cut-year 387**. That is the age of the town Trees. Years are numbered from the First Cut. That number is a Cut-year. Town Trees stand in most squares. The walk to the origin is no longer required, except where the wood is still travelling, or has failed. On Heskoren the planting is not finished. Kumbaan, the storm-walled isle, has no Tree, and no graft has ever crossed to it.

This book is the world as it stands.

Kind and Condition

Every person in the Turning carries two layers, and both are true at once.

You are born with the shape of a body and a bloodline. That is **Kind**. Human, Elf, Drakona, Kitsune, Selkie, Tengu, and the rest. A Kind is ordinary. Nobody blinks at it. You arrived in that ancestry.

Condition is what you become. Something happens, and a vampire, a werewolf, or their kin is changed. That is a becoming. Roughly three in four people acquire a Condition over a lifetime. One in four never do. People manage a Condition through law, guild, medicine, and work attached to it. Society is built around what people with a Condition can do, and around helping them live with the cost.

How a becoming arrives

There are two paths, and which path a person took is the main division in society.

Children gather with their families around a **Turning Tree** for the **Leaf-Fall**. That is a child's tenth-year solstice. Most towns have a living cutting of the origin Tree. That is a **scion**. A town that is too new, too remote, or has lost its Tree sends its children to a neighbour's Tree. Leaves fall and wrap around each ten-year-old. A colour falls, and a Condition is **Given**; the leaf-colour names which one. It is ceremonial, expected, proper. A Given child grows up already knowing what they will become, and is trained and guilded for it. No colour, but the leaves hug the child. That child is one of **the Kept**. The Tree keeps them as they are. That hug is a blessing in its own right. The Kept are wanted and special.

Later, some people are **Struck**. Some Conditions cannot be Given to a child. A ten-year-old cannot die and walk back. A child cannot consent to a contract. These arrive only when a person crosses a threshold later in life, and the threshold they cross decides what they become. No leaf, no ceremony. Onlookers call it tragic, miraculous, or a little suspect. Some of the Kept are Struck later.

The sorting is simple. Conditions that need no act from the child are Given only: the Long-Lived (vampire), the Two-Bodied (werewolf), the Answered (djinn), and the Phoenix. Things a child physically cannot have done are Struck only: the Returned (death), the Bound (a sworn pact). A near-death a person can survive can be foreseen by the Tree or walked into by accident, and those Conditions come both ways: the Far-Voiced (siren), the Stilled (gorgon), and the Taken-In (leshy). A

Given Far-Voiced (blue leaf at ten, guild-trained) and a Struck Far-Voiced (survived a drowning at thirty) are the same becoming and very different people.

Of the whole population, over a lifetime: about **60 percent Given** at the Tree, about **15 percent Struck** later, about **25 percent Kept for life**. The Given and the Struck together are the three-quarters who carry a Condition. At the ceremony itself, about 40 percent of children are hugged and receive no colour; a little over a third of those children will still be Struck someday.

The Tithe

Every Condition carries a **Tithe**. You meet that upkeep to live well with the becoming. You pay it to stay whole. Meet it, and you are a valued citizen. Neighbours, colleagues, and family treat you as one. Fall behind, and a small, real edge shows: hunger, restlessness, a Cry, a limb locking stone-still, an element that lets go in a crowded room. The infrastructure that helps people pay their Tithes is part of why society organizes around people with a Condition.

A Tithe is satisfied by ordinary work and rest. A person can walk toward the dangerous edge, or circumstances can press them toward it. It does not seize the will. A person with a Condition remains themselves. The cost is paid in body, memory, Stress, standing, and time, never in stolen control.

Standing differs from one Condition to another. Some Conditions are common and ordinary. Some are rare and looked up to. Some are rare and looked down on. Some are feared. One is legendary.

Nine to choose, ten in the world

Nine Conditions can be Given or Struck. The tenth is **the Unbound**. Common speech calls it the Hollow. It comes later. A Bound enters it when a term-limited contract ends without another being signed. You become Unbound only through Bound.

The world uses **the Given-Over** as a title for a Bound who signs contract after contract until the being on the other side effectively holds them. The contract-guilds call it **the Forfeit**. A player character does not take this fate.

RULES

Conditions are Daggerheart **Transformation cards**. Each card has a flavor line and features, at minimum a boon and a labeled Tithe, hooked to Hope, Stress, Hit Points, Fear, and Experiences. One transformation per player character. It sits in the loadout like a heritage card and does not count against domain-card limits. Feature count varies. Conditions that take the table’s focus, and the complicated ones, carry more features than the common cards. What is constant is a clean boon and a labeled Tithe on every card.

Roster

Condition	Folk still know	Path	Share of the people	Standing
Long-Lived	vampire	Given	~2.5%	rare / revered
Two-Bodied	werewolf	Given	~18%	common
Returned	zombie	Struck	~7%	normal / quietly respected
Bound	demon (by contract)	Struck	~5%, counting the Unbound (about 3.5% currently Bound, 1.5% Unbound)	feared
The Unbound *(the Hollow)*	the price of a contract	Struck, chains off Bound only	~1.5%, *inside* Bound's ~5%	pitied / uneasy
Far-Voiced	siren	Both	~12%	revered
The Stilled	gorgon	Both	~7%	feared / guild-regulated
The Answered	djinn	Given	~10%	wildcard (no single standing)
The Taken-In	leshy	Both	~13%	respected-but-looked-down / frontier
Phoenix	phoenix	Given	<0.1% (one at a time)	legendary

The Kept are not on this table. They are the ~25 percent who carry no Condition for life. The Tree hugged them at the ceremony. They are wanted in their own right.

Book II

Peoples

The Conditions

Condition cards do not advance with character level. The card you hold at level 1 is the card you hold at level 10. Class features, domain cards, Experiences, weapon tier, and Hope scars are what change around it.

What can still deepen: a Two-Bodied may attach an animal-form Experience when they would gain an Experience, and a second signature capability only as a once-ever story milestone. Returned and Phoenix cross out Hope slots, and the slots left are the returns they have left. The standing obligations written into a Bound’s contract, and the piece of themselves named at signing as the price, change when the story changes them. Those are the Terms and the Pledge. Attacks that use Proficiency (Kindle, Reach, the Green Word, the Two-Bodied natural weapon) rise because Proficiency rises.

A becoming has an upkeep. That is a **Tithe**. Its tokens drain or fill on a **long rest** unless the card names another trigger. A day with two short rests does not change these tokens twice. At each long rest, run this list once. Each line is yes-or-no.

Condition	At this long rest	Counted outside that rest
Long-Lived	Spent Hope on Unfading Mind, used Blood-Read, or spent a downtime move in study or witness? **Refill.** Else **remove a Memory token.**	—
The Answered	Spent Hope on Reach since last long rest? **Refill.** Else **remove a token.**	A question to the element leaves the tokens where they are
The Taken-In	Can you touch a living plant where you rest? **Refill.** Else **remove a Green token.**	—
The Stilled	This long rest included a physical downtime move, a spar, a drill, or a fight? If not, **add a Grey token** (stillness settling in the body).	Each use of the Gaze also adds a Grey token
The Unbound	Rested with someone who knows your name and shares the meal or the watch? **Refill Quiet** (tokens for acting through what the contract took). Else tokens stay.	Quiet tokens are spent in play
Returned	Did anything toward your Purpose (the unfinished thing that keeps them walking) since last long rest? If not, you settle: mark a Stress, and your touch runs cold.	—
Far-Voiced	—	In a scene, marking Stress from feeling, or the GM naming grief, terror, rage, or joy, means you vent before the scene ends
Two-Bodied	—	A full day without the other self, then the next Fear roll shifts you
Bound	—	Broken Terms, and the Whisper while a debt is owed
Phoenix	—	Death, and each Rise From Ash

The share given for each Condition below is the one in the roster table at the end of Kind and Condition. That table is the one count of how many people carry each Condition.

Long-Lived

Folk recognition. The old tales called them vampires. **Path.** Given only, by a rare leaf-colour when a child stands at a town Turning Tree on their tenth-year solstice. That day is Leaf-Fall. **Share.** About 2.5 percent. **Standing.** Rare and revered.

Aging simply stops, and nothing witnessed is ever forgotten. They live on what they learn. When they are starved they fade, forget, and finally empty out. What remains of the old blood-hunger is this: a Long-Lived can read a memory in a single drop of blood. By ancient courtesy they will not cross a threshold uninvited.

They keep the archives, judge disputes, and witness records as notaries, and people consult them because they remember what they have witnessed. Courts, guilds, and archives are built around them. Too many deathless people would lock institutions into the shape they already have, so their scarcity is part of the world's shape. People consult them and hold them a little apart from ordinary company.

Every Long-Lived is asked once to join the Pourers, a circle whose members give memory into a cup one year at a time, each year on its own night, and may stop before the next; most Long-Lived say no, and a person who says no is received everywhere as before. The Pourers are described with the other houses in Orders and Houses.

The old courtesy. A Long-Lived waits to be asked in, always. It is held as the deepest good manners, a mark of trustworthiness, and no one quite remembers it as anything else. A keeper of records does not intrude. It is old, and it is universal among them. A Long-Lived who is refused the door feels the refusal more than they will say. It is simply how the Long-Lived have always been.

Meeting the Tithe is why they hold the jobs they do. A Long-Lived wants to keep learning, so scholarship, judging, and record-keeping are the careers that keep that upkeep met. Deprivation is the danger: imprisonment, a dull siege, exile somewhere with nothing new. Isolating a Long-Lived is a recognized cruelty.

They can have children and families, but none are guaranteed to inherit the Condition; most don't. They watch spouses and children grow old and die, then either stop and live on alone with the memory, or begin again and outlive that family too. Beneath the hunger for knowledge, they outlive the people they love. That is the deeper Tithe. They are deathless. Violence, accident, or a failed Tithe still ends them, which keeps their numbers stable across centuries.

RULES

> *Ageless keepers of memory, law, and record: they live on what they learn.*

- **Unfading Mind:** Your aging has stopped and you forget nothing you take in. You have **advantage** on rolls to recognize, appraise, or recall what you have personally witnessed. **Spend a Hope** to recall a witnessed detail *complete* — the vow as spoken, the face, the exact count. The advantage covers ordinary recall. The Hope buys the perfect record.
- **Blood-Read:** Memory rides in blood. Taste a **single drop** of a creature's blood (freely given, or from a wound) and you read a **true memory** carried in it, a fragment of what that person has lived, chosen by the GM to fit what the blood remembers. The donor is unharmed: one drop, one glimpse. The older or more guarded the memory you reach for, the less you may get.
- **The Hunger to Know** *(Tithe):* Place **3 Memory tokens** on this card. **At a long rest, refill all tokens** if since your last long rest you **spent Hope on Unfading Mind**, **used Blood-Read**, or **spent a downtime move** in study or first-hand witness. Otherwise **remove a token**. The always-on advantage leaves the tokens where they are. They refill when you spend that Hope, use Blood-Read, or spend that downtime move. Each time you lose a token:
- **2 tokens:** no effect.
- **1 token:** the **fade** begins: **disadvantage** on rolls to recall, recognize, appraise, or use Presence, and you start losing older memories (describe what slips). Other action and reaction rolls are untouched.
- **0 tokens:** you are **starving** — you are **Vulnerable**, and at the start of each **long rest** still at 0 tokens you **mark a Stress**. If you would mark your last Stress this way, mark a **Hit Point** instead. If you would mark your last Hit Point this way, you do **not** make a death move: you simply **go still**, mind emptied, the true death of the Long-Lived. You may clear Hit Points and Stress as usual. Getting a token back (a Hope spent on recall, a Blood-Read, a downtime study) stops the starve before the next long rest.

Two-Bodied

Folk recognition. The old tales called them werewolves. **Path.** Given only. **Share.** About 18 percent. **Standing.** Common.

A Two-Bodied carries a second, animal self, and that self is always theirs to command. The second body is a useful animal partner you carry inside you. They do the common labor, and they are the most versatile labor force: rescue, herding, wild-work, war, courier, and scout work, each with a second body suited to the job.

Shifting is voluntary and clean. The animal shape carries its own personality, temperament, and inner voice, distinct from the born self. The Two-Bodied converse with it in the head, a running second opinion. The animal mouth cannot form human speech. The wolf that wants to run the scent *now*. The hawk that trusts height over talk. The otter that finds the whole meeting tedious. It is named. Townsfolk say “that’s Bramble, her otter,” and they come to recognize its moods. The change and every action stay the person’s to command. It nags, it wants, and it colors how the day feels: a live companion you happen to be.

The Condition runs in families. Children of a Two-Bodied parent are far more likely to be Given it at their Awakening, and usually as the same animal. That day is Leaf-Fall. Whole bloodlines are wolf-folk, hawk-folk, otter-folk. A first-in-the-line, or one who breaks type, is notable.

The other self is a real, natural animal, roughly between a housecat and a large wolf, bear, boar, or horse in size. A real animal does exactly what that animal really does. A hawk flies. An otter swims and holds its breath. A bear is strong. The size stays in that range: a hawk is hawk-sized, and a wolf is wolf-sized. A roc and a kelpie are stories, and neither is a body anyone carries. In the animal form the limbs and the mouth are the animal’s. There are no hands, no human speech, and no tools. The person still chooses every action. A flying Two-Bodied is a superb scout and courier. A Tengu is a person aloft, with hands to carry and fight and a human mind and voice in the air. An aquatic Two-Bodied swims brilliantly and works the water as that animal. An Answered uses tools in the water. A true amphibious person keeps a person’s body there. The body is a magnificent animal, in the animal’s own shape.

Because the upkeep is simply being the animal sometimes, most Two-Bodied satisfy it without thinking. Their jobs demand the animal form anyway. The restless forced-shift is the dangerous part of the Tithe: it strikes at the worst moment (mid-negotiation, mid-stealth) and costs a Stress. You stay in command of what the body does. Only the timing belongs to the Tithe.

RULES

> *A person who carries a second, animal self, and the change stays theirs to command.*

- **The Other Self** *(boon):* You have a second body: a specific real animal, chosen when you become Two-Bodied. You may **shift between your two selves at will**, as an action. The change is **always yours to command**, no Stress and no roll (your gear melds with you and returns when you change back). In animal form you gain:
- **Natural build.** Your animal's real gifts are yours: a **natural weapon** (teeth, claws, antler, hoof): **Primary** · **Instinct**, or **Strength** if the animal's signature is brute force (bear, boar) · **Melee** · **d8 phy** (housecat-sized: **d6 phy**; bear or boar: **d10 phy**) · **One-Handed** · **Natural** — cannot be disarmed; usable only in animal form; you cannot equip another Primary while in this form. Roll damage dice equal to your **Proficiency**, as with any other weapon. You do not add a second weapon's dice on top. Plus the beast's movement: a wolf's run, an otter's swim, a hawk's flight. You are one or the other.
- **A signature capability,** chosen with the GM to fit the animal: e.g. a hawk's *see a mouse from the sky*, a wolf's *run a scent for miles*, a bear's *shrug off a blow* (**advantage** on the fitting rolls, or a small once-per-scene effect the GM sets). One signature to start.
- **An animal Experience.** Choose one **Experience** reflecting your animal's nature (e.g. "Wolf's Nose," "Cat's Balance," "Bear's Strength"), usable only in animal form.
- **A voice, not a driver.** Your other self has its own name, temperament, and inner voice you can converse with. It is pure roleplay: it flavors and nags, grants no mechanical bonus on its own, and **every action it takes is one you choose**.
- **Both Must Be Lived** *(Tithe):* If a full day passes without time spent as your other self, it grows restless. The next time you roll with **Fear**, you **shift into it whether you meant to or not, and mark a Stress**. You stay fully in control. The timing belongs to the Tithe. The actions stay yours. Shift back normally.

Growth. You start with **one** animal-form Experience and **one** signature capability. Whenever you would gain an Experience, you may attach a new **animal-form Experience** to your other self (usable only in animal form). Your **signature capability stays one**, with a single exception: **a second signature is a once-ever milestone**. It is granted by the GM as the payoff of a genuine story arc (a season lived almost entirely in your other self, a defining trial passed in that shape), and it is the only way the capability count ever grows. Proficiency is what raises the natural weapon's damage. The die on the card stays the die you started with. This Tithe does not move at a long rest. After a full day without the other self, the next roll with Fear shifts you.

Returned

Folk recognition. The old tales called them zombies. **Path.** Struck only. It arrives later in life, and it requires death. **Share.** About 7 percent. **Standing.** Normal and quietly respected.

They died with something unfinished, and the purpose keeps them walking: calm, deliberate, unafraid of death because they have already met it. They persist.

Someone dies with a thing left undone strong enough to hold them, and they get back up. Society sends them where the work kills the living: into plague wards, down mine collapses, out on battlefield recovery, and to tend and speak for the dead. They are solemn, dependable, the people you send where the living cannot safely go. They are unshaken by gore and death, and a death that takes them may still not be the last.

The Tithe is a feeling as much as an upkeep. A Returned is only steady while they have a reason. Neglect it and they cool, literally and socially. The living can tell a settling Returned at a touch. The Returned build their lives around their purpose with almost religious care. Their returns are counted: each Refuse to Fall crosses out a Hope slot, so a long-walking Returned is a person whose remaining Hope slots you can count. After a life of refusing rest, they can go out spectacularly on their own terms, including when the last scar would otherwise end them. That death is **Blaze of Glory**.

When the unfinished thing is finally done, the choice is theirs. They may lie down and take the rest they skipped, at last, or lay the Condition aside and live out the rest of their days as a mortal again. Lying down is **Settle**. Laying the Condition aside, they live on with no Condition. Taking up a new Purpose instead keeps them Returned and walking. That is a major character beat, coordinated with the GM.

RULES

> *You died with something unfinished. It keeps you walking.*

- **Unfinished Business** *(boon):* You have already died once, and death does not hold you the way it holds other people. When you make a **death move**, your options are **Blaze of Glory**, **Risk It All**, and a fourth option this card gives you: **Refuse to Fall.** Avoid Death is the option where you fall unconscious, may take a scar, and come back when an ally clears a Hit Point or the party finishes a long rest. A Returned has already died once, so that option is closed. **Refuse to Fall:** you go down (taken out of the current scene) and pull yourself back together by the next **long rest** (describe how). Coming back leaves a mark: **cross out a Hope slot as a scar. If you would cross out your last Hope slot this way, you cannot Refuse to Fall** — the unfinished thing finally lets go, and that death is true and final. You may still choose **Blaze of Glory**, or gamble on **Risk It All** and die if it fails. Refuse to Fall is the *steady* way back, and it is **finite**, counted in scars. You are also **unshaken by the dead and dying**: automatically pass rolls to resist fear, horror, or despair from corpses, gore, and deathly places.
- **The Tether** *(Tithe):* Name your **Purpose**, the unfinished thing that holds you here (write it on the card). While you can still act toward it, you are steady. If a **long rest** passes in which you did nothing in service of your Purpose, you begin to **settle**: mark a **Stress** that can't be cleared until you next act toward it, and your **touch runs cold**. Living creatures you touch (or that touch you) feel a bone-deep wrongness and mark a Stress, and you have **disadvantage** on rolls to comfort, persuade, or charm the living until you act toward your Purpose again.

When the Purpose is fulfilled. Settle, live on with no Condition, or name a new Purpose and keep walking.

Bound

Folk recognition. The old tales called them demons. In this world the demon is a contract. **Path.** Struck only. The Tree does not Give a contract. **Share.** About 5 percent, counting the Unbound (about 3.5 percent currently Bound, 1.5 percent Unbound). **Standing.** Feared.

The Bound are the only people with a Condition who chose it. In some extremity they swore a contract with something on the other side, and got power in exchange for the standing obligations written into

the contract. Those are the Terms. The horror is the contract: a debt, and the other party, who always watches the ledger. That party is the counterparty. You can be born to Daggerheart's demon-blooded ancestry. That Kind is called Infernis. You swear, and the Condition you acquire is Bound.

Society fears them. The power is real, the terms are binding, and the contract collects from a Bound who falls behind. Society also needs them. A Bound's sworn word is literally binding, and many can tell a lie when they hear one, so they enforce agreements, keep oaths, witness them, and settle debts. When a treaty absolutely must hold, a Bound swears to it.

The counterparty may be chosen at creation, or left unknown for the Bound to learn later: a named demon or lesser power that bargains; a cosmic-horror intelligence (vast, indifferent, *wrong*); or unknown even to the Bound, who do not know who holds the contract.

The only sure release is to kill the thing that holds the contract, but a patron that can grant power can often sense the intent forming, so plotting it is its own peril. Term-limited contracts instead simply end, releasing the Bound and collecting the piece of themselves named at signing as the price. That piece is the Pledge. What walks away is Unbound: free of the contract, and missing the Pledge.

True flight may be contracted. True flight belongs to the Tengu and, in legend, the Phoenix. A contract for flight is uncommon, and it always shows: it grants literal, visible wings (or a stranger tell: a shadow that lifts, feet that will not touch ground) that a Bound cannot furl or hide, marking them plainly as something that made a bargain, the way a Phoenix's fire marks them. Most who want the sky are better served by gliding or a saving slow-fall. True sustained flight is a GM's call, priced with heavier Terms and a Pledge to match. The wings stay visible in any crowd.

A Bound keeps signing, power after power, pledge after pledge: first out of fear of paying what they already owe, signing another contract to defer the debt, then because it becomes too much to stop. Bit by bit they give themselves over until the being effectively holds them. A person who has signed away nearly all of themselves is a person the table no longer plays as a character. The plain name is the Given-Over. Among the contract-guilds, the Forfeit.

RULES

> *You swore a contract to a counterparty, and it answered. Now you both keep the terms.*

- **The Granted Power:** When you became Bound, you named what you wanted, and the contract granted it. With the GM, choose one small, defined boon your class doesn't give you. Examples: **you can never become lost** (always know true north and the way back), **you don't need to breathe**, **you need no food or water**, **you can speak and understand any tongue**, **you always know when someone lies to you**. Active boons cost a **Stress** to use. Passive ones simply work. Flight, if granted at all, follows the visible-wings terms above.
- **The Terms** *(Tithe):* Your contract carries **Terms** written on the card, a standing obligation the counterparty exacts (for example, "never refuse a sincere plea," "collect what is owed," "tell no lie on a holy day"). Keep the Terms and the power is clean. **Break a Term, or miss a payment, and the contract collects.** The GM gains **Fear**. Until you make restitution (a defined act the GM sets), your Granted Power costs a **Hit Point** instead of Stress, and **The Whisper** begins. While you owe a debt, when you roll with **Fear** the GM may voice an intrusive thought or a plausible lie the counterparty wants you to believe. You may act against it freely, but **shutting it out costs a Stress**. The debt compounds each time you fall further behind. You choose every action.
- **The Pledge:** At signing you also named **what you would give when the contract ends**, a part of yourself (an eye, a leg, your capacity for fear, your memory of home). Written on the card. You keep it while the contract runs. When a term-limited contract comes due, the counterparty releases you and **collects the Pledge**, and you become one of **the Unbound** (colloquially, the Hollow).

The Unbound

Folk recognition. The price of a contract. Colloquially, **the Hollow**. **Path.** Struck only. It follows a finished Bound contract. **Share.** About 1.5 percent: only the subset of Bound whose contracts were term-limited. An open-ended contract does not come due. **Standing.** Pitied / uneasy.

When the term ends, the counterparty releases the person and collects the part of themselves they named at signing. That part is the Pledge. They walk away unbound, free of the contract at last, but left

with a hole where a piece of them used to be, exactly as agreed. The common tongue calls them the Hollow, after the hole. Both are true: a freedom, and an absence.

The Pledge was chosen up front, at the signing. You knew what you would owe. So the loss is both grief and gift: the hole is also an immunity. People are unsettled by the absence in them. A Long-Lived keeps learning to stay whole. An Unbound keeps connecting to stay quiet.

You become Unbound only after playing through (or arranging at session zero, with the GM) an actual Bound contract, establishing what the contract was, what you Pledged, and the moment the term came due and it was collected. What was taken is specific, agreed, and it has real weight. That loss is the Absence.

RULES

> *You paid what you promised. Something is missing now, and the missing place is quiet, and strong.*

- **The Absence:** Name what the contract took (the Bound Pledge). You permanently lose it, in the fiction and, where it matters, on the sheet. The hole is also a **narrow immunity**: you are immune to effects that would **mark Stress** (or grant the GM **Fear**) *by working through that capacity*. Other rolls in ordinary life still happen. Agree the details with the GM at the moment you become Hollow. Three kinds of loss:
- **A capacity of the mind** (fear, grief, love, the ability to lie, memory of a person or place) → immunity only to **Stress-marking** (or Fear-granting) effects that use that capacity. Gave up fear: a terror that would mark Stress does not; you still have to treat a scared crowd as a crowd. Gave up deceit: you *cannot* lie, and a lie that would mark Stress if it landed does not mark Stress on you. You do not automatically know every lie.
- **A sense of the body** (an eye, hearing, taste) → immunity to **Stress-marking** effects that require that sense (the Stilling Gaze aimed at you, a blinding light that would mark Stress). Illusions you must see still work unless they would mark Stress through that sense.
- **A part of the body** (a leg, a hand) → immunity to **Stress-marking** pain or effects through that part (and often a prosthetic or Condition-crafted replacement in the fiction).
- **The Quiet** *(Tithe):* Place **3 Quiet tokens** on this card; begin play with them filled. **Spend a Quiet token** to act through the hole: take an action the missing thing would have stopped, or gain **advantage** on a roll where the empty place makes the hard thing easy. You still mark Stress from effects outside your Absence immunity. Quiet spends a token for an action or for advantage. The immunity stays the one the Absence already gave. **At a long rest, refill all tokens** if you rest with at least one other person who **knows your name** and shares the meal or the watch. Alone, or among strangers who do not know you, the tokens stay where they are. **At 0 tokens** the ache is loud: while empty, whenever a bargain, favor, or offer of power is on the table, the GM may present it as unusually reasonable, and **refusing to reach for it costs a Stress**. The offer is a suggestion. You can say no, and saying no aches. Taking the offer is how an Unbound becomes Bound again, and how a Bound moves toward the Given-Over.

Far-Voiced

Folk recognition. The old tales called them sirens. **Path.** Both Given and Struck. **Share.** About 12 percent (~11% Given, ~1% Struck). **Standing.** Revered.

A Far-Voiced's voice carries exactly as far, and exactly as true, as the Far-Voiced means it to. The danger lands on the Far-Voiced themself.

A Far-Voiced's voice is never drowned out by distance, storm, battle-noise, or water, and it never says less than it means. That is why the signal network runs on them: relay-singers post along coasts, roads, and border-towns to carry warnings, alarms, and orders faster and farther than any horn or drum. Courts and treaties want them as witnesses, because a Far-Voiced's own voice betrays real feeling the moment they are under pressure, so their sworn word is trusted precisely because they are bad at lying under strain. They fill concert halls because emotion, delivered audibly and exactly, is the whole art form. They are revered. A Far-Voiced who cannot keep that voice in hand is a genuine hazard to everyone in earshot, which is exactly why guild training exists.

The two paths read differently. A **Given** Far-Voiced drew the colour at the Awakening and spent childhood guild-trained (breath control, projection, the discipline of venting on purpose), controlled, professional, poised. A **Struck** Far-Voiced survived a drowning. They came up with the voice raw and untrained, the pull of unvented feeling already on them before anyone taught them to vent it. Same Condition, very different person. Onlookers see no leaf-colour and no ceremony. They call it a miracle, or faintly uncanny. A Struck Far-Voiced usually needs a guild's help fast, before they learn in public what happens at zero tokens.

Meeting the Tithe is why the jobs exist. Deliberate, controlled venting (performance, ritual song, relay-calls) is how a working Far-Voiced keeps that upkeep met, so the careers that need a big voice are also the careers that keep one healthy. The guild drilling (breath work, scheduled performance, the discipline of singing it out before a shift ends) exists because an un-vented Far-Voiced is unpleasant to be near, and an un-vented outburst of feeling in a crowded hall or a command tent is a real, documented hazard. That outburst is a Cry.

Many Bound can tell when someone else lies. A Far-Voiced betrays their own feeling.

RULES

> *Your voice carries exactly as far, and exactly as true, as you mean it to.*

- **The Carrying Voice:** Your voice is never lost to distance, weather, noise, or water, and it lands with the emotional weight you intend. Spend a **Hope** to be heard clearly and understood by everyone you intend, across any distance or chaos in the scene, **or** to land a rally, warning, plea, or calming word with exact emotional force: gain **advantage** on that roll.
- **The Undertow** *(Tithe):* Place **3 Breath tokens** on this card. These tokens change in a scene. A long rest leaves them where they are. When you **mark Stress from feeling**, or the GM names grief, terror, rage, or joy as what's in you this scene, you must **vent it**: sing, cry out, laugh, weep, something audible, before the scene ends. If you don't, **remove a token**:
- **2 tokens:** no effect.
- **1 token:** the **undertow pulls**. Your voice starts leaking whatever you're actually feeling underneath your words. You have **disadvantage** on rolls to persuade, deceive, or perform a feeling you don't hold.
- **0 tokens:** the next strong emotion you feel escapes as an involuntary **Cry**. Everyone within earshot marks a **Stress** as your raw feeling crashes into them (the GM may instead gain a **Fear** for a crowd or hostile scene). The Cry empties you: mark a **Stress** yourself, then refill to **2 tokens**. It's out now, one way or another.

The Cry costs listeners Stress and costs the Far-Voiced a Stress. Listeners feel the feeling and still choose what they do.

The Stilled

Folk recognition. The old tales called them gorgons. **Path.** Both Given and Struck. **Share.** About 7 percent (~6% Given, ~1% Struck). **Standing.** Feared and guild-regulated.

One of the Stilled can arrest a wound, freeze a fight before it turns lethal, or hold a struggling patient steady under the knife. The danger is that the stillness has to come from somewhere, and if one of the Stilled doesn't keep moving, it starts settling into them.

Their look can hold a moment still. A bleeding wound stops bleeding, a spreading poison stops spreading, a blade already swinging hangs a beat too long. That look is the Gaze. Peacekeepers want

them on a riot line. A stilled brawl is a brawl that didn’t turn into a massacre. Surgeons and medics want them in the theatre: a patient held perfectly still is a patient who survives the knife. They are feared and licensed, because the same Gaze that stops a wound bleeding can, misused, leave a person helpless in a fight. Licenses, oversight, and a strict code govern who may still and why.

Their hair stirs faintly when something nearby has gone dangerously still (a held breath, a nocked arrow, a predator about to spring). A tell their trade has learned to read.

The two paths read differently. A **Given** Stilled drew the colour at the Awakening and trained young under guild discipline: knows exactly how much stillness they can spend and how to keep moving to shed it, composed and professional. A **Struck** Stilled actually survived being turned to stone, held rigid and unbreathing for however long it took someone to reverse it, and came back to flesh with the stillness now living inside them, unpracticed, and the stillness comes on more easily. The stone came from a trap, a curse, or an accident. Onlookers see no leaf-colour and no ceremony. They call it a miracle, a mercy, or a little unnerving, depending on who did the reversing. A Struck member of the Stilled usually needs a guild’s help fast, before unmanaged stillness collects in them and shows them in public what a seizing feels like. That collected stillness is the Grey.

The Stilled drill hard, spar often, and stay physically busy almost as a matter of professional identity. Every use of the Gaze adds a little Grey, so the guilds build constant motion into the job itself (patrols, practice bouts, dance as therapy) to work it back out before it settles. An unlicensed or careless one of the Stilled who lets the Grey fill and seize is a real, documented hazard, first to themselves. A doorknob turned to stone is scenery. Their own hand, locked on a weapon, is the limb the seizing takes. The guild’s oversight is strict.

RULES

> *You can hold a moment still. The stillness has to come from somewhere, and if you don't move it along, it settles into you.*

- **The Stilling Gaze:** You may still a wound, a spreading harm, or a struggle you can see. **A harm** (bleeding, poison, disease) you can see: no roll. The harm pauses until you look away, use the Gaze again, or the scene ends. **A willing or downed creature:** no roll. They gain **Stilled** (below). **An unwilling creature:** make an **attack roll** (Instinct or Presence). On a success, they gain **Stilled**. A miss still adds Grey. You can keep **one** stilling at a time; a new use releases the last. Nothing you still this way is harmed by the stilling itself. The stillness has to come from somewhere: **each time you use the Gaze, add a Grey token**.
- **Stilled** — A Stilled creature cannot take **actions or reactions**. They can speak, perceive, and be targeted. Other people can move them. A Restrained creature would stay in place. They may **mark a Stress** to clear Stilled when they would act. It also clears if you look away, use the Gaze on another target, or the scene ends.
- **The Grey** *(Tithe):* The stillness you spend collects in you, and if you don't work it back out, it settles. Place **Grey tokens** on this card, starting at **0**. **Add a Grey token** each time you use the Stilling Gaze, and **add one** when you take a **long rest** that did not include vigorous exertion (a downtime move spent on labor, a spar, a drill, or a fight). **Clear one token** at the end of a scene in which you marked Stress from physical effort, or dealt or took damage. The stillness rises:
- **1 token:** no effect.
- **2 tokens:** the **grey creeps in**. Your joints stiffen; you have **disadvantage** on Agility rolls and on rolls to evade.
- **3 tokens (full):** the stillness **seizes**. The next time you use the Stilling Gaze, or the next time you take damage, one of your own limbs **locks stone-still**, useless until it's tended and rested off (describe it: an arm, a leg, your jaw). The GM may instead gain a **Fear**: something small and nearby (a doorknob, a cup, a patch of ground) turns permanently to stone, a side effect of the seizing. Afterward, clear back to **1 token**.

The seizing locks the Stilled's own body, or turns something small nearby to stone. Every other creature stays as they are, and each player keeps their turn.

The Answered

Folk recognition. The old tales called them djinn. In those tales, a jinni sat in a lamp and granted wishes. **Path.** Given only. **Share.** About 10 percent. **Standing.** Wildcard.

One of the four elements answered them at the Awakening, and the element goes on answering for the rest of their life. The element talks back to the Answered's hands the way a native tongue talks back to a native speaker.

At Leaf-Fall, an Answered child's leaf marks them Given, and its **shade** names which element answered: fire, water, earth and stone, or air. Those shades are **Ember**, **Tide**, **Root**, and **Gale**. From that day the element is theirs to speak to. They coax it the way a potter coaxes clay.

That is why the Answered run the craft guilds built around their element. Ember-Answered glasswrights and smiths who don't need a furnace at full heat. Tide-Answered shipwrights and dyers who can bend a hull's planks or set a colour without steam or mordant. Root-Answered masons and potters who coax stone and clay without chisel or wheel. Gale-Answered sailmakers and instrument-makers who cut and voice their work with the wind's own help. Watch rotations, escort work, and firefighting crews give them a steady outlet as well.

Which element answers, and what temperament came with it, is different every time. An even-tempered Root-Answered potter and a short-fused Ember-Answered smith have nothing in common but the name. Some guilds prize them above any other artisan. Some households are wary of hosting one whose element runs hot. The leaf-shade names the element; it does not tell you which kind of person you are getting until you meet them. That is why "wildcard" sticks as a label.

Real, purposeful use of the element keeps an Answered steady, so apprenticeships run long and workshops exist to give them work. One of the Answered kept idle, grieving, or benched too long is a genuine hazard to be near, and every guild hall has a story about the time someone's untended element finally let go in a crowded room.

An element answers at the Awakening, or it does not. A Bound becomes Bound by swearing a contract with a counterparty.

RULES

> *An element answered you at the Awakening. It still does, and it still expects to be spoken to.*

Choose your **element** at creation: **Ember**, **Tide**, **Root**, or **Gale**. It sets both features below.

- **The Answering Hand** *(boon):* Your element obeys your hands without tool, forge, or force (glass blown with no furnace, a hull bent with no steam, stone coaxed with no chisel), granting **advantage** on any action roll to shape, repair, wield, or read something made of your element. In the moment, it answers too: **spend a Hope** to use your element's **Reach** (see the table). The Reach is always available. The tokens below wear down when you go without using it.
- **Spoken, not commanded** — Once per **long rest**, you may **ask** your element one question it can feel through its medium. Ember: heat, fuel, and what would burn. Tide: flow, depth, and what the water has touched. Root: weight, fault, and what the stone holds. Gale: pressure, scent, and what the air carries. The GM gives a clear impression of what that element can feel. The element answers the Answered. Another creature's order or bargain gets silence. You may **spend a Hope** to turn that silence into a Reach effect aimed at the interruption.
- **The Untended Element** *(Tithe):* Place **3 tokens** on this card. **At a long rest, refill all tokens** if since your last long rest you **spent Hope on Reach**. Otherwise **remove a token**. Spending Hope on Reach refills the tokens. Asking the element a question leaves them where they are. At **2 tokens:** no effect. At **1** and **0**, the element starts speaking for itself. See the table.

Element	Reach (*spend a Hope*)	1 token (restless)	0 tokens (it lets go)
Ember *(fire)*	Send a burst of fire at a target within **Very Close** range. Make an attack roll (Instinct or Strength). On a success, deal **magic damage in d6s equal to your Proficiency** and the target is temporarily **On Fire**.	You run **hot:** disadvantage on action rolls needing a steady hand or a cool head (stealth, precision, composure).	You **flare:** mark a **Stress**; searing heat rolls off you and anyone within **Very Close** must give ground or work through it (scorched cloth, singed hair; no direct damage). Refill to 2.
Tide *(water)*	Move like water: breathe and swim freely as though water were air, flow out of a fall or a grapple unharmed, **or** slick the ground within **Very Close**. Creatures there must succeed on an **Agility Roll** to move out of it.	You run **thin:** disadvantage on action rolls needing brute force or holding your ground.	You **flood:** mark a **Stress**; water and mud spread under you (**Very Close**), and you *and* everyone in it must make an **Agility Roll** to move out until it drains. Refill to 2.
Root *(earth/stone)*	Turn skin to bark and stone until the spotlight leaves you: **reduce the severity of the next damage you take by one threshold**, and gain **advantage** on rolls to resist being moved, knocked down, or Restrained.	You run **slow:** disadvantage on Agility rolls.	You **calcify:** mark a **Stress**; you become **Restrained** by your own stiffening body until you or an ally clears it with a successful action roll. Refill to 2.
Gale *(air)*	Move like wind: on a move, reach anywhere within **Close** range with no roll even under pressure; **or** a sudden gust slams a door, knocks something loose, or carries your voice clearly across a storm.	You run **wild:** disadvantage on action rolls needing careful aim or a steady stance.	You **gust:** mark a **Stress**; uncontrolled wind scatters every loose or unsecured thing within **Very Close** (dropped weapons, papers, smoke, dust; GM adjudicates). Refill to 2.

Every 0-token consequence lands on the Answered's own body or the air, water, and ground immediately around them. Other people keep their own will, and that letting-go deals them no

> direct harm.

The Taken-In

Folk recognition. The old tales called them leshy. In those tales, a trickster forest-spirit led travelers in circles until they died. **Path.** Both Given and Struck. **Share.** About 13 percent (~12% Given, ~1% Struck). **Standing.** Respected but looked-down; frontier.

The wild took them partway into itself and gave them back changed: bark at the knuckles, moss in the hair, a spread of antler or a knot of root somewhere on the body, and green things that lean toward them. The wild lives in them now, and answers them, which is exactly why the hard land gets worked at all.

They can coax growth, read the wild, and move through it unseen and unlost. The frontier runs on them. A Taken-In steward makes thin soil yield, keeps a herd through a bad winter, walks a forest without ever losing north, and knows a day out which way the weather turns. They are society's farmers, foresters, herders, and frontier-wardens.

The cities and their guilds need the grain, timber, and wardens the Taken-In provide, and eat well because of them. But one of the Taken-In is dirt-handed, backcountry, and no longer quite human to look at. The bark and antler unsettle people who have never left the paved districts. Prosperous farm-country reveres them. Polite city society finds them a little coarse, a little uncanny, and keeps them at arm's length.

The two paths read differently. A **Given** Taken-In drew the green at the Awakening and grew up in it: a farm or forest child comfortable in their half-wild skin, the change coming on gentle and known. A **Struck** Taken-In got lost and dying in the deep wild, days without a path, ready to lie down, and the wild took them in and kept them alive, remaking them partway. They come back more uncanny, more overgrown, and quietly unsure whether they walked out a person or something the forest sent.

Their work *is* their upkeep. A life spent on soil, among growing things, under open sky keeps the green in them fed without a thought. The Tithe goes unpaid when one of the Taken-In is pulled off the land: a long sea voyage, a stretch in a stone gaol, a season stuck in a walled city on a lord's business. Old frontier custom is to send them home before they wilt. City hosts who must keep one indoors learn to fill the room with potted green and open windows, courtesy that also keeps their guest from going to seed on the parlour floor.

RULES

> *The wild took you in and gave you back green. It still lives in you, and it needs living things around it.*

- **The Green Word** *(boon):* Growing things heed you. You have **advantage** on action rolls to forage, track, navigate wild land, calm or read an animal, or find your way, and you never become lost in a natural place. In the moment, the green answers:
- **Spend a Hope** to make roots, vines, and brush erupt from any natural ground within **Close** range. Make an **attack roll** (Instinct or Strength) against a target there. On a success, deal **physical damage in d6s equal to your Proficiency** and the target is temporarily **Restrained**; **or**
- **Spend a Hope**, while in any natural cover (brush, trees, tall grass, roots, soil), to draw it around you and become **Hidden**; **or**
- **Spend a Hope** to force sudden, useful growth. A branch bridging a gap, a screen of thicket, a root ladder, a burst of ripe forage. The GM sets the scale.
- **The Rooting** *(Tithe):* Place **3 Green tokens** on this card. **At a long rest, refill all tokens** if you can **touch a living plant** where you rest (soil, a tree, a field, a potted green). Otherwise **remove a token**. The test is yes or no. Open sky without a plant does not count. A window-box does.
- **2 tokens:** no effect.
- **1 token:** you **wilt**. Your green browns and sheds, and you have **disadvantage** on action rolls to resist fear, despair, or exhaustion (the wild in you is starving and it drags at you).
- **0 tokens:** you **go to seed**. Mark a **Stress**; you are **Vulnerable** until you next touch living land, and the wild reaches for any it can find (weeds crack the flagstones, a beam sprouts leaves, roots buckle the floor: the room around you goes riotously overgrown). The GM may instead gain a **Fear** in a tense scene. Reach living land and refill to **2**.

The go-to-seed growth erupts from the ground and structures around the Taken-In and stays there. Each person keeps their own will and takes no harm from it.

Phoenix

Folk recognition. They are called what the stories call them: **the Phoenix**. Every other Condition wears a plain, euphemistic title (the Long-Lived, the Returned, the Far-Voiced) because those becomings pass unremarked in the crowd, and the quiet name is their camouflage. The Phoenix cannot pass, cannot hide, and the whole world already knows the story. The naming itself marks them as singular. **Path.** Given only. The Tree's leaf is the only way a Phoenix begins. **Share.** Less than 0.1 percent, and there is only ever **one at a time in the entire world**. **Standing.** Legendary.

A Phoenix burns down to ash and rises again. Each death takes a piece of who they were; each life is a little further from the first. The Long-Lived never die. The Returned refuse to stay dead. A Phoenix dies completely, and comes back a new turn of the same soul, carrying fewer and fewer of the old one's memories.

When the current Phoenix finally spends their last life, the Tree gives the leaf to a single child, somewhere, and the next one begins. They are the one living person the whole world's phoenix-stories are currently about. The Tree names them once a generation or once an age, and then not again until they're gone. Almost nobody has ever met them. They are known through stories.

A whole city arranges itself around a Phoenix. In a single town they may be, all at once:

- **Revered:** believers call them proof the Leaf-Mother is real, and parade them as a living miracle on holy days;
- **Worshipped:** followers who believe touching them, or their ashes, blesses or heals;
- **Hunted:** those who want their ashes, their blood, their feathers, or their death (some believe a Phoenix's ash grants a life; some just want the one irreplaceable thing gone);
- **Hated and feared:** skeptics who call them a fraud, faiths who call them heresy, rulers who can't stand a symbol they don't control.

They cannot hide in a crowd. A Phoenix is *the* Phoenix, and everyone has heard the stories. This is the true weight of the Condition, heavier than any Tithe: you are the most known person alive, and the world has already decided what you mean.

The **whole table** agrees to a Phoenix — the Phoenix player and the **other players** commit together, the way you'd agree to a campaign about a chosen one. If anyone at the table does not want that weight, pick another Condition or run the Phoenix as a legend the party meets. The player commits to roleplaying the legend: the constant recognition, the followers and hunters, the impossibility of an ordinary life. It plays as a slow story with a counted number of lives, and it asks more of the table than a casual pick. It also works as a recurring legend whose rebirths a party witnesses across an age.

Day to day, a Phoenix pays nothing. The whole cost is spent at death: a little less memory, one fewer life. The real upkeep is social and unrelenting: being the only one. A Phoenix is recognized in any

market. Other people pour meaning onto them, and that meaning sticks. Worshippers and hunters find them anyway. A rebirth is grieved in public. The stories are heavy with loss for a reason: Phoenixes who rose so many times they forgot their own children, and Phoenixes who chose to stay dead instead of rising as still less of themselves. A Phoenix late in their cycle is a person made mostly of legend, with almost none of their first life left inside.

They can furl the wings of fire and pass, for a moment, as ordinary. The moment they fly, everyone watching knows what they are.

RULES

> *You are the only one. You will die, as you have died before, and rise, a few more times, and no more.*

The living-fire boons (a Phoenix simply *is* these, no cost unless noted):

- **Deathless to Flame:** You cannot be harmed by fire or heat of any kind: you take **no damage from fire** and can walk through, stand in, and breathe within flame unharmed. Ash and cinder are home.
- **Wings of Fire:** You have wings of living flame and **you can fly. Once per rest**, while flying, you may **mark a Stress** after an adversary attacks you to gain a **+2 bonus to your Evasion** against that attack. (You can furl the wings to pass for ordinary, but the moment you fly, everyone watching *knows what you are*.)
- **Kindle: Spend a Hope** to send a burst of fire at a target within **Close** range. Make an attack roll (Instinct or Strength). On a success, deal **magic damage in d6s equal to your Proficiency** and the target is temporarily **On Fire**.

The rebirth:

- **Rise From Ash:** When you make a **death move**, you gain a fourth option: **Rise From Ash.** Your body burns to nothing and reforms whole by the end of the next scene. You return with **Hit Points cleared**. **Stress is not cleared.** You are **Vulnerable** until your next rest, standing in your own ashes. Rebirth burns part of who you were. With the GM, name a piece of the old life that did *not* come back: a memory, a face, a skill, a fear, a name you used to answer to. You come back *you*, with that piece gone, and a little more like something that has done this before.
- **The Dwindling** *(Tithe):* Rebirth is finite, and paid in a piece of the old life and in a Hope slot. **Each Rise From Ash permanently crosses out a Hope slot**, as a scar does; your lives are counted in Hope. **When you would cross out your last Hope slot to Rise, you cannot.** That death is your true and final one, and this turn of the soul ends for good (per the SRD scar rule: crossing out your last Hope slot ends the character's journey). *Then, somewhere, a leaf falls for the next Phoenix.* There is never a second living Phoenix while this one can still Rise. A person who looks like a second Phoenix is not one. The dread is the **count**: everyone at the table can see how many risings are left, and so, quietly, can the Phoenix.

> Rise From Ash acts only on the Phoenix’s own body and Hope. Kindle is an ordinary attack, no different from a torch or a blade in what it may target. Each creature chooses their own next action.

The Kinds

Kinds

A place raises you. You were born in a body. That body is your **Kind**.

You are born with an ancestry, and with the shape of that birth. Nobody blinks at a fox-tail in a Maiethorn market or wings on a Heskoren ridge. The world organizes around the becoming. That is a Condition. You brought that born body to the Turning Tree. Kitsune, Selkie, and Tengu live in the towns around them. None of those Kinds is a country of its own.

Custom Kinds are born to a ground, and they are densest there. Other people live on that ground too. Forest, coast, ridge, dry country, isle: that ground is a **hearth**, and so is the home fire.

Yumboes are rare off Kumbaan because of the storm-wall, the distance. On the isle they are ordinary. On the mainland they are a sailor’s tale. Same people. The storm-wall on the map made that difference.

Kind, Condition, place

Layer	What it tells you	Where the rest of a person lives
Kind	Birth-shape; sometimes a hearth (coast, ridge, wood, isle)	Loyalty, faith, legal standing, and country are decided apart from the body
Condition	What they became (most people carry one); the Tithe (the upkeep of a becoming); guild or licence	The birth-body stays the Kind
Place	The local speech they use (their drift), the institution-names they use, the country that stood witness for them	Ears, wings, and tails stay the Kind

A Kitsune clerk works the Lestrand docks. A Tengu pilgrim walks in Threnmaieth. A Selkie stands as a witness for someone in Vaethorn. Each of those is an ordinary life. The life that matters is the Kind, the Condition, and the place together.

A Tithe belongs to a Condition.

The four custom hearths

Kitsune: three hearths, one Kind. The fox-born already come in three Foxes: Wilds, Snows, and Sands. That is the distribution, written into the body. Three grounds, shared with whoever else lives there. They marry and mingle; a child takes after one parent's line. You meet Kitsune in every port and every court. You meet more of a given Fox where that ground is.

Fox	Hearth	Where on the map
Wilds (red / forest)	tangled wood, hedgerow, Motherwood	densest in Maiethorn's Motherwood and Heskoren's deep forests
Snows (white / high cold)	high snow, pale open country	densest on Maiethorn's Rain-Wall and Heskoren's highland spines
Sands (pale / dry)	dry hills, rain-shadow, sand-country	densest in Maiethorn's Rain-Shadow: the leeward east of the Rain-Wall, the one true dry country in the known world

A Fox of the Sands in a wet Strandoren harbour has simply moved, the way people do. A town in the Rain-Shadow with no fox-born at all is the thing worth asking about.

Old Kitsune hearths still have a word for a fourth fox no one is born as anymore. People still say the word. No one is born that Fox. A grandmother will say the word and will not say why.

Selkie: the coasts. Selkies belong to two homes at once, so their hearth is the line between: strand, estuary, cold harbour, the towns that face water. Densest on Strandoren's indented coasts (the continent is almost all shoreline). Common in Maiethorn's western ports on the Old Crossing. Present on Heskoren's wild coast, thinner inland. Kumbaan has no native Selkies. A Selkie who makes that crossing is one person's story.

Inland Selkies exist. The skin Anchors: they always know the way back to wherever they left it, and they can always find their way back to water. They are simply fewer, and they miss whichever home they are away from, which they consider normal.

Tengu: the ridges. Tengu hearths are peaks, cliff-shelves, and the wind that lives there. Densest on Maiethorn's Rain-Wall and Heskoren's highland spines, the two continents that actually have killing height. Rare as a settled people on low Strandoren. The ones you meet there are usually sky-couriers: a family, a perch on a clock-tower, a run over the Old Crossing.

Tengu settlements cling to crags and are reached by wing or by rope. A lowlander arriving on foot is a guest who climbed. That is the courtesy.

They keep a running, half-teasing rivalry with the Selkies. Sky-folk and sea-folk each remain convinced their element is the one worth belonging to. The rivalry stays a tease between neighbours.

Yumboe: the isle. Kumbaan, and almost nowhere else. Mythic-rare off the isle; on it, ordinary. Kumbaan has no Leaf-Fall, so no child there is Given a Condition. A Struck Condition can still happen, and it is rare. Their ancestry is their own, and so is the feast they keep. A Yumboe on the mainland is usually the only one anyone in that town has ever seen. They have no mainland hearth: the storm-wall keeps them on the isle.

Stock ancestries

Daggerheart's stock set (Clank, Drakona, Dwarf, Elf, Faerie, Faun, Firbolg, Fungril, Galapa, Giant, Goblin, Halfling, Human, Infernis, Katari, Orc, Ribbet, Simiah) lives everywhere the Trees do. They live on every continent that has Trees. A few tendencies keep one stock thicker in some country than another:

- Water-born stock (Ribbet, Galapa, some Seaborne communities) cluster on the same coasts as Selkies. Ribbet breathe the deep. Selkies hold their breath, and a grip does not keep them.
- Height-and-wild stock (Giant, some Ridgeborne / Wildborne) show thicker on Heskoren's uplands, beside Tengu ridges. Tengu still live on those ridges.
- Old-wood stock (Elf, Faerie, Fungril, Firbolg) show thicker in Maiethorn's Motherwood, beside Wilds-fox hearths.
- Infernis are born demon-blooded. A person swears a contract later, and becomes Bound. Infernis live in the same towns as everyone else, and they have no country of their own.
- Faeries are the small people with flight. Halflings are the small people with luck. Yumboes are the good people of the isle, tied to the moon and to unseen hands.

A Ribbet judge in inland Threnmaieth is ordinary. A Giant on a Lestrand dock is ordinary. A thicker pocket of one stock in a town is a fact about that town. The town stays mixed. Country, guild, and a faith's seat are decided apart from that pocket.

The kitchens cook what the place grows. The staple belongs to the town's larder.

- **Ribbet and Galapa** cook on the quay, close enough to hear the tide: bread softened in fish broth, with seaweed or a cockle when the tide was good.
- **Giants** eat the usual upland meal, oat mash and dried peas, down off the Tengu perch.
- **Elves, Faeries, Fungril, and Firbolg** are thicker in the Motherwood, beside Wilds-fox hearths. The clearing is still mixed. Oat pottage, dried peas, mushrooms when the week was wet. A Fungril

household sets one spoonful aside. They will not say who it is for.

- **Fauns and Halflings** are thicker on farmland. They cook cabbage in the morning's milk and eat it in the yard. That is the house's own breakfast.
- **Katari and Simiah** eat a handful where they were working, a loft or a mast or a branch, and still come to the town's supper.
- **Clanks, Dwarves, Goblins, and Drakona** are thicker where a town already mends things. Bread and beans at the bench, still warm from the work. Ember is a lean some Drakona share with the Answered. The mill and the forge stay the town's.
- **Orcs** are thicker where the day's work is lifting. A pot of peas in the yard, the cart still hitched.
- **Humans** are common on every continent that has Trees, and equally common on each. They cook what the town cooks. Every Kind is a full body.
- **Infernis** are born with demon blood. A person swears a contract, and becomes Bound. They have no homeland. They eat from the same pot as the rest of the house.

The quay, the ridge, the wood, the field, the canopy, the mill, the road, and the pot belong to the town. A kitchen cooks there. It does not hold the ground.

Humans are common. A marriage between Kinds is a marriage. Every Kind is already a full body.

Factions recruit by Condition, by guild, and by faith. A settlement may have a hearth-neighbourhood (a Selkie quay, a Tengu perch, a Rain-Shadow fox-market). The town stays mixed. Ornsael shows it: fox-market by the well, mixed Kinds, no gate. A person has a Kind, a Condition or the Kept, and a place. The Tree left the Kept as they were. The place names them.

Hearth-Mark

Stock Daggerheart ancestries grant two features. Each custom Kind grants three. Beside them, a stock ancestry with two features looks weak.

A character whose two ancestry features are **both from stock ancestries** — a single stock Kind, or a stock-and-stock mix — takes a **Hearth-Mark** at character creation. A character who takes **any custom-Kind feature** does not take a Hearth-Mark. The third feature *is* the hearth written into the body.

Name the **place that raised you**: a town, a quay, a ridge-road, a walk-hold, a roll-street. Write it as a place-phrase. *Hallowquay salvage-child* names the place, and that is a Hearth-Mark. *Seal-blood* names a Kind, and that line stays off the Mark.

Once per session, when you make an action or reaction roll that leans on how that place taught you to live, add **+2**. The +2 costs no Hope. You may still spend Hope to add a relevant Experience on the same roll.

The +2 is the whole of the Mark. A phrase that starts granting swim-breath, flight, or freedom from being caught off guard has turned into a feature. Write the place again.

Everyone still takes a **Community** as the SRD requires. The Hearth-Mark sits beside that Community. It adds no ancestry feature. You still take the two Experiences the SRD gives every character.

Mixed Ancestry

The table allows what Daggerheart allows. People mix ancestry in the ordinary way Daggerheart allows. Two mainland Kinds — stock, custom, or one of each — mix by the SRD rule. One ancestry gives its first-listed feature. The other gives its second-listed feature. Those are the **top** and the **bottom**.

Custom Kinds have a third feature. That third feature is the **hearth feature**. A mix leaves it out.

Kind	Top	Bottom	Hearth feature, only on the full Kind
Kitsune	Slip the Frame	Fox’s Glamour	Your Fox (Wilds / Snows / Sands)
Selkie	Second Skin	Slip the Hold	Seal-Kin
Tengu	Wind-Winged	Wind-Caller	The Mountain’s Mood

Yumboe is taken whole. That Kind is written below.

How to build one:

1. Take **one Top** from one parent Kind and **one Bottom** from the other.
2. Take **no** hearth feature from either custom Kind.
3. Take **no** Hearth-Mark if either feature is custom. Take a Hearth-Mark if both features are stock.
4. If both chosen features grant the same verb (fly and fly, swim and swim), keep one and take the unused listed Top or Bottom from either parent instead. One copy of that verb is the mix.
5. Write both sides on the body — ears and webbing, wings and a fox-brush, whatever the pairing is. That pairing is the whole mix.

One Top and one Bottom is the whole mix. A hearth feature stays with the full Kind. Community is unchanged. Kind still stacks with a Condition. A mixed-heritage character meets the Leaf-Fall, or is Kept, or is Struck, like anyone else.

A mixed Kitsune has Slip the Frame or Fox’s Glamour. The Fox of the Wilds, the Snows, or the Sands comes only with the full Kind.

Yumboe at the table

A Yumboe character needs **GM leave**. They are mythic-rare off Kumbaan; a mainland campaign that seats one has decided the storm-wall let someone through.

If the table says yes, they are the **full Kind**: Hollow-Hill, Moon-Waked, and The Unseen Hands, and nothing mixed in. The three features already include the hearth, so there is no separate Hearth-Mark.

A child of a Yumboe and anyone else is either a full Yumboe (same GM leave) or the other parent's Kind, with at most a detail in the fiction, and no extra feature. That detail is a story-tell. The sheet has no half-Yumboe. Distance and the storm-wall are why.

Kitsune

Kitsune are slight and quick-eyed, fox-born, with a fox's ears and a brush of tail, and the cold pale light of **foxfire** always a thought away at their fingertips. They say *kitsunebi* for that fox-flame. A Kitsune can draw that foxfire into the shape of another face, a borrowed voice, a trick of the eye. That is a **glamour**. The body underneath stays the same. It changes what a person perceives. The decision stays theirs. Kitsune are as honest as their neighbours. They simply cannot quite be pinned down. They redirect. They step out of the frame of a situation and leave you looking at where they were, or at a face that isn't theirs. The tail is real and worn openly, and often the surest way to catch a glamoured fox. The fire leaves the tail in sight.

Foxfire is common to every Kitsune: the ghost-light that leads travelers off the mountain path, the pale fire that hides the sacred white fox, the flame the old nine-tails were said to carry. Each kind of fox bends the same fire a different way.

Just as the world holds arctic, desert, and forest foxes, the fox-born come in kinds shaped by the country they were born to. The **Fox of the Wilds** is red-and-russet, a forest and hedgerow fox. The **Fox of the Snows** is white-coated, born to the cold north and the high snows. The **Fox of the Sands** is pale and huge-eared, born to the dry country. All are Kitsune. All share the same slipperiness and the same foxfire, and marry and mingle freely; a child takes after one parent's line or the other. Each carries a gift bred into it by its home ground, and turns its foxfire to a different old fox-story: the will-o'-wisp that leads a hunter astray, the pale flame that swallows the white fox from sight, the ward-fire of the fox that always knows what's coming.

A Kitsune is not changed into anything. A Kitsune is known for never quite being where you left them. Their reputation is misdirection without deceit. They slip a trap, and they do not lie about the trap being there.

Values

Kitsune prize the graceful exit and the unfought fight: the deal that dissolves before it comes to blows, the door found before the room fills with smoke. They tend to distrust cornered situations and to admire cleverness over force. Their instinct in a corner is to make a new corner. Kitsune say: “Never the last one holding it.” They keep their word carefully, because a people so slippery would be trusted by no one if they were also untrustworthy. A Kitsune’s given word tends to be very solid, and they know it is their most valuable possession.

Customs

They defuse a fight, and they can never quite be cornered, so Kitsune work as mediators, brokers, and night-couriers. They carry delicate news between rival houses, hold the neutral ground in a negotiation, walk the dark roads by their own cold foxfire, and are trusted to be somewhere unnoticed and gone again without a scene. Foxfire is a small everyday grace, too. Children are taught to make it before they’re taught to read, and a home with a fox-born in it never wants for a soft, safe light. Older Kitsune, by tradition, carry themselves with more tails in the telling of it. People take the folklore of nine tails as a reputation and an honorific. The body keeps one brush. The extra tails live in the telling.

Daggerheart ancestry features

Every Kitsune has **Slip the Frame** and **Fox’s Glamour**, and chooses one **Fox** at character creation. The Fox is a full feature. Each grants a lasting knack and a foxfire signature move. The home ground bred in the real animal’s gift. Each Fox turns the same ghost-flame a different way, after the old fox-spirit myth.

- **Slip the Frame:** When you would take damage from an attack, you can mark a **Stress** to slip aside: halve the damage, then immediately move up to **Very Close** range to a position out of the attacker’s reach. If you end this movement out of line of sight, you are **Hidden**.
- **Fox’s Glamour:** You can wrap yourself in foxfire-glamour to seem other than you are: veil your fox features to pass unremarked, cast your voice or a small sound a short way off, or throw a minor sensory illusion (a flicker of movement, a scent, a light) into a space within **Close** range. Once per scene, you can mark a **Stress** to **wear another face**: take on the convincing seeming of another person you’ve seen, holding it as long as you concentrate. The glamour is illusion. It doesn’t change your body or fool touch, and a creature that has strong reason to doubt what it’s seeing can make an appropriate roll to catch the tell (a fox-shadow, a reflection that’s a beat late, an animal’s unease). This is disguise and misdirection. It changes what others perceive. What they decide stays theirs.
- **Your Fox:** Choose the fox you were born to. Each has a lasting knack and a foxfire move:

- **Fox of the Wilds** *(red / forest fox: the will-o'-wisp that leads travelers off the path). Knack:* you are at home in tangled, broken, or overgrown country: **advantage** on Agility Rolls to climb, leap, tumble, or move through difficult terrain, and you ignore its movement penalty. *Foxfire (Wisp-Lure):* mark a **Stress** to send dancing ghost-lights and false trails around a creature within **Close** range; until the end of its next turn it is drawn after the lights: its attacks against anyone but you are made with **disadvantage**, and you may immediately move up to **Very Close** range without drawing an attack. The lights are a lure. The target is baited to look the wrong way, and still chooses where to move.
- **Fox of the Snows** *(arctic fox: the sacred white fox that vanishes in its own pale fire). Knack:* you leave no trail worth following. Adversaries have **disadvantage** on rolls to track, trail, or find you, and you have **advantage** on rolls to **Hide** or move unseen in open, snowy, pale, or exposed terrain. *Foxfire (Cold Vanishing):* once per scene, mark a **Stress** to wrap yourself in cold white foxfire and let the eye slide off you, and become **Hidden** even while observed and in the open, so long as you don't take an action that would obviously reveal you.
- **Fox of the Sands** *(fennec: the many-tailed fox that always knows what's coming). Knack:* you see clearly in darkness and dim light as far as you would in daylight, and your great ears miss nothing: **advantage** on rolls to hear, notice, or locate hidden creatures, sounds, or movement. *Foxfire (Ward-Flame):* when you or an ally within **Close** range would be targeted by an attack, you can mark a **Stress** to throw up a sudden curtain of foxfire. The target gains a **+2 bonus to their Evasion** against that attack.

Naming

Hearth-register **Kusawe**, said koo-SAH-way. The sound is light, slipping, sibilant. Daily speech is the local Maiethren drift; the fox-name is what they answer to when someone is trying to pin them down. Given names include Raki, Nenyu, Wishi, Kiraye, Suti, Hatu, Ranyu, Sinro, Foryo, Heka, Sofan.

A Kitsune raised devout in Threnmaieth may still be Raki at home and Raki Maethaem on the roll.

Selkie

Selkies are sleek, cool-skinned people who carry a second self, a **sealskin** they can wear or set aside. They are sea-born, skin-kin. The skin is genuinely them, a spare body kept close, and slipping it on or off takes only a moment. Frog-folk live underwater and breathe there. A Selkie's gift is the way out: you cannot keep hold of one. A Selkie in the water, in a net, in a grip, in a locked room, has a way out. The sea taught them that being held is temporary.

Out of the skin, a Selkie reads as an ordinary person with a few quiet tells: cool, faintly sleek skin, large dark eyes, and sometimes a little webbing at the fingers. Nobody stares. The seal-blood shows the way any other Kind's does. The real transformation lives in the skin. The face keeps only the quiet tells.

People still tell the old story, in which a stolen skin means you own her and she pines for a sea she can't return to. A Selkie belongs fully to **two homes at once**, shore and sea, and so they are the people who move easily between worlds that don't understand each other. The removable skin is a private, tender thing. Loaning it, or having it taken, is a real intimacy and a real violation, handled in story. It never becomes a penalty on the sheet.

Values

Selkies value belonging without being bound: deep loyalty freely given, resented the instant it's demanded. They are hard to detain and hard to hold onto. A Selkie loves fiercely but will not be caged, and a relationship or a job that starts to feel like a net is one they will quietly, gracefully leave. They carry a comfortable double-homesickness their whole lives and consider it normal. To always miss the place you aren't is, to them, simply the price of getting to have two homes.

Customs

Because they can't be kept down and can't be kept out, Selkies work as rescue swimmers, cold-water divers and salvors, and go-betweens: the ones sent into the surf after the drowning, down to the wreck, or across the water to a community the shore-folk can't talk to. Escape-artistry makes them trusted couriers for anything that mustn't be seized in transit. The sealskin is treated with real ceremony. Where a Selkie keeps their skin, who they'd ever let hold it, and the day a child is first given the run of their own skin are all significant, private matters.

Surviving a drowning is the threshold that Strikes the Far-Voiced. Selkies live in that water, and the stories about them and that drowning are many.

Daggerheart ancestry features

- **Second Skin:** You carry a **sealskin**, a second self you can don or shed in a moment. While you wear it, you ignore the effects of cold and deep water, you can hold your breath far longer than anyone should, and you always know which way is up and where the nearest surface or shore lies. You have **advantage** on Agility Rolls to swim, dive, or move through water.
- *Anchored.* Your skin is your fixed point in the world. Wherever you leave it stashed, you always know the direction and distance to it and can find your way back to it unerringly, however far

you've travelled or however turned-around you are. (Loaning your skin, or having it taken, is a matter of story and trust, never a mechanical penalty.)

- **Slip the Hold:** When a creature grabs or restrains you, or succeeds on an attack against you, you can mark a **Stress** to slip free like a seal from a net: you end any grab or **Restrained** effect on you, ignore any forced movement from that attack, and move up to **Very Close** range out of the creature's reach.
- **Seal-Kin:** Seals and the beasts of the sea treat you as kin. You have **advantage** on rolls to calm, read, or call an animal of the sea. Once per scene, while you are in or near water, you can mark a **Stress** to let the sea itself warn you: the GM **names** what is approaching through the water, and until the end of your next turn the nearest seal-kin surfaces to aid you — a distraction that draws a foe's attention, a tow through the current, or a shove that carries you toward shore or safety. You may move up to **Close** range before the named approach arrives. That is a warning and a help. The Mountain's Mood is the feature that says you cannot be caught off guard, and it belongs to the Tengu.

Selkies are at home in water (long breath-hold, ignore cold and deep, swim advantage). Ribbets are the ones who breathe underwater. Seal-Kin calls seal-kin to aid. People keep their own will.

Naming

Hearth-register **Sakoa**, said sah-KOH-ah. The sound is liquid, rounded, coastal. Daily speech is the local Maiethren drift. Given names include Lavo, Fesa, Moka, Dovo, Neson, Foaro, Veakea, Didel, Roadoa, Woanun, Laknea.

The hearth-name is spoken to the water the day a child is first given the run of their skin; the second name, a byname or a house-name, comes from the town that watched them Turn. Two homes, two names. They treat that as ordinary.

Tengu

Tengu are lean, sharp-featured people of the high country, crow-born, with dark feathers through their hair and down their arms, black bright eyes, and broad wings that carry them off any cliff or updraft. They are the folk of the peaks and the wind, born where the air is thin and the weather turns in a heartbeat, and utterly unbothered by either. Where lowlanders see a killing drop and a coming storm, a Tengu reads a launch point and a rising thermal. They fly, and the mountain never surprises them. They feel the rockfall before it slides and the squall before it breaks.

The crow-born of the Turning belong to the high wild the way Selkies belong to the sea: at home in the exact place that kills everyone else. The fox-born move unseen through society, the sea-born through water, the crow-born through the sky and the heights.

Wings are always present. A Tengu reads as Tengu at a glance, as ordinary in-world as any other Kind.

Values

Tengu prize the view from height, and the habit of mind that comes with it. Their instinct in any tangle is to get above it and look down: gain height, gain distance, see the whole shape of a thing before acting. They tend toward blunt directness and a certain impatience with those who won't climb to look for themselves. They are used to seeing exactly where a path leads, and they say so. Tengu say: "The valley argues about the storm; the ridge just watches it come." They respect earned skill and hard-won height, and have little patience for status that wasn't climbed to.

Customs

Because they can go where footpaths can't and read the mountain's mood before it turns, Tengu work as high-pass guides, weather-callers, sky-couriers, and mountain rescue. They carry word over the peaks faster than any road, call the avalanche warning down to the valley towns, and go over the edge after the fallen climber. Tengu settlements cling to cliff faces and ridge-shelves, reached by wing or by rope, and a Tengu's first solo flight off the home crag is as significant a coming-of-age as a Selkie child first given the run of their own skin. They keep a running, half-teasing rivalry with the Selkies. Sky-folk and sea-folk each remain convinced their element is the one worth belonging to.

Daggerheart ancestry features

- **Wind-Winged:** You can fly. While flying, you can mark a **Stress** to fold your wings and **dive** on a target within Close range: treat it as a **Finesse** attack dealing **d8** physical damage using your Proficiency, and end the dive anywhere within **Very Close** range of that target.
- **The Mountain's Mood:** You read the high wild before it moves. You have **advantage** on rolls to sense danger in the natural world (a coming storm, rockfall, avalanche, unstable footing, treacherous terrain) and to navigate mountainous or aerial ground. You **cannot be caught off guard by an environmental hazard or a terrain-based ambush**. You always feel it coming in time to act or call a warning before it lands. That wording is written **once**, here. It applies to weather and to ground. Seal-Kin names an approach through the water. Hollow-Hill feels gait through earth. Those two senses are theirs. This immunity is the Tengu's.
- **Wind-Caller:** You command the mountain wind the way the old fan-bearers did (the fan is a **ha-uchiwa**, a Tengu feather-fan). Mark a **Stress** to call a sudden gust and choose one: **shove** a target within **Far** range a step closer or farther and knock it **Vulnerable**; **carry** yourself or a willing ally

an extra move on the wind (a great leap, a saving glide down from a height, a boost across a gap); or **sweep** an area within Close range clear of smoke, gas, fog, or loose airborne projectiles until the start of your next turn.

Naming

Hearth-register **Gonan**, said GO-nan, sounds clipped, windy, and high-country. It does not sound like Kusawe. Daily speech is the local Maiethren drift. Given names include Teku, Kukra, Gobak, Hosen, Kotak, Buka, Rekren, Kuhos, Hrarat, Gonan. Gonan names the people too. Giving it to a child honors the hearth, as naming a child after the ridge does.

The second name is often a byname that is a perch or a pass (Teku of Highgate, Hosen of the White Stair), or a house-name where a list keeps them. A harbour-name belongs to the coast.

Yumboe

Yumboes are the small, moon-waked hill-folk of the far isle of Kumbaan. In their own tongue they call themselves *Bakhna Rakhna*, the good people. They stand about waist-high to a mainlander, with pearl-pale skin that catches the light, hair like spun silver, and wide dark eyes made for the night. They live within the green hills of their home, a warren of hearths and long feast-halls hollowed under the turf, and come up by moonlight, for they keep the night the way other folk keep the day. Yumboes are hospitable, openly so. A Yumboe's table is open to native and stranger alike, laid with more than a small people should be able to carry, and waited on by hands and feet you can plainly see and bodies you cannot: the unseen servants that are the good people's oldest wonder.

Unlike Kitsune, Selkie, and Tengu, who are native to the mainland and unremarkable there, a Yumboe is mythic-rare off their far isle. Most people of Maiethorn, Strandoren, and Heskoren have only heard stories of the pearly, silver-haired good people from across the drowning sea.

On the isle they are an ordinary, warm, whole people who happen to live somewhere almost no one can reach, so their strangeness is distance. On the isle they are ordinary to themselves. They are a legend to a world that has never had them to supper. The mainland files them, and the hands with no bodies, under fairy-tale.

A Yumboe reads as a Yumboe at a glance, which is exactly why they are remarked on the moment they leave their isle. The "two-foot good people" of the oldest tellings are the deep-hill kin of legend. The ones at the table are the waist-high people.

Values

Yumboes prize hospitality above nearly all else. To feed a guest, and to be fed as one, is their deepest courtesy and their firmest bond; a shared table is as binding to them as a sworn word is to the Bound. They are a people of the threshold and the hearth: comfortable underground and after dark, unhurried, and quietly certain that the surface world's noon-day bustle misses most of what matters. Because they are small and their home is hidden, they have never learned to meet force with force. They meet it with welcome and misdirection, and with a great many helping hands. Yumboes say: "No one is a stranger twice." They find the mainland's daylight faiths loud and its treatment of the unwelcomed baffling.

Customs

On Kumbaan, life runs by the moon. The good people wake at dusk, work and feast and dance the bright nights, and sleep out the glare of day in the cool of the hills. Their halls are famous (in their own telling) for feasts that outshine their means. The unseen hands fetch and pour and serve, so that even a poor household sets a table like a lord's. They keep terrace-gardens and standing-stone marks on the surface and the real life below. They fish the storm-walled shallows and, the old accounts say, were not above lifting a little corn from anyone careless enough to leave it: a small people's small mischief, told fondly.

Off the isle, and very few cross, a Yumboe is a walking wonder, and knows it. They tend to become hosts, keepers, cooks, and go-betweens wherever they land, turning a welcome and hands to lay a table into a place in a world that first meets them as a myth. A Yumboe abroad is usually the only one anyone has ever seen.

Kumbaan has no Turning Tree. The isle has no Leaf-Fall and no Given Conditions. Struck can still happen, at far smaller percentages than the mainland: enough for a story, and too few to be a social class. Being a Kind, Yumboe still stacks with a Condition in principle. A Yumboe abroad under a mainland Tree could be Given. It almost never arises.

Daggerheart ancestry features

Every Yumboe has all three: **Hollow-Hill**, **Moon-Waked**, and **The Unseen Hands**.

- **Hollow-Hill:** You are one of the good people: **small** (hill-folk stature), and born to the deep earth. You can move through gaps and spaces too tight for a larger creature, and you have **advantage** on Agility Rolls to squeeze, climb, or move through cramped, broken, or underground terrain and to **Hide** where there is cover to slip behind. Underground, or within stone and hill, you always know your depth and heading and **cannot become lost**. You feel movement through the ground: the **direction, number, and gait** (walk, crawl, or slide) of creatures within **Close** range who are on or

under the earth. That is a sense of who is moving. The Mountain's Mood is where "cannot be caught off guard" is written, and it belongs to the Tengu.

- **Moon-Waked:** You keep the night. You see in darkness and dim light as clearly as others see by day, and you have **advantage** on rolls to notice, search, or act **at night or underground**, anywhere the sun doesn't reach. When you take rest **under the open night sky or moonlight**, you clear **1 additional Stress** (or your party gains a little of the good people's ease: the GM's call on the fiction). Daylight leaves you unhurt. Glare is when you are least at your best.
- **The Unseen Hands:** You can call the good people's unseen servants (**hands and feet plainly visible, but no body between them**) to attend you. At will, they perform small tasks within **Close** range: fetch and carry a light object, pour and serve, hold a door or a rope, steady a load, lay a table. Once per scene, you can mark a **Stress** to set them to **harry** instead: a flurry of unseen hands swarms a target within **Close** range, and until the end of its next turn choose one: the target has **disadvantage** on its next attack, **or** the next ally to act against it has **advantage**. The hands are a conjured seeming of many small helpers. They can distract, fumble, and fetch. Damage, a weapon, and holding a determined creature are outside their work.

Naming

The Yumboes speak their own tongue, unrelated to Maiethren. It is the one tongue that owes nothing to the Leaf-Mother's liturgy, because the Trees never crossed the storm-wall. Its sound is open-voweled and warm, with soft pre-nasal clusters (*mb, nd, nk, nj*) and a lilting, drum-like rhythm. A Yumboe name sounds foreign the instant it's spoken.

- They call themselves *Bakhna Rakhna*, the good people.
- They call the isle *Kumbaan*, said koom-BAHN, the hidden home. Mainlanders call it the Sundering Isle.
- Given names include Ambaa, Njeela, Kumbo, Sambanka, Ndeya, Mbaraan, Njunda, Rakhilo, Sonkaa, Mbindaa, Yumbaka, Ndoolu, Sambiyo, Lunji, Yaaba, Saalo, Mbela, Soonke, Njili, Yendo, Waandi, Koriwaa.

Yumboes are too rare on the mainland to have grown a local byname-layer. They keep the one register.

Language and Naming

You need a person who sounds like they grew up somewhere, and a hall that sounds like the land that built it.

Speak the common name; write the liturgical name. A traveller asks for the *hall-keepers* or sails to *the Night Shore*. A rite, charter, learned map, or scholar may write *Orenhael* or *Netstrand*. The common handle comes first at the table. The Hinge Shore has no current liturgical form; *Eolstrand* is retired.

A person is named by the place that raised them. If they are Kitsune, Selkie, Tengu, or Yumboe, they also keep a hearth-name from their Kind. Everyone else uses the local speech of the Old Tongue. Two names is ordinary. You introduce them as **Raki of Hallowquay**.

This chapter is the how-to: how names work, how to pick one, and how to make one that is not on a list. The lists come first. Under each Kind, **To make another** is how you build a name that is not on the list. **How to Name a Place or a Hall** names towns and offices from the old-word table. The lookup tables are what each land calls the same building.

Continent and region names wait for **The Four Continents**, where the map is. The sound-system, and what the linguistics words mean, live in Book X under **GM only: Language**.

How to Name a Person

1. **Where were they raised?** That sets the second name, and the sound of a common-tongue first name.
2. **Are they one of the four custom Kinds?** If yes, pick the given name from that Kind's list. If no, pick from the place-list.
3. **Add the second name that place uses.** A **byname** where people are witnessed. A **house-name** where a list has to find them again. The civic name is one of those. The Kind-name stays the hearth-name.
4. **Say it once with the stress marked** (CAPS), then use it normally.

A byname is *of a town, of a Tree, called such for a deed,* or *of the house you actually sleep in* when that house is not a list. The road, the live front, the waiting towns, and every power that names people by witness use this. A fox-born broker on a witness quay: **Raki of Hallowquay**. The human at the next desk: **Valen of Hallowquay**. Same street, same civic name, different first sound.

A house-name is inherited. Children wear it. A neighbour says the given name. A clerk says the **house first**, then the given name. The house-word is that place's own drift, often an old given name that stuck to a line. Two crowns keep a roll of persons. Threnmaieth calls its roll holy and files the house-name on it. Trenledd keeps its roll without calling it holy, and the column may file a person under the house that pays. In Rothallo, which people still call the Inner Close, the line can cast a person out and keep the house on them. The Walled Book there keeps an heir-roll, and it lists only its own heirs. A filing house on a quay files the house-name while the paper is open. Shut the paper, and the quay goes back to the witness way. *Closed* on a roster is a rank.

Who is asking	What you give
A neighbour	the given name
A clerk in a list-land	the house first, then the given name
A witness-town, and you are a stranger	the given name, and *of the place*
Kumbaan	the given name

Kumbaan asks for the given name. At the table, that is the name they use. Witness-lands keep the witness way. Maiethvael writes the witnessed name. The Waiting Lands write the witnessed name. Harrow's uses a roll-name only to keep the greeting distant.

A Tengu's byname is often a perch or a pass: **Teku of Highgate**, **Hosen of the White Stair**.

Yumboes are the exception. They are too rare on the mainland to have grown a local second name. They keep one name, and it sounds foreign the moment it is spoken.

Keep the cast distinct

- **Raki** and **Ranyu** in the same party are easy to mix up. **Teku** and **Kukra** sound like twins, so they belong together only if they are twins.
- A Selkie named **Wishi**, or a Tengu named **Maethaem**, was raised away, adopted, or passing.
- Place-names already on the map are reserved. No person is called Vaethorn, Lestrand, Threnmaieth, Thaeloren, Maieth, Kumbaan, Ndeyaan, Haelthael, Leddoren, or Vaeloren. The same goes for church and house names (Orenhael, Thaelvaeth, Nethoren, Leddhael, Vaelbren, Njaalo,

Njawaal, Vaethledd), the squares Ornsael, Brenthael, Brenod, Vaelun, Ornath, Harrow’s, and the seats Eolvaeth, Orentel, Maiethlir.

Names by Place

Everyday names are the Old Tongue worn down to something you can shout across a yard. Soft *th*, long vowels, liquids. Stress follows the Old Tongue rule under **How to Say It**, and the stress marked on first use wins.

A town in any Tree-touched land uses these sounds, worn the way that land wears them. The isle of Kumbaan is the exception. It already has its own speech.

How a place speaks

A traveller can say Turning Tree, the Mother, a hug, a colour, a tree-warden, and a graft, and be understood on every mainland road. Use those words and you will be understood. The table below is what each kind of place calls the same six things in its own words. Use a local word when you want a scene to sound like that place. Say who is speaking.

The pious core keeps the old *th* sound. Waiting towns soften it. A dock drops it. Kumbaan speaks its own speech and has no Tree to name. That is the Sundering Isle.

	Pious core	Waiting lands, the live front	The docks	The hill
the Tree	**the Mother’s Hand**	**the Thallow**	**Tallo** *(TAL-oh)*	**the far tree**
the Mother	**Maieth** *(MY-eth)*	**Mait** *(MAYT)*	**the old rite**	**the loud story**
a hug	**a keeping**	**a hug**	**a clear**	**the place**
a colour	**the colour**	**the gift**	**the fall**	**a test**
a warden	**the Reckoned Hands** (the crown’s word; Maiethvael says **tree-warden**)	**Hands-folk**	**a tree-tender**	**the loud guest**
a graft	**a Hand carried in**	**a carried Thallow**; on the live front, until it can Turn, **the wood**	**a carrying**	**their cutting**

Careful prayer in a waiting town says “Maieth,” with the *th* restored, for as long as the prayer is open. The kitchen says “Mait.” A no-colour is still a hug. On a dock, Tallo is how a quay says the Thallow once the *th* is gone. Say Tallo on the dock. A charter keeps the long name. A no-colour is a clear. The child came up clear, and is free to be hired. Trenledd speaks this dock way and keeps a list. The hill has a table and no Tree. The hill says “the far tree” for the mainland Tree and “their cutting” for a mainland graft. The loud story is what they call the Mother when a guest brings her up. A warden who climbs the hill is the loud guest, and is still fed.

A scene uses one of four ways of talking: a devout square, a dock, a waiting town or the live front, and a hill-hall on Kumbaan.

In a devout square, people finish the practical sentence, then put “the Mother’s Hand” or “Maieth” back in if the first sentence left them out. While the room is mixed, they say “the Mother’s Hand” and “Maieth,” and they greet a neighbour by the given name.

On a dock, people speak in about six words, then give the number or the berth if they need them. They repeat the last hard fact. They speak the dock form, with the old *th* gone. They say “clear”. That is a child the Tree hugged and gave no Condition. While no document is open, they ask the given name. While a filing house has the paper open, they ask the house-name first, then the given name.

A waiting town, and the live front, say a short line and then repeat it. A waiting town repeats “not this week.” The live front repeats “the wood,” and then the neighbour’s town if their own wood cannot

Turn yet. They call their Tree the Thallow.

A hill-hall on Kumbaan uses three short sentences: a welcome, a pause, and one practical thing. They repeat “sit,” and “the place.” A newcomer is seated on that welcome.

Each of these places also has one phrase it says whole. In a devout square, someone says “Lei thulen” *(lay THOO-len)*. On a dock, someone says “Ka doven” *(kah DOV-en)*. In a waiting town, and on the live front, someone says “Len soret” *(len so-RET)*. In a hill-hall, someone says “Aman ndo” *(ah-MAHN ndoh)*.

Raised in	How the name sounds	Pick from
Threnmaieth, pious Maiethorn	The old church sound, kept whole. You hear the *th*.	**Maethaem** (MAY-thaym), **Reimaethe** (RYE-may-theh), **Thilim** (THIL-im), **Rithnali** (rith-NAH-lee), **Valein** (vah-LAYN)
Vaethorn, Heskoren folk	Worn. The *th* is still there, softer. Endings simplify.	**Nathdo** (NATH-doh), **Saelid** (SAY-lid), **Tora**, **Seine** (SAY-neh), **Nethiro** (neth-EE-ro)
Lestrand, Strandoren docks	Clipped. The *th* has gone to t or d, or dropped.	**Valen**, **Tilim**, **Mataero** (mah-TAY-ro), **Ledan**, **Sorel**

Devout places keep the old *th*. Dock towns turn it to t or d, or drop it. A name that still has the *th* comes from a devout place. A name that has dropped it comes from a dock.

To make a new common-tongue name, start from one of the lists above and keep those sounds. There are three drifts and no fourth human language. Vaelhesk keeps older *vael* and frontier *hesk-*. It is this same speech, worn further.

Names for the Four Custom Kinds

Kitsune, Selkie, Tengu, and Yumboe keep a hearth-name for given names, kin, and in-group talk. On the street they still wear the local byname. You can often hear both homes in one introduction.

The lists are what you pick from. The short recipe under each is only for when you need a name that is not on the list. Make one that could sit next to the others without anyone blinking.

Kitsune: Kusawe (koo-SAH-way)

A Kitsune hearth-name sounds light, slipping, and a little hissy.

Pick from: Raki, Nenyu, Wishi, Kiraye, Suti, Hatu, Ranyu, Sinro, Foryo, Heka, Sofan.

The hearth-name is the one they answer to when someone is trying to pin them down. They consider this funny. A fox raised devout in Threnmaieth may still be Raki at home and Maethaem, Raki on the roll.

To make another: two or three short beats. Use k, s, sh, n, r, m, t, w, y, f, h, and the vowels a, i, u, e, o, plus *ai* as in *eye*. You can end on n, m, or r. No *th*: that is church-speech. No *kr* or *gr* at the start: that is Tengu. No *mb* or *nd*: that is Yumboe.

Selkie: Sakoa (sah-KOH-ah)

A Selkie hearth-name sounds liquid, rounded, and coastal. You can say it on a breath of cold air.

Pick from: Lavo, Fesa, Moka, Dovo, Neson, Foaro, Veakea, Didel, Roadoa, Woanun, Laknea.

The day a child is first given the run of their own skin is when the hearth-name is spoken to the water. The civic byname comes later, from the town that watched them Turn. Two homes, two names.

To make another: two or three beats. Use l, r, n, m, s, v, f, d, b, k, w, and the vowels o, u, a, i, e, plus *ea* and *oa*. No *th*, *sh*, *kr*, *gr*, or *mb* / *nd*.

Tengu: Gonan (GO-nan)

A Tengu hearth-name is clipped, windy, and high-country. The names are short, with hard onsets, said as if the wind might take the end. This is ridge-speech.

Pick from: Teku, Kukra, Gobak, Hosen, Kotak, Buka, Rekren, Kuhos, Hrarat, Gonan.

Gonan is also the people-name. Reusing it as a given name is a hearth-honor, like naming a child after the ridge.

To make another: prefer two beats. Use k, t, g, n, r, h, s, b, d. *Kr*, *gr*, and *hr* at the front are at home here. Vowels a, o, u, e. Few *i*. That vowel lives with the foxes. No *th*, *sh*, *mb* / *nd*, or long *ai* / *ea* / *oa*.

Yumboe

Yumboe is its own tongue. Open vowels, a drum-like rhythm, and *mb*, *nd*, *nk*, *nj* at the start of a beat. A Yumboe name sounds foreign the instant it is spoken. The Trees never crossed the storm-wall, so the speech stayed the island’s own.

They call themselves **Bakhna Rakhna**. That is the good people. Their home is **Kumbaan** (koom-BAHN). Mainlanders call it the Sundering Isle.

Pick from: Ambaa, Njeela, Kumbo, Ndeya, Mbaraan, Njunda, Rakhilo, Sambiyo, Lunji, Yaaba, Saalo, Mbela, Soonke, Njili, Yendo, Waandi, Koriwaa.

To make another: keep the open vowels and the *mb* / *nd* / *nk* / *nj*. No *th*, and no clipping it down to a Lestrand dock-name. They keep the one register on the mainland. No *of Hallowquay* unless the story is that they have decided to stay.

How to Say It

CAPS is the stressed beat. Mark it the first time, then drop it.

- **ae** = "ay" as in *day*
- **ai** and **ei** = "eye"
- **eo** = an "ay-oh" glide
- **a** as in *father* · **e** as in *bed* · **i** as in *machine* · **o** as in *go* · **u** as in *moon*
- **th** as in *thin*, never as in *the*
- A simple root keeps its own stress. A name glued from two old words stresses the **first word**, with a lighter beat on the second: THAEL-or-en, VAETH-orn. Old church forms and personal names can keep a stress of their own. The stress marked the first time a name appears is the one to use.

The Old Tongue is warm and weighty. It keeps a few old consonant clusters at the front of a word (*br*, *kr*, *st*, *str*, *thr*) and no harsh piles beyond them. If you cannot say it at the table, it is the wrong name.

How to Name a Place or a Hall

The Old Tongue is **Maiethren** (MAI-eth-ren). That is Mother-speech. It is the church language of the Awakening Tree. Nobody grows up speaking it at the market. Place-names, crowns, and old offices are built from it. Everyday talk uses plain compounds. People say *the Kept*, *the ranging*, and *tree-wardens*.

To name something old or official:

1. **Pick one or two old words** from the list below.
2. **Glue them together.** Thaeloren is *thael* + *oren*. That is Tree and witness.

3. **Wear it the way the land wears it.** A devout land keeps the *th* and the long vowels. A frontier town softens them. A dock town wears the *th* and the long vowels away. The most worn name belongs to the least-devout place.
4. **Mark the stress** on first use.

Same building, three names. A devout land calls the Far-Voiced hall a *gift-hall*. A merchant coast calls it a *release-house*. Threnmaieth calls it a *counted hall*. The lookup tables below are that fact, row by row.

Kumbaan’s names are Yumboe.

The old words

These are the blocks names are built from. Each old word has the meaning it had in the rite. A dock town may keep the sound and wear the rite-meaning down.

Word	Says	Means
oren	OR-en	to witness; to speak true
ren	ren	speech, tongue. As a suffix: “the speech of.” Maieth**ren** is Mother-speech.
thael	thayl	the Tree; sacred motherwood
maieth	MY-eth	the Mother
vael	vayl	a gift Given. Older: what the land yields (harvest, a child returned from water, a person the hill kept). The Old Ways still use the older sense.
vaeth	vayth	the waiting; the longing (the Kept; the pilgrim’s wait)
hael	hayl	whole, hale, sound
thren	thren	to count as stewardship, before the Mother
ledd	led	to reckon on a ledger. The commercial counterpart of *thren*.
orn	orn	land, ground, a holding
neth	neth	night; the long dark. Month-root.
eol	AY-ohl	a hinge; the year’s turning. Month-root, and the church-name of the First Cut: **Eoloren**.
bren	bren	hearth; the kept fire. Month-root.
lir	leer	thaw; water that runs again. Month-root.
sael	sayl	sowing; the first green. Month-root. Not *vael* (a gift) and not *hael* (wholeness).
ael	ayl	to air; to let feeling out. The Far-Voiced hall is the **ael-hall**.
stel	stel	to still; to hold from moving. The Stilled’s craft.
crae	kray	craft; the working of an element. The Answered shops as a sector.
hesk	hesk	far, outer edge. Frontier coinage, not in the old rite. Heskoren, Vaelhesk.

The Awakening Tree’s church-name is **Thaeloren** (THAEL-or-en). That is the Tree that witnesses. Everyday, people say **the Thallow**. A person belongs by being witnessed, and Thaeloren names that.

Vaethorn, Lestrand, and Threnmaieth are named by gluing two old words and wearing them down. Closer to the Tree, the old sound stays. Farther out, the *th* wears away:

- **Vaethorn** (VAETH-orn) is *vaeth* + *orn*. That is the Waiting Land. Careful writing and prayer keep the *th*. Everyday speech wears it to *t* and says **Wetorn**. People say the Waiting Lands, or the Waiting.
- **Lestrand** (LES-trand) is *ledd* + *strand*, worn smooth. That is the Reckoning Coast. It is the most worn of the three names. People say the Ledger Coast. Formal records keep *Lestrand*.
- **Threnmaieth** (THREN-mai-eth) is *thren* + *maieth*. That is the Mother's Reckoning. It keeps the full old sound. People say the Tallied Crown. The crown writes *Threnmaieth*.

Further from the Tree, the old words keep wearing down. In Trenledd, *thren* is worn down to *Tren*. In Maiethvael, *maieth* names the gift. On Heskoren, Vaelhesk is named from *vael* and Vaethorn is named from *vaeth*.

Faiths are named from the same blocks, so a faith sounds like the land that keeps it:

- **Haelthael** (HAEL-thael) is *hael* + *thael*. That is the Tree kept whole. The Watching keeps it as its own name. Its people are the Watchers.
- **Leddoren** (LEDD-or-en) is *ledd* + *oren*. That is the witnessed account. The Fair Hand keeps it as its own name. Its people are the Book-hands.
- **Vaeloren** (VAEL-or-en) is *vael* + *oren* in the older sense. That is the land's witnessing. The Old Ways keep it. Its people are the door-keepers and the Kin-speakers.
- **Ndeyaan** (ndey-AHN) is said in the Open Table's speech. That is the Open Table's own name. Its people are the table-keepers and the hill-hosts.

The church and guild names are settled, and no new ones are being made. These are the church-names in use:

Tree-wardens keep **Orenhael** (OREN-hael). That is witness and whole. Road-hands keep **Thaelvaeth** (THAEL-vaeth). That is the Tree gone to the waiting. Watchers keep **Nethoren** (NETH-or-en). That is night-witnesses. Book-hands keep **Leddhael** (LEDD-hael). That is the accounted-whole. Door-keepers keep **Vaelbren** (VAEL-bren). That is the yield-hearth. The table-keepers and the hill-hosts keep **Njaalo** (NJAH-lo). The shore-sitters keep **Njawaal** (njah-WAHL). Both names are Yumboe. The Slide keeps **Vaethledd** (VAETH-ledd). That is the waiting reckoned. Greens-keepers keep **Saelhael** (SAEL-hael). That is the sown-whole. Hall-keepers have no current liturgical form. *Aeloren* is retired. Stillers keep **Stelhael** (STEL-hael). That is the held-whole. The element-guilds keep **the Crae** (kray). That is craft. The Intake has no church-name.

Era-names come from the same old words. **Brenvaeth** (BREN-vaeth) is the Walking Years. **Eoloren** (EOL-or-en) is the First Cut. **Ornthael** (ORN-thael) is the Years of Hands. A road-house's cant is **brenhael** (BREN-hael). That is the hearth kept whole.

What Each Land Calls the Same Thing

Every land has the same institutions. They flow from the Trees and the Conditions. What each calls them shows how that land treats the Tree, the faith, and the roll.

Use the **common tongue** column unless you need the local word. Use the local word when a Vaethorn pilgrim, a Lestrand factor, or a Threnmaieth clerk is speaking, or when you want the table to hear the difference.

Citizenship and law

Thing	Common tongue	Vaethorn (devout)	Lestrand (secular)	Threnmaieth (surveillance)
proof-by-people (vouching)	**standing-for**	*the speaking* (vouched at worship)	*warranting* (a commercial guarantee)	*the naming* (you are named to the crown)
the safety-licence	**the ticket**	*the blessing-to-practice*	*the guild-ticket*	*the crown-warrant*
a census of persons	*(no common name; only two crowns keep one: Trenledd's **roll**, and Threnmaieth's Threnhael)*	*(none; the giving is the Mother's to know)*	*the roll* (a **tax** roll only, never of persons)	**the Threnhael** (THREN-hayl, "the whole-keeping")
the Inviolate Will	**"the will is one's own"**	*the Mother's own line* (held as scripture)	*the free-will clause* (sound commercial law)	*the crown's assurance* (cited to justify the roll)

Threnmaieth's census calls itself the **Threnhael**. That is *thren* + *hael*, the keeping-whole. It sounds like care. It is total surveillance. Its clerks say they keep the realm hale. Its subjects are kept whole. Outsiders hear "the Counting."

Tithe-provision

Thing	Common tongue	Vaethorn (devout)	Lestrand (secular)	Threnmaieth (surveillance)
venting-hall (Far-Voiced)	**the ael-hall** (AYL, “the airing”)	*the gift-hall*	*the release-house* (also the playhouse)	*the counted hall*
ranging-commons (Two-Bodied)	**the ranging**	*the wild-leave*	*the beast-yard* (a hired yard)	*the ranging-roll*
garden-commons (the Taken-In)	**the greens**	*the Mother’s green* (held in common)	*the leaf-lot* (rented by the season)	*the tended green* (crown-furnished)
endowed library (Long-Lived novelty)	**the long-house of books**	*the deathless gift*	*the endowment* / *the house*	*the crown archive*

The people

The three standing-terms keep their plain names **everywhere**: *the Given*, *the Struck*, *the Kept*. Each land’s second word is how it feels about them.

Common tongue	Vaethorn (devout)	Lestrand (secular)	Threnmaieth (surveillance)
the Given (a Condition Given)	*the gifted* (blessed)	*the Given* (plain)	*the marked* (on the roll)
the Struck (turned later, alone)	*the late-come* (met at a later door)	*the turned* (neutral, a fact)	*the unwitnessed* (suspect until named)
the Kept (untithed, whole)	*the Waited* / *Mother-kept* (pitied, passed over)	*the free* (their labor carries no Tithe)	*the unmarked* / *the passed-over* (noted as such)

The Kept are pitied in devout Vaethorn. They missed the gift. They are envied on mercantile Lestrand. They carry no Tithe and no guild, and they can go anywhere. Threnmaieth files them as unmarked. That is a gap in the roll to be explained.

Clergy

Thing	Common tongue	Vaethorn (devout)	Lestrand (secular)	Threnmaieth (surveillance)
the Motherfaith's working clergy	**tree-wardens** (church-name *Orenhael*)	*Hands-folk*	*tree-tenders*	*the Reckoned Hands*
the pilgrimage college	**the First Seat**	*the First Hand's college*	*the old seat* (a civic bureau)	*the Reckoned Seat* (the crown would file the college)
graft-carriers / sick-Tree circuit	**Road-hands** (church-name *Thaelvaeth*)	*the waiting-hands*	*the graft-carts*	*the counted road*
authorization to cut a scion	**Cutting-leave**	*the wood's blessing*	*the carrying-licence*	*the scion-warrant*
the Watching's people	**Watchers** (church-name *Nethoren*)	*the night-kin*	*vigil-folk* (rarely met)	*the second column*
the Fair Hand's people	**Book-hands** (church-name *Leddhael*)	*Bargainers' clerks*	*the Settling-hands*	*the Uncounted Book*
the Old Ways' people	**door-keepers** / **Kin-speakers** (church-name *Vaelbren*)	*the door-folk*	*grove-talkers*	*the Unreached*
the Open Table's people	**table-keepers** / **hill-hosts** (own *Njaalo*)	*(a sailor's tale)*	*the Moon-Feast people*	*(off the map)*
the Shore-Sitters (isle flavor)	**shore-sitters** (own *Njawaal*)	*(a sailor's tale)*	*(the wreck-waiters)*	*(off the map)*
the Slide (shadow house)	**the Slide** / **week-keepers** (cant *Vaethledd*)	*the last pot* / *gift-credit*	*week-rent*	*(the late week, unfiled)*

Tithe-infrastructure and tickets

Thing	Common tongue	Vaethorn (devout)	Lestrand (secular)	Threnmaieth (surveillance)
the official furnishing sector	**the furnishing** / **the greens and the halls**	*the gift-works*	*the provision*	*the counted channel*
greens-keepers	**greens-keepers** / **lot-keepers** (church-name *Saelhael*)	*Mother's-green hands*	*lot-keepers*	*the Tended*
hall-keepers	**hall-keepers** / **ael-hands** (*Aeloren* retired)	*gift-hall folk*	*release-hands*	*counted-hall clerks*
the Stillers	**stillers** (church-name *Stelhael*)	*blessing-surgeons*	*ticket-surgeons*	*crown-stillers*
the element-guilds	**the element-guilds** (umbrella *the Crae*)	*gift-shops*	*the craft-houses*	*the Reckoned Craes*
the Intake	**the Intake** / **the shed** (cant *catching-year*)	*the late-catching*	*the emergency ticket*	*the unwitnessed warrant*

Faiths

The common-tongue name is what a traveller says. The own-name is what the house says. The land's second word is how the state files them.

Faith	Common tongue	Own name	Vaethorn	Lestrand	Threnmaieth
the Leaf-Mother	the Motherfaith	*Maieth*	*the Mother* (said fervently)	*the old rite* (said lightly)	*the Reckoned Faith*
the Watching	the Watching	*Haelthael*	*the First Watching* (a related dissent)	*(rarely met)*	**the Grown-Over** (a column on the roll)
the Fair Hand	the Fair Hand	*Leddoren*	*the Bargainers* (held suspect)	*the Settling* (ordinary)	*the Uncounted Book* (private books offend the crown)
the Old Ways	the Old Ways	*Vaeloren*	*the Before-Faith* (an open quarrel)	*(a frontier curiosity)*	*the Unreached*
the Open Table	the Open Table	*Ndeyaan*	*(a sailor's tale)*	*the Moon-Feast* (quay-story)	*(beyond the crown's map)*

Eras and dating

Each land numbers the year from its own mark.

Thing	Common tongue	Vaethorn (devout)	Lestrand (secular)	Threnmaieth (surveillance)
the pilgrimage-required past	**the Walking Years** (church-name *Brenvaeth*)	*the old mile* / *the waiting-road*	*the road-years* (years of moving people and goods)	*the uncounted summers* (the crown would file those years)
the first successful town-graft	**the First Cut** (church-name *Eoloren*)	*the wood's blessing*	*the first carrying*	*the first warrant*
the still-moving spread of grafts	**the Grafting**	*her hands travelling*	*the carrying* (supply)	*the counted road* (they would number it)
the town-Tree present	**the Years of Hands** (church-name *Ornthael*)	*Since the Hands*	*since the local canopy*	*the Reckoned Hands-years*
a year's number	*(none universal)*	*the year our graft took*	*a house-year* / *a note-year*	*a Cut-year* (and a crown-count, later)

Before the Walk goes unnamed on the mainland roads. The Watching keep **the Before**. Kumbaan keeps moons.

The road

Lived names of the Walking Years. People say the common-tongue name.

Thing	Common tongue	Vaethorn (devout)	Lestrand (secular)	Threnmaieth (surveillance)
Maiethorn inland walk	**the Near Mile**	*the waiting-road* (they use this for all three)	*the inland days*	*the counted near-miles*
Strandoren sea-then-land walk	**the Salt Walk**	*the salt-waiting*	*the berth-road*	*the uncounted crossing*
Heskoren (and far-interior) walk	**the Long Mile**	*the old mile*	*the far road-years*	*the uncounted long-miles*
a deathless inn on the walk	**road-house** (cant *brenhael*)	*waiting-hearth*	*the bed-house* (also the word for the bank)	*(the crown would file the inn)*
a day's stone	**mile-shrine**	*ribbon-stone*	*the mile-mark*	*the unfiled stone*
the tenth-year week at the origin	**the one-week door**	*the only hug*	*the appointment*	*the uncounted week*

The three walks keep their common-tongue names. People say the Near Mile, the Salt Walk, and the Long Mile when they plan the road.

The Cut and the spread

Lived names of the First Cut. People say the common-tongue name. The nameless knife and the nameless green have no church-form. A church-name for the green would name a hearth, and a hearth would name a hand.

Thing	Common tongue	Vaethorn (devout)	Lestrand (secular)	Threnmaieth (surveillance)
folk object of the first taking	**the nameless knife**	*the mother's knife*	*the first theft*	*the first unfiled cut*
the first town-graft (unnamed)	**the nameless green**	*the wood's blessing* (they also use this for the Cut)	*the first carrying's ground*	*the first warrant-green*
Seat quarrel before the paper	**the generation of argument**	*the unblessed years*	*the first unlicensed carrying*	*the uncounted cuts*
Old Ways courtesy at a planting	**the first meal**	*(suspect: a guest-word)*	*(a frontier courtesy)*	*(unfiled)*

Residues

Lived names of the Years of Hands. People say the common-tongue name. The Years of Hands are the present.

Thing	Common tongue	Vaethorn (devout)	Lestrand (secular)	Threnmaieth (surveillance)
origin-walk you already have a Tree for	**the extra mile**	*the First Hand's hug*	*the First-Hand year*	*the counted pilgrimage*
walk because the Tree is missing, young, or sick	**the neighbour's week** (still *the old mile* when the neighbour is a continent)	*the waiting-road* (they use this for all walks)	*the borrowed week*	*the uncounted neighbour*
prestige origin-winter	**the First-Hand year**	*(suspect: a bought hug)*	*the First-Hand year* (plain)	*the counted winter*
mile-shrine now in a Hands square	**the stone in the square**	*the ribbon still*	*the old mile-mark*	*the unfiled stone*
unused pilgrim dorm	**the upper room**	*the waiting-beds*	*merchant-loft* (when let)	*the uncounted loft*
bed never let	**the Held bed**	*the kept-place*	*the unlet* (house custom)	*(the crown would file the bed)*

Book III

The Tree and the Faiths

The Turning Tree

A Turning Tree is a broad, slow, long-lived hardwood. Its canopy is like a great oak or beech, but it is its own kind. It stands at the ceremonial heart of a town, usually in a square, a green, or a walled temple-yard kept for it. Out of season it looks like an unusually grand old tree, and townsfolk treat it as one: children climb the low boughs, courts and markets convene in its shade, lovers leave the bark uncarved, and to cut a mark in it is taboo. In the tenth-year solstice week it turns. The canopy shifts through colours no ordinary tree wears, and a leaf falls for a child, or the leaves close around them.

People say **Turning Tree** for what it does at the solstice. It *turns*, and it *turns children into what they'll become*. The devout call each one **a Hand of the Mother**. In liturgy they call that wood **motherwood**. In the old liturgical tongue the Awakening Tree's own name is **Thaeloren** *(THAEL-or-en)*. *thael* is Tree and *oren* is to witness, and the name says the Tree witnesses. People shorten **Thaeloren** to **the Thallow**.

The Awakening Tree

There is one origin Tree: the **Awakening Tree**. It is the great, first Tree. People come to it on pilgrimage from across the world. It is old beyond reliable dating, and vast. The cuttings begin with it. Every other Turning Tree descends from it. Liturgy calls it **the First Hand**. Devout families make the journey to be Turned under the origin; some settle nearby. The faith's central clergy sit in its shadow. They are a college of tree-wardens, and the Trees are their work. People call them the **First Seat**. The Tree stands on Maiethorn, in the Sacred Core. The Sacred Core is the old country around that Tree.

Grafts

Every town Turning Tree is a living graft of the Awakening Tree. As towns take root, especially far-flung ones a family could never reach the origin from, someone cuts living wood from the Awakening Tree, carries it on the road, and joins it to the new town's square so it grows as the same plant. That is a **graft**. The piece kept alive on the road is a **scion**.

Everyday families walk to their town's Tree for the **Leaf-Fall**. That is the tenth-year solstice, and the leaves fall for the children. A family can keep the rite in its own town. That is the ordinary way in the Years of Hands. It was not always so. The truly faithful travel to the Awakening Tree itself to have a child Turned there or simply to stand under the origin. On Heskoren, and wherever a graft has failed, the walk is a necessity.

The faithful hold that because every scion is continuous tissue of the one Tree, “the Turning Trees are her hands” is literally true: when any town’s Tree chooses, it is the one power choosing through a grafted hand. Skeptics grant the grafting. They can see it. They hold that the act is the plant, doing what a plant does, and that the plant is the whole of it.

That graft is also a rite. Cutting a scion from the Awakening Tree (or, in practice, from an established healthy town Tree acting on the origin’s behalf) is done by the tree-wardens. The cutting is carried in living earth and planted with ceremony. That rite was captured, first as a heresy, then as a paper. That is the First Cut.

A young Tree can’t yet Turn. A freshly planted scion takes years, a generation by common reckoning, to mature enough to hold a Leaf-Fall. New towns lean on a neighbour’s Tree in the meantime; children travel to the nearest turning town. A younger town still says, “We Turned at Harrow’s Tree before we had our own.”

When Trees sicken and die

They are mortal wood, not indestructible. A blighted or dying Tree is a genuine civic crisis. A town may lose its ability to Turn its own children and fall back on pilgrimage or a neighbour. A dead Tree is replaced only by a fresh graft and the long wait. A mature Tree is hard to move once planted; the practice is to graft a new scion rather than transplant.

A town without a Tree is too new, too remote, or Tree-bereaved. That is the natural frontier condition. Such places send their ten-year-olds on the road to Turn, and the journey marks them as people of the frontier.

The Leaf-Fall

The Leaf-Fall is the rite the whole world is built around. It is held in **Turning-Week**. That week brackets the High Solstice of midsummer, when the Trees hold their colour and the leaves fall.

Every child who turns ten since the last solstice is brought by family. The town gathers as witness. A tree-warden officiates. That person tends that town’s Tree and says what the leaves did. The town’s own warden does it. The First Seat is present only in a pilgrimage week. It is at once a sacred rite and the town’s biggest festival of the year. People treat it as part christening, part graduation, part fair.

Children come to the Tree one at a time (or in the small cohort of a given year), stand within the canopy’s reach, and wait. The Tree turns and lets fall what it will. The rest of the town watches from the edge of the boughs.

Two outcomes:

- **A colour falls, and a Condition is Given.** One or more leaves of a telling colour drift down and settle on the child. The colour names the Condition. This is expected, “proper,” celebrated. The child grows up already knowing what they’ll become, and is trained and guilded toward it.
- **The leaves hug, no colour, and the child is Kept.** Instead of a coloured fall, the ordinary leaves *gather and wrap the child*, a green embrace with no naming colour. This marks one of **the Kept**. The child is kept whole, and wanted in their own right. The faith holds the hug as a chosen kindness. The schism argues over that reading.

The feel of the hour is a held breath, a whole town watching a single child, a parent who was themselves Given the same colour weeping when it falls again, or a parent who quietly hoped for the hug. The Leaf-Fall itself is warm, weighty, and communal. Most of what is frightening in this world comes later, from the **Tithe**, the upkeep every Condition must meet. The rite has a shadow too, and it is human: a wrong word, a missed week.

Turning-Week in a city

A Gift can still be given only in that **one week**. The Tree is still at the centre. A city of tens of thousands keeps that one Tree and that one week. It does not grow a second rite. The city splits the witnesses into hearths.

- **Stands are by hearth.** A quay-gang, a courtyard, a guild-stair: eighty to two hundred people who already know the child take a named slot of the week, morning, afternoon, or eve. The week-slate says which hearth stands at which bell. It is a festival schedule, like who has the square for the fair.
- **The warden says the colour or the hug aloud.** The colours are not written in a roll.
- **A crowd does not witness a child. A hearth does.** That is the legal fact. A Long-Lived, a Bound, or a Far-Voiced who stood there carries that memory when a distant office asks. That person is a pillar of the hearth.
- **Threnmaieth writes the stand down.** No one else does. A clerk who copies colours off a week-slate is starting a register of Conditions, which the hearths do not keep.

A village still watches as one circle.

Reading the colours

The colour that falls tells the town which Condition has been Given.

The core colour-meanings are folk-known. An ordinary townsperson can read the obvious ones. Everyone knows what the deep-red Long-Lived leaf or the storm-grey Two-Bodied fall looks like. The tree-wardens hold the authoritative reading, confirm it aloud at the ceremony, and handle the rare, subtle, or mixed falls: a colour few have seen, or a fall that could be read two ways. This gives the

wardens a civic job as well as a devout one. Someone has to say what the leaf meant, and people also pray at the Tree.

The Given-only Conditions have clear, well-known colours (they're only ever seen at the Tree). The Struck-capable Conditions (Far-Voiced, the Stilled, the Taken-In) *can* fall as colours too, which is why a Given Far-Voiced and a Struck Far-Voiced share a nature but not a story.

Leaf-colour	Condition	Who can read it
deep red / wine	Long-Lived	folk-known (already proverbial)
storm-grey	Two-Bodied	folk-known (already proverbial)
lamp-amber / brass	the Answered	folk-known
sea-blue	Far-Voiced	folk-known (a Given blue-leaf child is trained; a Struck Far-Voiced has no leaf at all)
pale stone / marble-white	the Stilled	folk-known, and feared. The warden says it carefully
copper-green / verdigris	the Taken-In	folk-known. This green is metallic, distinct from the Tree's own summer green and from the hug
white-fire / opal	Phoenix	clergy-known from texts. Almost no living town has seen it fall. A warden who names it at a ceremony has just made history (and a problem).

The Tree never Strikes. Struck comes later, by a threshold away from the Tree, so Returned and Bound have **no colour** (and the Unbound has none; it chains off Bound). The Kept hug is ordinary summer-green, *no naming colour*. That is why the Taken-In leaf must not be ordinary green.

Rare, mixed, or argumentative falls (two colours; a colour no one present has seen; a Phoenix-reading someone wants to be wrong) are why the tree-wardens are a civic office as well as a devout one.

A Tree never Strikes. The Tree only **Gives** or **Keeps**. The Struck arrive by a later threshold, a drowning, an oath, or a death survived. They happen *away* from the Tree, with no leaf and no ceremony. The faith's reading of the Struck, whether they're still the Mother's doing, is exactly the live schism.

Questions a warden gets asked

What a warden answers, when the week is already going wrong:

What they ask	What you say	What you do not
We missed the week. Fever, a shut pass, a boat that did not come.	They are **unTurned**. The child never stood. Their week for a Gift is over. Next summer they may visit the square; they do not stand for a Gift. A Struck threshold can still come later. The costly mercy is the old one: house a nine-year-old through the winter near a sound Tree.	Call them Kept. A Kept child was hugged while the town watched.
We will not stand. The Old Ways kept their own rites before the grafts arrived. The Isle keeps the Open Table as its own faith. Some refuse from fear, or from a quarrel.	The Tree does not chase them. Same legal result as a miss: **unTurned**, and the week for a Gift is over. A warden may ask once. They do not put a rope on a child to make a Gift.	Treat refusal as a failure of the wood.
Who brings an orphan?	The town is the family. Kin first; then the household that feeds them; then the **warden-hearth**. That is the warden's house on the square. An orphan who stands is witnessed like anyone. An orphan no one brings is a miss.	A second leaf as consolation.
An adult who never Turned.	They stay **unTurned**. They do not stand for a Gift at thirty. They can be vouched as the person the town raised. They can still be Struck. Some hearths file them as Kept to be kind. That kindness is sloppy law.	A late appointment.
Can they stand again? Wrong colour wanted. Hug regretted.	**No.** A completed standing — colour *or* hug, under a Tree the warden called sound — is once. You may correct a **Speaking**. That is the colour or the hug as the warden said it. You may not rerun a fall.	Offer a second Leaf-Fall. The wood has never answered one.
Our Tree is sick this week.	Do not stand them under unsound wood. Borrow a neighbour's canopy *this same week*. A warden who lets a cohort stand under a Tree they know cannot Turn has spent the week. Those children are unTurned.	Next year as a repair.
White-fire fell. Or someone wants to say it did.	A town-warden does not guess Phoenix. They send to the First Seat by runner. Naming	Guess from a book in the square.

What they ask	What you say	What you do not
	white-fire is history, and a problem.	
A child of the Open Table, from the Isle. A Yumboe from that isle, under our boughs.	If they stand in their tenth-year week, the Tree does what it does. If the host will not bring them, the week can end. No warden is sent to Kumbaan to fetch a child. Kumbaan is the storm-walled isle.	Wait for the argument to finish. The week does not wait.
The city cannot know every child.	They stand **by hearth**, in named slots. The square is full. The memory is the street that brought them, plus one pillar who can carry it. The colours stay unwritten.	A city register.

When the leaves hugged and the town watched, that child is Kept. When the child never stood, that child is unTurned. Both lives can look the same: no Tithe to meet, and no guild. Of those two lives, only the hug was witnessed at the Tree. Citizenship still runs on who saw you. An unTurned neighbour is vouched as the child the town raised.

A miss, a refusal, or a week spent under unsound wood leaves a child unTurned. Struck remains the later mercy.

The Leaf-Mother

Some hold that the **Leaf-Mother** blessed the world with the Conditions, and that the Turning Trees are her hands reaching down to choose. Each **Leaf-Fall** is, in this belief, an act of a mother's love. That is the tenth-year solstice, when a leaf falls or the leaves hug a child. Many people hold this. Skeptics hold otherwise, and they mean it. They are full members of society, and the faith keeps a place for them. Everyday people call the faith **the Motherfaith**. The faith calls itself **Maieth**.

A gift-religion

The faith begins from the Conditions the world received, and from the gifts that still come at each solstice. Its long question is how a person lives worthy of a gift.

The rite counts ahead of the creed. What makes you of the Motherfaith is what you **do**. You bring your children to the Tree, you tend your **Tithe** honestly, and you keep the festival. A Condition must meet that upkeep. That counts far more than what you privately believe about who does the choosing. You belong by the rite you keep. This is why a devout believer and a quiet skeptic can stand at the same Leaf-Fall and both belong. The practice is binding. Belief is argued about.

The faithful speak of a mother. They call her benevolent, attentive, generous, and quiet. They say she gives and watches, and that she does not command them. For them, you worship by not wasting what she hands you. People do not come to her in fear.

The Motherfaith is the dominant faith in the Turning lands. Other religions are lived beside it. To the people who hold her, she is their Mother.

The houses share no picture of her. The picture is the wood. A pressed leaf kept in a chest is common, and it is only a leaf. Some hearths keep no image at all. The faith does not picture her at a drowning, at an oath, or in the deep wild, because it argues about whether she is there.

Doctrine (as the faithful hold it)

The Giving. In the beginning, the faithful say, a person was only what they were born. They say that was their Kind, and nothing more. They say her gift was **becoming**, and that a person could be given something beyond birth, a Condition the world would need. They say she first reached down at the Awakening Tree. Someone plants a cutting of that Tree in new ground. That is a **graft**, and every town Tree is one. The faithful call each one a Hand of the Mother, so that no child is too far for her to reach.

She chooses, and she chooses well. Doctrine holds that the colour a child receives is *chosen*. They say it was looked-at, intended, and fitted to the child and to the town's need. The gifts "fit too well" to be accident (believers point to this; skeptics call it hindsight).

The Tithe is the weight of a gift. Every Condition costs upkeep. The faith reads a real gift as a real charge to carry, and it reads tending that charge as the ordinary devotion of a lifetime. The faith's nearest thing to a first commandment is the line, "Tend what you're given."

The Kept are given wholeness. Doctrine calls a Kept child a gift of being left whole. The leaves hugged that child and gave no colour. This is the question the schism argues hardest.

People meet her, the faithful say, at the Tree, in the turning of a life, and in the fittingness of things. They say she is quiet, and that she is not summoned. Doctrine calls that quietness intended. They say a mother lets her children live. That quiet leaves room for honest doubt.

Practice

- **The Leaf-Fall.** A child comes for the tenth-year solstice Turning. People keep that rite as sacrament, coming-of-age, and the town's great festival.
- **The Tending.** You keep paying your Tithe well, in private. The faith says that to tend your Condition honestly is to honour the gift. A Two-Bodied person works in their second body. A Long-Lived person keeps their vigils. The faith calls that life worship, lived as the upkeep itself.
- **The Turning-week festival.** In the solstice week around the Leaf-Falls, towns hold markets and feasts, families reunite, and people name the year's new Given and new Kept. A colour fell on the new Given. The leaves hugged the new Kept. It is the emotional high point of the calendar.
- **Threshold rites for the Struck.** The Struck receive a Condition away from the Tree, so the faith has grown quiet rites to receive them back. A Struck person is brought to the Tree after the fact, to be **acknowledged** and folded into the community of the Given. The Tree does not Strike, so this is not a Turning. How warmly this is done is itself contested.
- **Tree-tending.** People water the town's Turning Tree, ward it against blight, and plant a new living cutting. That cutting is a **scion**. The **tree-wardens** do this civic and sacred work. They tend the town's Tree.

The town keeps the **warden-hearth**. That is the warden's house on the square. During Turning-Week the warden is fed from the festival, the way the town feeds any office it needs that week. Someone on **Cutting-leave** takes a cutting, and the leave carries a fee. The Seat describes that fee as the cost of carrying-earth. The cutting travels in that living soil. Pilgrimage supports the First Seat. The tree-wardens tend the Trees. The halls that help people meet a Tithe are other people's work.

The live schism

The faith holds more than one reading. The central argument is sincere on every side, and no one has settled it. That open argument is why the faith endures. It turns on three questions the doctrine does not prove.

1. The Kept: spared, or slighted? If the Mother blesses everyone, why does the Tree hug so many children and give them no colour at all?

- **The Tender reading** is the majority, and the faith's usual teaching. The Kept are given wholeness, a real gift, chosen for them. To be Kept is to be trusted to need nothing added.
- **The Wanting reading** is the minority. The Kept were passed over, loved, but not chosen, and the doctrine of "wholeness" is a kindness the faithful tell them. This reading quietly stings, and shapes how some Kept feel about the festival.

2. The Struck: still hers, or not? The Struck receive a Condition the Tree never handed out. Did the Mother reach through the threshold too, or did *something else* give the gift?

- **The Wide-Hand reading:** she meets people at the drowning, the oath, and the death. The Tree is only her *ordinary* hand. The Struck are fully hers.
- **The Narrow-Hand reading:** she gives only at the Tree. The Struck received their Condition by *some other means*, which is why the Struck are "a little suspect." This reading is the seed of real social friction toward the Struck.

3. Does a mind choose at all? This question is the line between believer and skeptic.

- **Believers:** the fittingness of the gifts, the care of the Kept, the way the Struck feel *received*. These add up to a Someone.
- **Skeptics** say, "It's just what the Trees do." They mean biology, or a phenomenon so old it wears a face people gave it. They can see the grafting. A choosing mind is an inference they decline to make.

Because you belong by the rite you keep, a skeptic who tends their Tithe and brings their children to the Tree is a good member of the Motherfaith. Belief in the Mother is honoured, and no one is made to hold it. A skeptic may speak their doubt and remain that member.

Each branch is held in good faith. No house is a villain. Being a skeptic costs nothing day to day, because the practice is what binds. The questions stay open because no one in the square can close them.

Two sayings

The Tender's blessing, spoken over each child at the Leaf-Fall:

> *"What falls to you, wear well. What is kept from you, keep. The Hand that reaches is the Mother's own, and the Mother does not reach twice by chance."*

The blessing comforts the child, and it says to tend the gift. Believers hear intent in it. Skeptics hear a proverb about not asking the wood twice. Both can say the words.

A Kept-child's saying (folk, half-consoling, half-barbed):

> *"The Tree that gives to all its neighbours held me instead. I have decided that is not the same as being forgotten."*

The saying takes the Tender reading of the Kept and makes it personal, and a little defiant. The words "I have decided" are a choice the speaker makes while the doubt is still there.

The Five Faiths

The Motherfaith is the dominant faith of the Turning lands. Five lived faiths each answer a different experience the Trees, or their absence, actually produce.

Faith	Home	A Condition is…	Everyday name	Own name
the Leaf-Mother	everywhere the Trees stand; born on Maiethorn	a **gift chosen**	the Motherfaith	*Maieth*
the Watching	Maiethorn's oldest districts	a **seeing**, later named a gift	the Watching	*Haelthael*
the Fair Hand	Strandoren's ports and houses	a **bargain struck**	the Fair Hand	*Leddoren*
the Old Ways	Heskoren's groves and doors	the **land making its own**	the Old Ways	*Vaeloren*
the Open Table	Kumbaan, the Sundering Isle	a mainland hunger **they never had**	the Open Table	*Ndeyaan*

The Watching, the Fair Hand, and the Old Ways live where the Trees stand. The Open Table grew on Kumbaan with no Tree and no Mother-name.

Smaller household rites, quay-charms, and Kind-customs stay local. The clergy are the tree-wardens, who keep the Motherfaith at the Tree; the Watchers, who keep the vigil; the Book-Hands, who witness a signing; the Door-Keepers, who walk the rivers, stones, and groves; the Table-Keepers, who keep the supper; and the Shore-Sitters of the isle, who wait on the storm-beach.

The argument (what a becoming *is*)

Every faith in this world has to answer the same fact: most people *become* something they were not born as. They do not agree on what that becoming is.

- **Given.** The Motherfaith says *chosen*. The Watching says *seen*. The Fair Hand says *signed*. The Old Ways say the Tree is a *late guest* at a door the land already kept.

- **Struck.** The Motherfaith argues whether she reached the threshold. The Watching says the threshold was always a place of seeing. The Fair Hand says a later contract, struck in extremity. The Old Ways say this is the *oldest* becoming. That is the land's own children.
- **Kept.** The same hug. The Motherfaith calls it a gift of wholeness, or being passed over. The Watching calls it a seeing. The Fair Hand says no bargain was taken. The Old Ways say the land had no door for you that year.
- **Tithe.** The same upkeep. The Motherfaith calls it the honest weight of a gift. The Watching calls it the cost someone once paid. The Fair Hand calls it the term of the contract. The Old Ways call it the land's due.

Each of these is a sincere answer to something people live with. The Motherfaith answers gifts that fit. The Watching answers a reach that runs thin at the edge. The Fair Hand answers the Bound's written terms. The Old Ways answer the Struck who change with no Tree nearby. The Open Table answers a whole isle that never Turned. Dual practice is common.

How they live together

People belong by the rite they keep. The creed can wait. Because the Motherfaith counts you by what you *do* at the Tree, a Watcher who brings their child, a Settler of the Fair Hand who stands as witness to the colour, and a Kin-speaker of the Old Ways who also walks the rivers, hills, and stones can all belong at the same Leaf-Fall. Doctrine fights. The festival usually does not.

Each fight stays in its own land.

- **Maiethorn.** The fight is at the centre. The Watching and the Motherfaith share the same Trees and argue over the blessing spoken there. Threnmaieth files Watchers on the Threnhael as a known, counted dissent. That is its census. The file calls that dissent the Grown-Over. The pressure is that file.
- **Strandoren.** Faith is practiced lightly, so the fight is over the Bound and the books. The Fair Hand and the Motherfaith compete for the same oath-keepers in the same port. Lestrand prices both and polices neither.
- **Heskoren.** The fight is over the grove. The Old Ways were there before the grafts. The Motherfaith is fiercest where the gift is scarcest. A dying Tree has two claimants. Vaethorn's piety makes this tender and sharp.
- **The Sundering Isle.** Almost no contact. A Yumboe on the mainland is a guest at everyone else's rite. They keep their supper, and the mainland's daylight rites sound loud to them. The quarrel is already in the port: a host counts a guest as family after two suppers, a clerk wants to know where the person was Turned, and a host will not spend a child's tenth-year week on a Tree.

Mixed practice, most years:

Pair	The common blend	The hard edge
Motherfaith + Watching	Same Tree, two blessings; families inherit which words they use	Threnmaieth's roll asks for one name for what you are
Motherfaith + Fair Hand	Leaf-Fall as festival *and* signing-watch; Tithe paid as both tending and settling	The Motherfaith calls it a gift and the Fair Hand calls it a debt, for the same Bound person
Motherfaith + Old Ways	Pilgrimage to a graft *and* threshold-walking the old doors	Who tends a sickening Tree: warden or door-keeper
Any mainland + Open Table	A rare shared supper; someone says "no one is a stranger twice"	On the mainland a person belongs because a town watched them Turn. The Open Table says a person belongs after two suppers. A child of the table who reaches Turning-Week in Eolthael is the hard case

All five houses tell the Child at Four Doors, and the last line changes. That is how the world argues without a council.

The Leaf-Mother remains a *belief* in public life. The other faiths stay beliefs. The Watching says it remembers a cost. That claim stays unsettled in public.

The Watching

The Watching is Maiethorn's heartland heresy. It is an older Tree-faith the Motherfaith grew over, at the centre. They keep the Tree and refuse the Mother-name. They say the colours fall because the Tree sees.

A neighbour says **the Watching**. The house says **Haelthael** (*HAEL-thael*). That is *hael* + *thael*, the Tree kept whole. They mean the Tree before anyone split it into a Mother and her hands. The Motherfaith says **the First Watching**. Threnmaieth's file says **the Grown-Over**.

Shape of the faith

- **The Tree looks.** A colour is a seeing made visible. To live well is to name what was seen.

- **Their practice is older than the Motherfaith's.** They stand at the same Leaf-Fall. They keep their own words when the warden says the Tender's blessing. That is the warden's line over the child. Practice binds them to the town. The withheld word is the whole dissent.
- **The Tree is the Tree.** They give it no mother, no bargain-partner, and no land-spirit in a new dress. Naming it *Maieth* is, to them, the overlay. That is a comfort the heartland invented when the seeing needed a face.
- **You know them by the name they keep.** They keep **Thaeloren**. That is the Tree that witnesses. They refuse **Hand of the Mother**. Same wood. The title is the schism.

Doctrine (as believed)

The Before. In the beginning the world was Kind and Kind alone. This they share with the Motherfaith. Then the Tree was already there, watching. The Giving came *after* the Watching. The Mother-name came after that. Each layer is a story laid over a seeing.

They say "she chooses well" is a later sentence. Fittingness, they say, is what a witness produces: the Tree sees what you can carry and what the town will need, and the leaf matches the seeing. They call that intent, and they do not call it a mother's. The skeptics of the Motherfaith are, to a Watcher, almost right, and still too quick to call the Tree a phenomenon with no mind. The Watchers say there is a mind, and that it does not comfort you the way a mother would.

The cost is remembered. Haelthael teaching holds that the Giving was not free. Something was spent, someone was lessened; the Tree (or whatever stands behind it) does not reach twice by chance because *reaching costs*. They will not name a Mother who pretends otherwise. What the cost *was* they will not agree on. They agree it was real.

The Kept were seen. A hug and no colour is a seeing of wholeness, or a seeing that did not reach. They argue this as fiercely as the Motherfaith does, without a mother's comfort. They say the hug is a witness.

The Struck were seen at a harder door. A drowning, an oath, a death: the Tree is the ordinary place of seeing; the threshold is an older one. The Watching leaves the Motherfaith's Wide-Hand and Narrow-Hand readings with the Motherfaith. Those are a wide reach and a narrow one. Seeing, they say, was never confined to a grafted scion.

Practice

- **The Night Watch.** The night before Turning-Week, Watchers keep a silent vigil at the town Tree. They speak no blessing and read no colour. They keep watch on the Tree all night, as they believe it watches the town.

- **The withheld blessing.** They attend the Leaf-Fall, and their children Turn. When the warden says the Tender's line, a Watcher household speaks their own, quietly:

> *"What falls, was seen. What is kept, was seen. The Tree does not reach twice by chance."*

The cadence matches the Motherfaith's blessing. The line names the Tree and the seeing. Towns that have lived together a long time barely notice the difference. Threnmaieth notices.
- **Name what you saw.** After a Turning, a Watcher sits with the child and describes the fall: the colour, the way the leaf came, what the year will ask. Devotion is accurate speech. The warden's line, "tend what you're given," is the one they leave unspoken.
- **Pre-Mother names.** In Haelthael liturgy the origin Tree is only **Thaeloren**. "First Hand" is tolerated as poetry. "Hand of the Mother" is the overlay they will not say.

Watchers keep the Night Watch, teach the withheld blessing, and (where a town will have it) offer a second reading of a rare or mixed fall. The reading sits beside the tree-warden's, and the tree-warden's reading stays the town's. In Threnmaieth they are a known column on the roll. Anyone of the Watching may keep the Night Watch. The second reading is a reputation. That is the person a town asks to sit beside the warden.

The Watching has no seat in the Awakening Tree's shadow. That seat was grown-over by the First Seat. Their oldest rooms are under older chapels, or in houses that never took a warden's blessing on the door. The Watching keeps no offices beyond the Night Watch and the withheld blessing.

The live schism

1. **The Masked.** The Mother is a later face the Witness learned to wear, or a name people needed, and the Tree allowed. Almost Motherfaith; common in mixed families. A Masked Watcher will stand for the Tender's blessing and add the withheld line under it.
2. **The Bare Tree.** There was never a she. The overlay is a comfort the heartland invented, and they say comfort is a different thing from truth. Harder, smaller, the ones Threnmaieth files most carefully.
3. **What was spent?** Both branches agree the Giving cost. They do not agree *what*: a wound in the Tree, a year the watching failed, a someone who became the wood. This is the question they will not close. It is also the one the Motherfaith most wants left unasked.

An inscription on a door-beam

The inscription was recut, and found when a warden-chapel on Maiethorn was re-floored. The new beam faces the Tree; this face was turned to the stone.

> *We kept the watch before the name. The wood was already looking. If a mother came after, she came to a work begun. Do not thank the latecomer for the seeing.*

It reads as heresy, stubborn and local. It claims that the Tree is older than the Mother-name.

The Fair Hand

Strandoren's fortune-and-contract faith reads Conditions not as gifts given but as **bargains struck**. The world is a ledger of deals; the Tithe is a *term*, not a devotion; when the book is closed you are *even*, and owe no gratitude forever. It is the direct doctrinal rival to the Motherfaith's gift-language, at home on the trade continent and especially among the Bound.

A neighbour says **the Fair Hand**. The house says **Leddoren** (*LEDD-or-en*). That is *ledd* + *oren*, the witnessed account. Lestrand says **the Settling**. The Motherfaith says **the Bargainers.** A Bound who has paid their year's Terms will say they have **a closed book**.

Shape of the faith

- **Fair terms.** Know what you owe, pay it, walk. A gift you cannot put down is, to them, an imposition. No one here is being saved from a fall.
- **The book is the practice.** What makes you of the Fair Hand is that you keep accounts honestly: Tithe, contract, witness. Many Settlers still bring a child to the Tree. They attend as witnesses to a signing.
- **A counterparty, or none.** The faith splits on whether anyone sits across the table. They call the other party to the deal a counterparty. Both branches agree the table is real. The Leaf-Mother, if she exists, is a giver who will not show her terms, which, to a Settler, is the one unforgivable clause.
- **You know them by a small personal book,** in which a Settler writes colour, Tithe, and what they are owed. Threnmaieth's census is a different book, and the Fair Hand calls that census a sin. The Bound did not invent the personal book. They are the ones whose book is also a contract.

Doctrine (as believed)

Nothing is given. The Leaf-Fall is a *striking of terms*. The colour is the grant; the Tithe is the price; the town's need is the other side of the deal. "Tend what you're given" is how a creditor teaches you to be grateful for the interest.

The Bound prove the model. A Bound chose, named a grant, named Terms, named a Pledge. The Fair Hand says a Bound's bargain is every becoming, written large enough to read. The Motherfaith's fear of the Bound is, to them, embarrassment: the Bound make the ledger visible.

The Kept declined, or were not offered. No bargain taken; nothing owed; nothing owed to them. On Lestrand this sits beside calling the Kept *the free*. The Fair Hand gave that word a theology.

The Struck signed later, in a storm. Extremity is when people accept bad terms. A drowning, an oath, a death: of course the book opens then. The Struck are not suspects; they are people who bargained without a clerk. The faith's kindness is to *settle the year fairly* after the fact, by a hall or a warrant. That vouching remakes the year as a new agreement. A clerk says novation. A Bound's *Terms* are the exception. Those belong to the Counterparty, not to a clerk. Its cruelty is the same motion. A Struck who cannot settle fades, and the quay steps around them.

Grace is a closed book. The Fair Hand says: you paid, you are even, walk.

Practice

- **The signing-watch.** Settlers attend the Leaf-Fall as witnesses. They leave the Tender's blessing to the warden. They speak, if they speak:

  > *"Grant and term, seen and spoken. The book is open. Keep it fair."*

- **Public settling.** Tithe paid where a neighbour can see it. They call that clearing. A Bound's oath-day is the high holy day. The Terms are recited, and the year's book is closed or marked owing. The Motherfaith calls this showing off. The Fair Hand calls it the only honest worship.
- **Quay-blessings.** Short, worn, in the eroded tongue. A Settler says "fair wind, fair term" over a hull, a contract, a marriage. The sacred and the commercial use the same sentence, and that is the teaching.
- **The personal book.** Colour, Tithe, debts, what the year owes you. It stays private. A Settler will die to keep a crown-clerk out of it. That fury they share with every other faith on the subject.

Book-hands are notaries who are also theologians. Neighbours also call them Settlers. They witness signings, teach children how to keep a book, and settle a Struck's *civic* year by a hall or a warrant. They recite a Bound's Terms on oath-day. They do not rewrite those Terms. The Terms are the Counterparty's clause, not a clerk's. On Lestrand they are often the same people as commercial clerks. The faith is the profession, held lightly.

The Fair Hand meets in guild-rooms and quay-shrines. A "high house" in a rich port is the oldest book-room. They keep no membership roll. A roll would be a Threnhael.

The live schism

1. **The Counterparty.** Something sits across the table: a mind, a power, a hand that is fair rather than mothering. The Bound's unknown is this branch's whole theology. They call it **the other hand**. Her terms, they say, are hidden, so the name is not Mother. The Motherfaith's scare-word is demon, and they leave that word unused.
2. **The Book Alone.** The world is the ledger. No one is across the table. This branch shares the Motherfaith skeptics' doubt that anyone is there, and it lives easily on Lestrand. Practice is identical. The argument is whether gratitude has an address.

Both branches agree that *hidden terms* are the sin. That is why they cannot join the Motherfaith even when they share a festival: "the Mother does not reach twice by chance" is, to them, a clause with no number on it.

From a Bound's working contract

The form-words a Lestrand book-hand uses when the grant is ordinary and the Terms are not:

> *I was not given. I asked, and I was answered, and I named what I would pay. If a mother had wanted me she would have sent a leaf, not a clause. I prefer the clause. I can read it.*

The words are a Bound's pride, a little cold. They make the Fair Hand's whole case against gift-doctrine. The Bound who prefers the clause is sincere. They have felt the cost and named it a price.

The Old Ways

The Old Ways are the ancestor-and-land faith of Heskoren. The faith predates the grafts. It says the Mother's reach is new here, and the land was already making children of its own, the Struck, the Taken-In, at rivers, drowning-pools, oath-stones, and groves. The Trees are *guests*, not the source.

A neighbour says **the Old Ways**. That is also the house's common name. The rite writes **Vaeloren** (*VAEL-or-en*). That is *vael + oren*. They use **vael** in an older sense. That is not "a Condition Given", but **what the land yields**. The Motherfaith, they say, *narrowed* the word to a leaf-colour. Vaethorn-pious speech calls them **the Before-Faith**. The Taken-In among them say **the Green Kin**.

Shape of the faith

- **Place makes people.** A river that has drowned and returned, a hill that took someone in, an oath-stone that heard a vow: these are **the old doors**. The grafted Tree is a new door, welcome if it behaves.
- **You keep the Old Ways by walking.** Go to the doors, feed the kin who stayed, and stand for the Struck when a town will not. Belief about the Mother comes second. Many Kin-speakers also bring a child to a healthy graft when they can reach one.
- **The land is many, and the dead stay.** Hills, waters, old trees, and the people who went into them. The old trees are the wild kin of motherwood. The grafts are the planted Trees. The Returned come through a different door. Ancestors, here, are kin who remained in the ground.
- **You know them by a worn token from their door:** a river-stone, grove-twig, or pinch of hill, carried the way a Settler carries a book. No two look alike. The mismatch is the teaching: no two doors are the same.

Doctrine (as believed)

The land was first. Before grafts, before pilgrimage, Heskoren's people already became things. The Struck are the oldest rite, the land doing what the land does. The Taken-In are the grove's own children.

Vael meant yield. Grain, game, a child returned from water, a person the hill kept. The Motherfaith's *vael* is a *special case* they mistook for the whole word. That is a Given Condition. To call a leaf a *vael* is fine. To say only a leaf is a *vael* is a theft of speech.

Grafts are guests. A healthy Tree is a new kin-house. You may tend it. You may Turn under it. You may not pretend it invented becoming, or that a town without one is empty of the sacred. A sickening Tree is a guest who is dying in your grove. The fight with the tree-wardens is *who is host*.

The Kept are a year the land had no door. Some years a door does not open for you. You are still the land's. Next year, or the drowning-year, or never. The waiting that Vaethorn sanctifies as pilgrimage is, here, just weather.

The Mother is a late name. Either the land wearing a face the newcomers needed, or a claiming. The first is the Guest-reading. The second is the First-reading. Both agree she did not *arrive first*.

Practice

- **Threshold-walking.** At the year's hinges, and not only High Solstice, people walk the old doors of their district. You greet the water, the hill, the stone. You leave food. You do not ask for a colour. You ask to be *known*.

- **Ancestor-meals.** A place at the board for the ones in the ground. Quiet, domestic, easy to miss as religion if you came from Maiethorn looking for a chapel. The courtesy is the rite.
- **Standing for the Struck.** When a person changes later and alone, the Old Ways do not take them to a Tree to be *acknowledged as Given*. They take them back to the door that made them, if it can be found, and *name them kin*. The Motherfaith's quiet receiving-rite and this one sometimes happen in the same week, for the same person, and the argument is which name goes first.
- **The contested grove.** An ailing graft in an old Taken-In green is the fight everyone knows: warden against door-keeper, guest against host, pilgrimage-scarcity against "we had ways." Neighbours who both love the wood.

Door-keepers know which doors still open. Neighbours also call them Kin-speakers. They speak at ancestor-meals. They stand for the unvouched Struck when they can. Their standing is a reputation. A famous door-keeper is the one three valleys will walk to. The two jobs often belong to the same person.

The land is the seat. Vaethorn's tree-wardens find this infuriating and, in a dry year, quietly useful. Door-keepers walk the doors. A scion is not theirs to carry.

The live schism

1. **The Guest-reading.** The Mother is the land in a new dress. Grafts are kin. Common in Vaethorn towns that finally got a Tree and did not want to throw their grandparents out of the rite. They will pilgrimage *and* walk the doors.
2. **The First-reading.** The grafts are a claiming. The old doors were enough. Harder, thinner-reach districts, the ones still waiting on a scion that will not take. They will tend a dying graft as a *guest in their house* and still refuse the Tender's blessing.

Both branches revere the Struck and the Taken-In. That courtesy is what the faith stands on. A reading that started pitying them as "unreached" has already become Motherfaith.

Said at a drowning-stone

On Heskoren's wet margin, the year after a graft sickened and a child came back from the river Changed:

> *The tree is young. The water is not. If a mother sent the water she sent it before she sent the leaf, and she has not told the wardens. We will feed both. We will not let either pretend it was first.*

The words are frontier courtesy, with a barb. They make the Old Ways' case. This telling says becoming happens at doors where there is no healthy Tree.

The Open Table

Kumbaan's isolate faith grew with no Tree and no Mother-name. The good people keep the night, set a place for hands that have no bodies, and hold that a stranger at the table is the holiest thing in the world.

On the mainland a neighbour says **the Open Table**. A sailor says **the Moon-Feast**. The house says **Ndeyaan** (*ndey-AHN*). That is the night-keeping. In full courtesy they say **Bakhna Ndeya**. That is the good night. The opening of every meal that matters is already their creed. Someone at the table says "No one is a stranger twice."

Shape of the faith

- **The table is the founding fact.** To feed and be fed is how the living sit with the staying-kin and with anyone the storm-wall did not keep out. There is no Leaf-Fall because, they say, there was nothing missing to give.
- **The rite is the meal.** Ndeyaan has almost no clergy and no chapel. The rite is supper under the moon, a place set for hands you can see and for a body you cannot see, daylight reserved for sleep. A Yumboe who keeps this on the mainland is still of the Open Table. A mainlander who sits once is a guest; one who sits twice is kin.
- **The hill, the moon, the ones who stayed.** The dead do not leave; they stay as hands. Whether those hands are the dead or the hill's own courtesy is the house-argument. The dead are the Staying. The hill's own courtesy is the Serving. The good people are a living Kind. The idiom is ancestral. The bodies are warm.
- **You know them by an extra place laid,** even when the household is poor. The unseen hands make this possible. The extra place is furniture.

Doctrine (as believed)

Wholeness is the default. The mainland invented a hunger and called it a gift. On Kumbaan you are born Yumboe and that is enough. If the good people become anything else, they do not become it at a Tree (there is none). How that happens stays in the family, and they are not in a hurry.

The dead stay to serve. Folklore on the mainland calls Yumboes spirits of the dead. They find this rude. In their telling, the hands are the staying-kin. The living host. The staying pour. A feast that

outshines its means is a theological statement. The household is larger than the bodies you can count.

The moon wakes both. Night is the shared day of the living and the staying. Daylight is a Sabbath of sleep. That is a rest-day. They call the mainland's daylight faiths loud, as they would call a guest loud who will not sit.

A stranger is the sacrament. The storm-wall keeps the world out. Anyone who crosses it has already been through drowning-water. You feed them. The second supper is the rite of belonging. This is why a lone Yumboe on Strandoren becomes a host wherever they land: they are still keeping Ndeyaan, with whatever table they can make.

The Mother is a story about a quiet table, told too loud. They do not hate her. They have never met her. They do not understand why a people would need to be *chosen* in order to be wanted.

Practice

- **The moon-feast.** The ordinary high rite is night, a hill-hall or open turf, the extra place, and the unseen hands fetching and pouring. Songs. No colour-reading. No terms recited.
- **The place set.** Even a poor house lays it. To omit it is the one real impiety: not because the staying starve (they do not), but because you have counted the household too small.
- **No one is a stranger twice.** Spoken at the second sitting. The first night you are a guest, and a guest is already sacred. The second, you are of the table. On Kumbaan the sentence decides belonging. It is spoken, and it is not written down.
- **Daylight sleep.** Daylight is when the good people and the staying-kin rest. A Yumboe abroad still takes their long rest when the moon is down, if they can, and they keep that rest quiet.

Table-keepers are the person whose hall the valley comes to on the bright nights. Neighbours also call them hill-hosts. The standing is a reputation. Their job is to keep the table.

Shore-sitters are the other isle job. Neighbours also call them wall-waiters. They sit the storm-beach and wait. Swimming out is outside the job. The living go uphill to a table.

A Yumboe abroad is a table-keeper by necessity. One person can keep Ndeyaan in a Lestrand attic. That is how the faith travels, when it travels at all. Whoever will lay the extra place can keep it. Kumbaan sends no mission.

The live schism

1. **The Staying.** The unseen hands are the dead: grandparents, the drowned, the ones the hill kept. Ancestral-literal. Older tellings; still common in deep-hill halls. The dead are family who took the serving-work.

2. **The Serving.** The hands are the hill's own courtesy, the good people's oldest wonder, not a roster of names. Gentler, majority in the surface-facing halls, easier to explain to a mainland guest who has gone pale.

Both branches set the extra place. A Serving host who will not say the dead's names and a Staying host who will not stop saying them will still pass the same cup. The argument is for after the dishes.

Two suppers, or a Turning-witness

On Kumbaan, *no one is a stranger twice* is how you belong. On the mainland, you belong because a town watched you Turn. A host counts a guest as family after two suppers. A town clerk wants to know where the person was Turned.

This is the faith's edge on the mainland. It does not need a mission, and it does not need a chapel on Strandoren. It needs a room, a tenth year, and a clerk who counts belonging a different way.

The everyday collision. That is citizenship. A guest sits a second night in a Lestrand attic. The host says the sentence and means it. A quay clerk, a Book-hand, or a warden passing through asks for a Turning-witness before treating that person as of a place. Inside the room, the person is kin. Outside the door, the person is a guest. Neither office is cruel. The sentence does not mean the same thing outside the room.

The week that can close. A child of the table — isle-raised, convert-raised, a sailor's tenth summer in a port — reaches Turning-Week. The host will not walk them to a Turning Tree. In the host's telling, they were never lacking. A neighbour or a town-warden will. The Given-door is **one week**. If the argument outlasts Eolthael, the child is unTurned. Eolthael is the Turning-month. Struck doors still open later. The host did not ask for that comfort. The warden cannot file it as kindness.

This is not a crusade on Kumbaan. The child is already on the mainland. The storm-wall stayed where it was.

When a tenth year is in the house, the extra place is set slightly back, and the host says the sentence or refuses to take the child down to the Tree in the morning. A warden, a clerk, or a neighbour is in the street with a list of this year's children. In Hale-month it is manners. In Eolthael it is a child's life.

Mbela *(MBEH-lah)* keeps an attic off a Lestrand salt-stair and will not spend a child's week on a colour. **Sorel** of the quay will not file a second supper as belonging, and will walk a tenth-year neighbour to the Tree if the host will not. They are not enemies. They count belonging differently, and they share a stair.

Lestrand prints the sentence on a luck-card and calls that the faith. The woman in the attic still sets the place.

A place-setting blessing

Said to the empty plate before the hands arrive. Taught to children. Heard once, badly copied, by a Strandor sailor who did come back.

> *We have counted you. Sit. If you have a name we have not learned it yet; if you have a colour we have no tree to read it. The moon is enough light. Eat, and be the household.*

The words read as hospitality. They also say that being wanted never depended on a colour. The sailor who copied them thought they were a grace. The blessing claims that being wanted was never a gift.

Kumbaan keeps the moon, not the solstice. The High Solstice, the mainland's holiest week, is an ordinary week on the isle.

The Child at Four Doors

A teaching-story told in every house. The bones stay the same; the last line does not. Children hear their own ending first. Travellers hear the others and do not sleep well.

The story (as told)

A child came to the year of their Turning and found **four doors** where the town said there was one.

The first door was a Tree, and a leaf hung over it, coloured, waiting.
The second door was a book, open, a line already drawn, a space for a name.
The third door was a river-stone, wet, older than the road.
The fourth door was a table with a place set, and no one sitting in it.

The child asked which door was theirs.

No one would say. Each keeper only said: *this one opens.*

The child sat down in the middle and waited to be chosen, or seen, or signed, or fed.

They waited a long time.

When they looked up, all four doors were open, and the child was still in the middle, and the year had gone on without a colour, or with one (the tellings do not agree), and the child had to stand, and pick, and did, and the story ends before you see which.

The last lines (by house)

The bones above are common. What a house adds last is the faith:

- **Motherfaith (Tender):** *The Mother had opened the Tree before the child sat down. The waiting was the hug. They were wanted either way.*
- **Motherfaith (Wanting):** *The Mother opened one door and the child was looking at the other three. That is how a person is passed over: by having too many doors.*
- **The Watching:** *The Tree had been looking the whole time. The other three doors were people talking. The child was seen. That was the Turning. The leaf was optional.*
- **The Fair Hand:** *The child signed by sitting. Waiting is a term. Someone should have told them the price of a year in the middle.*
- **The Old Ways:** *The stone was wet before the Tree was planted. The child was already the land's. The waiting was weather.*
- **The Open Table:** *The place was set. The child was the guest, then the household. There was never a test. The other doors are how hungry people decorate a supper.*

Skeptics of every faith tell a seventh ending, which is not kind and is very short: *There were not four doors. There was a child, and a year, and a town that needed a story.*

Variants

- On Maiethorn the four doors are carved on the underside of old door-beams; wardens call it decoration.
- On Strandoren it is a quay-song with a chorus the Bound like: *name the term or get up.*
- On Heskoren the river-stone door is told first, and the Tree is the third, and some tellers omit the book entirely.
- On Kumbaan there is only the table. The other doors are "mainland verses," told as a curiosity after the dishes, if a guest insists.
- A Threnmaieth school-version adds a clerk who writes all four doors on a roll. Children are not meant to laugh. They do.

Orders and Houses

The Tree-Wardens

The working clergy of the Motherfaith. A **warden** tends a town's Turning Tree, speaks the colour when a leaf falls, and belongs to one order with several offices. They recruit by the office, by the work, and sometimes by the Condition a person carries.

Everyday, everywhere: **tree-wardens**, or just **wardens**. Liturgical: **the Orenhael** (OREN-hayl). The three lands keep local names for them. Vaethorn says **Hands-folk**. Lestrand says **tree-tenders**. Threnmaieth files them as **the Reckoned Hands.**

Shape of the order

- **One order, several offices.** The Motherfaith keeps a single order. Someone takes a Condition later, at a death, an oath, or a drowning, rather than at Leaf-Fall. That person is Struck. Inside the order, people already argue three questions: whether a hug was wholeness or a passing-over (Tender or Wanting), whether a Struck person belongs to the Mother's reach (Wide-Hand or Narrow-Hand), and whether anyone is choosing (believer or skeptic). The Orenhael holds that argument in the one order.
- **The town needs the wood tended.** A town keeps a warden because someone must water the wood, name a rare colour, and know when a scion is dying. Someone takes a living cutting of a Turning Tree and plants it so a town can hold its own Leaf-Fall. That is a **scion**. Doctrine comes after the watering. That is why a quiet skeptic can hold a town-hearth, and why Lestrand still pays its tenders.
- **A college at the origin, one hearth in the town.** The **First Seat**. Speakers and elder wardens sit in that college, and the desk there writes **Cutting-leave**. The leave says who may take wood, and for where. A town has one warden-hearth. Someone grows a town Tree from a cutting. That is a **graft**. The Seat cannot direct a far graft from day to day, and does not pretend to.
- **They tend, they speak, and they carry.** Belief is outside the office.

The warden-hearth (the town)

Every town with a mature Tree keeps a house on the square or in the temple-yard, close enough that blight is smelled before it is announced. That house is the **warden-hearth**. The warden (sometimes a small household of apprentice and elder) does the civic-sacred work:

- **Tree-tending:** watering rites, blight-watch, the ordinary care of mortal wood.
- **The Leaf-Fall:** they officiate. They bring the child under the boughs. They wait with the town.
- **The Speaking:** they confirm the colour aloud. Folk-known colours (deep red, storm-grey, lamp-amber, sea-blue, pale stone, copper-green) any neighbour can read; the warden's word makes the reading *civic*. Rare, mixed, or argumentative falls are why the office exists. A **white-fire** fall is sent to the First Seat by runner. A town-warden who names Phoenix from a book has just made history, and a problem.
- **Receiving the Struck:** a quiet rite at the Tree after the fact, for a **Struck** person. It is not a Turning. The Tree does not Strike. How warmly it is done follows the warden's Wide-Hand or Narrow-Hand lean, which is how the schism reaches the square.

A new town without a mature Tree borrows a neighbour's warden and a neighbour's canopy until its own scion comes of age. That borrowed year is remembered. People in the new town say, "We Turned at Harrow's Tree before we had our own."

The Speaking (colour-authority)

The Speaking is an *act*, not always a separate person. In a small town the warden Speaks. In a pilgrimage-town or at the First Seat, an elder **Speaker** holds the rare-colour texts and the last word on a mixed fall.

They do not invent the palette. They *keep* it. The folk already know the commons. The Speaker is the reason a copper-green is not mistaken for the hug, and the reason a Watcher's second reading stays a witness *alongside*, not a rival authority. Dual practice is common. Two authoritative Speakers in one square is a fight.

The Road-hands (graft and sickness)

Road-hands carry living scions in living earth, plant them with ceremony, and are the ones sent when a Tree sickens. Everyday name everywhere. Liturgical: **Thaelvaeth** (THALE-vayth).

They are the order's thin edge. A dying Tree is a civic crisis; a waiting town is a political one. The First Seat writes the Cutting-leave. The Road-hand walks it. Far from the Motherwood they have almost no authority except the scion in the cart and whatever reputation three valleys will grant.

Mandate: keep sickening Trees alive; deliver a living scion to a town that has already waited too long. Time is the enemy, and thin soil, and a Cutting-leave written for someone else.

Constraints: living earth and mortal wood only. A thin circuit of hands for a whole thin-reach. Authority that expires a week out from the Motherwood: they advise. They do not command a town that has decided to meet a feared Struck with a rope.

The Seat's support is conditional. A live Tree is a quiet success no one writes down. A dead one is a name on a complaint. Success gets you the next hard road, not a better cart.

The Tree hugged some people and left them without a Condition. Those are the **Kept**. **Who walks it:** people who already range; the Kept who will not sit a comfortable hearth; and the Wide-Hand Struck who still want the Tree to acknowledge them. Any Kind may walk it. The road fills with the people who will take it.

The college will grant a grudging Cutting-leave and still decide which waiting town is next.

The First Seat (the college)

The faith's central authority sits in the **Motherwood** about Thaeloren, on Maiethorn. Everyday: **the First Seat.** Speakers, elder wardens, the Cutting-leave desk.

What the Seat actually holds (and this is all it holds):

- **The graft-source.** Scions are cut from the Awakening Tree, or, in practice, from an established healthy town Tree *acting on the origin's behalf.* The Seat **authorizes** the cut. It does not uniquely possess every knife. A far college-town that cuts without leave is in schism with the Seat, not with the Tree.
- **The rare-colour texts.** Phoenix. Argumentative mixed falls. The book a town-warden has never opened.
- **The queue.** Which waiting settlement receives the next scion. This is the order's real power, and its injustice.

The Seat does not appoint every town-warden. A hearth is taken by apprenticeship and confirmed by the town that *watched* the new warden tend a year: the same witness that makes a citizen, applied to the clergy. The Seat confirms Road-hands and Speakers. A far town's hearth is beyond the appointments the Seat can make.

Who may be a warden

Any Kind may hold the office. A Kitsune hearth-child and a human neighbour hold the same office if they can tend wood and speak a colour. The order keeps no separate chapter for foxes, for ridge-folk,

or for any Kind.

By practice first. You are taken as a hand, apprenticed to a warden-hearth, confirmed when the town has watched you through a Turning-Week. What you *do* at the Tree makes you of the order. That is **orthopraxy**. What you privately believe about *who* chooses is the schism, not the hiring test.

Skeptics at the hearth; believers at the Seat. A town-warden may be a sincere skeptic ("it is what the Trees do") and still be a good warden, because the wood is mortal and the colours are folk-known. The First Seat runs believer-heavy. Pilgrimage wants a Someone; the rare-colour texts are kept as *hers*. A skeptic Speaker at Thaeloren is possible and uncomfortable.

The office draws the Tithe that fits the work. A Condition has an upkeep it has to meet. That upkeep is the **Tithe**. People whose upkeep fits the job often take it. Anyone who can do the work may still hold the office.

Office	Often	Why the Tithe fits	Also, and welcome
Town-warden	the Kept	untithed; can sit a hearth year-round	anyone who will tend
Speaker (Seat and pilgrimage-towns)	Long-Lived	incorruptible memory of rare falls; the Phoenix texts are a century's job	a sharp Kept scholar; a Wide-Hand Struck who has seen a threshold-colour from the other side
Road-hand	Two-Bodied	the road *is* the ranging	Kept; the Taken-In when the job is a sickening grove
Grove-tending / blight	the Taken-In	green Tithe + living wood	Root-Answered for the carrying-earth
Threshold-receiving	Struck wardens (Wide-Hand lean)	they have been on the far side of the door	any warden the town will stand for

The feared-licensed (the Stilled, heavy Far-Voiced, Bound) are not barred. They are *rare* at the First Seat: a Stilled Speaker is a civic comfort and a pilgrimage fright; a Bound warden is easier on Lestrand (where the faith is already a profession) than in the Motherwood (where a written Term next to a gift-doctrine looks like the Fair Hand leaking in). A Phoenix is never clergy. They are a problem the Seat cannot file.

Struck wardens must still be **vouched anew** like any Struck: someone the town trusts still has to stand and say who they are. The order does not stand in for that witness.

How they live with the other houses

The shared rite is the peace. The Orenhael officiates the Leaf-Fall; the other four houses stand at it. Conflict is local.

House	Everyday arrangement	The hard edge
the Watching	Same Tree, two blessings. A Watcher may offer a *second reading* of a rare fall: witness alongside, not over.	The crown keeps the Threnhael. Threnmaieth wants one name on that roll. A Speaker who lets the withheld blessing stand is a column the crown can count.
the Fair Hand	Leaf-Fall as festival *and* signing-watch. Book-hands and wardens share a square on Lestrand and ignore each other's sentences.	The warden calls the Condition a gift. The Book-hand calls it a debt. A Bound warden lives in both sentences.
the Old Ways	A healthy graft is a guest. Guest-reading Kin-speakers pilgrimage *and* walk the old doors.	A sickening Tree in an old grove: who is host, warden or door-keeper. Neighbours who both love the wood.
the Open Table	Almost no contact. A warden who crosses the storm-wall is a guest at supper. There is no Tree to tend.	There is no mission-chapter on Kumbaan.

How they live in the three corners

Same order. The local name changes, and so does the pressure on the hearth.

- **Vaethorn (Hands-folk).** The warden *is* most of the state. Thin reach, hot faith, almost no guild to issue a licence. A Road-hand here is doing the Seat's real work: sick Trees, borrowed Turnings, a scion that may not take. On this hearth a Kept apprentice is pitied for "missing" the gift they are about to spend a life tending.
- **Lestrand (tree-tenders).** A paid civic office. The Leaf-Fall is a commercial milestone; the warden Speaks so the guild-ticket can open. Faith worn light. The Seat's queue looks, from the docks, like any other scarce good. Cutting-leave can be brokered. That is Lestrand's clergy-sin, and it does not require a heresy.

- **Threnmaieth (the Reckoned Hands).** The darkest pressure. The First Seat stands in the same Sacred Core as the Tallied Crown. The crown wants wardens *named to the Threnhael* as officers of the Reckoned Faith: colours written down, Speakers as clerks of stewardship. Some Speakers cooperate (they believe they are keeping the realm hale). Some refuse: the Tree witnessed; a ledger is a second, lesser seeing. The Orenhael's kindness does not lift that pressure.

Proximity is pressure, not ownership. The college can refuse the roll, and some Speakers don't.

The scion-queue

A graft takes a generation to Turn. There are always more waiting towns than carrying-earth. Someone decides the order.

The First Seat frames the **scion-queue** as horticulture: which waiting settlement receives the next living cutting. The wood will take *here*; the soil is thin *there*. A scion travels in living soil. That carrying-earth is needed for the first. All of that can be true. It is also a choice about who lives another twenty years sending children down the road to a neighbour's canopy. Those years run **Kept-heavy and Struck-heavy**, which the frontier already knows as weather.

The Leaf-Mother's kindness did not write the queue. People did.

Road-hands walk the consequence. They plant what they were given leave to plant. They sleep in the town that was not chosen, and they learn not to say *queue*.

Economy of the order

- **Towns house and feed the warden-hearth.** A civic stipend in kind: bread, wood, a place on the square. Not a tax on Conditions.
- **Turning-Week is the festival share.** Markets, reunion, the year's namings. The warden eats from the fair like any other needed office.
- **Cutting-leave has a fee.** The Seat frames it as the cost of carrying-earth and a Road-hand's year. At the edge, people experience it as the price of a future Tree. Lestrand will broker it. Vaethorn will call it an offering. Threnmaieth will want it on the roll. Historically, this is how the Seat took over a practice that began without a fee.
- **Pilgrimage keeps the Seat.** Offerings, lodging, the devout who settle in the Motherwood. The college is rich in *proximity*, not in a Condition-tithe.

Venting-halls, greens, ranging-commons, and the safety-guilds belong to other houses. A child just received a Condition at Leaf-Fall. Wardens *point* that new **Given** at a guild. They do not licence the Stilled.

A Cutting-leave

First Seat hand, carried north in the same earth as the scion. The verso is travel-stained; the recto is clean.

> *The wood will take at Harrow's green. It will not take this year at the three hamlets past the ford. The soil is thin there, and the carrying-earth is needed for the first. Cut from a healthy hand, not from the First, and married with the watering-words. If the scion sickens, send to the Seat; do not cut a second without leave. The Mother does not reach twice by chance, and neither do we.*

The leave is competent and a little cold. It reuses the Tender's blessing as a shipping clause. The clerk writes that the soil is thin at the three hamlets, and the three hamlets will run Kept-heavy and call it weather.

The Watchers

The working people of the Watching. They keep a vigil and a second voice. They have no mother-church. The First Seat grew over the rooms that would have been that church.

Everyday, everywhere they are known: **Watchers.** Liturgical: **the Nethoren** (neth-OR-en). Vaethorn's local name is **the night-kin**. Lestrand barely has one: **vigil-folk**, when a clerk needs a label. Threnmaieth files the house as **the Grown-Over** and the people who keep the vigil as **the second column**.

In one sentence: they are the neighbour who will sit up with the Tree the night before Turning-Week, and the second pair of eyes a family sends for when a leaf comes down strange. They *describe*, they do not *confirm*. They have day jobs. The house is a practice, not a wage.

Shape of the order

- **They have no seat.** The Watching has no college in the Motherwood. Their oldest rooms sit under older chapels, or in houses that never took a warden's mark. Those rooms are the belief they keep: the Watching was already here. A Watcher who wants a mother-church has already become something else.
- **Two acts.** The **Night Watch** is what the house *does*. The Watching calls itself Haelthael. Anyone of that name may keep the night. A town asks someone to sit beside the warden when a fall is rare, mixed, or argued. That reputation is the **Second Reading**. There is no Speaker with the last word,

no Road-hand circuit, and no Cutting-leave desk. Those jobs belong to a faith that has a Tree to carry.

- **A town does not keep a Watcher the way it keeps a warden.** The wood still wants watering. What a Watcher is for is accurate speech, and a night of matching the Tree's attention with their own. Lestrand can live without that. Threnmaieth cannot stop counting it.
- **They withhold the Mother-name.** They do not correct it in the street.

If you meet one

A Watcher looks like a neighbour. Baker, weaver, a Long-Lived who copies texts, a Kept who sits a quiet hearth. They do not wear a warden's mark. That mark belongs to the warden. You know them because a neighbour said "ask the old room," or "send for the one who sat last year's mixed fall," or because you saw them under the Tree the night before Turning-Week with no lamp and no blessing.

They are useful the way a second opinion is useful. A town can live without them. A family that does not trust a single speaker on a strange leaf cannot.

Who knocks, and when

Who	Why they come	What the Watcher does	What they will not do
A household of the house	Turning-Week is coming; a child needs the withheld line taught	Sit at the hearth and make the child *say what they saw last year* (a neighbour's fall, a colour in the square) until the speech is accurate	Will not teach the Tender's blessing as the true one. A Masked Watcher will teach both, the withheld line under.
The family of a ten-year-old, after a rare or mixed fall	The warden Spoke one colour; the leaf looked like two; the year will argue	Sit *beside* the warden (or after, in the old room) and **describe**: stem, serration, how the leaf turned, whether the child flinched. Write it if asked. File nothing unless Threnmaieth makes them.	Will not **Speak**. Description is not confirmation. They will not say *Two-Bodied* or *Answered* if they saw two colours. They will say the two colours.
A Struck, or the people standing for one	The warden did the quiet receiving-rite; the family wants a witness who will not call it a late gift	Describe the threshold as a seeing at a harder door. Sit the rite. Say the withheld line if they say anything.	Will not take them to be *acknowledged as Given*. Will not novate terms (that is a Book-hand). Will not name them kin at a drowning-stone (that is a door-keeper).
A crown-clerk (Threnmaieth)	The Night Watch needs a time on the festival roll; a second reading needs a column	Give the night, or the description, as counted dissent	Will not call the withheld word a heresy they recant. A Bare Tree Watcher will not say *she* to make the docket cleaner.
Almost no one, most weeks	the ordinary week	Their day job. Sweep the old room. Keep the coats hung.	Will not invent a reason to be sent for. They are not a circuit.

An ordinary year

Eleven months they are not "on duty." They bake, copy, range, keep a stall. The house-work that still happens:

- **Teaching the withheld blessing** at the hearth, the year a child turns nine. Same cadence as the Tender's line; the Mother is not in it. This is how you can tell a Watcher household in a mixed street. The child can recite both, or will only recite one.
- **Name what you saw**, after any Turning they attend. Not a sermon. They sit with *their* child (or a neighbour's, if asked) and make the fall into accurate speech: the colour, the way the leaf came, what the year will ask. Devotion is the description. A sloppy Watcher is a bad Watcher.
- **The old room.** Sweep it. Keep the recut beam's hidden face from rotting, if the house still has one. Hang the Night Watch coats. In Threnmaieth, answer the clerk who wants to know the room is still a room.
- They do **not** water the Tree. That is the warden-hearth. A Watcher who starts blight-watching has started doing the Orenhael's job.

The Night Watch

The night before Turning-Week, the eve of Eolthael in a town that keeps the clergy's year. Watchers keep a silent vigil at the town Tree. No blessing. No colour-reading. No lamps if they can help it. The point is to be seen keeping the night.

This is not an office you are appointed to. A household that speaks the withheld blessing is expected to send someone. A town with three Watcher families may have six people under the boughs and no one in charge. A town with one old room under the chapel may have a single Long-Lived who has kept the same night for eighty years. Both are the order, such as it is.

They count the silences, not the hours. They will not tell a guest why. A first-time sitter who asks how long is told, by whoever is already sitting, "until it has been seen."

They do **not** officiate the Leaf-Fall the next day. The warden does that. They attend (orthopraxy; their children Turn) and speak their own line when the Tender's blessing is said.

The Second Reading

Where a town will have it, a Watcher may sit a **second reading** of a rare or mixed fall: not authoritative over the warden, a *witness alongside*. They describe what they saw. They do not confirm. Confirmation is civic; it belongs to the Speaking.

How the hour actually runs:

1. The child is still under the boughs, or has just been walked to the warden-hearth. The town is still there. The warden Speaks. The warden might say "storm-grey."
2. If a household asked, or if the fall was mixed enough that the square muttered, the Watcher is already standing to the side. They do not interrupt the Speaking.

3. They say what they saw, in the square or afterward in the old room. Stem, serration, the turn, the flinch or the lack of one. They will use colour-words. They will resist Condition-names if the leaf was not one colour.
4. Most years the town nods at both accounts and goes to the fair. The child is Two-Bodied because the warden Spoke it, and also someone in the square said “there was amber at the edge,” and that sentence lives in the family.

A Second-reader is just the Watcher three streets will send for when the fall is argumentative. No diploma. No Seat confirmation.

In Threnmaieth they are a known column on the Threnhael. The second reading is tolerated as counted dissent. The night is tolerated as a festival-eve custom. The withheld word is what the roll wants a name for.

What they carry

Almost nothing that looks like clergy. A scrap for the description (plain paper, not a book; a book would be a Settler’s tool). A coat that lives in the old room and smells of last year’s eve. In a Bare Tree household, no Mother-mark on the door-frame; in a Masked one, the warden’s mark *and* a second, older scratch underneath that a clerk can miss.

They have no stamp, no Cutting-leave, no ticket. They cannot licence a Stilled. They cannot plant a Tree.

What they refuse

- They will not **Speak**. If a town has no warden that year, they will still only describe. A civic confirmation from a Watcher is the house breaking itself.
- They will not take a warden’s mark. Their oldest rooms are in houses that never took one, and under chapels.
- They will not police the Mother-name in the street. They withhold it.
- They will not travel as a circuit. A Watcher in another town is a cousin visiting.

There is no chapter-house circuit. The order meets, when it meets, because Turning-Week gathers people who already keep the same night. From the outside that can look organised. What gathers is the building: the house that never took a warden’s mark; the beam that was turned to the stone when the chapel was re-floored; the room under the nave where the Night Watch leaves its coats. The First Seat knows those rooms exist. It grew over them. It does not inventory them, except in Threnmaieth, where the crown inventories as a matter of course.

Who may keep the watch

Whoever will sit the night. A Kitsune hearth-child and a human neighbour keep the same night if they will sit it and speak accurately.

By practice first. You are of the house when you keep the Night Watch and teach a child the withheld blessing. The withheld word is the dissent. Standing at the Tree is the belonging. That orthopraxy is older than the Motherfaith's.

Both branches keep the watch. A Masked Watcher will stand for the Tender's blessing and add the withheld line under it. They are the ones a mixed town barely notices. A Bare Tree Watcher will not say "she" at all. Both may Second-read. They will not always describe the same fall the same way. The house argues with itself in the square, and the square allows it. That argument is why they have no single word that outranks the warden.

The act draws the person whose Tithe fits it. Anyone of the house may still keep the night.

Act	Often	Why the Tithe (or the lack) fits	Also, and welcome
Night Watch	anyone of the house	the night does not care what you carry	the Kept, who were seen as whole; the Struck, who were seen at a harder door
Second Reading	Long-Lived	incorruptible memory of how a rare fall looked *last time*	a sharp Kept; a Stilled who will describe without flinching; a Wide-Hand Struck who has seen a threshold-colour from the other side
Keeping an old room	families that never took a warden's mark	the room under the chapel is inherited	a new household that refuses the warden's mark

The feared-licensed are not barred. A Stilled Second-reader is a civic comfort (the gaze holds a room still for accurate speech) and a pilgrimage fright; they are rarer at the sacred centre than in an old district that never stopped being Haelthael. A Phoenix is not clergy here either. They are a seeing no one in the square is ready to describe twice.

Struck Watchers must still be vouched anew like any Struck. The old rooms do not stand in for that witness.

How they live with the other houses

House	Everyday arrangement	The hard edge
the Tree-Wardens	Same Tree, two blessings. Second reading alongside, not over.	Threnmaieth wants one name on the Threnhael. A Speaker who lets the withheld line stand is a column the crown can count. Two authoritative Speakers in one square is a fight.
the Fair Hand	Rarely share a square. A Settler hears “what falls, was seen” as a clause with no number.	Almost none, until a Bound wants a second reading of an oath-day and a Watcher will not call it a signing.
the Old Ways	Two old memories, opposite edges. A Watcher remembers a Before at the Tree. A door-keeper remembers a Before without one.	They will not agree, and the argument can leave the table. The First Bowl, the guest-grove, is the ordinary room for it. A meal refused, a Night Watch held in an old green, and a Road-hand arriving in the middle are how it starts.
the Open Table	Almost no contact. A Watcher who crossed the storm-wall would be a guest at supper, and would find the night already kept, for a different reason.	None that matters. There is no Night Watch on Kumbaan.

How they live in the three corners

- **Vaethorn (the night-kin).** Cousin-dissent. Thin reach, hot faith: a Watcher household is unusual and not hunted. The Night Watch looks, from a Hands-folk hearth, like extra piety. The withheld Mother-name is the only sting, and a Guest-reading town has larger fights (the grove) than this one.
- **Lestrand (vigil-folk, when named).** Rarely met. A Watcher on the docks is a scholar or a migrant from the core. The signing-watch does not need a second reading; the book is the second reading. Faith worn light enough that a withheld blessing is just another quay-sentence.
- **Threnmaieth (the second column).** This is where the pressure is heaviest. They are a known column on the roll, the Grown-Over, counted. The crown does not hunt the households. The Night Watch is a festival-eve custom the crown can schedule. The second reading is tolerated until it contradicts the Speaker the Threnhael has already named. A Long-Lived who still has a copy of the beam from before it was recut is a person this house keeps. The pressure is a tolerated column on the roll, not a hunt.

The recut beam

They remember a cost, and they have no institution that can keep a beam from being turned to the stone.

The First Seat did not steal a throne from them. There was no throne. What was lost is quieter: a beam recut, a room under a chapel that is now a vestry, a second reading that remains *alongside* because the civic word was given to the warden when the Mother-name grew over the Seeing. All of that can be described as history. It is also a choice, still being made, about whose speech counts in the square.

A second reading does not buy a seat. The Grown-Over column stays a column. They have hold of the Before and the cost. They do not have the last word on a colour. A settled Mother-name would not promote them.

They do not walk a scion-queue. That grievance is the Orenhael's. Theirs is the recut beam: whose speech counts in the square.

Economy of the house

The house has almost no money of its own.

- **Households keep the night.** Bread from the same table. No stipend, no Cutting-leave, no pilgrimage-share.
- **A Second-reader eats as a neighbour.** Some old districts leave a plate at the room under the chapel during Turning-Week. That is courtesy, not a wage.
- **Threnmaieth pays for the column.** Being a column can become a living if a crown-clerk pays for a copied beam or a listed name. A Watcher who takes that coin has not left the house. They have let the roll furnish it. The Bare Tree branch will not eat with them. The Masked will, and argue after.

They point no one at a licence. They describe a fall. Venting-halls, greens, and the safety-guilds are other houses' work.

A second-reading slip

Written in a Watcher's own hand the morning after a mixed fall, and filed by a Threnmaieth Speaker under "alongside, not over." The Speaker's docket-mark is cleaner than the slip.

> *Storm-grey at the stem, lamp-amber at the serration, and the child did not flinch when the leaf turned. I will not say Two-Bodied. I will not say Answered. I will say what I saw: the Tree looked twice and did not choose the easier colour. The warden Spoke storm-grey. I sat*

> *beside and said the amber. Both were seen. File me as the second column if you must. Do not file the amber as an error.*

The writer is a careful witness, a little stubborn, and useful to a clerk who needs a name for dissent. The slip's whole case is that seeing something is not the same as choosing it. The Speaker who filed it "alongside" was keeping the peace between the warden and the Watcher.

The Book-Hands

The working people of the Fair Hand. They have no seat and many tables. On Lestrand they are often the same people as commercial clerks; the faith *is* the profession, worn lightly. They do not rewrite a Bound's Terms. The Bound's contract has another party. That clause belongs to them, not the clerk. The house calls that other party the **Counterparty**. They may *witness an ask*; they do not dictate.

Everyday: **Book-hands**, or **Settlers.** Liturgical: **the Leddhael** (LED-hayl). Vaethorn's local name is **Bargainers' clerks**. Lestrand's is **the Settling-hands**, ordinary, the way a quay says "notary." Threnmaieth files them with the house as **the Uncounted Book**. Private books offend the crown.

In one sentence: they are notaries (hull in the morning, a child's private book at Turning-Week) and the person who will help a Struck find a *payable year* (a hall, a warrant). They will recite a Bound's Terms on oath-day. They will not change those Terms.

Shape of the order

- **No seat, many tables.** Guild-rooms and quay-shrines, not a college in anyone's sacred wood. A "high house" in a rich port is the oldest book-room: age, not authority. The next quay has its own table and does not write to the first for leave.
- **The faith is the profession.** A Book-hand witnesses a signing, teaches a child to keep a book, and helps a Struck settle a year that can actually be lived. On Lestrand the same person may stamp a hull before noon and recite a Bound's oath-day after. Doctrine is the ethic of the stamp: *fair terms, then walk.* They copy a Bound's Terms. They do not author them.
- **No membership roll.** A roll of Book-hands would be a Threnhael in a clerk's pocket. What makes you of the house is that you keep accounts honestly and will die to keep a crown-clerk out of a personal book.
- **They sit at tables.** They witness a signing and copy what was already written.

If you meet one

On Lestrand a Book-hand looks like a clerk. Ink-stained, a small stamp on a cord, a table in a guild-room or a quay-shrine the size of a pantry. Before noon they may witness a hull. After, a Bound's oath-day. Both hours, the clerk says "fair wind, fair term." You would not know which hour was the rite unless you already kept Leddoren.

Off the coast they are rarer and more obviously religious: the person a pilgrim-town sends for when a Struck cannot live *this year* (no hall, no one to stand), and the Hands-folk would rather walk them to a Tree.

They are useful the way a notary is useful. A port cannot live without someone who will stamp a signing. The faith treats the stamp on a contract and the record of a becoming as the same kind of account.

Who sits down, and when

Who	Why they come	What the Book-hand does	What they will not do
A ten-year-old's Settler household, Turning-Week	The child Turned (or was Kept); the personal book must open	Stand as *witness*, not petitioner. Speak the signing-watch line if they speak. Enter colour (or the hug), Tithe, what the year owes. Put the book in the child's hands.	Will not speak the Tender's blessing. Will not call the colour a gift. Will not Speak the civic name. The warden does that; they copy what was seen into a private book.
Anyone with a contract	Marriage, hull, a year's closing	Witness, copy, stamp, date.	Will not hide a clause. Hidden terms are the house's one sin. Will not show a *personal* book to a crown-clerk.
A Bound, on oath-day	The year's Terms must be spoken where a neighbour can hear	Recite the Terms *as already written*. Mark the civic book closed if the Tithe-year was paid, or owing if it was not.	**Will not rewrite the Terms.** That is the Counterparty's clause, not a clerk's. Will not pretend a stamp can ease a Pledge.
A Bound who wants the clause changed	The Terms are killing them; they have heard a clerk can "fix it"	A **Counterparty** Book-hand may sit a *petition-watch*: they witness the ask, keep the book open, and wait. If something answers, they copy what was answered. A **Book Alone** hand will not sit that hour. They do not believe anyone is across the table.	Will not dictate a new clause. Will not sell an easing. Anyone who claims they can is a liar, or someone taking coin in a cellar.
A Struck who is not Bound	They Changed later (drowned, died, taken); this town cannot house the Tithe	**Civic settling:** find a payable year. Passage to a hall that exists, a warrant, someone to stand for them.	Will not take them to a Tree to be acknowledged as Given. Will not name them kin at a door. Will not rewrite a Bound contract under this heading.

Who	Why they come	What the Book-hand does	What they will not do
A child of the house, about nine	They must learn to keep a book before they Turn	Sit with a blank personal book: colour, Tithe, debts, what the year owes you. Private. Not the Threnhael.	Will not let a Reckoned clerk “help” copy it. Will not teach the book as a census.
A Tithe-poor Settler	The year will not close; they cannot stamp a fee	Some stay and rewrite until the candle dies. Some mark *owing* faster. Both are of the house.	Will not furnish a venting-hall or a greens-share. They may *write a term that assumes one*. The Hall-Keepers and Greens-Keepers own the hall and the lot.

An ordinary week on Lestrand

Morning, the commercial table. Hulls, marriages, copies, a deathless house’s instrument. Paid by the stamp. A Kept clerk (Lestrand’s *free*) may do only this and still be of the house if they keep accounts honestly and will die to keep a crown-clerk out of a personal book.

Turning-Week and oath-days, the signing-watch. They attend the Leaf-Fall as witnesses. They do not officiate. They stand at the edge of the square with a child’s first book and wait for a colour they can enter. A Bound’s oath-day is the high holy day: Terms recited in a voice the quay can hear, the year’s book closed or marked owing.

When someone Changed last week, the work is civic settling. It does not rewrite a Bound’s Terms. A drowning came back Far-Voiced in a town with no hall for the voice. That town has no ael-hall. A death came back Returned with a purpose the street will not house. The Book-hand finds a year that can be *paid*: passage, a warrant, a neighbour who will stand. If no one will stand, they write *owing*. The quay steps around. That is still the house’s kindness and its cruelty. It is **not** a Bound’s Terms being edited.

A Bound’s oath-day. They recite what was already sworn. They do not improve it. A Bound who wants the clause itself changed is asking the Counterparty, not the clerk. The honest house will witness the ask or refuse to pretend. Anyone selling a new clause after the lamps is another table.

They never write the word *gift*, even as a loan. A first-year apprentice who copies *vael* into a personal book is made to strike it and write *grant*. No one calls this a rule. It is how the ink goes.

They do not cut grafts, tend Trees, or carry scions. A sickening Tree is a warden's crisis and a door-keeper's fight. A Book-hand will write the delay into a contract.

No Book-hand holds a last word over the others. If two Book-hands disagree on a clause, they write both readings and date them. The book holds both readings. The house stays one house.

How civic settling actually runs

This is for a Struck whose *Tithe* cannot be lived here. It is not for a Bound's supernatural Terms. Civic settling rewrites the payable civic terms of a year: passage, warrant, a seventh day. It never rewrites the Bound's clause. That rewriting is the house's **novation**.

1. The Struck sits. The Book-hand names what is already true, and says "you carry a voice," or "you carry a purpose."
2. They name what cannot be paid *here*: a hall that is not in this town; a warmth no one will give.
3. They find a year a neighbour can see being paid. Passage to a release-house, a warrant, a seventh day.
4. They find someone to **stand for** the person. The Book-hand does not stand for them unless the Book-hand is Bound, Long-Lived, or Far-Voiced. Those three are the pillars a town will accept as proof.
5. If that fails: *owing, not broken.* The civic book stays open. The quay learns the name.

How a Bound petition-watch runs (if they sit it)

1. The Bound speaks the ask. The Book-hand writes the ask, not the answer.
2. They wait. They do not invent a clause to fill the silence.
3. If nothing answers, they close the hour. The old Terms still stand. The house was honest.
4. If something answers, they copy the new clause *as heard*. They do not improve the wording. They do not take a fee for "getting a better deal."

A Book Alone hand stops at step 1 and sends the Bound home. They will not play at a table they believe is empty. That is also honest.

What they carry

A personal **stamp**, and the ticket is a different paper. The stamp is not a guild-licence. Ink. A cord-knife for striking a line. The small **personal books** they sell or gift to children of the house, not the Threnhael. A clerk who confuses them has started a fight. On a Bound's oath-day, the year's working contract, read aloud, *as written*, not as improved.

A “high house” is a room with old copies and a better lamp. The next quay does not write here for leave.

What they refuse

- They will not show a personal book to the crown. A crown order that demands one is, in their words, stealing a soul.
- They will not call a Leaf-Fall a gift, and they will not rewrite a Given child’s past so the child was always a debtor. The book opens at the colour. It does not invent an earlier debt.
- They stay at the table. They do not carry a scion.
- They will not keep a membership roll of Book-hands. A roll would be a Threnhael.
- They will not rewrite a Bound’s Terms or sell an easing of a Pledge. The clerk is not the Counterparty.

Who may keep a table

Any Kind may hold the stamp. A Selkie quay-child and a human clerk hold the same stamp if they keep accounts honestly.

By practice first. You are taken as a hand, apprenticed at a table, confirmed when a quay has watched you through a year’s closings and at least one signing-watch. What you privately believe about whether anyone sits across the table (Counterparty or Book Alone) is the schism, and it is not the hiring test. Both branches refuse hidden terms. That is enough to share a desk.

The work draws the Tithe that fits it. Anyone who keeps the accounts honestly may still hold the table.

Act	Often	Why the Tithe (or the lack) fits	Also, and welcome
Witnessing / teaching	Bound	their book *is* a contract; the faith did not invent this, they made it legible	the Unbound who have closed a year and will teach the closing; a Kept clerk. Lestrand's *free* carry no Tithe and no guild, and the book is a choice
Novation of the Struck	Bound; Wide-Hand Struck who settled	they have been on the far side of a bad term	a Far-Voiced who can make a feeling unfakeable at the table
Oldest book-rooms	Long-Lived houses that endow a room	a century of fair copies is a high house	anyone the port still comes to

The feared-licensed are not barred. A Bound Book-hand is ordinary on Lestrand and a problem for doctrine in the Motherwood. A Stilled at a table is rare and useful: the room holds still for the clause. A Phoenix is not a clerk. There is no term that covers them.

Struck Book-hands must still be vouched anew. Civic settling is how the house helps that vouching, and the help is also how the house can pressure the person it settled. It still does not rewrite a Bound's clause.

How they live with the other houses

House	Everyday arrangement	The hard edge
the Tree-Wardens	Leaf-Fall as festival *and* signing-watch. On Lestrand they share a square and ignore each other's sentences.	The warden calls the Condition a gift. The Book-hand calls it a debt. A Bound warden lives in both sentences. A Bound Book-hand is the house at home.
the Watchers	Rarely share a square. "What falls, was seen" sounds, to a Settler, like a clause with no number.	A Bound who wants a second reading of an oath-day and a Watcher who will not call it a signing.
the Old Ways	A door-keeper names a Struck *kin* at the door that made them; a Book-hand settles the civic year at a table. Sometimes the same week, same person.	Which name goes first, kin or payable year. Two courtesies, not a trial.
the Open Table	A Settler who sits a moon-feast twice has been called kin in a language with no book.	"No one is a stranger twice" is not a term in any book. There is no Leddoren mission on Kumbaan.
the Holding Desk	Upstairs and downstairs. A Settler who marked *owing* has made a customer.	A clerk who follows a customer down the stair has started a case. The honest stamp and the hold do not share a docket, and a personhood case can start there.

How they live in the three corners

- **Lestrand (the Settling-hands).** This is their home. The faith *is* the profession. A high house is a proud old room on a rich quay. It is not a seat over the other tables. Cutting-leave can be brokered by the same people who close books. That brokerage is Lestrand's clergy-sin, and it belongs to the wardens' fee, not to a Book-hand's stamp, except when a clerk "helps" a waiting town write the delay. The Tithe-poor Settler who cannot close the book is still a person the rich city steps around, and the faith treats that step-around as part of the rite.
- **Vaethorn (Bargainers' clerks).** Suspect, useful, few. A Book-hand on the pilgrim edge is settling a Struck's year in a land that would rather take them to a Tree to be acknowledged as Given. The Hands-folk will eat with them if the year comes out kind. A Narrow-Hand preacher will not.
- **Threnmaieth (the Uncounted Book).** Private books offend the crown. A personal ledger that is *not* the Threnhael is, to a Reckoned clerk, a second seeing the crown does not hold. Book-hands

here work quietly, or not at all, or as commercial notaries who have learned not to say *Leddoren* on a docket.

The book that will not close

The house settles a person's year and closes the book. That is its kindness, and its cruelty.

Every civic settling that saves a Struck who can pay is paid for, somewhere, by the Struck who cannot. The Book-hand sees one table. The quay sees a step-around. A settled Mother-name would not make the fading kind, and would not turn a Bound's clause into a clerk's draft.

Their other hard case is the Bound they cannot help. A clerk who will not rewrite Terms will watch someone walk down the quay looking for a cellar that will lie to them. That cellar is the Holding Desk. The refusal to rewrite is still honest, and it is no reason the clerk cannot follow. The lived face of illicit Tithe-supply is the Slide. Sold vouching is the Standing Trade. Book-hands do not stamp those books either.

Economy of the house

- **The stamp is the living.** On Lestrand a Book-hand is paid as a clerk is paid, by the signing, the copy, the year's closing. The faith does not take a cut of the Tithe.
- **High houses endow rooms.** Deathless money likes a fair copy that will outlive a hull. That wealth is nearness to the quay. It is not a tax on Conditions, and it is why the oldest rooms sit on the richest quays.
- **Civic settling is badly paid.** The Struck who most need a hall and a warrant are the ones who can least stamp a fee. Some Book-hands stay until the candle dies. Some mark *owing* faster. Both are of the house.

They may write a term that assumes a venting-hall or a greens-share. They do not furnish one. The halls and the greens are other houses' work.

A civic settling

Lestrand quay-hand, written the week after a drowning came back Far-Voiced and could not pay a singer's Tithe in a town that had no ael-hall. The verso has the old storm-terms of *the year*, struck through. Not a Bound's clause.

> *Grant: the voice, already carried. Old term: a hall that is not here. New term: one honest outlet each seventh day at the release-house in Greyhull, passage stamped, warrant by M.*

> *Senn the hull-clerk. If the seventh day is missed, the book is owing, not broken. Walk, if you can walk. If you cannot, the quay will not call it a gift.*

The slip is the house's kindness: a storm-year's terms rewritten so a person can live. "The quay will not call it a gift" is honest, and it is also how the quay steps around the person. Greyhull's release-house will take the seventh day. The eighth week the passage-money fails, the slip will still be fair, and the person will still owe a book that does not close.

The Door-Keepers

The working people of the Old Ways. They have no seat because the land is the seat. Not a hierarchy; a reputation.

Everyday: **door-keepers**, also **Kin-speakers.** Liturgical: **the Vaelbren** (VAYL-bren). Vaethorn's local name is **the door-folk**, or **Before-speakers** when the fight is hot. Lestrand's is **grove-talkers**, a frontier curiosity. Threnmaieth files them with the house as **the Unreached**.

In one sentence: they are the person three valleys walk to when someone needs to know which drowning-pool still returns, which grove still takes people in, and the person who names a Struck *kin* at the door that made them, instead of walking them to a Tree to be filed as late.

Shape of the order

- **The land is the seat.** The Old Ways cannot have a mother-church. A hill, a drowning-stone, a grove, an oath-rock: these are the offices. A person is of the house when three valleys will walk to them, not when a college confirms them.
- **Two jobs, often one person.** A **door-keeper** knows which doors still open and will walk them at the year's hinges. A **Kin-speaker** speaks at ancestor-meals and names a Struck *kin* at the door that made them. In a thin-reach district this is one tired person. In a Guest-reading town that finally got a Tree, the two jobs may split for a generation and fold again when the old one dies.
- **They do not carry the wood.** They do not carry scions. They do not confirm colours. They do not authorise a cut. When a graft sickens in an old green, they argue who is host of the wood. The Road-hands already walk the carrying.
- **A land-and-kin house.** They do not police the Mother-name. Many also bring a child to a healthy graft.

If you meet one

A door-keeper looks like someone who knows the district. Mud on the hem, a worn token at the belt (river-stone, grove-twig, a pinch of hill in a twist of cloth; no two alike), a sack that is sometimes food for a door and sometimes food for a meal. You would miss them as clergy if you came from Maiethorn looking for a chapel. You would find them by asking, “Who still walks the drowning-stone?” or “Who will speak at the board for the ones in the ground?”

They are useful the way a midwife is useful. The becoming they attend comes later in a life, and the map they keep is which doors still open. A thin-reach town can live without a warden for a generation. It cannot live long without someone who remembers the water.

Who sends for them, and when

Who	Why they come	What the door-keeper does	What they will not do
Anyone in the district, at a year's hinge	The doors must be walked. Deep Solstice, the equinoxes, High Solstice, and the local hinges the map does not print	Walk. Greet water, hill, stone, in that order. Leave food. Ask to be *known*, not Given. Take the young one who carried last year.	Will not ask the door for a colour. Will not skip a door because a Tree is healthier this year.
A household at an ancestor-meal	Someone must know the names and keep the empty place	Speak the names. Set the place. Not let a guest sit in it. Eat. Argue Guest/First after the dishes if they argue.	Will not treat the empty place as a Returned's chair. Different door. Will not make this a chapel service.
A Struck, or the people who found them	They Changed at a river, a grove, an oath-stone, a death; the town wants them vouched or gone	Take them back to the door that made them, if it can be found, and **name them kin**. Feed them. Walk with them if the town will not house them.	Will not walk them to a Tree to be acknowledged as Given (the warden may do that the same week; the fight is which name goes first). Will not settle a civic year (that is a Book-hand). Cannot *be* a civic pillar unless they themselves are Long-Lived, Bound, or Far-Voiced.
A warden or a Road-hand	A graft in an old green is sickening; someone has Cutting-leave	Tend the wood as host or as keeper of a guest. Demand the meal before a second cut.	Will not carry the next scion up the road. Will not sell a cut. Will not call the Struck "unreached."
A scholar, a Lestrand clerk, a curious pilgrim	They want the older sense of *vael*, or a drowning-stone found	They show the door and use the old word for a harvest and a returned child.	Will not give them a map of every door. Some doors are walked, not published.

An ordinary season

Most weeks. Someone asks whether the pool below the ford still returns. The door-keeper goes and looks. They know which grove took someone in ten years ago and whether that hill is still a door. They carry food when the hinge is close. They have a day life (ranging, green-tending, a stall) and the reputation sits on top of it. A famous one is just the one three valleys will walk to. A young one is the apprentice who carried the food last year and was watched doing it.

The year's hinges. Not only High Solstice / Turning-Week. Deep Solstice (the long night, the low year). The two equinoxes. Local hinges a Maiethorn calendar does not print: the first flood, the night the hill-ice breaks. They walk the old doors of the district. Water, then hill, then stone. They will not say why that order. A guest who reverses it is corrected without a sermon.

The meal. A place at the board for the ones in the ground. Quiet, domestic. The Kin-speaker is the one who knows the names. In a thin-reach district this is the same tired person who walked the ford at dawn.

When someone Changed later. They do not start at the Tree. They start at the door: the river if it was water, the grove if it was green, the oath-stone if it was a vow, the death-place if it was unfinished work. They name the person kin. The Motherfaith's quiet receiving-rite may happen the same week. A Book-hand's novation may happen the same month. Three courtesies can share a month. The hard case is the Struck the town will not house. The door-keeper can give a kin-name. Unless the door-keeper is Long-Lived, Bound, or Far-Voiced, they cannot stand for that person in the town. They may spend a season walking with one person. They may not be able to.

They tend a healthy graft as a *guest in the grove* if the town has one. They may Turn under it. They may not pretend it invented becoming.

How a kin-naming actually runs

1. Find the door, if it can be found. If it cannot, the nearest old door of the same kind: water for a drowning, green for a taking. A door that is only a Tree is a last resort, and a First-reading walker will hate it.
2. Food first. The door is greeted. The person is not tested with a colour.
3. The Kin-speaker says the name they already had, then the kin-name the door is owed. No leaf. No stamp. The token at the belt is shown, not given, unless this person will walk next year, in which case they will find their own.
4. The town, if it is watching, still wants a warrant to let them *stay*. The kin-name is courtesy. Standing-for is civic. A door-keeper who is also Long-Lived, Bound, or Far-Voiced can do both. Most cannot.

The contested grove

An ailing graft in an old Taken-In green is the signature fight: warden vs. door-keeper, guest vs. host, pilgrimage-scarcity vs. “we had ways.” Neighbours who both love the wood.

What they *do* with their hands is the same as the warden for an hour: water, watch blight, sit up with mortal wood. The argument is not horticulture. It is whether this Tree is a guest in the grove or a Tree the town failed. A Guest-reading Kin-speaker will pilgrimage *and* walk the doors, and will tend a dying graft as kin. A First-reading door-keeper will tend the same graft as a *guest in their house* and still refuse the Tender’s blessing. Both revere the Struck and the Taken-In. A reading that starts pitying them as “unreached” has already become Motherfaith.

If a Road-hand arrives with Cutting-leave, the door-keeper’s job is the meal first, then the question “does this grove receive a guest?” They do not ask to be the ones who carried the wood. They do not carry scions.

What they carry

The **token** from their door: river-stone, grove-twig, a pinch of hill. Food for the walk. Names in the head (the ones in the ground; the doors that still open). No stamp. No colour-book. No Cutting-leave.

What they refuse

- They will not confirm a colour or officiate a Leaf-Fall. If they bring a child to a healthy graft, the warden Speaks.
- They will not carry a scion or sell a cut.
- They will not call the Struck or the Taken-In “unreached.” That word is Motherfaith leaking in.
- They will not publish every door. Some are walked, not mapped.
- Ancestor-meals are for kin in the ground. The Returned are a different door, and a door-keeper is not their priest.

Who may keep a door

Whoever knows the stone. A Tengu ridge-child and a human neighbour walk the same stone if they know it and will stand for kin. The Taken-In are revered here. Reverence is not a membership test.

By practice first. You are taken as a walker. You carried the food, you were watched at a meal, three households will send for you. Belief about the Mother (Guest / First) is secondary. Many Kin-speakers also bring a child to a healthy graft when they can reach one.

The walk draws the Tithe that fits it. Anyone the valleys will send for may still keep a door.

Act	Often	Why the Tithe (or the lack) fits	Also, and welcome
Walking the doors	the Taken-In	the grove's own children; green Tithe + old green	Two-Bodied (the walk *is* a ranging); Kept for whom a closed door was weather, not a slight
Naming the Struck kin	Struck door-keepers	they have been through a door with no warden	a Wide-Hand warden who will share the week; a Bound whose oath-stone is the door
Ancestor-meals	anyone of the house	the dead stay in the ground, not the Returned's door	a Returned guest is a *different* door; the Kin-speaker is not their priest

The feared-licensed are not barred. A Taken-In door-keeper is ordinary on Heskoren and a frontier embarrassment in a Narrow-Hand sermon. A Phoenix is not a walker. There is no old door that answers to white-fire.

Struck door-keepers must still be vouched anew. Naming them kin is courtesy. It does not replace a pillar: a Long-Lived, a Bound, or a Far-Voiced standing for them. The town may still want a warrant.

How they live with the other houses

House	Everyday arrangement	The hard edge
the Tree-Wardens	A healthy graft is a guest. Guest-reading Kin-speakers pilgrimage *and* walk the doors. Vaethorn's Hands-folk find the missing seat infuriating and, in a dry year, quietly useful.	A sickening Tree in an old grove: who is host. A Narrow-Hand preacher calling the Struck "not hers" is who they will not eat with.
the Watchers	Two old memories, opposite edges. A Before at the Tree, and a Before without one.	They will not agree on the Before, and neither will give way. The First Bowl, the guest-grove, is the ordinary room for it. It escalates with a meal refused, a Night Watch held in the green, or a Road-hand arriving in the middle.
the Book-Hands	Kin-name and rewritten terms, sometimes the same Struck, same month.	Which name goes first. Two courtesies, not a trial.
the Open Table	Ancestor-meals set a place for the dead who stayed in the ground. A traveller can mistake that place for the Open Table's extra seat. The dead in the ground are not the hands that fetch and pour.	The Door-Keepers walk no doors on Kumbaan. There is no Vaeloren mission on Kumbaan.

How they live in the three corners

- **Vaethorn (the door-folk).** This is their home, and the live fight. The warden is most of the state. The door-keeper is the older state the land still keeps. Guest-reading towns that finally got a Tree did not throw their grandparents out of the rite. They pilgrimage and walk. First-reading districts still waiting on a scion that will not take tend a dying guest and refuse the blessing. What they oppose is the habit of reading a scarce gift as unworthiness. A closed door, in their speech, is weather: a year the land did not open.
- **Lestrand (grove-talkers).** A frontier curiosity. A door-keeper on the docks is a migrant or a story. The Settling will stamp a Struck's terms and call the kin-name poetry. Useful, if someone needs a drowning-stone found. Not a rival for the quay.
- **Threnmaieth (the Unreached).** Filed as a gap: people who were not at a proper Tree, doors the roll cannot name. A Kin-speaker in the core is rare and interesting to a crown-archivist. The census wants a column. The land does not sit in one. The pressure is the filing. It does not become a hunt of households.

The host of a dying guest

Someone decides whether a sickening graft is a *guest in the grove* or a *Tree the town failed*.

The Road-hand arrives with leave and a case about the soil. The door-keeper arrives with grandparents and food. Both can be right about the wood. The years the grove spends arguing are years children walk to a neighbour’s canopy, Kept-heavy, Struck-heavy, which the frontier already knows as weather, and which Vaethorn will sanctify as unworthiness if no one says otherwise.

The Seat’s scion-queue is the Orenhael’s grievance. The door-keepers’ grievance is who is host, and who will stand for the Struck the town will not. A healthy Tree in the grove would not change which wood came first, and would not make a closed door a slight. The grievance stays. The grafts are late, and the Motherfaith did talk as if becoming were new.

Economy of the house

- **Meals and walking.** A door-keeper eats at the boards they speak for. No stipend from a seat. A famous one is housed because three valleys would be ashamed not to.
- **No Cutting-leave, no fee.** They do not sell wood. If a Guest-reading town wants a scion, that coin goes to the Seat, not to the Kin-speaker. A First-reading district that pays a Cutting-leave and still refuses the blessing is doing both courtesies at once, and will argue about it after.
- **Standing for the Struck is unpaid.** The ones who most need a kin-name are the ones a town will not house. Some door-keepers spend a year on one person. Some cannot. Both are of the house.

Garden-commons and ranging-commons are other houses’ work. A Taken-In door-keeper may live in a green. They do not licence it.

Left tied to an ailing graft

In an old Taken-In green, the week a Road-hand’s cart was seen at the ford. Two hands; one knife-cut for the string.

> *The tree is young. The grove is not. We have fed it as a guest and we will feed it still. If you have come with leave, come to the meal first. If you have come with a second cut in mind, know that the hill already yielded a child this year and does not owe you a colour. We will not let either wood pretend it was first.*

The writer is polite and a little barbed, and the note reuses the drowning-stone saying on a trunk. The house’s case is that becoming happens at doors with no healthy Tree. The Road-hand who eats first

will plant as a guest. The one who cuts without the meal will be remembered as a claiming, and the wood may still take.

The Table-Keepers

The working people of the Open Table, hill-hosts on Kumbaan. They are almost not clergy. A Yumboe abroad keeping an attic is how the faith travels, rarely. The storm-shore is a different isle job: the Shore-Sitters.

Mainland everyday: **table-keepers**, also **hill-hosts.** Own-name: **the Njaalo** (NJAH-lo), a Yumboe coinage in the night-keeping tongue. Not Maiethren; this house owes the liturgy nothing. Sailors say **moon-hosts**. Vaethorn has them as a sailor's tale. Lestrand says **the Moon-Feast people** when a quay wants a story. Threnmaieth does not file them. They are off the map.

In one sentence: they are the person who opens the hall (or the attic) and lays an extra place. On Kumbaan that is how a valley eats and how a stranger becomes kin. On the mainland it is one room, one supper, and a sentence the quay will not enforce.

Shape of the order

- **Almost not an order.** Ndeyaan has no chapel, no college, no colour-authority, no graft, no book, no door-walk that wants a title. The person whose hall the valley comes to on the bright nights is a table-keeper. Reputation, not office. When they die, the valley comes to the next hall that still sets the extra place.
- **One job.** Keep the table. Lay the extra place. On the second sitting, the host says "no one is a stranger twice." That sentence is the whole of the office. There is no second office above it.
- **No seat across the sea, no mission.** A Yumboe who wants a hill-hall on Strandoren keeps Ndeyaan in whatever room they have. They do not send for a scion, a stamp, or a Night Watch. The mainland does not send wardens to Kumbaan. The storm-wall is the boundary.
- **A hospitality-house.** The unseen hands belong to the hall. They fetch and pour. Sitting at the table does not bind a guest by spell or by contract. A human who has sat twice and will lay the place is of the table. A Yumboe who will not is just a neighbour who sleeps through the bright night. The house takes people by who will keep the table.

If you meet one

On Kumbaan a table-keeper looks like the person whose hill-hall the valley already knows. Small, pearl-pale, silver-haired if they are Yumboe (most are, because that is who lives there). They open the

door on the bright nights. By mainland noon they are often asleep. You would not call them a priest. You would go to their hall when the moon is up because that is where the food is and where a stranger is allowed to sit.

On the mainland they look like one person in a rented room who still sets a place no guest is meant to sit in. A sailor finds them by asking for the Moon-Feast. A clerk finds them by following a rumour and then files them as a guest. They cook. They pour. They say the sentence on the second night.

They are useful the way a host is useful. They do not water Trees, stamp books, or walk drowning-stones. If you came for those jobs you have the wrong house.

Who comes, and when

Who	Why they come	What the table-keeper does	What they will not do
The valley, on a bright night (Kumbaan)	The moon is up; the hall is where you eat	Open the hall. Lay the extra place *slightly back from the board*, not at the end. Let the unseen hands fetch and pour. Sing. Sleep when the moon is down.	Will not read a colour. Will not test a guest. Will not omit the extra place.
A stranger who crossed the storm-wall	They have already been through drowning-water; they need a seat	First night: guest (already sacred). Feed them. Learn a name if they offer one. Second night: say *no one is a stranger twice* and treat them as of the table.	Will not make them Turn. Will not ask what they *are*. Will not sell the sentence as a proverb.
Anyone at an ordinary supper	The extra place is every meal that matters, not only the feast	Set it. A poor house still sets it. The hands make the extra possible.	Will not count the household as the bodies you can see. That is the one impiety.
A guest on the mainland (attic)	They heard of a Moon-Feast; they are hungry; they are curious	Same two sittings, smaller room. Feed them. Say the sentence on the second night. Treat them as kin *inside the room*.	Will not walk them to a warden to be filed as belonging. Will not stamp a book. Will not collect for a hall across the water.
A rare Struck on the isle	A drowning, a death, a green taking, uncommon enough to be family news	Feed them. Keep them in the household. They are not treated as a class apart.	Will not invent a mainland receiving-rite. Will not send them to a Tree that is not there.
A warden, a Book-hand, a Watcher who crossed	Courtesy, curiosity	They are a guest. First night, second night. The host will find their noon-faith *loud*.	Will not give them a Tree to tend, a book to stamp, or a Night Watch to keep. There is nothing here for those jobs.

A bright night on Kumbaan

Dusk. The table-keeper opens the hill-hall, often because it was their grandmother's, often because it was the only roof that still fitted the crowd. People arrive as the moon clears the Paps. The extra place is already set, slightly back, a little apart. The unseen hands begin to fetch and pour; you can see the cups move. Songs. No colour-reading. No terms recited. A Staying host says the dead's names when they fill that place. A Serving host does not say the names, and still fills the place. That host calls the hands the hill's own courtesy.

The table-keeper's work in the hour: open, set, greet, keep the extra place from being used as a spare stool, send a child for more bread if the hands have not already gone, and say the sentence if someone is sitting their second night. When the moon goes down they sleep. Daylight is their Sabbath: the day is for sleep.

They do not confirm becoming. There is no Leaf-Fall on the isle. They do not vouch a Struck in the mainland sense; Struck are rare enough to be a family matter, not a class. They do not licence, graft, or file.

An ordinary supper

The extra place is not only feast-furniture. A poor house lays it on a quiet night. To omit it is the one real impiety. The people the place is kept for do not starve when it is omitted. The wrong is the count: you have counted the household too small. The hands fetch and pour. That work is why a table-keeper can host beyond their means without running a charity for Tithes.

A child of the house learns the work by carrying dishes and by being told not to sit in the extra place. That is the apprenticeship. There is no Seat to confirm it.

An attic on Lestrand

A Yumboe on the mainland is a table-keeper **by necessity**. Morning (their night-end): they may work a quay kitchen, mend, copy, rent in the local coin. Evening: they lay the extra place in a room that fits four. Someone climbs the stair. First night they are a guest. Second night the host says the sentence and means it. The quay will not file the guest as a citizen. The host will still set them a place the third night.

This is how the faith travels, when it travels at all. It does not travel as a mission. There is no Njaalo chapter-house, no collection, no Road-hand of the moon. A second Yumboe in the same city may share a supper and not share a roof. Both are of the table. A mainlander who has sat twice and opened their *own* room is of the table too.

The second sitting

The first night you are a guest (and a guest is already sacred). The second, you are of the table. On Kumbaan this is how a stranger becomes kin, nearly law, in all but parchment. On the mainland this collides with citizenship-by-witness: you belong because your town *watched you Turn*, not because you ate twice.

A table-keeper who treats the second supper as belonging is doing their faith honestly. A warden who smiles and files them as a guest is doing the warden's faith. The sentence does not cross the storm-wall intact. The host's job, abroad, is to keep the sentence inside the room and not pretend the clerk will honour it.

What they carry

An extra plate. Songs. The sentence. On the isle, a hall (inherited, or the one that still fits). On the mainland, rent and whatever the room will hold. No stamp. No token from a land-door. No colour-scrap. No Cutting-leave.

The extra place is set slightly back from the board, not at the end. A mainlander who puts it at the foot "for a servant" is corrected. No sermon. The plate is moved.

What they refuse

- They will not read a colour, tend a Tree, or keep a Night Watch.
- They will not turn the sentence into a contract or a binding spell. The host says, "Eat, and be the household."
- They will not test a guest. The storm-wall already did.
- They will not send a mission, collect for a hall across the water, or plant a Moon-Feast chapter in Vaethorn.
- They will not omit the extra place to look poorer or more devout. That is the one impiety.

Who may keep a table

Whoever will lay the place. A mainlander who sits once is a guest. A mainlander who sits twice is kin. A human, a Selkie, or a Kitsune who will lay the extra place is of the Njaalo. A Yumboe who will not is a neighbour, and not of the table.

By practice first. You are a table-keeper when the valley (or the attic-stair) comes to you, and you set the place. There is no apprenticeship confirmed by a Seat. A child who has carried dishes on the bright nights is being watched. A mainland convert who has sat twice and opened their own room is being watched by whoever they fed.

Staying and Serving set the same table. A Staying host will say the dead’s names. A Serving host will not, and will call the hands the hill’s own courtesy. Both set the extra place. Both pass the same cup. The argument waits until the dishes are done.

On Kumbaan the work barely follows a Condition. Elsewhere, the person whose life fits the table often keeps it. The table still seats the others.

Act	Often	Why	Also, and welcome
Hill-hall on the isle	whoever inherited the hall	no Given Conditions on Kumbaan; Kind is Yumboe *because that is who lives there*, not because the order requires it	a rare Struck who still hosts; a mainlander who stayed after the second sitting
Attic on the mainland	a Yumboe abroad (by necessity)	they are still keeping Ndeyaan with whatever table they can make	a mainland convert who sat twice; a Kept clerk who likes the night better than the Tree
Laying the extra place	anyone of the table	the one impiety is omitting it	the poor house as much as the deep-hill hall

The feared-licensed are not barred and almost never arise on the isle. A Phoenix is not a host the Njaalo have a rite for. A Bound who sits twice is kin; their Terms are not a grace said over the plate.

Struck table-keepers on the mainland must still be vouched anew if they want to stay in a town. The second supper will not satisfy a clerk who wants a Turning-witness. Abroad, that is how the house lives.

How they live with the other houses

House	Everyday arrangement	The hard edge
the Tree-Wardens	Almost no contact. A warden who crosses the storm-wall is a guest at supper. There is no Tree to tend.	No mission-chapter on Kumbaan. No moon-warden on the mainland.
the Watchers	A Watcher who crossed would find the night already kept, for a different reason.	No Night Watch on the isle.
the Book-Hands	A Settler who sits twice has been called kin in a language with no book.	The sentence is a courtesy, not a term.
the Door-Keepers	Ancestor-meals set a place for the dead who stayed in the ground. A traveller can mistake that place for the extra seat. The dead in the ground are not the hands that fetch and pour.	The Door-Keepers walk no doors on Kumbaan.
the Shore-Sitters	Sister house. They sit the storm-beach. A living wreck they walk uphill; they do not seat on the sand.	A Table-Keeper does not go down to wait. The sand decides *alive*; the hall decides *kin*.

How they live in the three corners (and off the map)

Vaethorn, Lestrand, and Threnmaieth barely reach this house.

- **Kumbaan (hill-hosts).** This is their home. The Njaalo is simply who opened the hall. The moon sets the night, not the solstice. Wholeness is the default. They keep no queue, no roll, no book, and no second reading.
- **Lestrand (the Moon-Feast people).** A quay-story. An attic-host is a curiosity and a good supper. “No one is a stranger twice” is printed, by sailors, as a proverb on a card. The Settling will not enforce it. The attic-host will, inside the room, and cannot outside it.
- **Vaethorn (a sailor’s tale).** Hot faith, thin reach: a table-keeper is a wonder if they ever arrive, and a test of Guest-reading courtesy. They will be fed. They will be asked about the Mother. They will not understand why a people need to be *chosen* in order to be wanted.
- **Threnmaieth (off the map).** Not on the roll. A Yumboe in the Sacred Core is a diplomatic incident of manners, not a column. The crown cannot file a people who were never at a Tree. That is a relief and a slight at once.

The sentence that will not travel

On Kumbaan, the second sitting is how you belong. On the mainland, you belong because a town watched you Turn.

A table-keeper abroad who treats the second supper as kin-making is keeping Ndeyaan. The warden, the clerk, and the Book-hand who smile and file them as a guest are keeping their own rule for belonging. The sentence does not cross the storm-wall intact. The hardest case is Turning-Week: a child of the table, a host who will not walk them to a Tree, a neighbour who will, and a door that shuts on the last day of Eolthael.

Hospitality that is nearly law on one side of the water is a proverb on the other, and romanticizing the Moon-Feast is itself a slight. They have no scion-queue and no mission. An attic-host is one person and one supper, with no authority outside the room.

Economy of the house

- **The hall is the living.** On Kumbaan a table-keeper is fed by the same feast they host. The unseen hands make a poor house's extra place possible. There is no stipend, no Cutting-leave, no pilgrimage-share.
- **An attic pays rent in the local coin.** A Yumboe abroad works as anyone works. They may cook for a quay. They do not furnish a venting-hall.
- **No collection for a hall across the water.** That would be a mission. There isn't one.

A place-card

Badly copied by a Strandor sailor who did come back, and sold on a Lestrand quay as a dinner-grace. The verso is the sailor's own hand: "for luck at second sitting."

> *We have counted you. Sit. If you have a name we have not learned it yet; if you have a colour we have no tree to read it. The moon is enough light. Eat, and be the household. And if you sit again, you are not a stranger. This is not a proverb. Do not sell it as one.*

The card is a hospitality blessing, half-ruined by the quay copy. The sailor thought it was a grace. On the isle it is a legal sentence in all but parchment. The last two lines were added by the table-keeper when she saw him copy the blessing, and he sold them anyway. Lestrand files the Njaalo as a Moon-Feast story, lucky if you eat twice. The woman in the attic still sets the place.

The Shore-Sitters

A second Kumbaan house. They belong to the isle, and they do not keep a mainland order. The Table-Keepers open the hall. These sit the storm-beaches. Almost no one reaches the isle. Someone still sits the beach for the wreck that does.

Everyday: **shore-sitters**, also **wall-waiters.** Own-name: **Njawaal** (njah-WAHL), a Yumboe coinage. Not Maiethren. Table-keepers call them **the first night**. The joke is that a wreck is not yet kin.

In one sentence: they sit the storm-shore with their back to the hill-hall and wait. They do not swim the wall, they do not test anyone with a colour, and if someone is still breathing they walk them uphill to a table.

If you meet one

A small person on a bad beach, lamp hooded so it does not call ships in. They look like they have been there a long time. They will not wade. They will take a living mainlander by the sleeve and start the path up. They will name a drowned body if the house leans Staying, or they will not, if it leans Serving, and they will still carry the body above the tide.

You would not call them a priest. You would find them by asking, “Who sits the black sand when the wall is loud?”

What they actually do

- **Sit.** Storm nights, wreck-moons, the weeks after a crossing rumor. One person per stretch if the coast is kept at all. Reputation, not a roster.
- **Receive.** Living: water, a blanket, no questions about Kind or colour. Dead: above the tide. Cargo: what the hall can use. They do not loot for a market. There is no quay.
- **Hand uphill.** The living go to a table-keeper. First night as *guest* starts at the hall, not on the sand. The shore-sitter is why there was a first night.
- **Refuse the wall.** They do not swim out. They do not keep a boat for rescue. The wall is not a door they walk. A mainlander who asks “why didn’t you come for me sooner?” is told, by the shore-sitter, “We do not call the sea. We wait.”

They do not keep the extra place (that is the hall). They do not Speak, stamp, or walk old mainland doors. They do not send anyone back across.

Who comes

Almost no one comes. A shore-sitter's year may be empty. The job is still to sit. When someone does come, the whole valley hears it as news, not as a shipping schedule.

How they sit with the table-keepers

Same faith, two jobs. The shore decides *alive*. The hall decides *kin*. A shore-sitter who starts laying the extra place on the sand has started doing the other house's work. A table-keeper who walks the black sand every storm has started doing this one. Both can happen in a thin year. Most years they are different people.

Said to a sailor who did come back

The night before he was walked uphill. Copied later as a quay-story, badly.

> *We did not fetch you. The wall does not owe you a hand. Sit until you can walk. If you walk, there is a hall. If you do not, we will still take you off the sand. Do not thank the sea. It was not kind. We were only here.*

The sitter sounds cold, and the message is plain: they did not fetch the sailor, the wall owes nobody a hand, and what he got was a wait, not a rescue. They do not say the crossing was a gift or a pilgrimage the Mother arranged.

The Slide

The lived face of illicit Tithe-supply. They are not clergy, and they are not one of the five faiths. They are the house for the week you cannot pay. They do not help a person pay a Tithe. They step in when a person starts to fail, and they make the failing last.

Everyday: **the Slide**, also **week-keepers.** Cant: **the Vaethledd** (VAYTH-led). Vaethorn says **the last pot** (or *gift-credit*, when the commons have run out). Lestrand says **week-rent** the way it says landlord. Threnmaieth files nothing; the roll already has a counted hall. A clerk who knows will say **the late week**.

In one sentence: they rent you *not falling*. One week of green, one outlet, one new page, and they are never in a hurry to let you get free.

They do not rewrite Bound Terms, steal scions, or sell a false Turning-witness.

Shape of the house

- **A practice with a key.** There is no seat, no colour, no roster, no cellar liturgy. You are of the Slide when someone comes back next week. Reputation. When they die, the book of weeks goes to whoever still has a pot, a room, or a key.
- **One job.** Furnish just enough Tithe-supply that the person does not become a public hazard, and never enough that they recover. The product is the week. The price is remaining theirs.
- **They call it rent.** They extend. They keep a book. They will tell you, “I kept someone whole.” A kind face, a real key, a measured withhold later.
- **They are not the official halls.** They do not stamp books, Speak colours, walk old doors, or open a hill-hall. They do not run the town greenhouse, the counted ael-hall, or a licence-guild. Those are the doors that make a person wait. On ordinary days the guilds pretend not to know these people. When an official gate closes on purpose, the pretence is over, because the guild and the Slide are then serving the same street.

If you meet one

They look like a landlord. A cousin who still has a pot after the commons ran dry. A junior clerk at a deathless house who will extend a novelty subscription one more week. A person with a spare room and a voice who will let you cry there, for a price that is never quite coin.

You would not call them a priest. You would find them by asking, “Who still has green when the leaf-lot is closed?”

They are useful the way a week is useful. They do not stamp a book, Speak a colour, or sell a false witness of a Turning.

Who comes, and when

Who	Why they come	What the week-keeper does	What they will not do
A Taken-In cut off from land	The greens-queue is longer than the wilt	Rent a pot, a strip, a night on living dirt. Extend if the week cannot be paid.	Will not give them a commons-share that lasts. Will not walk them to a warden to be filed as housed.
A Far-Voiced who lost a stage	Isolated posting, dull labor, nowhere to vent. A feeling is about to break into everyone in earshot. That is the Cry.	A room, an hour, a door that shuts. One outlet. The next week is the same week.	Will not find them honest work. Will not let the Cry happen in the street. That brings the watch, and ruins the book.
A Long-Lived whose novelty has thinned	The endowment is late; the fade has started	A page, a letter, a gossip that is *new enough*. Rationed.	Will not endow a library. Will not be their deathless patron in public.
An Unbound losing warmth	Company costs; the hole is getting loud	Sit with them. Be known, a little. Charge for the company.	Will not be family. Will not sign them a new Bargain. That is another table.
A Bound behind on *civic* coin	Rent, a guild fee, a year that will not close	Hold the debt. Extend. Use the hold.	**Will not rewrite Terms.** Money, not a clause. Will not sell a cellar-easing.
A Returned whose Purpose pays nothing	The work the dead want is not a trade	A week of keep so they can keep walking.	Will not furnish the Purpose. Will not send them to a plague-ward unless the ward pays *them*.
A family, before the town sees	A child or a parent is sliding; they will pay so the square does not	Take the week. Take the family's coin. Keep the person *quiet*.	Will not tell the warden. Will not make the slide a sermon.

An ordinary week

They **extend first.** That is the hook, and it is also what they believe about themselves. A person arrives already late. The week-keeper does not withhold on the first night. They open the lot, the room, the page. They write *extended*. They name a day.

The withhold comes later, and it is measured. Never enough to make a public hazard (a wilt in the square, a Cry in the market, a fade a neighbour can name), because that brings the watch, the guild, the counted hall, and the book dies. Never enough to let the person stand up and walk to a commons that would keep them. The asset is a person who is always almost whole.

They keep a **book of weeks**, not a ledger of coin. Coin is how some weeks are paid. The thing they are counting is *how long you have not fallen, on their floor.*

A child of the house learns the work by carrying water to the pots and by being told not to let a guest sleep a second week for nothing. There is no Seat to confirm it.

What they carry

A key. A pot, a spare room, a stack of pages that are new enough. A book of weeks. No stamp. No colour-scrap. No Cutting-leave. No false witness to sell in the square.

What they refuse

- They will not pretend to be clergy. No colour, no book-stamp, no door-walk, no extra place.
- They will not rewrite a Bound's Terms. They may hold a Bound's *rent*. That is money.
- They will not steal a scion or sell *I watched you Turn.*
- They prefer not to push someone over the scary edge. A corpse, a public Cry, a wilt the town can see: a ruined week and a ruined name. Nothing stops a keeper who is losing the book from withholding too far, and a measured week can miss.
- They will not run a mission, a cellar-church, or a Kumbaan export. There is almost no Tithe on the isle to own.
- They will not call the week a gift. They will also not call it a cruelty. They call it a week.

Who may keep a week

Whoever has the pot and the book. A human, a Kitsune, a Selkie, or a Tengu who has a pot and a book can be of the Slide. A Yumboe abroad who has started charging for the extra place has committed a different sin, one that belongs to the Table-Keepers' argument and not to the Slide.

By practice first. You are of the Slide when someone comes back next week, and you still have the key. There is no apprenticeship confirmed by anyone. A cousin who extended once and then let the person recover was kind. They are not of this house.

The week draws whoever already has the supply. Anyone with the key may still keep it. The house does not bar a Condition.

Act	Often	Why	Also, and welcome
A pot, a strip, a night of dirt	a Taken-In who kept a private lot	they already furnish green	a Kept with a window-box and no Tithe of their own
A shut room, an hour of voice	a Far-Voiced with a spare hall	they already know what an outlet costs	a performer who lost the honest stage and kept the door
A page that is new enough	a Long-Lived clerk, a junior at a deathless house	novelty is already what their year runs on	anyone who can still find a rumour the fade has not heard
The book of weeks itself	whoever can read a late face	the house is the count, not the crop	a Kept broker, unencumbered, can move, can carry the book to the next town

The feared-licensed are not barred. A Stilled who rents stillness-hours is rare and tightly watched. A Bound who holds civic debt is dealing in money, not in a Counterparty’s Terms.

How they live with the other houses

House	Everyday arrangement	The hard edge
the Tree-Wardens	Almost no contact. A warden furnishes a Tree, not a week.	A Road-hand is not a week-cart. A scion is not Tithe-pay.
the Watchers	A Watcher who sat an eve-vigil is not in this book.	They do not sell a false watch.
the Book-Hands	A Settler who marked *owing* has just made a customer. The clerk will watch them walk down the quay.	The Slide does not stamp. The clerk does not furnish. The Bound they cannot help is still not this house's Terms to rewrite.
the Door-Keepers	A Struck named *kin* at a door still has a Tithe. Kinship is not green.	A drowning-stone is not a rented lot.
the Table-Keepers	No contact that matters. The second sitting is not a week.	They do not charge for the extra place. That is a different faith's one impiety.
Official halls and greens	The official hall, the counted green, the licence. The town is glad someone "takes the late ones."	The pretence ends when the official gate closes on purpose. The worst case is a public wilt or Cry that the gate caused.

How they live in the three corners (and off the map)

- **Vaethorn (the last pot).** This is where the pious version lives. The commons ran out. A cousin still has a pot. They will say they are tending a gift. The quiet obligation is the week: you are helped, and you are theirs. Public help here already shades toward service you cannot refuse. The last pot is that pressure, kept private.
- **Lestrand (week-rent).** Ordinary. Posted, almost. A leaf-lot by the season is already the honest market. The Slide is the lot that will still open after the season-fee failed, at a price that is the next season. No sermon. A landlord.
- **Threnmaieth (the late week).** The crown already holds Tithe. The Slide does not compete with the counted hall on ordinary days. They sell the week the hall is late, the extra green the roll does not cover, the novelty the archive will not release. They look like a clerk. The crown's count is cold and precise. The Slide is the week that count cannot write down without admitting the channel failed. The roll pretends not to know.
- **Kumbaan.** The Slide has no work there, because the isle has no Tree and almost nobody on it carries a Given Tithe. A wreck walked uphill is a guest, not a debtor.

The week that will not end

Whoever supplies a Tithe that someone else depends on holds power over that person. The Slide is that power with a landlord's face, and with a patience the official hall is not allowed.

The town is glad. A person who is quietly almost falling is not a Cry in the market. A devout neighbour can say the gift is still being tended. A crown clerk can say the channel held. The quay can say the owing was marked and someone took them in.

The Motherfaith says she gave the need. The book of weeks is people's work, and nobody in a town expects the Tree to make the week fair.

The house has no queue of scions, no refinancing, and no authority except the one the Tithe gives its keepers: one key and a measured week.

Adding a Term to a Bound, and selling a person who will swear they watched a Turning, are other trades. The Slide does not do either. Those trades are the Holding Desk and the Standing Trade.

Economy of the house

- **The week is the living.** Paid in coin, in labor, in a favor, in a child sent to carry water. The book counts weeks first.
- **The official doors sit next to them.** A town greenhouse, a counted ael-hall, an endowed long-house of books: those are the official sector. A week-keeper may sit next to all three and take the overflow.
- **Deathless proximity.** A junior at a long-house who rations novelty is how a fortune that never dies feels on the street: not a loan of a century, a page at a time. The house does not run the bank.
- **No collection for a hall across the water.** There isn't one.

A week-slip

Lestrand leaf-lot, pinned inside a door that still opens after the season-fee has failed. The verso is the same slip, last week, the date scratched once.

> *One week of the lot. Extended. Do not let the pot dry. If you cannot come, send a child. The week is the same week. We do not call this a gift. We do not call it a debt. Come before the leaves turn. If you have already turned, come anyway.*

The slip is a landlord's, practical and almost kind. The product is not falling, and the slip never calls the week a debt, which is how the book stays a book of weeks and never closes. "If you have already

turned, come anyway” is the house’s whole case: becoming did not save anyone from needing them. The child who carries water is learning the trade.

The Holding Desk

Everyday: **the Holding Desk**, also **hold-clerks**. Lestrand says it the way it says *extension*. Vaethorn has no clean word and calls it **the second signing** when a preacher wants a sin. Threnmaieth files nothing.

They are not the Slide. They do not rent green, an hour, or a page. They work in **clauses**.

A Bound finishes a civic year at an honest table. The year is payable. The **Terms** are not. The Term still hangs over them. That hanging Term is the Pledge, and the fear of it starts the next ask. The hold-clerk names a smaller Term that covers the larger one for a season. Each signing gives up more of the person. The accumulated Terms now hold the Bound. That last signing is the Given-Over. Guild speech calls it the Forfeit. The law has never decided when the person on the stool stopped being one.

Mutelo of the Lower Slip *(moo-TEL-o)* keeps the oldest chair on Orentel. They will tell you they kept a person walking. The book on the shelf is labelled “extensions.” The last page is the Forfeit.

They will not rent a Tithe-week. They will not sell the sentence “I watched you Turn.” They will not rewrite a Term the Counterparty has already named. They add a Term. They rest on that distinction: an added Term is not a rewritten one.

The Standing Trade

Citizenship is witnessed, not recorded. At a distance, the proof is a person who will speak. The unvouched will buy one.

Everyday: **the Standing Trade**. A buyer asks for “a standing.” A seller says “I was there,” and means they will say it later, in a square that was not theirs. Lestrand prices it. Vaethorn calls it **false kin**. Threnmaieth does not need it on ordinary days, because the roll is already the proof, and wants a bought witness badly when a name is missing.

They are not the Slide. They do not rent a week. They are not the Holding Desk. They do not write a Term. The product is a person who will stand and say they watched.

Nomele of the Hinge *(no-MEL-eh)* works the Old Crossing face — the Hinge Shore more often than Orentel, because the Old Crossing has two shores and a standing has to travel between them. They do

not sell paper. They sell who will walk with you to the next Tree.

The market fails in public when an honest Long-Lived is asked to Blood-Read the seller. They taste one drop of blood and see a true memory, and if the memory is the sale, every standing that seller has sold dies with it. It also fails when a Far-Voiced sells a feeling of belonging and a Cry in the same square spreads that false feeling to everyone in earshot.

The Reckoned Offices

Everyday: **the Reckoned Offices**, or just **the tablet offices**. They are four jobs the Tallied Crown already had, now with names a traveller can ask for at the hall. Naming them did not found a church, and it did not found a country. They sit in the tablet-hall at Maiethlir. The grove and the First Seat are other buildings. Rithim is still town Speaker. These offices speak for the roll. They do not replace Rithim. The fight is the space between a colour Spoken in the square and a name written down.

Who	Job	What they want
Menirein *(men-EE-rayn)*	registrar	the roll complete. An unlisted child is a child the crown cannot keep hale.
Tarvae *(TAR-vay)*	Reckoned Speaker	Speaking and filing to stay one act. A colour Spoken and not written is a seeing that can be stolen.
Videm *(VEE-dem)*	channel-clerk	the counted hall, the tended green, and the hour of each, matched to the name on the roll.
Sirtal *(SIR-tal)*	warrant-hand	a channel that can be shut until the name is on the roll and stops changing.

They recruit by office and practice, not by Kind. Long-Lived memory is common at the tablet and is bent to the census rather than free to check it.

The Pourers

Everyday: **the Pourers**, also **the Cup Circle**. Neighbours call the practice **the five-year cup**, because five years is what the circle asks of a member in all, and they smile when they say it, the way people smile about a rich uncle’s hobby. The Motherfaith calls it a private devotion. The Fair Hand will not stamp it, because they cannot see anyone on the other side of the deal. The Watching counts it as one more cost of a long life, and says it has nothing to do with the Mother. The Old Ways do not treat it as a sacred place or a door. The Open Table has no use for it.

They are Long-Lived who give years of memory into a cup, one year at a time, so they can keep living without carrying everything. They say the cup holds a god they made. That claim is the centre of the practice. It is not a Turning. No leaf falls, and no warden Speaks a colour. It is not one of the five lived faiths.

If you meet one

You meet a Long-Lived person with a small, ordinary cup. They have given some of their years of memory away, one year at a time, up to five. They are missing those years, and they are still recognizably the same person. They will tell you they invented the god on the other side of the cup. They will describe how their circle pictures it this decade: as a librarian, a quiet guest, or a child who never left home. The picture changes. The rule does not. Members give years. The cup keeps what they gave. The cup cannot Give a Condition, and it cannot save anyone from death.

Molevad *(mo-LEV-ad)* keeps the minutes of the best-known circle, on a long-house shelf in Lestrand. Molevad comes from an old quay that the sea has worn down, and is the oldest member in the room. Molevad keeps the book and the key to the shelf. Molevad is not a priest.

A second, quieter circle meets in Orenbren, in an upper room of a lodging-house that once slept travellers. It keeps the same practice. It does not ask Molevad's circle for permission, and the two circles do not write to each other.

The ask

Every Long-Lived person is asked once to join the Pourers. A member asks them in person. At the long-house shelf in Lestrand, a member of Molevad's circle asks. In the upper room in Orenbren, a member of that circle asks. A Long-Lived person who lives in another town is still asked once, by a member who can reach them. A person who has already been asked says so, and that answer stands.

The invitation is real. The member asks because the circle will accept the person who says yes. A yes makes them a member.

A refusal is not punished. The person keeps their standing. People still consult them, and the work a court, a guild, or an archive already gave them stays theirs. A long-house still seats a person who refused. Most Long-Lived people are not members. Every Long-Lived person knows the circle exists.

The gift

A member gives **one year** into the cup. Each year is its own night, with its own minutes, and the member may stop before the next one. Five years is what the circle asks of a member in all. Members say they give "the memories that year held, and the year itself." Each year given means three things.

- **The memory goes into the cup.** The member puts a single drop of their own blood in the cup, because Long-Lived already read memory from blood. Afterward the member no longer has the memories of that year. They still need to keep learning, as every Long-Lived does. What changes is that they no longer carry that year of other people's funerals.
- **The papers go onto the shelf.** The member also gives the long-house shelf everything they wrote or kept in that year: letters, account books, diaries, and court notes. The papers are not put in the cup. They are filed on the shelf under the member's name. Other members can read them, and so can a visitor Molevad allows to read them. Letters name other people, and those people were not asked before their letters went onto the shelf.
- **The long-house counts the member one year younger.** At a long-house that keeps the circle, a Long-Lived person's age and standing are counted only in the years they still remember. A member who has given three years is seated as if they were three years younger. Among the Long-Lived, age decides who speaks first, who judges a hard case, and who keeps a key, so every year given costs a member rank inside those long-houses. Courts, guilds, banks, and Long-Lived who are not members keep counting the ordinary way. The same person can be a bank's most senior clerk and sit below a younger member at the long-house.

Members can read the cup the way a Long-Lived reads a drop of blood. What they read is true. It is also mixed: one reading can hold memories of the same year from more than one member. The oldest member writes down who gave which year, how the circle described the god that decade, and whether anyone asked to stop.

Leaving

A member may stop before the next year, or leave the circle. The years already given stay in the cup. The circle gives back the papers from those years. It does not give back the memory. Members call the returned papers a **thinner copy** of what was given.

The real cost is social. The circle treats the person as someone who weakened the god. Other Pourers will not read blood with them. A long-house that keeps the circle will not give them a seat. They are free to go, and they will be alone among the other people who do not age.

Reimaethe *(RYE-may-theh)* lives in a rise-loft in Orentel. They have given four years, one at a time, and want to stop before the fifth. They want their papers back, thin as that copy is, because the papers are all the circle returns. Neighbours still call the loft a hobby.

The members who have asked to stop are called the withdrawers. They have each given one or more years. They do not all want to stop for the same reason. They are not a second circle, and they keep no minutes. When a circle meets, a withdrawer stands in the passage and does not go in. They will not say why they stand there instead of going home.

The work

Members keep the library on the long-house shelf in Lestrand. That shelf is the deathless library on the Ledger Coast. They copy the Old Tongue, and they copy the common speech people already use. The copies stay on the shelf, beside the papers members have given with their years. Molevad keeps the minute-book on the same shelf. The circle in the upper room in Orenbren keeps the records of its own meetings. People use the books and the copies. The work is real.

They do not take over medicine. That work stays with the Stilled. Towns already call on the Stilled as surgeons, menders, and peacekeepers.

What the circle says it made

The circle calls the presence in the cup the Cup We Made. On a quay people call it the Poured God. Its name is **the Unspent**. It is a small household presence that stores the memories it is given, and the circle says they made it. It does not make plans. It cannot Give a Condition or Strike anyone into one, and it cannot make anyone Long-Lived. If a member asks the cup for more years, a second Condition, or a rescue from death, the cup only keeps what it already holds.

In Lestrand the Pourers are an ordinary hobby that happens to have a library key. In Vaethorn a preacher who needs a sin may call the cup an insult to the Mother's gift, and most households will not notice. Threnmaieth wants the minutes on its roll. Molevad's circle files nothing the crown could use.

From the minutes

On the Lestrand long-house shelf, in Molevad's hand. Someone drew a face in the margin and scratched it out twice.

> *One year from S. into the Cup We Made. Face this decade: the quiet guest. Blood as record. The circle read a year that was not only S.'s. We do not write which. If S. asks the years back, the return is thinner and the copy stays. If S. asks the cup for a leaf, the cup keeps what it already has. We made the listener. We will not stand it in a square. We will not say Mother. We will say the shelf.*

These are the circle's own words. They record a member, S., giving one year. They say that a reading of the cup held memories of a year that belonged to more than one person. They say what happens if S. asks for the years back: the papers come back, and the memory stays in the cup. The scratched-out face in the margin is the circle changing its mind about how to picture the god.

The Walled Book and the Inner Close

Everyday: **the Walled Book**. The class that keeps it: **the Closed Heirs**. The place: **Rothallo** *(roh-THAL-oh)*, Orenbren's walled capital, one day's walk from the Motherwood. People still say **the Inner Close**, and **the Close**. The walls answer to those names. It is the same city. It stays inside Orenbren, and it is not a realm of its own. Orenbren calls the arrangement a guest-compact: its inns lodge anyone outside the wall, and the Book rules inside it. Threnmaieth treats the Book as a rival roll, because the Book will not let Threnmaieth's clerks copy its pages. The First Seat stays in the wood. Rothallo is not the college.

This is political class rule, not a church. They do not Speak colours. They classify. Folk still say there was an older empire of the untithed, and that it sat on the grove. They are right. The everyday historical name for it is **the Closed Seat.** The walls are what is left of it. How the Closed Seat broke is the history of the Closing. The Book is present tense.

If you meet one

They look like lodging-gentry who never took a Tithe. They do not take the heavy turns of work inside the walls. Each one carries a key to a gate in the wall, and a person with a Condition may not carry that key. You would miss them as clergy. You would find them if you asked who still decides what a Given owes besides the Tithe they already carry.

Delamem *(del-AH-mem)* keeps the Book of Tithes. Delamem will tell you the Book is housekeeping. The page that assigns labour is in the same hand as the page that assigns a hearth-tax. **Talnin of the Inner Close** *(TAL-nin)* is a Closed Heir of the present generation. The name is on the heir-roll. Talnin's tenth year, the Leaf-Fall year, is not finished. Delamem has already drafted the turns of work for the case where the leaf is not a hug.

A Closed child Given at the next Leaf-Fall is the house's fear. Threnmaieth copying the Book onto the Threnhael is the other. The third is Orenbren deciding the guest-compact is a bed-tax.

What a visitor sees

A visitor to Rothallo does not need to read the Book to see the rank. It shows in four places.

- **Where a person sits.** At a meal in a Closed house, the Kept sit at the end of the table nearest the host. A guest who received a Condition is shown to the far end, past the last Kept guest. When the Book is read aloud in the Book's house, the Kept sit on the front benches and everyone else sits behind them. Nobody is turned away from the table. The host says where each guest sits, and the guest is expected to sit there.

- **Whose word is taken.** When two people disagree in front of a clerk of the Book, over a debt, a boundary, or a broken pot, and one of them is Kept and the other has a Condition, the clerk writes the Kept person's account as what happened. The other account is written underneath it as "also said." The person with a Condition can still win. To win, they need a second Kept person to say the same thing they said.
- **Who holds a key.** Only a Kept person may hold a key to a gate in the wall, to the Book's house, to a cistern, or to a granary. A person with a Condition holds the key to their own door and to their own stall, and no others.
- **What the school teaches.** The children of the Closed houses learn their letters at a school beside the Book's house. Other families inside the walls may send a child if they pay. The teacher, **Volnai** *(VOL-nai)*, tells the children that a hug is rare, and that a child the Tree hugged was kept back for something better than a colour. Volnai believes this and teaches it every year.

A person with a Condition who lives inside the walls works for wages, keeps what they earn, owns their tools and their household goods, marries whom they choose, and can own a stall. The Book writes a licence for that stall. A Kept stall-keeper needs no licence. A person with a Condition can walk out of the gate on any day it is open and live somewhere else. Nobody owns them. They are not slaves. What they cannot have inside the walls is the heir's place, a gate key, a vote in the Close's compact, or the first word in front of a clerk.

The lesson and the count

The Close teaches that a hug is rare. It is not. Most towns have Kept neighbours, and the real shares are the ones given with the Conditions. Most Kept people have never heard of the heir-roll.

What is actually rare is a family that has stayed without a Condition on purpose, generation after generation, and treats that record as a birthright. The Closed houses do it in two ways. An heir who receives a colour is struck from the heir-roll, so the roll only ever lists people who were hugged. An heir also does not swear the kind of oath that can Strike a person, and stays away from the other ways a person can be Struck where they can. After enough generations, every name on the roll belongs to a hugged person. A family like that is rare. Being hugged is common.

Delamem and the other clerks of the Book can read the count. The school does not teach it. If a visitor brings the count to the Close, a clerk will say the count is someone else's record and does not bind the Close, and the school teaches the same lesson the next year.

The Book of Tithes

The Book is a roster, not a hymn.

- **Taxes.** Coin, board, and a cut of self-paying labour. An Answered shop inside the walls pays a craft-due the Ember-yard on the quay does not. A Two-Bodied ranging-week is scheduled as owed work before it is a ranging.
- **Restrictions.** Where a person with a Condition may hold a key, a stall, or a vote in the Close's compact. The Kept hold those. A Given who keeps a stall does it as a licensed exception, written down.
- **Turns of work.** Everyone who lives inside the walls owes the Close turns of work, the way a town expects each household to take a turn on the watch. The Book keeps the list of turns: green, hall, wall, road, and the beds outside the gate. A Kept household's turns are mostly the watch on the wall and the keeping of keys. A household with a Condition is given the heavier turns, and more of them, and the Book picks the turn by the Condition. The turns are not the Tithe. A person with a Condition owes the turns in addition to their Tithe. A person who does not want the turns can leave the city. The Book's list has no claim on anyone who lives outside the walls. The Book does not sell a person, lend a person to an employer, or hand a person over the way an owner hands over a worker. It cannot send for someone who has left.

A Closed Heir who is **Given** at Leaf-Fall loses the heir's place. The hug keeps the name on the heir-roll. The colour takes it off. The person is still a person, and no longer a Closed Heir. The Book already has turns of work written for what they have become. A Closed Heir who is **Struck** later, by a drowning, an oath, or a death, is treated the same way. The Book strikes the name from the heir-roll when the clerks learn of it.

The heir-roll lists only the Close's own heirs. Threnmaieth's Threnhael writes everyone and keeps them. The Book ranks people by whether they carry a Tithe, and will strike an heir for receiving a gift. Orenbren's sleep-line at the gate records who slept in a bed. The Book records who owes turns of work. Neither lets the other copy its page.

Outside the walls

The Book stays inside Rothallo. The habit of ranking a hug above a colour does not. Three places show how far it reaches and where it stops.

- **Orenbren, outside the wall.** The lodging-guilds do not ask a guest's colour, and the sleep-line at the gate does not record it. Near the gate it is different. An inn that wants the Closed houses' business keeps its best table for Kept guests on the nights a Closed house dines there, and moves a guest with a Condition to another table if the Closed house asks. The guild does not forbid this. In Turning-Week, when the Close will not lodge a Given pilgrim, the inns outside the wall take that pilgrim in. Some of them charge more for it.
- **Vaethorn, which rejects the ranking in public.** At Eolvaeth, the gift-hall teaches that a colour is the Mother's gift and a hug is the Mother keeping a child as they are, and that neither makes a

person better than the other. The gift-hall says out loud, in its Eolthael preaching, that the Close's teaching is wrong. A Given person who has left the Close can eat at the gift-hall without being asked for a house. That is why **Hithaen** *(hith-AYN)* walked there. The Waiting Lands have their own unkindness, the other way round: a hugged child there is sometimes pitied as passed over by the Mother. The two teachings disagree with each other. Neither one matches the count.

- **Brenthael, which copies the seating.** Brenthael is the town with its own Tree a day's walk past the Third Hearth on the Near Mile. At its Turning-Week supper in the square, Kept people sit on the benches nearest the Tree, and people with a Condition sit on the outer benches, even when that splits a family. A child who has just received a colour gets up from an inner bench and moves to an outer one before the food is served. Brenthael has no copy of the Book, no heir-roll, and no list of turns. Nobody in the town can say when the seating started. They keep it because it is how the supper has always been laid out.

A leaf from the Book of Tithes

Inner Close, Delamem's hand. The line for heirs and the line for turns of work share a fold.

> *Talnin, Closed, heir. If the fall is a colour, strike heir. Enter labour under the colour as the page already holds. The hug keeps the line. We do not file this as a slight. We file it as a house. Orenbren may lodge who they witness. They may not lodge who we rank. The Threnhael may count who they can see from the river. They may not copy this page. A gift is a gift. A gift is not a seat.*

This is a page from the Book of Tithes. It records an heir, says the Book will strike the name if the Tree gives a colour, and tells Orenbren and Threnmaieth that neither may copy it. Delamem writes that the Book does not mean the striking as a slight, and that is how a child learns that a leaf can take a name.

The Protectors (as the square knows them)

Everyday, when anyone speaks of them: **the Protectors**. The building the world is allowed to know: **the Care**. A hospice-endowment. Old money. A closed court. The story that travels is that the one Phoenix is being kept safe, and that is why no town has seen them in a generation.

The Care says it holds the Phoenix, and says there is only one. They worship the one. They do not hold the worship in a square.

Vimein *(vih-MAYN)* keeps the outer book of the Care. Vimein speaks quietly and says little. They will say the Phoenix is in care. They will not produce them. They will offer a viewing of the closed court, a

hymn that does not name a Mother, and a request that you not carry a story back to a square that has finally gone quiet.

You would take them for a hospice clerk, and the building is a hospice.

What a neighbour can see: a hospice with old money and a closed court, and a generation of squares that speak of the Phoenix in the past tense and the present tense in the same sentence.

What they admit to refusing: they will not parade the Phoenix, because they say every square was staring at the one and the Care ended that. They will not open the inner court to a relic-hunter or to a Speaker who wants a colour-copy. They will not work a Kumbaan wreck. They will not stamp a ticket or rent a week.

A visitor’s slip

The Care, Vimein’s hand. The inner court is not on the slip.

> *The one is in care. The stories may rest. We do not produce a person for a square that has already decided what they mean. If you have come to worship, the hymn is said in the closed court and not in the street. If you have come to hunt, you will find a hospice. We keep the one. We keep the quiet.*

These are the Care’s own words to a visitor. They say the Phoenix is in care, that nobody will be shown them, and that the Care would like the story left alone.

What happens in the inner court is not told here.

Book IV

How People Live

Law and Citizenship

You belong to a town because that town watched you Turn. In your tenth year you stand at the town's Turning Tree. The people see a coloured leaf fall on you, and a Condition is Given, or they see the Tree hug you, and you are one of the Kept: witnessed, and left without a Condition.

The Leaf-Fall is the most-attended day of a community's year: kin, neighbours, the tree-wardens, all gathered. That is the tenth-year day.

So citizenship in the Turning is **witnessed, not recorded.** You are of a place because that place remembers you. It watched you become who you are.

There is no general register of the people. No town or church keeps a list of everyone and their gift. A list like that would be a record held on people. Belonging is the memory of the people who stood there. The Walled Book keeps its own heir-roll inside its walls, but it lists only its own heirs. Two crowns are exceptions and do keep a roll of persons: Threnmaieth, the Tallied Crown, calls its roll holy, and Trenledd, the Worn Count, does not. The rest of the world finds both unsettling.

This is how belonging works in the **Years of Hands**. That is the present age, and a town Tree is the ordinary place to Turn. In the **Walking Years**, people still had to walk to Thaeloren. That is the Awakening Tree. The crowd that saw you Turn was the crowd under it, or no one, if you never arrived. Someone who saw you there, or a word from that someone, can still carry the witness home.

In a village the witness is the whole settlement. In a city it is a **hearth** — a street, a quay-gang, a courtyard, a guild-stair — not twenty thousand people pretending to remember one child. The legal fact does not change.

Turning in a city: the hearth stood

A village of three hundred can remember every child. A salt-city of tens of thousands cannot. At that scale the witness is **nested**: a smaller circle inside the city, still the people who saw the child, and still no register.

The Tree is still at the centre. Turning-Week is still the week the town keeps for the rite. The square is still full. The legal fact is that **your hearth stood**. Naming the city only says where that hearth sits.

A hearth is eighty to two hundred people who already know the child. They bring their ten-year-olds in a named slot of the week. The warden speaks the colour, saying aloud the leaf's colour and so the

Condition, or names the hug. The city as a crowd saw a crowd. The hearth saw a child.

One **pillar** of that hearth — a Long-Lived, a Bound, or a Far-Voiced who stood — carries the memory when a far desk asks. Kin and neighbours carry it first; the pillar is how that memory travels. An orphan is still brought by kin, by the household that feeds them, or by the warden-hearth. A child no hearth will bring has missed the Turning, the same as in a village.

To prove you are of a city, you **name a hearth** and produce someone of it, or a pillar who stood. The person says, “I am of the third quay.” That sentence is citizenship. “I am of Orentel” names a place on the map.

Threnmaieth and Trenledd write down who stood. That is still the aberration. Everyone else keeps the week’s slate as hours: which hearth stands at which bell. The slate does not record the gift.

How you prove who you are: by *people*, not papers

Trust runs through people who cannot be faked, so you prove yourself by a person, not by a paper from a state.

You are known by **witnesses**. Everyday speech calls this **standing-for**. In Vaethorn, the Waiting Lands, someone vouches for you at worship, and they call that *the speaking*. In Lestrand, the Ledger Coast, they call a commercial guarantee *warranting*. In Threnmaieth, the Tallied Crown, you are named to the crown, and they call that *the naming*.

- A **Long-Lived** remembers you, and their memory is incorruptible and runs back centuries.
- A **Bound** vouches for you. A Bound’s sworn word is literally binding, so a false vouch is not a lie they can cheaply tell.
- A **Far-Voiced** speaks for you. Their voice betrays real feeling under strain, so they cannot smoothly lie on your behalf.

To establish yourself in a new place is to **be vouched into it**. You acquire people who will stand for you. **The friendless and the rootless are the truly vulnerable**, because they have no one to vouch. The law shuts out **the unvouched**.

The customs below keep a traveler vouched.

How a traveler stays vouched

The unvouched remain the vulnerable class. A legitimate traveler moves on someone’s word. The road still works the way it did when the witness had to come home from Thaeloren. The person who saw you, or their word, still has to be able to answer.

A watch that stops a stranger asks three things: **name, last hearth, who stands.** Answer any two and the road continues. Answer none and you are held until dawn, or until someone will stand, or you are walked to the next gate. The watch presses the person who can give none of the three. A company that can name a last host and show one mark is let through. An adventuring party uses the same three answers.

Custom	What it is	Where it stops
Road-word	A named person at origin or last town. You tell the watch, “Ask Halim of the third quay.” A Far-Voiced can call; a Bound can send a word; a letter is a token of the person who vouched.	The word holds while that person lives and will stand.
Company-vouch	A party stands for each other. One locally known or ticketed member covers the rest for passage.	You may sleep. You are not of this town.
Guild-mark	A stiller’s ticket, a Crae journeyman-mark from the element-guilds, a Voice-ticket. Craft marks travel. The mark says you may Gaze, work an element, or Cry in a hall.	Leave for that use, and nothing further.
House-note	A note from a deathless house. The Long-Lived who founded it still runs the bank. Credit that also stands for you, lightly.	Most travelers carry none.
Guest-right	A host who takes you in stands for the stay. An inn, a table, a road-house. You say, “I ate at X,” and it holds about a week.	The host must have taken you in.
Walk-custom	Someone on a named walk (Near Mile, Salt Walk, Long Mile, First-Hand year) is vouched as a walker by the road: mile-shrines, road-houses, a berth-slate.	When the walk ends, the word ends.

A person Struck on the road is vouched anew at the next desk that will take them. If the change is dangerous, that desk is the **Intake**. The guild takes them in because the hazard is already live. Changing without witnesses still leaves a gap someone must speak for. Having changed is lawful.

People still sell a vouch under no name. That sale sits outside the customs in the table. If the bought speaker will not answer when a Far-Voiced calls, the sale fails where everyone can hear it.

Kumbaan, the Sundering Isle, keeps no mainland road-word. You arrive unknown. A road-word, a company’s vouch, or a guild-mark still helps you leave a quay on Strandoren. That is the continent across the water. None of those make you known on the hill. On the isle, the right to be a guest is a seat at the table. Eating at the table a second time makes you kin of that table. A mainland watch will not take that table as the last hearth you name when they ask where you slept.

The Struck: those who changed *unwitnessed*

A Struck person acquired their Condition later, and alone: a drowning, a death, a sworn contract, long after their tenth-year Turning. The town watched everyone else become who they are. **No one watched the Struck.** They changed with no witnesses.

So a Struck person must be **vouched anew**. The community has to re-know them as what they have become, on the word of those who will stand for them. The old unease that the Struck are "a little suspect" is not only prejudice. Their becoming happened where no one could see it. A change everyone witnessed is trusted; a change that happened in the dark must be spoken for. Every polity has people whose transformation went unwitnessed, and every polity feels differently about that.

Two facts make that gap harder to close:

- **The dangerous Struck arrive raw.** A Struck Stilled or Far-Voiced manifests untrained, with the hazard already live and no guild to have caught it young. For these, being vouched-in is bound up with **mandatory guild-intake**. You are taken in hand and apprenticed at once, for everyone's safety, whether you wanted the vocation or not.
- **Some Struck changes sit beside a crime.** The Bound are Struck by a sworn contract; the Returned by dying. To vouch a Bound into a community is to acknowledge a contract no one witnessed being sworn, which is why contract-law and the acceptance of the Bound are tangled together.

Vaethorn's second word for the Struck is *the late-come*: met at a later door. Lestrand's is *the turned*: a fact, said plainly. Threnmaieth's is *the unwitnessed*: suspect until named.

The hour someone is Struck

The first hour is care. The person has changed, and nobody has a leaf-colour for them yet. The formal words can wait.

On a quay, the crew hauls the person up, counts the breaths, and does not walk them to the Tree that night. If a clerk opens a book over someone who cannot yet refuse a line, whoever is holding the person's head shuts the book. In a devout house, the family takes the person inside and does not take them to the Tree's roots tonight. A sibling who needs to may say "Maieth" over the blanket. Maieth is the short name devout people use for the Leaf-Mother. The person under the blanket is not required to say it. In a waiting town, they get the person dry and, if the person can sit, to the common pot. Nobody names a leaf-colour over the steam. The wet leaf on the town spring is not a sign for this hour. On the Sundering Isle, which is rare, Njunda feeds them. Nobody gives them a test, and nobody tells them the mainland story about the Mother.

If the change came by an oath, the people with them take the pen out of the hand until the person can hear the clause they are still agreeing to. If the change came by a death that did not finish, they keep

the person warm and do not name their Purpose that night. Later, a family that knows them can tell by a touch whether the Purpose is being tended, because a Returned who is settling goes cool. Someone who was turned to stone and came back, or who came out of the deep wild changed, is fed, and nobody brings them to a canopy that night. Being acknowledged at a Tree, settling their civic standing, or walking them back to an Old Ways door are later days. That door is the older faith's own household rite. If they are still inside their tenth year and Turning-Week is still open, they are brought to be welcomed. Nobody stands them under the Tree as if it were giving them a second life.

The Inviolate Will

Every polity holds one principle as the floor of law, and it holds because it is true: **no Condition can compel, control, or bend another person's will.** That is the **Inviolate Will**. The Bound's Whisper, the Far-Voiced's Cry, and the Long-Lived's regard cannot cross it: every Condition's danger stops at property, pain, and fear, at the edge of another's choosing. Every child is taught this maxim:

> ***"The will is one's own."***

Vaethorn keeps the maxim as *the Mother's own line*, and reads it as scripture. Lestrand cites *the free-will clause*, and treats it as ordinary commercial law. Threnmaieth cites *the crown's assurance*, and uses that citation to justify the roll.

A **Tithe** is the upkeep a Condition requires from the person who carries it.

- **The law has no charge for one Condition seizing another's mind,** because a Condition cannot do it. The Conditioned are charged as neighbours on that ground, and everyone knows the limit.
- **Harm done with a Condition splits in two. Negligent Tithe-lapse** (letting your element vent, your Cry break, your green go to seed) is a regulatory or public-nuisance matter. **Willful weaponizing** (deliberately turning a gift on someone) is ordinary violent crime, no gentler for the instrument. In practice only the Stilled's gaze supports a charge the hearing can speak as "you held a citizen still." Most of what the law deals with here is negligence. Assault is the smaller share.
- **A Bound can say, truthfully, "my contract cannot make you do anything."** Whether a given polity listens is where they diverge.

The safety-licence: how hazard is regulated (and by whom)

The law attaches to a particular person in one place: public safety. **A ticket attaches to a hazardous use, not to being Conditioned.** Across the world, a licence attaches where a practice is dangerous to others. Power alone does not require a licence. The paper names the use.

Everyday speech calls this leave **the ticket**. In Vaethorn a practitioner asks for *the blessing-to-practice*. In Lestrand they show *the guild-ticket*. In Threnmaieth they show *the crown-warrant*.

The three ticket-Conditions are the Stilled, Far-Voiced, and the Answered. Together that is **about three people in ten**; the shares are in *The Conditions*. They can be asked for a ticket if they practise the hazardous use. Those shares are people who can be asked. They are not names on a crown list.

A ticket names a competence (stiller, hall-voice, Crae-hand), the work you may do. It does not name the Condition as an identity. Three guilds keep no shared roll. The state watches the charter.

Who	Ticket names	Who is not on it
the Stilled — personal Gaze-ticket	Anyone who Gazes in public: surgeons, riot-lines, demolition. Most stillers hold one, because the vocation is the Gaze.	A Stilled who never Gazes (rare). The guild still wants them in the yard.
Far-Voiced — Voice-ticket / hall-hour	Those who Cry in a crowd or keep a scheduled hour: criers, performers, sworn witnesses. Hall-keepers stamp that you are competent and sell you the hour at the same desk.	A field-voice who lets the Cry out at the hedge. The hall-slate lists hours. A Far-Voiced who never takes an hour is not on it.
the Answered — shop charter / journeyman-mark	Those who let an element loose in a crowded yard. The Crae, the element-guilds, charter the shop; journeymen work under that charter.	A Tide-Answered on their own boat under a master’s eye. They work under the shop’s charter and carry no paper of their own.
Bound — a table, not a body-ticket	No licence. The honest table oversees Terms. The Whisper cannot command.	A ticket. A Bound is not counted among the licensed.
No ticket	—	Two-Bodied, Long-Lived, Returned, the Taken-In, the Unbound, Phoenix, and all the Kept. Most people hold no ticket. They are simply neighbours.

Active papers in a working city are fewer than the people who could be asked for one, and fewer again on the frontier, where a feared Condition is as likely to be hanged as to be licensed at the ticket-stool, the guild seat that stamps the paper. The share is who might be asked. It is not a census anyone keeps.

Licences are **guild-issued, not state-issued**. A guild knows its own members the way any craft guild does. The roll is a roster of practitioners of a dangerous art, kept by the art’s own masters. The state charters the guild and lets it police its own under threat of losing the charter. No single authority holds

the Conditioned. Guilds guard monopolies, tickets become property, and an unlicensed practitioner threatens the guild's charter as much as the public's safety.

Harm, the watch, and the hearing

The Inviolate Will already sorts the charge: **negligent Tithe-lapse** versus **willful weaponizing**. This is the ladder the charge walks. There is no crime of *being* a Condition.

1. **Neighbour-word.** Most harm dies on the street. Restitution, apology, a Bound word if they have one. The watch is not called.
2. **The watch.** Night-watch, ward-watch. Often the Kept, whose nights are not spent on a Tithe, and the Two-Bodied, whose ranging is the Tithe, with a Far-Voiced for the shout. They hold a body until morning. They do not investigate Conditions. They fetch a pillar or a guild.
3. **Guild-hearing.** Tithe-lapse, unlicensed Gaze, an element let go in a shop. The guild fines, suspends a ticket, binds to apprenticeship. The state is not in the room unless the charter is at risk.
4. **Open hearing.** Willful harm. Witnesses — especially the three pillars. The charge is the act. The hearing can say "You Gazed a man," and that is assault. "You are Stilled" is not a charge. Using the Gaze to hold a person still and leave them helpless is the rare charge the Stillers' own code already names.
5. **What the hearing can do** without writing you down:
   - Restitution — coin, labor, furnish a Tithe you broke
   - Ticket-stripping — you may not practice the dangerous act
   - A Bound word, or a term
   - **Exile from the hearth** — you become unvouched in your own city. This is the civic death. It does not require a file.
   - The rope or the wall — murder, and the rare Gaze used to hold a person still. Used more often on the frontier. Rare in the Warm.

The two Watchful crowns write you down. That extra record is their extra punishment, and it is why a Watchful town feels like a different country.

The watch and the cohort

The watch holds you until morning. You sit. In a village the watch is whoever is awake. In Maiethlir, the Tallied Crown's seat, the watch is the Down Gate and the path along the flood-wall. In Orentel, the salt-quay, the watch is the night-gate on the quay. In Eolvaeth, the waiting-lands seat, the square watches. In a year when a cohort goes out, the camp-streets watch instead, because the people who would have stood watch have gone with the children toward another town's Tree. Threnmaieth's roll

belongs to the clerks. The watch in a Watchful town can be told to hold someone the roll wants. The holding is still until morning unless a clerk comes.

A **cohort** is the group a town sends when its own Hand cannot Turn its children this week. The Hand is that town's Turning Tree. The group is kin, the children who are ten, and a warden's word. It is not a company kept under arms. Eolvaeth has sent one toward Saelvaeth in years when its own wood did not Turn the children that week. The children come back Given, or not, or unvouched. Saelid's bread stall feels that winter, because the people who buy bread are the people the cohort takes away. There is no barracks to come back to. When the week is over, the cohort breaks up, and people remember it by the summer it went. The Mill-hold sends its ten-year-olds toward Brenthael when its Tree is unsound, and Talen writes them on the neighbour-slate as one more summer's walk. The children are not soldiers, and the slate is not a muster-roll. Between sends, the people are at their stalls. A power does not keep a cohort in the field as its ordinary year. A sent cohort from Eolvaeth stops at the thorn outside the vale and eats before they go on, even when the path is clear. They will not say why.

Two old wars left a wall and a rate, and no army. The Closing ran from Cut-year 19 to the Retreat in Cut-year 38. Riders tried to pull up copied wood, and towns hid slips. By the end, Hildal closed a wall and saved a book, and the riders went home. The wall is Rothallo, the walled city inside Orenbren and its capital, still called the Inner Close. The Book still ranks who owes. That is a class rule, not a garrison on the wall. No one kept the riders as a host that could be called again.

The Hinge Hush is the peace on the Old Crossing. From Cut-year 299 to 304, the Hinge Shore and the Ledger Coast tied up each other's hulls over who set the crossing's price. People died. In 304 they made the Hush: a rate, a west-water clause, and no named winner. It left no fleet. Dock-bells on the Hinge Shore still pause in Hale-month, then go back to work. Netstrand still keeps hulls for hire under the west-water clause, and a charter is one crossing at a set price. The fifteen powers do not keep standing armies.

A door-custom, pinned inside a Lestrand night-gate. No crest. The back of the page is a week-old rain note.

> *Name. Last hearth. Who stands. Two will do. None, and you sit the bench until the second bell, or until someone comes to stand for you, or we walk you to the next gate. We do not ask your colour. We do not keep the three answers past dawn. If you are on a walk, say which. If you ate at the bed-house, say so. If you have a ticket, show the stool-mark, not a story. The bench is not a cell. The bench is until morning.*

The stool-mark is the stamp from the ticket-stool. The notice is a watch doing the practical work. The three questions are how this gate checks belonging. The writer believes that not asking your colour is what sets this gate apart from Threnmaieth. The gate also does not write the answers down, and that is how a city of tens of thousands still runs on hearths.

The three pillars: why the Conditioned *are* the legal system

Three Conditions **are the legal apparatus itself**, and they are the people who make a register unnecessary:

- **Long-Lived**: incorruptible memory. The archivists, notaries, and judges. A matter of record is whatever they say they witnessed a century ago. Where documents would be forged, a Long-Lived simply remembers.
- **Bound**: binding word. A Bound's sworn oath is literally binding and they hear a lie as it is told, so they are the witnesses, oath-keepers, and debt-arbiters. **When a treaty must truly hold, a Bound swears it.**
- **Far-Voiced**: unfakeable feeling. Trusted as sworn witnesses because their voice betrays real emotion under strain, so they cannot lie well on the stand.

Evidence and contract in the Turning are therefore made of people. Memory that does not corrupt, an oath that hears a lie, and testimony that cannot fake a feeling are enough. The Turning does not write everyone down.

Rights of the Kept

The Kept are the quiet centre of citizenship, and their legal position is **unremarkable.** They were witnessed at their Turning like everyone. They carry no Tithe, need no licence, answer to no guild. In most polities the Kept are the **default legal person**. The rest of the law is drawn around them. In one surviving compact they are also a ruling class: the Walled Book ranks the tithed and will strike a Closed Heir for taking a colour.

Vaethorn's second word is *the Waited*, or *Mother-kept*: people speak it with pity, as if the Tree passed them over. Lestrand's is *the free*: labor with no Tithe attached, and Lestrand says that with approval. Threnmaieth's is *the unmarked*, or *the passed-over*, and the clerks note it.

Two facts sit under that quiet position:

- **Kept status is not permanent immunity.** About a third of the Kept are still **Struck** later. So a Kept person lives untithed and unlicensed but never wholly outside the safety system's reach. The day they are Struck, they too must be vouched anew. Legally, "Kept" describes your present, not a promise about your future.
- **Where reverence for the gift runs hot, the Kept can be quietly pitied or pressured**: treated as having "missed out," leaned on to explain why the Tree passed them over. This is a social harm the law rarely names, and it runs hardest in the most devout polities.

The Given keep their plain name everywhere. Vaethorn's second word is *the gifted*, said as a blessing. Lestrand's is *the Given*, said as a plain fact. Threnmaieth's is *the marked*, because the name goes on

the roll.

Edge cases the law must hold

- **The Hollow (the Unbound)** have lost the Pledge they paid and been freed from the contract, and an isolated Hollow is pulled to sign again. The law has to decide whether they still have the capacity to be held to a new contract, and whether someone must protect them from one. Kinder polities extend a **protective status** (a guardian, a claim on connection, a bar on presenting them fresh contracts). Harsher ones leave them to the pull.
- **The Given-Over (the "Forfeit")** is the setting's sharpest legal wound: a Bound who kept re-signing until the counterparty effectively owns the person. This is a living case of **legal personhood erased by accumulated contract**, and the contract-guilds have a term of art for it because the law has never fully decided at what point a person has bargained away enough of themselves to stop being one. The question comes back, and it stays unresolved.
- **Phoenix** is a political matter. One legendary person who cannot hide is a symbol no ruler controls. Whoever currently wants the one alive tries to own them or protect them.
- **A child who missed, refused, or never stood is UnTurned.** They have no hug and no colour. Folk will call them Kept. The law files them as the person the town raised, vouched if someone will stand, unwitnessed at the Tree. A second Leaf-Fall is not a remedy. Struck doors still open later.

Three polity stances

The rules above hold in every polity. The tone changes from place to place. Variation comes from three choices every polity makes separately:

- **Theology: how gift-devout is it?** From ardent Motherfaith gift-integration (a Condition is a blessing, belonging is a birthright) through worn-lightly civic religion to frank secular pragmatism, and the odd local heresy. This decides how the Struck, the Kept, and the feared Conditions are read before the law even speaks.
- **Reach: Tree-rich core or Tree-poor edge?** Where healthy Trees stand, reach is full and the Given are dense. Where Trees are few, young, or sickening, the population runs higher on the Kept and the Struck.
- **Governance: how far does the state reach onto the person?** From light guild self-rule, the usual arrangement (the craft polices its own, the crown charters the guild), all the way to a crown that writes its subjects down. This decides how far a safety licence becomes a way of watching people.

Three recurring points on these choices:

The Warm *(high theology).* Law flows straight from the Motherfaith's gift-theology: a Condition is a blessing, the Struck are vouched-in graciously as people the Mother met at a later door, licences are

framed as helping you tend your gift. Warmest near the Awakening Tree. **Its injustice is soft and hard to name:** everyone is expected to serve their gift, so guild "vocation" shades into pressure, the Kept get pitied for missing out, and to decline your Condition's obvious use reads as ingratitude to the Mother herself.

The Watchful *(governance at its extreme: a deliberate aberration).* At the far end of the governance choice are crowns that break the world's norm and do write their people down. They do not trust living memory, and they keep a **roll of every subject and their Condition.** Every polity has guild rolls, notarial acts, and tax ledgers. The aberration is the further record: **a census of persons and their gifts**, a record held on people. Two crowns do it. Threnmaieth, the Tallied Crown, calls its roll holy. Its census calls itself the **Threnhael** *(THREN-hayl)*: *thren* (sacred counting) + *hael* (whole, hale), "the keeping-whole." Clerks say they "keep the realm hale." Subjects are "kept whole." Outsiders hear "the Counting." Trenledd, the Worn Count, calls its list the roll and does not call it holy. At home each crown calls its roll prudence and order. The people who live under either roll live under surveillance. The unvouched are hunted, the Struck are pursued to be catalogued, Tithe-needs become points of leverage, and the Bound especially are watched far past their real hazard. The Whisper cannot command, and the clerks know it. The extra watch is stigma carried out as safety. Most of the world finds the two rolls chilling because nobody else keeps a roll of everyone. The Walled Book's heir-roll lists only its own heirs. A Watchful kingdom that is also devout and Tree-rich is the darkest mix of the three choices.

The Frontier *(low reach).* Far from any healthy Tree, witnessing is thin and custom outruns law. These lands run higher on the Kept and higher on the Struck: more hugs, more later changes, fewer coloured falls. In town that is read as distance and young wood. No one asks for a licence. The Taken-In, whom cities keep at arm's length socially and still employ on the lots, are neighbours here, and they are the backbone of the frontier economy. An unvouched Struck person may have no one to stand for them and no guild to train them, and a feared Condition may meet a rope where a city would have issued a licence. Reach and governance often move together. A thin-reach edge tends to be thinly governed too. A devout frontier and a lightly-governed core both exist.

Economy and the Tithe

Every Condition has a Tithe. That is an ongoing need that must be met, or the danger comes out. About three people in four carry a Condition, so keeping them able to carry it is part of how the economy is built. What began as a private need becomes a public one at that scale.

Tithe-provision is a permanent civic utility, like wells and roads: visible in every town, fought over, load-bearing for the people who need it. Grain is the other supply. Grain feeds everyone, every day. The greens and halls keep an exposed minority from sliding into the Condition's danger, and keep their neighbours from living next to that slide. The sector is large enough to organize a town around. It is not the food supply.

Most of the Conditioned pay the Tithe by working: the need and the job are the same act. A smaller share must be furnished. The people who furnish it and the people who need it are often the same. Whoever controls the furnishing holds power.

Who actually buys provision

The share of people with each Condition is given in *The Conditions*. This table sorts the Conditions by how they pay the Tithe and gives no numbers of its own.

Who	Conditions	What "provision" is
Self-paying by vocation	the Answered · Two-Bodied · the Stilled	Work is the Tithe. They are a labor market.
If the work fits	Far-Voiced · Returned	Self-pay if the job fits. Buy a hall-hour or carry the need unpaid when it does not. The hour is booked for a Far-Voiced voice.
Provided-for	the Taken-In · Long-Lived · the Unbound · Bound Terms	Green, novelty, warmth, whatever the clause set.
The Kept	no Condition	No Tithe. They buy bread. They do not buy a lot-hour. That is an hour on the city's green.

Green is free on a farm. Most Taken-In live where it is free. The **purchased or civic customer base** — urban Taken-In, hall-users without a stage, novelty-seekers, warmth that money can only approximate — is a minority of the people, concentrated in stone towns. The queues are real. A city fights over lot-hours and hall-bells the way it fights over wells: a wilt or a Cry in the square is a public problem. Tithe-goods do not move in the grain carts.

Self-paying vs provided-for Tithes

Tithes do not all cost the same to pay. Some cost nothing in coin, because paying them is doing useful work. That sorts the Conditioned from self-paying to provided-for, and almost everything else follows from where a Condition sits. Which side a person lands on can depend on their vocation, not only their Condition.

Self-paying Tithes: the work is the payment. For several Conditions, the upkeep is discharged by doing exactly the labor society needs. Their maintenance and their productive output are the same act.

Condition	The Tithe	…paid by doing
the Answered	use the element in earnest	**the craft itself:** a Tide-Answered shipwright slakes the Tithe by building the ship
Two-Bodied	spend time as the animal	**the ranging work:** herding, rescue, courier, scout; being the beast is the job
the Stilled	burn off the Grey by exertion. The Grey is the residue each Gaze leaves	**active labor:** surgery, riot-lines, demolition; the vigorous work burns that Grey off

If the work fits, the Tithe is self-paying. If it does not, someone has to furnish it. Two Conditions sit in both columns. The job decides which.

Condition	The Tithe	Self-pays when…	Falls to provided-for when…
Far-Voiced	vent strong emotion each day	the vocation is the vent: **performer, crier, negotiator, sworn witness**; feeling in earnest on the job discharges the Tithe	the voice has **no outlet** (isolated posting, dull labor, silence) and they need a **venting-hall**. That hall is furnished so the voice can be let out
Returned	act toward the Purpose. That is the unfinished task they still have to finish	the **Purpose aligns with the work:** plague wards, recovery, tending the dead; doing the deadly job pays it	the Purpose is **personal or unmet by any trade** (a vengeance, a vow, a person to find). No employer can furnish it, and it pulls against ordinary work

Provided-for Tithes: upkeep that must be supplied. For the rest, the Tithe is a cost with no productive by-product. Someone must furnish the green, the novelty, the warmth, and that furnishing is the Tithe-provision sector.

Condition	The Tithe	…must be provided
the Taken-In	rest on living land	**green:** trivial on the farm, a real expense in a stone city (potted groves, leave to use a garden)
Long-Lived	learn something genuinely new	**novelty:** books, travel, correspondence, the traffic of a university town
the Unbound	keep connecting to others	**warmth:** company, being known; the one Tithe money buys least well
Bound	keep the Terms	**whatever the counterparty set:** idiosyncratic, sometimes ruinous

The self-payers make a living because their Condition is a trade. A living is not the same thing as an easy life. The Stilled self-pays and is still the most tightly licensed person in the world. The Answered self-pays under heavy guild discipline. Self-paying buys a living. It does not buy social comfort. The provided-for are economically **exposed**: they depend on someone furnishing their upkeep, and whoever furnishes it holds power over them. The people whose Tithe depends on the job are the most precarious of all. A Far-Voiced who loses their stage, or a Returned whose Purpose turns personal, can **slide from self-paying to exposed overnight.**

Tithe-poverty and the safety net

Because provided-for Tithes cost money, **you can be too poor to stay whole.** A Taken-In who can't afford green, a Long-Lived with no access to anything new, a Far-Voiced with nowhere to vent: these people suffer want, and they slide toward the danger: the wilting, the fade, the involuntary Cry. Destitution here has a visible, dangerous face.

Who pays for Tithe-provision is the political question, and polities answer it differently:

- **Public good.** Warm polities treat Tithe-provision like roads or wells (town greenhouses, free venting-halls, endowed libraries) because a town whose Conditioned stay whole is a town that stays safe and productive. The pious framing is the same practice: help everyone tend their gift.
- **Private burden.** Harsher polities leave it to the individual and the guild, and the Tithe-poor fall, becoming a genuine public hazard, which the same polities then police rather than prevent.
- **Leverage.** Provide it, and hold it. An employer, guild, or crown that furnishes your Tithe can withhold it.

Labor: who does what

The Tithe and the vocation are usually the same shape. The Condition is the job. How large each workforce is, is given in *The Conditions*; this list is about the work.

- **Two-Bodied (the plurality).** The versatile backbone of physical labor: herding, haulage, rescue, courier, scouting, war. Runs in bloodlines (whole "wolf-folk" / "hawk-folk" families), so the family trade and the family Condition are one inheritance.
- **the Taken-In.** The food-and-timber base: farmers, foresters, herders, wardens. The frontier economy runs on them, because they thrive on living land. Cities need their grain and keep a working minority of them. Arm's length is how the city treats them. It is not an empty workplace.
- **Far-Voiced.** Coordination and trust at a distance: the relay of criers posted on coasts, roads, and borders, plus performers, negotiators, and sworn court witnesses. Criers posted along those roads give the country a live signal from coast to border.
- **the Answered.** The elemental crafts, guilded by element: Ember (smiths, glasswrights), Tide (shipwrights, dyers), Root (masons, potters), Gale (sailmakers, millers); plus firefighting and rescue rotations.
- **Returned.** The work that kills the living, done by those death can't take twice: plague wards, mine and cave-in recovery, deep and dangerous salvage, and tending the dead.
- **the Stilled.** Precision stillness: surgeons and medics, peacekeepers on riot-lines, controlled demolition and stonework. Licensed and guild-disciplined.
- **Long-Lived.** The memory professions: archivists, notaries, judges, scholars, and **bankers**. They are few. If many more people never died, those professions and the banks would lock up around

them.

- **Bound.** The enforcement and contract class: oath-keepers, debt-arbiters, treaty-swearers, witnesses whose word is literally binding. The Unbound sit inside this same contract work. A released Bound goes back to whatever they did before, and needs connection to keep at it. They are not a separate workforce.
- **Phoenix (a trace).** No characteristic trade. A political symbol.

And the Kept. The Kept carry no Tithe, so they have no upkeep cost, and no Condition, so they have no built-in trade. Economically that makes them the **free generalist labor**: unburdened by any Tithe-need, unclaimed by any Condition-guild, able to take any ordinary work and move where they like. Where the faithful pity the Kept for missing a gift, they are still the least encumbered people in the world.

Why Taken-In live in stone cities

Green is an expense in a stone city, and cities keep the Taken-In at arm's length because they thrive on the frontier. Both are true. **Arm's length is how polite districts stand toward the bark and antler a Taken-In carries on the body. The lots are still staffed.**

They are in the city because:

1. **They were Given here.** A copper-green leaf, the Taken-In's colour, at a city Tree. Family, work, and a hearth-witness keep them. Leaving the city is leaving the circle that saw you Turn.
2. **Grain and timber come in; people come with them.** Seasonal Taken-In on the quays, wintering, some staying. The harvest-hands who do not go home in Hale-month. Hale-month is the spring month, also called Haelren.
3. **The lot is a job.** Greens-keepers need Taken-In labor. The city imports green-skill for the commons, then will not sit them at the high table.
4. **The door can open in a city's old green.** Lost and dying in a deep wild is the Struck path that makes a Taken-In. A walled grove, a lot at night, a river-garden after a flood can open the same door. It is rare, and it is enough.
5. **They cannot afford to leave.** Green-poverty is a trap: you need the lot to stay whole, the lot is gated, you work for lot-hours, you never save the cart-fare home. That trap is the city's green trade inside the Slide. That is the illicit market in Tithe-goods. Week-keepers sell it, and the green is what they sell when the gate will not.

The Taken-In share of the world is given in *The Conditions*. A stone city runs **lower** than that, with its Taken-In concentrated on lots, orchards, river-gardens, and the week-keeper's pot. That private pot of green is what the same trade rents by the week. Enough for a queue. Enough for a wilt two streets off.

Enough for a customer at that pot. The frontier still has the density and the honour. The city has the gate.

Banking and the deathless houses

The Turning's banks do not die. These are the **deathless houses**. A Long-Lived founded the bank and is still personally running it two centuries later, the same memory, word, and ledger, unbroken. Merchants carry **letters of credit**. That is a written promise to pay in place of a chest of coin. Three things follow.

- **The trusted note.** A note issued by a deathless house is trusted almost as coin, because everyone knows the banker cannot forget a debt, cannot be quietly succeeded by a defaulting heir, and will personally answer for it in fifty years. Their paper circulates further and holds value better than any crown's. Other paper is trusted by how close it comes to the word of a house that will not die.
- **The long instrument.** Deathless houses lend and endow on horizons no mortal lender would risk: century loans, multi-generation trusts, the patient financing of cathedrals, canals, and universities. The instruments are letters of credit and endowments. The world has no stock exchange and no joint-stock company.
- **The concentration risk.** Wealth that never passes to an heir never disperses through inheritance. The scattering that a death forces on every other fortune never happens here. Even though there are few of them, the deathless can slowly gather an outsized share of standing capital. Their small numbers are what keep that share from becoming the whole of standing capital, and the economy never fully resolves the gathering. An endowment sends the coin out and keeps the steering of it, so influence concentrates even while the cash flows into the institutions they still direct.

Many houses began as **road-houses** in the Walking Years: inns, beds, and century-credit for that road. In that age, families still had to walk to Thaeloren. That is the Awakening Tree. When the core no longer required the walk, the same Long-Lived still remembered every debtor, and the paper outlived the pilgrimage season. The houses became banks. Two of them are still standing, on opposite errands. The White Note House collects on the old paper. The Third Hearth still makes the bed. The trusted note is an instrument from the Walking Years that outlived its road.

Inheritance and the problem of not dying

Inheritance law is bent by the deathless. A Long-Lived's children are **not guaranteed to inherit the Condition**. Most age and die while the parent does not. So a deathless person outlives most heirs, and their estate never enters the inheritance stream at all. A fortune that is never passed down still has to go somewhere.

The characteristic answer: **the deathless endow.** Outliving most of their heirs, and needing for their own Tithe a steady supply of novelty (new books, new scholarship, new things to learn), a Long-Lived characteristically funds the institutions that generate knowledge: libraries, universities, archives. The deathless banker becomes the deathless patron, and pays their own Tithe by building the places that feed it. It is also how they grieve: an endowment in the name of a child who died a century ago. **An endowment is coin converted into permanent, directed patronage.** The founder does not die, so they keep the chair, name the scholars, and steer the institution for centuries. The fortune has not been let go. Endowment eases the coin concentration, because liquid wealth flows out into public works, and deepens the influence concentration, because the same few deathless hands still guide the universities, courts, and archives their money built. Keeping the Long-Lived few does not end that lock-up. The lock-up changes shape, from hoarded coin to patronage that does not step down.

For everyone else inheritance is ordinary, except the **Two-Bodied bloodlines**, where the Condition, the family animal, and often the family trade descend together, so a guild place and a Condition can be a single inheritance. And the law's sharpest open question is economic at root: the **Given-Over**. A Bound contracted away so much of themselves that the counterparty effectively owns the person. That is the ultimate inheritance failure: an estate, and a self, absorbed by a creditor.

Center and periphery

The economy is not evenly spread. Near the mature Trees, in the core, Conditions are dense, guilds are strong, and specialized Condition-work and its goods are the great export. Out at the margins, on the frontier, the giving thins: more of the population are generalist Kept or untrained Struck, fewer are Given specialists. So:

- **The core** exports specialized work and finished goods (Answered crafts, Stilled medicine, deathless-house credit) and imports raw staples.
- **The frontier** leans hardest on the Taken-In, who thrive there and are neighbours, and on generalist Kept labor. It exports food, timber, and raw materials, and imports the specialists it can't grow. Trade friction is real. Distance, spoilage, and the thin reach all mean the frontier is specialist-poor and self-reliant. Cities still keep a working Taken-In minority behind a gate.

The shadow economy

A gate on Tithe-provision, and a gate on vouching, each grows a market on the far side of the gate.

- **Illicit Tithe-supply.** Where legitimate provision is rationed, gated, or unaffordable, a shadow market fills it: smuggled green for a Taken-In cut off from land, unlicensed venting-rooms, black-market novelty (rare texts, forbidden knowledge) for a starving Long-Lived. The desperate customer is someone sliding toward the wilting, the fade, or the involuntary Cry, which makes this

trade both lucrative and cruel. In the street this trade is called **the Slide**. The same people are called week-keepers, because the sale is rented by the week.

- **Off-book contracts.** The Bound's whole domain has an underside: contracts sworn outside the honest tables, unregistered terms, and the predatory brokers who arrange them, the pipeline that feeds the Given-Over. In the street this desk is called **the Holding Desk**. It sells clauses.
- **Sold vouching.** Since citizenship runs on standing-for, the unvouched will buy a person who will stand for them, and a market exists in dubious character-witnesses. The one thing that can't be faked is a Long-Lived's memory, which is why their honest vouch is priceless and their corrupt one catastrophic. In the street this market is called **the Standing Trade**. It sells a witness.

The Slide sells the Tithe. The Holding Desk sells clauses. The Standing Trade sells a person who will stand.

How polities vary (economic faces)

Who pays, and who is left to pay alone, is a political choice. It runs on the same three choices as the law: how gift-devout the polity is, how many healthy Trees it has, and how far the state reaches onto the person. Three points on those choices have these economic faces:

The Warm *(high theology).* Treats **Tithe-provision as a public good**: town greenhouses, endowed venting-halls and libraries, ranging-commons held in common. The Conditioned are kept whole at civic expense because a whole populace is a safe and productive one, and because the faith says tend every gift. **Its economic injustice is soft:** the same provision comes with expectation. You are helped to tend your gift, and quietly obligated to spend it as the community sees fit. The subsidy can harden into a requirement.

The Watchful *(governance at its extreme).* A crown that writes its people down, as the Tallied Crown and the Worn Count do, turns **Tithe-need into leverage.** It provides, efficiently, even generously, and it holds what it provides: the green, the outlet, the novelty, all furnished through channels the crown controls and can withhold. Its deathless-house finance is superb and centuries-deep. **Its injustice is cold and precise:** a population whose upkeep runs through the state is a population that cannot afford to refuse it. The crown calls that care. It is the most complete control in the world.

The Frontier *(low reach).* Little formal Tithe-infrastructure and few specialists. People improvise their own provision or go without. There is no guild monopoly, and no crown holding the Tithe. The Taken-In are neighbours, not curiosities. The provided-for who cannot pay their Tithe slide with no net, and untrained Struck people manage dangerous Conditions alone. At the edges the economy runs on barter and favors: cash-poor and land-rich.

A devout frontier runs commons-minded charity with almost no infrastructure to fund it. A secular Tree-rich republic has deep markets and thin welfare. A Watchful-and-pious core turns generous

provision into the tightest hold in the world.

Daily Life

Most families in the Turning are ordinary. Two people marry. Some of the household carry a Condition, and some do not. A Condition is the change a person becomes. The children have not Turned yet, and will not until their tenth year. A wife born a Selkie, a husband Returned from a drowning, a Kept grandmother, three children who are simply children so far: this is the ordinary household. A Kind is what you are born, and a Selkie is one. A Condition stacks onto that Kind, and it can arrive years later. Nearly every family is mixed in that way. Mixed is the normal house, and nobody keeps a separate name for it.

Family, the whole spectrum

At the warm, mundane end (most families): a Condition is just a texture of the household, the way a trade or a temperament is. A Two-Bodied parent's other self has a name, and the children know it. A child says, "That's Bramble, mother's otter," and grows up with that other self as much a part of the family as a pet that is also a person. A Far-Voiced household is a *loud* one, because the Tithe means feeling must be aired daily. You do not get to sulk quietly in a home with a Far-Voiced in it, and families learn to treat the evening's singing or weeping or laughing as ordinary weather. A Taken-In parent keeps the windows open and the rooms green. These are the small daily accommodations of living with what people have become.

In the middle, the Tithe becomes a shared family labor. Where a Condition is provided-for, keeping a family member whole is a household expense and a household duty: the green for the Taken-In, the books for the Long-Lived, the outlet for the Far-Voiced. Families organize around it the way a household organizes around a member's chronic need, mostly without drama, sometimes with strain, and with the quiet knowledge that **to let a loved one's Tithe lapse is to watch them slide toward the harm that Tithe was holding back.** A family too poor to furnish a Tithe carries a particular grief: they can see exactly what their kin needs and cannot buy it.

At the aching end sits the marriage ordinary life keeps returning to: **loving someone who will not share your span of years.** Chief among these is marrying a **Long-Lived.** Their aging simply stops; their spouse's does not. A Long-Lived can have children and a full family, but the Condition is **not reliably inherited**. Most children age and die like anyone, so a Long-Lived does not build a deathless dynasty; they **outlive it.** They watch a spouse grow old across a marriage that stays, on one side, unchanged. They bury their children. People at those tables say *the cost of the Long-Lived is measured in funerals,* and it is a cost paid inside the family, at the dinner table, over decades. A Long-Lived who

has done this once faces the choice their whole existence turns on: **stop** (live on alone, keep no more households) or **begin again**, marry again, love again, and outlive that family too. Both choices cost, and people live both of them. This is the setting's deepest, quietest ache, and it lives in the most ordinary place there is: a marriage.

A few threads:

- **The threshold courtesy in the home.** A Long-Lived never crosses another's home threshold uninvited. It is held as the deepest good manners, the mark of someone safe to let in. Inside a *family*, this softens into something tender: to be welcomed across a Long-Lived's own threshold, or to welcome them across yours without a thought, is a real intimacy. A door held open is how this world says *you are mine and I am yours.* (A door refused is felt more than a Long-Lived will ever say.)
- **The Returned come home.** A person who died and Returned is warm to the touch. They are calm, deliberate, unafraid, and quietly respected, and their loved ones get them back. The chill comes if their Purpose lapses: a Returned neglecting the unfinished thing that holds them runs cold, and the living can feel the wrongness at a touch. So a Returned's family learns a hard and intimate literacy. **You can tell, by an embrace, whether the one you love is tending what holds them here.** A warm embrace means they are well. A cold one means the Purpose is slipping, and the family treats that hug as an emergency.
- **Two-Bodied bloodlines are family lines.** Because the Condition runs in blood (children of a Two-Bodied parent usually Turn the same animal), "wolf-folk," "hawk-folk," and "otter-folk" are real extended families, and the family animal, the Condition, and often the family trade descend as a single inheritance. Marrying into such a line is marrying into a shape your children will likely wear.
- **Raising a child before they Turn.** Every parent lives the same open question until their child's tenth year: *what will they become, or will they be Kept?* In a devout home a parent will say, "The Mother will give what the child can carry." In an anxious one the decade is quiet dread or ambition. Parents who carry a heritable Condition (Two-Bodied especially) can half-guess; most cannot. The Leaf-Fall is therefore a civic day and the emotional hinge of a family's life: the day you finally meet who your child has been becoming all along. In the Walking Years, a child had to be walked to Thaeloren. That is the Awakening Tree. The question before the leaf was whether the household could get there at all. A household that could walk only one child still lives in the present as two siblings: one Given at the origin, and one UnTurned, who never stood under a Tree.

Medicine: miraculous, and strange to outside eyes

Two Conditions change what a sickbed and a deathbed can do. A clinic holds wonder and dread in the same room.

The Stilled are the surgeons. A stiller's gaze **arrests motion**. It holds a wound from bleeding, slows a poison's spread through the blood, keeps a patient perfectly still under the knife without holding them down. It does not petrify and does not harm; it simply *stops* what is moving for a beat. In a world with no anaesthetic worth the name and no way to halt a hemorrhage, this is the difference between a survivable operation and a death. The best surgeons in the world are Stilled, and a great infirmary is built around them. Sit in that operating room and watch what it is: a surgeon whose flat, patient gaze freezes the blood in your veins on command, working fast because the Grey is filling in them as they work. The Grey is the residue the Gaze leaves in the surgeon. Their Tithe is this: using the Gaze fills that Grey, and a Grey left full locks their own limb to stone. They drill and spar between patients to burn it off. The most gifted healers in the world are also the most tightly **licensed** and quietly **feared**. The same gaze that saves you on the table can, misused, hold a person helpless in a fight, and it is the one the law watches hardest. Wonder and dread, one person, one room.

The Returned do the work that kills the living. Plague wards, mine collapses, the recovery of bodies from places the living cannot safely go, and the tending of the dead: this is Returned work, done by those death cannot take a second time until their Purpose is met. A Turning mortuary is staffed by the Returned, people who have been dead, calmly and well. A plague ward that would empty a town's living physicians is walked by Returned who are unshaken by rot and contagion. The town **respects** the work. The Returned are the reason a plague does not take the doctors too, and everyone knows it. There is a real tenderness in it, too: no one speaks for the dead, or tends them, as gently as someone who has been dead.

The rest of medicine is ordinary, and ordinarily unequal. Midwives, bonesetters, herbalists, and the Answered's craft turned to apothecary and instrument-making do the everyday care. More of the population carries a useful becoming, so that everyday care is well staffed. The great Stilled infirmaries and the deathless-endowed hospitals stand in the rich, Tree-dense core. A frontier town makes do with a travelling stiller if it is lucky. If it is not, the care is cloth, a rope, and a prayer. The deepest inequity is the Tithe-poverty already named: **you can be too poor to stay whole,** and the medicine that treats a lapsing Condition is the medicine the poor can least reach. The care is real. So is the queue outside it.

Living in a Turning town: city design

A city is shaped by this fact: **most of its adults have an upkeep, and some of those upkeeps are dangerous or expensive to meet.** The town builds for the Tithe the way it builds for water and waste: **civic infrastructure, visible and load-bearing.**

- **The Tree at the centre.** Every town is *organized around* its Turning Tree. It is the civic and sacred heart, the site of the year's most-attended day, the thing the oldest quarter grew up around. A town's age and standing can be read in its Tree (a mature grafted Tree means an old, reach-rich

town; a young Tree or none means a new or frontier settlement). Geography and civic layout both point back to it. Older uses sit in the same square: a stone, an upper room, a road that ends at the boughs.

- **Tithe-provision as public utility.** Where the polity treats provision as a public good, the town furnishes it in the open.
- **Venting-halls** for the Far-Voiced, part concert hall and part a place to let the voice out, often also the town's performance venue. Everyday speech calls the building **the ael-hall**. Vaethorn, the Waiting Lands, calls it *the gift-hall* and speaks of the hour as care of the gift. Lestrand, the Ledger Coast, calls it *the release-house* and speaks of the hour as the voice let out. Threnmaieth, the Tallied Crown, calls it *the counted hall*, and the hour is a thing the crown counts.
- **Potted groves and garden-commons**, so a Taken-In in the city can meet the Tithe on living plants and does not go to seed indoors. Everyday speech calls them **the greens**. Vaethorn calls them *the Mother's green*, after the Mother the devout name. Lestrand calls them *the leaf-lot*. That lot is kept for the leaf. Threnmaieth calls them *the tended green*. The crown tends that green.
- **Endowed libraries**, feeding the Long-Lived's novelty-Tithe and often built by a Long-Lived. Everyday speech calls one **the long-house of books**. Vaethorn calls it *the deathless gift*. The patron who gives it does not die. Lestrand calls the money a house set aside *the endowment*, or *the house*. Threnmaieth calls it *the crown archive*, and the books sit with the crown.
- **Ranging-commons** at the town edge, where the Two-Bodied can be their other selves. Everyday speech calls the ground **the ranging**. Vaethorn calls it *the wild-leave*. That leave is to go out into the wild. Lestrand calls it *the beast-yard*. That yard is for the other body. Threnmaieth calls it *the ranging-roll*, and writes down who ranges.

  These are as normal a part of the streetscape as a well or a market cross.
- **The dangerous trades on the edges.** The work that carries a bystander hazard sits where such work always sits, at the margins and the edges. Stilled infirmaries and Answered element-workshops (fire, forge, tide) are guild-quartered and set slightly apart; the Returned's mortuaries and plague-work sit at the town's edge, near the dead. They sit there for the same reason a tannery sits downwind: the work can harm a bystander.
- **Homes that fit what people have become.** Ordinary domestic architecture quietly bends to the Conditions: windows that open and rooms kept green for a Taken-In guest, a household's evening rhythm built around a Far-Voiced's vent, a threshold a Long-Lived waits to be asked across. You can read the household in the house.
- **Core and frontier show in the streets.** Dense, Tree-rich core towns are thick with all this infrastructure; frontier settlements have little of it and improvise. How much of a town's Tithe-provision is public, private, or simply missing tells you where that town sits.

How polities vary (domestic faces)

The Warm *(high theology).* Family, medicine, and civic life all carry the gift-theology: a child's Turning is a joyous sacrament, mixed households are blessings compounded, Tithe-provision is a public good offered in the open, and the sick are tended as people whose gifts must be kept whole. **Its soft injustice reaches the hearth:** the Kept child is pitied for being passed over, marrying "beneath your gift" is quietly frowned on, and a family is expected to spend its members' Conditions as the community sees fit. The love and the pressure arrive in the same kindness.

The Watchful *(governance at its extreme).* A crown that keeps a roll of persons, as the Tallied Crown and the Worn Count do, reaches into the family: marriages of heritable Conditions may be *noticed* and encouraged or discouraged, a child's Turning is an event the state records, and the medicine that furnishes a Tithe runs through channels the crown controls. **Its cold injustice is domestic surveillance.** A household whose upkeep and bloodline are both on file is a household that cannot easily refuse the crown anything.

The Frontier *(low reach).* Thin infrastructure, thin medicine, thin ceremony. Families improvise their own Tithe-provision or do without. A travelling stiller is a rare blessing. The Taken-In, whom core cities keep at arm's length, are neighbours and kin here, the backbone of the place. No one polices your marriage or your gift. A lapsing Condition may have no infirmary to reach, and an untrained Struck child may have no guild to catch them. The feeling runs warm. The net under a lapse is thin.

A devout frontier holds joyous Turnings with almost no infirmary behind them. A secular Tree-rich republic has superb medicine and a marriage market that shrugs at theology. A Watchful-and-pious core turns the sacrament of a child's Turning into a state census with a hymn over it.

When the town buries

A funeral is a walk and a meal. It is not a Turning. Nobody asks the Tree what the dead person "was," and a warden does not read a leaf-colour over the body.

They wash the body in the house. The washer is often one of the Returned, because tending the dead is already their work. The family still chooses the burial cloth. Neighbours then carry the body. In a town with a Tree, the carry goes past the canopy, along the street the person used. The body is not stood under the branches. A tree-warden may walk with them. If the house wants the Mother named, the warden says "Maieth" the way a neighbour would. If the house asked for silence, the warden walks silent. Neighbours bring food to the door. The door stays open through the meal. The person who will sleep in the house that night shuts it, or the person who has been asked to.

A Long-Lived who loved the dead waits on the step until someone says come in, as a Long-Lived does at any door. A deathless life is measured in funerals like this one, and each is still a door and a loaf.

Most households already mix faiths, so the meal is mixed too. Each person does their own small rite at their own bowl. They do not stop the meal to argue which name comes first.

- A Motherfaith sibling says “Maieth” over their own bowl, and means the life.
- A sibling of the Watching describes the dead as they were at the market stall: the coat, the argument, the way they counted change. They do not thank a giver.
- If the dead kept a personal book, someone of the Fair Hand closes it on the table, where the room can see the last line, and does not write a new one. People call them Settlers.
- Someone of the Old Ways puts a little of the meal at the threshold. People call them kin-speakers. If the dead kept the Old Ways, the rest of that food goes to the door when the street has finished eating. A door is the Old Ways’ word for a household’s own old practice. In that rite, ancestors are kin who stayed. A “return” means a Returned person, still living a neighbour’s life. You do not summon one.

Speaking a fall is the warden’s sentence at Leaf-Fall, when a Tree gives a living child a colour. A funeral is not that day. Nobody does it over the bowls. A neighbour who tries is walked outside by whoever is nearest the pot.

On a dock, if the dead worked the water, the crew carries the coffin along the quay. It does not go under the town Tree to be read. Some of the crew say “fair wind, fair term,” because that is already their sentence for a leaving. Some will not, because they keep that sentence for a ship that is still going out. Both happen in the same hour, and the crew does not stop to settle it. If there is a book, it is closed where the crew can see. In another month, people put salt on the Tree’s roots. That habit is not part of the funeral. They will not say why the salt is there.

A waiting town such as Eolvaeth does not send for a warden to a Tree-town with one to spare. If the local warden is in the vale, they may walk. If the town sent its children elsewhere to Turn that summer, the town buries with the people who stayed. The pot is the gift-hall’s. Food goes to the door the person kept. A wet leaf lies on the town spring. That is the spring’s habit. It is not a funeral token. They will not say why the leaf is there.

At Ndenjoo, on the Sundering Isle, the body is laid above the tide. The hall does not set a second empty plate for the dead. The dead person’s own cup sits in the place that was already set, for one night, and then it goes back to the shelf. Whether anyone says a name is an argument the valley already has. It waits until after the dishes.

The guest-meal

Feed the guest before you ask who they are. That much is true on every mainland road. What people ask afterward depends on the town.

In a devout kitchen, such as a street in Maiethlir, the guest sits and eats. Then someone asks, “Of where?” They mean which town or vale. Nobody asks what leaf-colour the guest carries, or whether they have one. The host may say “Maieth” over the host’s own bowl. The guest is not asked to repeat it. A Watcher at the same table tells the guest what is in the pot, and then stops. A Settler at the end of the bench does not open a book. A letter can wait until the guest’s shoes are dry.

On a dock such as Orentel, the first bread is eaten standing, at a barrel, where the crane can be seen. Sitting down before that bread is how a person claims a berth they have not paid for. After the bread, if no clerk has a document open, there is a chair. They ask which berth. A guest with no berth still eats. If a filing house has a paper open, the clerk at that office asks for the house-name before offering the chair. They mean the inherited family name. The food does not wait for the name. If a book-hand wants the guest’s affairs written down that night, the person who cut the bread tells them to do it on the quay in the morning.

In a waiting town the guest is often a clerk from the core, come to watch a Turning week, who found a pot instead. They are fed from the common pot if the house is thin. Nobody promises that the local wood will speak this week. If the guest asks about the wet leaf on the spring, someone passes the bread. That is the whole answer. The town will not say what the leaf is for. A walker who came in with a cohort sent to another town’s Tree eats with the cohort. The town does not make a separate table for people who stood somewhere else this summer.

At Ndenjoo, on the first night, the guest does not serve food and does not sit in the place set back from the table. That place is already kept. On the second night, someone puts a plate in the guest’s hands to carry. That second supper is how the hall counts you as kin on the isle. It does not become papers you can show a mainland watch. On the one night the hall eats the heel of the loaf first, a guest who asks why is given more bread. They will not say why the heel came first.

If someone asks what the guest is before the food is down, the room goes quiet. The person nearest the pot puts the bowl down anyway. Talk starts again at the second bite, or it does not. Nobody makes a speech to repair it.

What a house keeps

When a town needs work done, it hires a person. A made thing, if a town has one at all, keeps going with nobody in it: a crane left running, a mill someone swears turns with nobody at the stones, a figure of clay. It has a maker, and it has a problem, such as a stop that broke or a debt the maker did not finish. It has no Kind and no Condition. A Clank is a person, born a Clank, who mends flood-walls and mills alongside everyone else who does that work. Most towns do not keep a made thing on a shelf.

Ordinary kit is whatever that ground already needed: clothing and tools.

Place	What they keep	Why it is there
Rain-Wall shelves, above the passes	An oiled wool coat	The shelf is wet and cold.
Orentel’s quay	A short hook, and a coat waxed against spray	Lines, crates, and salt water.
A young graft on the live front	A pruning knife, and a wind cloak	The wood is new and the weather is not. The knife is a tender’s tool.
The Rain-Shadow	A goat-hair blanket, and a water-skin	The days are dry and the well is shared.
Kumbaan	A peat cloak, and a short knife for mussels	Smoke, rain, and the rocks. The cloak is for the hall and the terrace.
A Mother-core orchard	Beeswax	The hives, and the halls that are owed wax when the blossom fails.

The pruning knife is not the one blade people mean when they say “the knife.” Some hearths hang an ordinary kitchen knife on a ribbon, because they cannot say whether they are honouring a theft or a gift. One house on the Near Mile hangs its knife beside a scorch on an old pot-ring, and the house knows which summer that was. Strangers want that ribboned knife to be the famous first blade. The house will not sell it as that. No house has produced the one blade. Who made the first cut is not written down.

Tithe-Infrastructure and Guilds

Towns furnish green, novelty, and outlets in public, and three guilds stamp a licence when a Tithe can hurt a bystander. That licence is the ticket, and it lets a person practice a hazardous Tithe. After that official door has closed, the Slide takes a paid week.

Everyday people say **the furnishing**, or just **the greens and the halls.** This is civic work. Vaethorn, the Waiting Lands, says **the gift-works**. Lestrand, the Ledger Coast, says **the provision** the way it says *the wells*. Threnmaieth, the Tallied Crown, files **the counted channel**.

In one sentence: they keep people whole *enough*, in public, and they stop at the gate.

Shape of the sector

- **Furnishing and ticketing are two jobs. Furnishing** keeps a provided-for Tithe from becoming a public hazard (green, an outlet, a new page). **Ticketing** marks competence for the three Conditions that can hurt a bystander (the Stilled, Far-Voiced, the Answered). A town may put both jobs in the same building. They are still two jobs. The Bound's hearing is at a table. It covers their Terms. The three body-licences remain the Stilled, the Far-Voiced, and the Answered.
- **Official work stops at enough.** A commons-share, a scheduled hour, a library that is open. The product is a person who can walk away until tomorrow. The Slide's product is a person who cannot. The town is glad of both and will not say so about the second.
- **They talk about the work in front of them.** Wells. Yards. A playhouse. A surgeon's college.
- **Each town keeps its own.** A town keeps its own lot and hall. A deathless house endows its own long-house. The licence-guilds charter *their* members.

Who furnishes what

Tithe	The official door	Lived house	What they will not do
Taken-In green	garden-commons / the greens / a leaf-lot	the Greens-Keepers	Will not follow you home. Will not rent you a private pot after the share fails. That is the Slide.
Far-Voiced outlet	the ael-hall. They vent a voice there on schedule. The building is the playhouse	the Hall-Keepers	Will not give you an unscheduled Cry. Will not keep you half-vented so you come back tonight.
Long-Lived novelty	the long-house of books	the deathless house that endowed it, still sitting the chair. No new order	Will not ration a page to own you. A junior who does that has started a week.
Unbound warmth	*almost none*	family; an attic of the Table-Keepers; the Slide's paid sitting	The sector cannot buy being known. Family, an attic, or a paid sitting is what there is.
Bound Terms	the honest table	the Book-Hands keep the civic year. The Counterparty keeps the clause	The hearing covers the Terms. The three body-licences remain the Stilled, the Far-Voiced, and the Answered.
Returned Purpose	*cannot be furnished*	a Book-hand may find a payable year; no one can supply a vengeance	No one can supply a vengeance.
Two-Bodied ranging	the ranging / a beast-yard	civic land, no guild	Self-paying on civic land. No ticket.

The three tickets. They cover danger to others only. The person holds one. The craft issues it.

Ticket	Condition	Lived house	Why a ticket at all
strictest	the Stilled	the Stillers	the stilling look, the Gaze, can leave a person helpless in a fight
heavy, training-first	Far-Voiced	the Hall-Keepers, in the same building as the outlet	a Cry in a crowded hall. Feeling got out, and everyone in earshot took it
heavy, training-first	the Answered	the Element-Guilds	an untended element in a workshop
not a body-ticket	Bound	a table, not a guild-yard	the Whisper cannot command another person; the hazard is the contract, heard at a table

The three ticket-houses share a desk. That desk is **the Intake**, and it takes a raw Struck who is already live and has no childhood apprenticeship. They keep the person for one catching-week in a shed, and then the apprenticeship.

Fellowships

A mill, a hull, and a road have people who keep them. Those people are fellowships. The work does not licence a body. The Stillers, the element-guilds, the Intake, and the hall-keepers already stamp the hazardous uses. A mill-share, a hull-wright, and a road-mend do not stamp any of those. A Gale-Answered miller can hold a ticket for the wind and still owe a share of grain. The ticket licences the wind. The share is the grain he still owes the mill.

You are of a fellowship when you have kept the thing through a season and someone of it will say so. A fellowship belongs to its town. Any Kind may keep the work. Kumbaan does not keep these three.

The **mill-share** will say whose race this is. At the Mill-hold the share is still taken when the culvert is opened. When the race is drawn down, they leave one measure of last year’s grain on the lip until the water comes back. They will not say why.

The **hull-wrights** know whether a hull will take water. They do not classify the cargo, set the Hush-rate, or sell a witness who will say *I was there*. Before a new hull takes water, they walk it once empty, from stem to stern, and do not speak. They will not say why.

The **road-mend** fills a hole, clears a ford, and shores a culvert. They are not Road-hands. A Road-hand carries living wood. A mender carries a shovel. At Nelath the mend stops with the road. They do not cut the thorns back. At the first ford after a town, they leave the shovel standing in the bank overnight after a mend. They will not say why.

The work people hire

A town already pays someone to do Daggerheart's domains. People do not enroll in a school of magic. Arcana handles workshop heat, water, stone, air, or light. Blade carries a weapon, keeps a watch until morning, uses a pruning knife, walks children to a sound Hand, or serves a town whose Tree can Turn them. Bone marks where to stand. Codex keeps the paper. Grace sets a guest-meal or a factor's terms. The hazardous Cry stays the hall-keepers' ticket. Midnight shuts a door and keeps a trade off the public square. Sage works ground, herd, weather, and the bark of a young graft. Splendor tends the room after harm. Valor stands a gap.

At Leaf-Fall a warden speaks the colour. That sentence is the Spoken colour. Hope does not buy a colour. A person becomes a Condition, and that becoming carries a Tithe. A craft does not Turn anyone. If the same person has both, each one does what its own card says.

The long-house (novelty without a new order)

A Long-Lived house that has endowed a library is already Tithe-infrastructure. A deathless member of the house still sits the chair and names the scholars. The money went out. The choice of scholars stayed. The Pourers keep one such shelf, in Lestrand.

Staff are clerks, often the Kept, unencumbered, able to fetch a book the founder has not read. A junior Long-Lived copies. There is no liturgical name and no college of librarians.

They furnish *something genuinely new*. They will not furnish a page at a time to a person who cannot walk in. A junior who extends a subscription one more week has started the Slide's measured week beside the long-house.

The gate (the sector's shared courtesy)

Every official door stops at a line the town has agreed to call *enough*:

- The greens-keeper keeps the lot. They do not walk the wilting room.
- The hall-keeper keeps the hour. They do not open after the lamps for a voice that missed its slate.
- The long-house is open to a person who can walk in. It will not carry news to a Long-Lived shut in a room.
- The ticket-house trains the Given child and stamps the competent adult. The raw Struck is the Intake's problem, and the guild is glad to forget them if the catching-year is quiet.

The Slide begins where that line is. The guilds **pretend not to know**. That pretending is already part of the town.

The Slide's measured week is a different shape. The guilds keep the commons. They do not keep the person.

How they live in the three corners

- **Vaethorn (the gift-works).** Tithe-provision as a public good with almost no guild to fund it. A commons that is a cousin's field. A blessing-to-practice said over a stiller who learned on a riot-line because there was no infirmary. You were helped, so the valley expects you to spend the gift as it sees fit. When the commons run out, they call the Slide *the last pot*.
- **Lestrand (the provision).** Posted. A leaf-lot by the season. A release-house that is also the playhouse. Guild-tickets as master's papers. You can be priced out of staying whole. After the season-fee failed, they call the Slide week-rent.
- **Threnmaieth (the counted channel).** The crown furnishes, efficiently, even generously, and *holds* what it furnishes. A counted hall. A tended green. A crown-warrant. The crown can close that channel, and it calls the closing care. They call the Slide the late week the channel will not admit failed.

Kumbaan. The sector has no greenhouse or ael-hall there. A wreck walked uphill is a guest.

A bed-list is plants. A hall-slate is hours. A guild-roll is practitioners of a dangerous art. Only two crowns write *persons and gifts*: Threnmaieth, which calls its roll holy, and Trenledd, which does not. Road-hands carry living wood. Greens-keepers keep soil. Hall-keepers keep an hour. The ticket-houses keep a licence.

The Greens-Keepers

Greens-keepers keep the garden-commons, the greens, and a leaf-lot. They furnish *enough* living land that a Taken-In can rest and walk away. After the share fails, the Slide rents a private pot.

Everyday people say **greens-keepers**, or **lot-keepers.** In liturgy they say **the Saelhael** (SAYL-hayl). *sael* is sowing, the first green, and *hael* is whole. The name says they keep you hale by putting you back on growing ground. Vaethorn's second word is **Mother's-green hands**. Lestrand's is **lot-keepers**. That is ordinary, like saying *gardener*. Threnmaieth files them as **the Tended**.

In one sentence: they keep the lot, and they do not go looking for anyone who is not at the gate.

Shape of the house

- **The house is the lot.** A town has a lot, a strip along the wall, pots in a yard the size of a tannery. Vaethorn's "lot" is often a cousin's field held in common. The house is whoever waters it and says who sleeps on which bed tonight.
- **Enough, then the gate.** A share gives a night on living dirt, a season on a bed, or a commons-hour. The person should leave able to work. A person who cannot leave is the Slide's work.
- **They talk about the garden.** Soil, blight, whose beans took.
- **A bed-slate is plants.** Rows, which bed is tired, which needs a year of beans. Names get onto it because a person is *on* a bed. The keepers will tell you it is horticulture. In Threnmaieth the crown already has another list.

If you meet one

Dirt under the nails. A key to a gate in a wall. A slate. Ask where a Taken-In sleeps when the rooms are stone.

A stone town cannot keep its Taken-In without a lot. The faith, if any, is extra.

Who comes, and when

Who	Why they come	What the greens-keeper does	What they will not do
A Taken-In who works in town	The rooms are stone; the Tithe is due	Give a share: a bed, a night, a commons-hour. Write the bed, not the person, if they write at all.	Will not follow them home with a pot. Will not open the gate after the share-hour because the wilt has started.
A family, before the town sees	A parent is going to seed indoors	Open the lot if there is a bed. Send them home with the hour named.	Will not make the wilt a sermon. Will not tell the warden unless the person asks.
A Struck Taken-In, raw	They came through a green door later, alone	Find them dirt *now*. Point them at a door-keeper if the door still needs walking.	Will not name them Given. Will not licence a grove.
A Book-hand with a settling	The term *assumes* a greens-share	Honour the term if there is a bed. Mark the slate *full* if there is not: the book becomes *owing*, not this lot's lie.	Will not invent a bed to close someone else's book.
A crown-clerk (Threnmaieth)	The tended green must match the channel	Give the beds the roll already expects	Will not pretend a wilt off the lot is not happening. They also will not walk to it.
Almost no one who is not Taken-In	the ordinary week	Water. Turn tired beds. Argue beans.	Will not become a food-guild. Grain is a different door.

An ordinary week

They **open the gate.** That is the whole kindness. A Taken-In lies down on living ground. The tokens fill. They leave. The bed is turned. The next row is watered.

They bury last year's commons-leaf under a new bed. No one will explain this to a guest. A first-year who asks is told, by whoever is on the gate, "That is how the lot remembers."

When the queue is longer than the wilt, they still open the gate for the share they have. They close it when the share is gone. They do not walk the three streets to the room where someone is going to seed. They know a cousin still has a pot. They do not say the cousin's name.

A child of the house learns the work by carrying water and by being told not to take the key home.

They will not follow you home. They will not rent a private pot after the share fails. They will not steal a scion to make a grove. They will not call the share a gift on Lestrand, or a debt anywhere they can help it. They call it a share. They will not run a Kumbaan export.

Who may keep a lot

Not by Kind. A human, a Kitsune, a Tengu who will water and keep the gate can be of the house.

By practice first. You are of the house when the lot is still alive in the dry month, and the town still sends its Taken-In to you.

Condition leans, not Condition-gates. Watering and blight often fall to a Taken-In who kept a commons, or a Kept with no Tithe of their own who can sit the gate year-round. The slate to whoever can read a tired row, sometimes a Long-Lived who remembers which bed failed twenty years ago. The gate at close to a Kept, or anyone who will lock it.

How they live in the three corners

- **Vaethorn (Mother's-green hands).** The commons *is* a cousin's field. They will say they are tending a gift. The quiet obligation is the harvest: you were laid on the Mother's green, you will spend the green as the valley asks. When the field fails, the last pot does the Slide's work, and they will still call it tending.
- **Lestrand (lot-keepers).** Posted. A leaf-lot by the season. Coin on the gate. A Taken-In who cannot pay the season is not this lot's problem until they wilt in the street, and then they are the watch's. The lot that still opens does the Slide's work.
- **Threnmaieth (the Tended).** The crown furnishes the tended green and can withhold it. Beds match the channel. A wilt off the lot is a leak the roll does not want to file. The keepers look like gardeners. What the crown can shut off is the water.
- **Kumbaan.** No greens-keepers, and no lot is sent there.

The gate

Whoever furnishes a provided-for Tithe holds power over its bearer. The greens-keepers hold that power *and refuse to carry it past the wall.*

That refusal is their kindness (they will not own you) and their cruelty (they will not walk three streets). The town is glad. A person who wilts *quietly* off the lot is not a public hazard. A devout town can say the gift was offered. A Lestrand quay can say the season was posted. The Threnmaieth crown can say the channel held.

The need for living land is the Tithe. People built the gate.

Tired beds are real. A lot can be botanically full and still have a queue. The keepers are also choosing who sleeps on stone.

A bed-slate

Lestrand leaf-lot, nailed inside the gate. The verso is last season's slate, the tired rows still marked.

> *Beds 1-12: taken through the next moon. 13-16: beans, do not lie here. 17 is tired; it will take next year. Share is one night or one hour at open sky, then the gate. If you cannot come, send no one. A bed is not a letter. We do not walk the rooms. If you have already wilted, the lot is still the lot. Come when we open. If you cannot wait, we do not know a pot.*

The slate is competent gardening, a little cold, a commons keeping itself honest. The keepers do know a cousin's pot. The slate says they do not, so that the lot is not blamed for what the pot does. The child who carries water can name the cousin. The slate cannot.

The Hall-Keepers

Hall-keepers keep the official outlet and the Far-Voiced ticket in the same building. A Far-Voiced person needs both the scheduled hour and the licence. In the ael-hall they empty a voice on that schedule. That hall is the town's playhouse. They furnish *enough* voice that a person can walk until tomorrow. After the lamps, the Slide keeps you in a room and never quite empties you.

Everyday people say **hall-keepers**, or **ael-hands,** in every register. Vaethorn's second word is **gift-hall folk**. Lestrand's is **release-hands**. That is ordinary, like saying *box-office*. Threnmaieth files them as **counted-hall clerks**.

In one sentence: they sell you an hour in which you may feel in earnest, and they will not open after the lamps.

Shape of the house

- **One building, two jobs.** The hall furnishes the outlet and stamps the Voice-ticket. The hall-keeper who says “your hour is the third” is the one who says “you may stand in a crowded room.”
- **The hour is enough.** A scheduled vent: song, weeping, a relay-call, a laugh that empties the chest. The person should leave emptied and able to work. The Slide’s shut room is one outlet that is never quite enough. This house wants you gone until tomorrow.
- **They talk about the playhouse.** Bills, benches, who carries the high note.
- **Each hall keeps its own slate.** The oldest playhouse on a Lestrand quay is old. The next town’s hall does not write to it for leave.

If you meet one

Ink on a finger, or chalk. A slate of hours. A hall that smells like sweat and lamp-oil and last night’s joy. Ask where a voice can be loud without becoming a Cry in the market.

A town with Far-Voiced and no hall has a Book-hand writing *owing* and a watch waiting for the market.

Who comes, and when

Who	Why they come	What the hall-keeper does	What they will not do
A Given Far-Voiced child, after the colour	The voice must be trained before it is a hazard	Apprentice them: breath, projection, venting on purpose. The ticket comes when the town can stand next to them.	Will not Speak the colour. The warden did that. Will not call the voice a gift on Lestrand.
A working Far-Voiced (performer, crier, witness)	The vocation *is* the vent: self-paying	Give them the stage, the relay-post, the stand. Stamp the year if the ticket is due.	Will not invent a crisis so they can vent off-slate.
A Far-Voiced who lost the honest stage	Isolated posting, dull labor; the Undertow is close	Sell or grant a **scheduled hour**. Empty them. Send them out.	Will not open after the lamps. Will not keep them half-full so they return tonight.
A Struck Far-Voiced, raw (the drowning-door)	The voice came back untrained	Hand them to the Intake. Sit the first hour *with* Intake if the Cry is already in the room.	Will not stamp a ticket on a raw Struck Far-Voiced. Will not leave them in the market.
A Book-hand with a settling	The term *assumes* a seventh-day hour	Honour it if the slate has a hole. Mark *full* if it does not.	Will not pretend Greyhull has a bench when Greyhull is full.
Anyone who came for a play	The hall is also the playhouse	Sell a bench. Take the coin. Let the working voices pay their Tithe *as* the show.	Will not stop a performance to process a ticket. The show *is* the Tithe for the people on the boards.

An ordinary week

Morning: the slate. Hours named. Relay-posts listed. A child’s breath-lesson in the cold hall. The ticket-desk is a stool by the door.

Evening: the house. Feeling in earnest, on purpose, where a neighbour paid to hear it. This is the pleasant version of the Tithe, and it is also the town’s entertainment. No one calls that a coincidence.

The unswept bench. One seat is never swept. A keeper says, “That’s the first Cry’s seat.” No one will explain which Cry. A first-year who sits there is moved without a sermon.

When a voice misses its hour, the keeper does not open the side door. They know a room that still shuts. They do not say the room’s name.

They will not stamp a raw Struck. That is the Intake. They will not rewrite a Bound’s Terms because a voice was used to swear them. They will not run a mission-hall on Kumbaan.

Who may keep a hall

Not by Kind. A Selkie crier and a human neighbour hold the same stool if they can keep a slate and hear when a voice is about to break.

By practice first. You are of the house when the town still comes to your hour, and when you have pulled a child off a Cry before it landed.

The boards, the relay, the stand often go to Far-Voiced whose vocation *is* the vent. The ticket-stool to a Given Far-Voiced who trained young, or a sharp Kept, or a Long-Lived who remembers last century’s Cry. The first hour with a raw Struck Far-Voiced to whoever will sit it. Intake borrows this room.

How they live in the three corners

- **Vaethorn (gift-hall folk).** A barn, a festival, a blessing said over the first note. Almost no ticket-stool. A Struck Far-Voiced is a late gift and a hazard the valley will stand around, singing, until someone who has been to a real hall arrives. You were given the hour, so the valley expects you to spend the voice as it asks: crier, witness, hymn.
- **Lestrand (release-hands).** The playhouse *is* the hall. Posted hours. Guild-ticket as master’s papers. A voice without coin for a bench still has a labour-hour at the back if they will sweep. A voice without even that goes to week-rent.
- **Threnmaieth (counted-hall clerks).** The crown furnishes the counted hall and can withhold the hour. Tickets are crown-warrants in all but the stamp. A Cry off-slate is a column. The hall looks like a festival. What the crown can withhold is the hour.
- **Kumbaan.** No ael-hall.

The scheduled hour

The hall sells (or grants) the right to feel in public *on time*. Off-time is a ticket problem. A performer who lost the honest stage still has the hour, if the slate has a hole, if the season-fee was paid, if the crown still lists them.

The town is glad. An emptied voice is not a Cry in the market. A devout town can say the gift was aired. A Lestrand quay can say the bill was posted. The Threnmaieth crown can say the channel held.

The eighth week, the week the passage-money fails, is not kinder because someone called the hour a gift. A voice must vent. People built the slate.

Self-paying voices subsidize provided-for ones when the polity lets them. The show *is* some people's Tithe and other people's night out. Lestrand calls this the market. Vaethorn calls this tending. Both can be true in one barn.

The first Cry's bench stays unswept. That is how the hall remembers.

An hour-slate

Lestrand release-house, chalked on the door beside tonight's bill. The verso is yesterday's slate, not washed.

> *Third hour: the boards (paid). Fifth: relay-drill, apprentices. Sixth: open hour, two benches, no coin if you sweep. After the lamps: the house is shut. A missed hour is a missed hour. We do not keep a voice half-full. If you have already cried in the street, this is still the house. Come at open, not now. If you cannot wait, we do not know a room.*

The slate is a playhouse being practical, almost kind (the sweep-hour). The keepers do know a room that still shuts. The slate says they do not, the same way the greens' slate does, so that the hall is not blamed for it. The first Cry's bench is not on the slate. Everyone knows which one it is.

The Stillers

The Stillers licence the Stilled and run the infirmaries. The guild issues the ticket. The state watches the guild. It does not keep a list of every Stilled person.

Everyday people say **stillers**, or **the Stillers' Guild.** In liturgy they say **the Stelhael** (STEL-hayl). *stel* is to still, to hold from moving, and *hael* is whole. The name says they keep you hale by holding you still. Vaethorn's second word is **blessing-surgeons**. Lestrand's is **ticket-surgeons**. Threnmaieth files them as **crown-stillers**.

In one sentence: they will save you on the table, and they will make you drill until the Grey is gone. When they use the Gaze, stillness collects. That stillness is the Grey. Left unpaid, it locks a limb toward stone. The ticket marks competence. The infirmary's pace follows the surgeon's Grey.

Shape of the house

- **The same kind of roster as the other two tickets.** The Hall-Keepers' Voice-ticket and the Element-Guilds' element-ticket work this way. Each keeps a roster of people who practice a dangerous art.
- **The infirmary and the yard are one guild.** They work the table in the infirmary. In the yard they spar, patrol, and hold the riot-line. Using the Gaze *fills* the Grey. The yard empties it. The guild's best work creates the guild's Tithe. That is the job.
- **They talk about a surgeon's college.** Apprentices, a code, a ticket like a master's papers.
- **The charter is local.** A rich core infirmary is rich. A frontier stiller is one tired person. The state watches the charter.

If you meet one

Calm. Flat-eyed when they are working. Hair that stirs when something nearby has gone too still. You meet them in an infirmary, on a drill-floor, or on a line that has not yet become a massacre. You find the guild hour when you need a ticket.

They are useful the way a surgeon is useful. A town without one makes do with a rope-and-prayer.

Who comes, and when

Who	Why they come	What the stiller does	What they will not do
A Given Stilled child, after pale stone	The Gaze must be trained before it is turned on a person	Apprentice them. Drill. Theatre. The ticket when they can still a wound and not a person.	Will not Speak the colour. Will not put them on a riot-line in the first year.
A patient	Bleeding, poison, a knife that needs a still field	Hold the moment. Work fast. Walk to the yard after and burn the Grey.	Will not hold a will. Cannot. Will not still a person as punishment.
The watch, or a street that is turning	A brawl about to become a pile of bodies	Stand the line. Still the swing, not the person, if they can help it.	Will not become the town's executioner. Using the Gaze to hold a person helpless is a crime the code names.
A Struck Stilled, raw (they were stone)	The Grey is already in them, unpracticed	Hand them to the Intake. Sit the first drill *with* Intake. Reverse what can still be reversed.	Will not stamp a ticket on a raw Gaze. Will not leave them in the square.
A charter-clerk	Someone unlicensed stills in public	Protect the charter: take them in, or swear they were not of the house	Will not write the town's people down. The guild-roll names stillers. The Threnhael is a different list. That is Threnmaieth's census of persons and their gifts.
Anyone who wants the Gaze as a weapon	no honest errand	Refuse. The code is the ticket.	Will not sell the Gaze to hold a person. Anyone who does is not of this house.

An ordinary week

Theatre. The pleasant horror outsiders remember: a gaze that stops blood, a surgeon who must then go and *move*. Between patients they drill. They spar. They dance, badly, because dance works the Grey out. No one calls this therapy in the core; they call it the job.

The doorknob. They touch a doorknob before they look at a patient. If the knob has gone still under an unwatched Gaze, the room is already wrong. A first-year who forgets is sent back to the yard.

The yard. Exertion on purpose. The Tithe paid as professional identity.

The ticket-stool. A master's mark. Held by the person. The guild *knows its members* the way any craft does. In Lestrand the ticket can come to include a place, a chair, and a name on a door. That fight stays in that house. Other towns do not have to keep it.

When a raw Struck arrives, the paying floor loses a master for a week. The guild is not grateful. That week is the Intake.

They will not still a will. They cannot. They will not pretend they can to frighten a street. They will not let the Grey run to a public seize if they can still drag the person to the yard. A seize on the floor is a ruined charter. The roll names stillers. It does not name every Stilled person, and it is not Threnmaieth's census. They will not export a college across the storm-wall.

Who may hold a ticket

Not by Kind. The Gaze does not care what you were born.

By practice first. You are of the house when you can still a wound and then *move*, and when the town has watched you do both.

Theatre and the line go to the Stilled. The Tithe and the vocation are the same shape. The yard to anyone who will make them *move*: a Kept drill-master; a Two-Bodied who will run them. Intake week to the master who can be spared (often the one the floor can least spare), or a Struck who remembers stone and will sit the first drill.

Skeptics are welcome. The Gaze does not require a Mother. Believers in Vaethorn will still say a blessing-to-practice. Both can hold the same ticket.

How they live in the three corners

- **Vaethorn (blessing-surgeons).** One tired stiller, a blessing-to-practice, a riot-line that is also the only theatre. Almost no college. You were trained, so the valley expects you to stand every line it has. The rope is still how a raw Struck is met if the stiller is three valleys away.
- **Lestrand (ticket-surgeons).** Superb infirmaries. Guild-ticket as property-adjacent. You can be priced out of the chair. The charter is a commercial good. Unlicensed practice threatens the charter as much as the street.
- **Threnmaieth (crown-stillers).** The crown wants the ticket as a crown-warrant and the roll as a column. Some masters cooperate, and call that stewardship. Some refuse: the guild-roll names

stillers, and the Threnhael is the census. The Gaze that saves you runs through a channel that can be withheld from a household the crown dislikes. It is the darkest infirmary in the world, and it is still a real infirmary.

- **Kumbaan.** A travelling stiller is a guest. The guild has no chapter there.

The Grey as labor

The guild's best work fills the Grey that will lock a limb if they do not then labor. So the house needs them on the table and in the yard. The charter needs them never to lapse in public. The infirmary's pace is set by the surgeon's Grey as much as by the patient.

It is a hospital that runs on its staff's Tithe.

The ticket-as-property argument (Lestrand, leaking elsewhere) is the second face: competence lives in a person; the chair can start to live in the guild.

The Motherfaith says she gave a gaze that costs. The roster is people's work, and nobody expects the Tree to make the drill optional.

Intake is badly paid. The raw Struck who most need a week in the shed are the week the floor can least spare. The paying floor treats that week as a loss.

A Grey-drill roster

Core infirmary, chalked on the yard wall. The verso is yesterday's, washed badly.

> *After third theatre: spar, full glass. After the line: the long run, no Gaze. Apprentices: the knob first, always. A Grey that stays overnight is a Grey we file as lapse, not as rest. The shed is not on this wall. If you were stone last week, you are not on this wall. Come to the door that does not face the street. We do not write that door. We do not still a person to close a day. Touch the knob. Then look.*

The roster is a college keeping its people hale, with the code written as a work-order. It also shows the paying floor refusing to write down the door to the Intake. "A Grey we file as lapse" makes a tired surgeon a charter problem. The person may need a longer run. They will not say why the knob comes first.

The Element-Guilds

The Answered, sorted by element, hold the third safety-ticket. The craft pays its own Tithe. Four houses share one way of licensing. Each house works a different element.

Everyday people say **the element-guilds**, or the **Ember-house**, **Tide-house**, **Root-house**, **Gale-house.** The umbrella name is **the Crae** (kray). *crae* is craft, the working of an element. A single Answered is *of the Crae*; they are *of Ember* if you need the door. Vaethorn's second word is **gift-shops**. Lestrand's is **the craft-houses**. Threnmaieth files **the Reckoned Craes**.

In one sentence: the shop is how an Answered pays the Tithe. Leaving the shop leaves the element idle, and idle is the hazard.

Shape of the house

- **Four houses, one way of licensing.** Ember keeps smiths, glass, and firefighting. Tide keeps hulls, dyers, and any work that needs water to behave. Root keeps masons, potters, and the carrying-earth a Road-hand may buy. Gale keeps sails, mills, instruments, and the wind a Tengu already knew. They share a ticket-logic and an Intake shed. An Ember-master does not set Tide's fees.
- **Self-paying until you leave.** Earnest work slakes the Tithe, so the guild is the upkeep. Bench an Answered and they are unemployed and idle. Idle is how an element leaves the shop.
- **They talk about the craft.** Apprenticeships, shop-rules, which coal may go dark.
- **The name is shared. The shops are not.** An even-tempered Root potter and a short-fused Ember smith are both of the Crae, and the work is not the same.

If you meet one

Sweat, clay, salt, or chalk-dust, depending on the door. A shop-rule nailed up. A ticket-stool that looks like any master's. You would hire them to build a hull. Ask, "Who may let an element speak in a crowded yard?" That answer is the ticket.

A town already needed smiths and masons. The Condition made those guilds necessary again, so the work does not let the element go.

Who comes, and when

Who	Why they come	What the house does	What they will not do
A Given Answered child, after lamp-amber	The shade named the element; the shop must catch them young	Apprentice to *that* door. Earnest work. The ticket when the element answers the hands and not the room.	Will not Speak the colour. Will not switch a child's element because the town needed Tide.
A working Answered	The craft *is* the Tithe	Give them the shop, the watch-rotation, the fire-crew, the escort.	Will not bench them "for a rest" without a plan. Idle is the hazard.
An Answered who lost the shop	Grief, a wrecked yard, a lord who benched them	Find earnest use *now*: a crew, a demolition, a night at the bellows.	Will not rent them a week of "just enough spark." That rented spark is the Slide.
A Struck Answered, raw	A threshold let an element in later, untrained	The Intake. The right door, not the nearest fire.	Will not stamp a ticket on a raw Reach. Will not put them on a hull the same day.
Anyone who wants a thing made	A hull, a glass, a wall, a sail	Make it. Charge as a craft charges.	Will not let an unlicensed cousin "just coax the stone" in the street. The charter is the street's safety *and* the shop's monopoly.
A Road-hand needing carrying-earth	Root can coax living earth to travel	Sell the earth. The guild does not carry the scion.	Walking the wood stays with the Road-hands. Their liturgical name is the Thaelvaeth.

Four doors

Door	The work	The shop-rule you notice	If left idle
Ember	smith, glass, fire-crew	they never let the last coal go dark	heat finds a place to be
Tide	hull, dye, anything wet	a cup of yesterday's water over the door	water finds a place to be
Root	mason, potter, carrying-earth	clay under the nails they will not wash on a work-day	stone and soil find a place to be
Gale	sail, mill, instrument	a window that is never fully shut	wind finds a place to be

The element goes somewhere. It does not seize a person's will. The guild's job is to make that place the shop, not the crowded hall.

An ordinary week

The shop. The rotation (fire-crew, escort, the watch that is also Tithe). The ticket-stool. The shop-rule no one explains to a guest.

When a master is pulled to Intake, the paying floor loses a Reach for a week. Ember hates this during a dry month. Tide hates this when a hull is mid-bend. That hatred is why the paying floor resents the shed.

They will not switch an element to suit a labour shortage. The shade named it. They will not bench "for their own good" without earnest use waiting. That is how a room lets go. They will not stamp a raw Struck. They will not export a Crae-college to Kumbaan.

Who may hold a ticket

Not by Kind. Any Kind may hold the ticket. A Tengu who is Gale-Answered is common. The element is not reserved to a Kind.

By practice first. You are of the house when the element answers your work and not the rafters.

The shop goes to the Answered of that element. Fire-crew and rescue rotations to Ember and Gale, also Two-Bodied on the line and Returned in the wreck. Carrying-earth to Root, also Taken-In who will not call it a grove-rite. Kept labor does the free generalist work around the Reach. They strike, they pull, and they hold the mundane tool. Lestrand's *free*. Vaethorn's *Waited*, still useful.

How they live in the three corners

- **Vaethorn (gift-shops).** One mixed yard, four tools, a blessing-to-practice. You were answered, so the valley expects you to spend the element as it asks: the mill, the wall, the fire-line. Idle is rare because the valley will not let a gift sit.
- **Lestrand (the craft-houses).** Deep shops, posted tickets, monopoly-teeth. You can be priced out of the *chair* and still need the work, which is how a person slides from self-paying to exposed overnight. The charter is money and safety in one paper.
- **Threnmaieth (the Reckoned Craes).** The crown wants element and person on the same column. Workshops are channels. A benched Answered is a withheld Reach. The shop looks like a gift-works. What the crown can withhold is the fire, the slip, the stone, or the wind.
- **Kumbaan.** A wrecked Tide-Answered is a guest. There is no Tide-house on the sand.

The shop you cannot leave

Self-paying holds until you want to stop. The Tithe does not care that you buried a child, that the yard burned, that you are tired of glass. Idle, the element acts without the person's hands.

So the guild's kindness, a shop, a crew, a rotation, is also how the guild holds you. Leaving is a Tithe-crisis. Vaethorn calls that a vocation. Lestrand calls that a contract. Threnmaieth calls that a channel.

A year away from the shop is not safe. The Motherfaith says she answered. The shop-rule is people's work.

The last coal, the cup of yesterday, the unwashed clay, the window that will not shut: those are how each door remembers.

A shop-rule

Ember-house, Lestrand glass-yard, nailed above the last coal. The verso is a Tide-house rule from the next quay, used as backing.

> *The last coal stays. A Reach used in play is not a Reach used in earnest: the ticket will not have it, and the room will. If you cannot work, you will still work: the fire-crew, the night bellows, the watch. We do not bench. We do not rent a spark. The shed is not this door; raw hands go to the door that does not face the street. If you have already let go, this is still the house. Come to the coal, not to the square. Gale will not take you. Tide will not take you. The coal will.*

The rule is a craft keeping its people steady, a little fierce. “We do not bench” also means “you may not leave.” The Tide-rule on the verso says the same thing about a cup of water. The two houses did not copy each other.

The Intake

The Stillers, the Hall-Keepers, and the Element-Guilds share one shed. It takes a dangerous Struck in hand for the catching-week. That person had no childhood apprenticeship. The Slide keeps a person for a paid week. This shed tries to make them safe enough to leave.

Everyday people say **the Intake**, or **the raw-desk**, or **the shed.** In guild-cant they say **the catching-year.** There is no liturgical name. The paying floor will not write the office on the wall. Vaethorn says **the late-catching**. Lestrand says **the emergency ticket**. Threnmaieth files **the unwitnessed warrant**.

In one sentence: they have a week to make a live hazard into a person the town will stand next to, and if they succeed, no one writes it down.

Shape of the office

- **The Struck is brought to the shed.** A runner arrives, or a master is pulled off the paying floor. When they travel, the nearest ticket-house is three days away and a rope is already in someone’s hand. That is distance. Road-hands already walk the long road. Intake does not.
- **Three ticket-houses, one shed.** A raw Gaze goes to the Stillers. A raw Far-Voiced goes to the Hall-Keepers. A raw Reach goes to the Element-Guilds, to the right element. The wrong house is how a Cry gets stilled quiet, or an Ember is put on a bench to sing. The shed is shared. Each hazard still has its own door.
- **They catch, they steady, and they hand the person to the apprenticeship.**
- **Success is silence.** Guild leadership is indifferent, and on a bad week hostile. A quiet catching-year is a week the floor lost. A loud one is a charter hearing. Nobody changes the guild’s mind about the shed. A grudging extra pair of hands is the most the yard will grant, and they will take them back.

What the catching-week requires

- **The task.** Take a raw Struck (Stilled, Far-Voiced, or Answered) in hand and begin the apprenticeship at once, before the town meets them with a rope. What they are racing is time: the hazard is already live, and the town wants them gone.
- **What they have.** The shed that does not face the street. It is not the theatre, the boards, or the paying shop. One master pulled off the floor, whoever will sit, maybe a Kept who has no Tithe of

their own. They can take the person if the person will come. They cannot overrule a frontier rope. They cannot stamp a ticket this week. The charter is at risk if the person harms someone, or if they refuse the Struck and the town later says the guild left a hazard. Leadership forgot them on a good day and will scapegoat them on a bad one. The yard lends a hand only while the week stays quiet.

- **Who sits.** Any Kind may sit it. The floor does not send its favourites. The master who can be spared is often the one who cannot. A Kept will sit because they are *free* and the floor resents that. A Struck who remembers their own door will sit. A junior ticket on probation will sit. The floor assigns the week, or last year's sitter hands it on. People are rarely recruited for it.
- **What counts as success.** The person is still alive, still here, and beginning to be safe to stand next to. The town pretends this was always going to happen. The guild does not apologize.

If you meet one

Tired. Chalk on a sleeve. A key to a door the slate does not name. You would miss them if you came in the front of the infirmary or the playhouse. Ask, "Where did the one who was stone yesterday go?" Or you are the runner, and you already know the door.

They are who a town has when a becoming has already happened, and the town may prefer it had not.

Who comes, and when

Who	Why they come	What Intake does	What they will not do
A raw Stilled (they were stone)	Grey already filling; a rope in the square	Get them off the square. First drill. Reverse what can still be reversed. Sit with them until the Gaze holds a wound and not a person.	Will not stamp a ticket. Will not still the crowd as a lesson.
A raw Far-Voiced (they drowned)	Undertow already pulling; a Cry in the market	Get them into the hall's back room. First hour *with* a hall-keeper if one will sit. Vent on purpose before it vents them.	Will not open after the lamps as policy. Will not keep them half-full.
A raw Answered	An element let go later, untrained	Right door. Earnest use *now* that is not the crowded shop.	Will not put them on a hull the same day. Will not bench them.
A family, or a door-keeper, or a Book-hand	Someone must stand; someone wrote *owing*	Take the person. Ask who will stand for them *as what they are now*.	Will not sell a vouch. Will not call them Given.
The watch	The town wants them off the square	Bargain for the shed instead of the rope. Sometimes lose.	They have a key. They cannot command the street.
The paying floor	They want their master back	Finish the week or fail it. Return the master.	Will not promise this will not happen again.

An ordinary catching-year (it is not ordinary)

There is no ordinary week. There is a week.

1. They get the person off the square, out of the water, away from the shop that is already wrong.
2. They name what is already true: *you carry a Gaze; you carry a voice; you carry a Reach.* They name no Mother unless the person does.
3. They help the person make a first honest payment of the Tithe that is not a public hazard: a drill, an hour, a coal that is not the public forge.
4. They find someone who will stand for the person *anew*. Intake does not take the place of that vouch.

5. At the end of the week the person is still raw and beginning to be safe, handed to the real apprenticeship, or gone. Gone, they meet the rope, the road, or a week-keeper who will not make them safe.

They write the catching-year on the **inside** of a ticket-blank, not on the face. The face stays empty until a real ticket is earned. A first-year who writes on the face is made to strike it.

They will not stamp a ticket this week. Competence is not a week old. If they must walk, it is toward this Struck. Road-hands already have the long road. They will not rewrite Bound Terms. A raw Bound goes to a table. The Whisper cannot command. They will not take a raw Taken-In, Returned, Two-Bodied, or Long-Lived. A raw Taken-In goes to a lot. A Returned's purpose cannot be furnished here. A Two-Bodied uses civic land. A Long-Lived uses a long-house. None of those is a bystander ticket, and none of them is this shed.

Who may sit the shed

Not by Kind. By practice first: you sat a week and the person did not become a public story.

The first drill / hour / coal to a ticket-holder of *that* hazard. The sitting, the water, the food to a Kept (no Tithe of their own; can stay). A Struck who came through Intake once may say, "I remember the door." The runner to whoever can run: Two-Bodied; a Far-Voiced crier who will not use the Cry to clear a street.

How they live with the other houses

The parent houses pretend the shed is not on the wall. Success is silence. A raw Taken-In goes to a lot, for dirt. If the week fails, a week-keeper may take the overflow. Intake wants them safe enough to leave. The Slide wants them not-fallen enough to stay. A quiet receiving-rite may happen the same week as a warden's. Civic settling may send them here. A door-keeper names the Struck kin at the door that made them. That naming is kinship. The ticket is still unstamped. The naming and the catching-week are two courtesies in the same week. A Watcher's second reading may describe the threshold. The guild's stamp is a separate act.

How they live in the three corners

- **Vaethorn (the late-catching).** The rope is real. The shed may be a barn. Once caught, the valley will spend them. The late-come are vouched graciously *and* put to work.
- **Lestrand (the emergency ticket).** Posted, almost. A fee if anyone can pay it. The charter-risk is commercial. A raw Struck who cannot stamp a fee is still taken, the street-hazard demands it, and the house will remember the debt.

- **Threnmaieth (the unwitnessed warrant).** The crown wants the Struck *named* as they are caught. Intake's inside-writing is already a defiance. A quiet week looks like a leak. A loud week looks like incompetence. The darkest pressure: catch them for the channel.
- **Kumbaan.** A wreck walked uphill is a guest. There is no shed on the sand.

The week no one writes

The paying floor needs the master. The town needs the hazard gone. The Struck needs a year. Intake is given a week and a shed, and is blamed for all three.

If they succeed, the story becomes: *the guild trains its own.* If they fail, the story becomes: *the shed.* Devotion does not make the rope kinder, and it does not give them a better door. The becoming was unwitnessed. The town built a square that would rather use a rope.

Badly paid, out of what the parent house has left after the paying floor: the shed, the food, the master's lost week. They do not furnish a commons. They do not sell an hour. They catch.

A catching-year slip

Written on the inside of a blank ticket, stillers' shed, core town. The face is empty.

> *Inside only. Gaze, raw. Came from stone on the third night. Stood for by the sister and by N. who will not give a family name. First drill held. Nobody held still. No ticket. If the week ends quiet, burn this. If it does not, the charter already knows. We do not face the street. We do not write the wall. If they have already been a rope-story, this is still the shed. Come if they will come. If they will not, we cannot make a town take them. The Mother does not reach twice by chance. Neither do we. That line is the wardens'. Strike it if you must. I have not.*

The slip is a competent catching, a little desperate, written on a folded paper the college would rather not keep. The empty face of the blank is deliberate. The writer kept the wardens' line on the slip. When the slip is burned, the success becomes the guild's ordinary story, and the person's becoming is never written down in public. The sister stood. N. would not be named. Both are someone standing for the Struck.

Three corners: Vaethorn, Lestrand, Threnmaieth

Every polity in the Turning chooses three things separately: how devout it is, how many healthy Trees it has, and how far the state reaches onto a person. Law, livelihood, and daily life stay the same from power to power, because they come from the Trees and the Conditions. What changes is the combination of those three choices.

These three lands are set so that each pair matches on one choice and differs on the other two.

Name	Devotion	Healthy Trees	The state on the person	The one-line feel
Vaethorn *(the Waiting Lands)*	high	low	low	Ardent faith, thin Trees, almost no state: a warm, poor, half-lawless pilgrim edge
Lestrand *(the Ledger Coast)*	low	high	low	Faith worn lightly, dense Trees, guilds not crowns: a rich, cool, transactional merchant power
Threnmaieth *(the Tallied Crown)*	high	high	high	Sacred *and* surveilled: a wealthy, pious core where the census is a holy duty

- Vaethorn and Lestrand share **low governance**: same light-touch state, opposite everything else. Warm-poor-faithful against rich-cool-secular.
- Vaethorn and Threnmaieth share **high theology**: same ardent faith, wildly different circumstances. Devotion at the starving edge against devotion in the sanctified, watched core.
- Lestrand and Threnmaieth share **high reach**: same Tree-wealth spent two opposite ways. Free markets against a crown that watches every person and calls the watching holy.

High devotion produces both the kindest corner to a whole neighbour (Vaethorn) and the most inescapable control in the world (Threnmaieth). Devotion makes whatever else the polity is doing stronger.

The name a polity gives a shared institution reveals its stance. A devout land’s “gift-hall” is a surveillance-crown’s “counted hall.” Same building, three worldviews.

Vaethorn: the Waiting Lands

(VAETH-orn · devotion high · few healthy Trees · the state barely reaches a person)

A broad, thinly-peopled land at the world's Tree-poor margin, where the faith burns hottest *because* the Trees are scarce, and where the ruling mood is *waiting*: for a graft to take, for a distant Tree to be reached, for a gift that may never fall. This is a frontier where devotion runs at its hottest. The two facts feed each other. Where the Trees are few and young, more children come away Kept, more people are Struck later and alone, and the Motherfaith answers that scarcity with more devotion: pilgrimage, longing, and a theology built around waiting for a gift that may not come.

Law here. Governance is almost absent. No crown reaches the individual, and custom outruns written law the way it does on any frontier. Citizenship is witnessed in the oldest, most literal way: a settlement small enough that everyone *was* there when you Turned. The Lands' thin reach makes citizenship-by-witness fragile. With few Long-Lived to remember and few Bound to vouch, the three pillars that make proof-by-people work are stretched thin: a Long-Lived's memory, a Bound's vouch, and a Far-Voiced's voice. The **unvouched Struck** changed alone, with no guild to catch them and few witnesses to stand for them. That person is a constant, aching problem Vaethorn meets with faith rather than machinery. A feared Condition here is more likely to be met with a rope or a blessing than a licence, because there is no guild to issue one. Someone vouches for you in a new place. That is standing-for. They call it *the speaking*, and they do it at worship. They call the ticket *the blessing-to-practice*. No Condition can command another person's will. That rule is the Inviolate Will. They call it *the Mother's own line*.

Economy here. Little formal Tithe-infrastructure and few specialists, but the theology reframes the frontier's poverty as *charity*. Where a purely secular frontier improvises Tithe-provision as barter and favor, Vaethorn does it as **alms and congregation**. The venting a Far-Voiced needs happens at worship, and they call that worship the *gift-hall*. Neighbours furnish the green a Taken-In needs and count it a sacred duty, and they call that green *the Mother's green*. The Taken-In whom rich cities keep at arm's length are here the honoured **backbone of the land**. Working the living earth *is* the holy economy. It is commons-minded generosity with almost nothing to fund it: real warmth, real want, and a persistent thin edge where the provided-for Tithe-poor slide with only prayer for a net. A Two-Bodied spends time as the animal on open land. They call that land *the wild-leave*. They call the long-house of books *the deathless gift*. When the commons run out, they call the Slide *the last pot*, and also *gift-credit*.

Daily life here. Thin ceremony made enormous by devotion. A child's Turning at a small, hard-won grafted Tree is the event of a decade, held as a joyous, anxious sacrament, and the **Kept child is felt most sharply here**, because in a land starved of the gift, to be passed over reads (wrongly, and cruelly) as being passed over *by the Mother herself.* People here call the Kept *the Waited*, or *Mother-kept*. The valley counts them passed over, and pities them for it. They call the Struck *the late-come*. If the

settlement is lucky, a travelling stiller does the medicine, and if it is not, they make do with a rope and a prayer; the core-vs-edge inequity is at its widest here. Families are warm, mixed, and self-reliant; a lapsing Condition with no infirmary to reach is a frontier tragedy the faith consoles but cannot cure. The tree-warden is most of the state. Vaethorn calls wardens Hands-folk. Door-keepers keep the older custom of the doors. People call them the door-folk. Guest-reading towns kept those doors when a Tree arrived. They pilgrimage and still walk them. First-reading districts treat the graft as a guest in an older house: they tend a dying graft and still refuse the blessing.

Its injustice. The harm is a **guilt**. The scarcity of the gift becomes a theology of *unworthiness*: the Kept wonder what they lacked, the Struck wonder why the Mother came to them at the wrong door and alone, and a hard, quiet piety can shade into treating want as a spiritual failing. Vaethorn is the kindest place in the world to a whole neighbour and the loneliest to an unvouched one.

The seat. Eolvaeth *(ay-ohl-VAYTH)*. That is a pilgrim-edge vale behind the Strandoren-facing coast. People walk *here to wait*. The Tree is not a certainty.

Lestrand: the Ledger Coast

(leh-STRAND · devotion low · many healthy Trees · the state barely reaches a person)

A dense, Tree-rich merchant power where the Trees are mature and many, the Given are dense, and the faith is worn *lightly.* Deep markets, thin welfare, and a cool, transactional read on the whole business of becoming. It shares Vaethorn's light-touch governance: no crown writes anyone down. Where Vaethorn's light state leaves a *gap the faith fills*, Lestrand's light state leaves a *space the guilds fill*, completely.

Law here. Guild self-rule, carried as far as it goes. The state is a charter-granting council of merchant houses and craft-guilds; it charters the Stilled's guild and the element-guilds and watches the guild, never the individual. Citizenship-by-witness runs *smoothly* here because reach is high: abundant Long-Lived notaries, Bound whose sworn word closes every contract, Far-Voiced on every dock and in every court. The three pillars are **infrastructure** here. That machinery lets a huge commercial city run on trust without a register. The Struck are vouched-in briskly, because an unvouched person is a transaction that can't clear. Here they call the Struck *the turned*. The Inviolate Will is cited as sound commercial law. A Bound's contract binds property, not persons, and the Coast likes that line because it makes the Bound the witness a written contract wants. They call standing-for *warranting*. That is a commercial guarantee. They call the ticket *the guild-ticket*. They call the Inviolate Will *the free-will clause*. They call the Motherfaith *the old rite*, and they wear it light. The Fair Hand keeps honest accounts. They call that faith *the Settling*, and on this coast that is ordinary.

Economy here. The richest corner, and the coolest. This is where **deathless banking** is fullest. Deathless houses keep trusted notes that other houses measure their paper against, and they keep century instruments. They endow fortunes rather than leave them as inheritances, at a scale the other lands do not match. The great endowed libraries and universities cluster here, and that money funds the Long-Lived's own novelty-Tithe. Self-paying Conditions prosper, the Answered crafts, the Two-Bodied haulage and courier trades, the Stilled surgeons, because their labor *is* their upkeep and the market pays for the labor. **Tithe-provision is a private market, not a public good.** You buy your green, and they call the plot *the leaf-lot*. You buy your novelty, and they call it *the endowment* or *the house*. You buy your outlet at the *release-house*, and that house is also the playhouse. If you can afford it you stay whole in comfort. **Its injustice is the market's.** The provided-for Tithe-poor get *thin welfare in a rich city*, the starkest have-and-have-not gap in the world, and the shadow economy (smuggled green, black-market novelty, sold vouching, off-book Bound contracts feeding the Given-Over) runs biggest here because the legitimate market is biggest here. The concentration risk the deathless pose is at its most acute: a handful of houses that never die, quietly steering the wealthiest polity through patronage that never disperses. After a fee fails, someone rents the week. They call that *week-rent*. They call the Kept *the free*. That means labor with no Tithe to furnish. They call the ranging *the beast-yard*. That yard can be hired. They call tree-wardens *tree-tenders*. They call book-hands *the Settling-hands*.

Daily life here. Superb Condition-medicine (the great Stilled infirmaries and deathless-endowed hospitals are *here*, in the rich core), for those who can reach it; the queue outside it is longest here too. Family life shrugs at theology: a **marriage market that reads Conditions as assets**, a Two-Bodied bloodline is a trade dynasty, a Long-Lived match is a century of credit, and the aching Long-Lived marriage gets weighed coolly as a balance of grief against advantage. The Turning is a civic and commercial milestone more than a sacrament. A family's Leaf-Fall is watched for what guild the child's colour opens. It is free, and it is prosperous. The Open Table feeds a guest before asking who they are. An attic-host of that faith is a curiosity and a good supper. Sailors print "no one is a stranger twice" as a proverb on a card. The Settling will not enforce it.

Its injustice. The coolest of the three. Nothing is *policed*. Your marriage, your gift, your faith are your own. Everything is *priced*, and a person who cannot pay slides with a whole rich city stepping around them. Lestrand will never file you or conscript you. It will simply let you fade if you run out of coin, and feel that it owed you nothing.

The seat. Orentel *(OREN-tel)*. That is a salt-quay city on the Old Crossing. The White Note House sits on the third quay, north side. It keeps terms. It does not govern the coast.

Threnmaieth: the Tallied Crown

(THREN-my-eth · devotion high · many healthy Trees · the state reaches the person)

A pious, Tree-rich core kingdom that keeps a census of persons and their Conditions, in the wealthiest, most devout, most Tree-dense land. Here the roll is kept as a holy duty: the Mother's gifts are precious and must be accounted for. That makes it the hardest of the three to resist. The other two have injustices you can name and resent. This one puts its injustice in the two things the world most trusts, faith and plenty.

Law here. The Tallied Crown keeps **a record held on people**. Every subject and their gift is written down, not as guild rolls or tax ledgers (everyone has those) but as a **census of persons**. At home they frame that census as reverent stewardship of the Mother's blessings. Elsewhere it is felt as surveillance. They call that census the **Threnhael**. Trenledd keeps a roll of persons too. The difference is that the Tallied Crown calls its roll holy, and Trenledd does not. Because reach is high, there is a great deal to count. The Given are dense, and the crown calls them *the marked*. The guilds are dense. Long-Lived memory is abundant, and the crown distrusts it, because that memory is not the crown's. What gives Threnmaieth away is this: it will not rely on the three pillars the rest of the world runs on, because living memory answers to itself and a ledger answers to the crown. The unvouched are hunted and the Struck pursued to be catalogued. They file that pursuit as *the unwitnessed*. The Bound are watched far past their real hazard. The roster's own clerks know the Inviolate Will means the Whisper cannot command. The watching is stigma, kept as if it were safety. Devotion supplies the justification a census without faith would lack. A steward will say, "You would not hide a gift from the Mother, so why hide it from her stewards?" They call standing-for *the naming*. You are named to the crown. They call the ticket *the crown-warrant*. They call the Inviolate Will *the crown's assurance*. They call the Motherfaith *the Reckoned Faith*. They file Watchers as *the Grown-Over*. That is a column on the roll. They file book-hands as *the Uncounted Book*. They file door-keepers as *the Unreached*. The Open Table is off the map.

Economy here. Tithe-need turned to leverage, and consecrated. The crown provides Tithe-upkeep **efficiently, even generously** (a pious, rich state can afford to), but *holds* what it provides. It holds the green, and calls that green *the tended green*. It holds the novelty, and calls that *the crown archive*. It holds the outlets, and calls those *the counted hall*. It holds the Stilled medicine. All of that runs through channels the crown controls and can withhold. A population whose staying-whole runs through the state is a population that **cannot afford to refuse it**, the most complete control in the world. To receive your Tithe-provision is to receive the Mother's bounty through her appointed hands, and to be cut off is framed as *your* lapse, not the crown's lever. Its deathless-house finance is superb and centuries-deep, but the Long-Lived here are courtiers and crown-archivists as much as bankers, their incorruptible memory bent to the census rather than free to check it. A Two-Bodied spends time as the animal on the ranging. The crown files that land as *the ranging-roll*. They call the furnishing *the*

counted channel. They call the Slide *the late week*. That is the leak the roll cannot file without admitting the channel failed. The roll pretends not to know.

Daily life here. The sacrament and the census fused. A child's Turning is a **joyous holy day that is also a state registration**. The colour that falls is celebrated with a hymn *and* recorded by a clerk. Marriages of heritable Conditions (Two-Bodied bloodlines especially) are *noticed*, encouraged or discouraged, filed. The medicine that furnishes a Tithe is excellent and runs through the crown's channels. A household whose **bloodline and upkeep are both on file** cannot easily refuse the crown anything. That is domestic surveillance with a blessing said over it. The Kept are pitied here the way a devout land pities them, and recorded the way this crown records them. The roll says *the unmarked*, or *the passed-over*. They were passed over by the Mother, and the crown notes them as such. They file tree-wardens as *the Reckoned Hands*. The First Seat stands in the same Sacred Core. The crown wants wardens named to the Threnhael as officers of the Reckoned Faith. Some Speakers cooperate. Some refuse: the Tree witnessed; a ledger is a second, lesser seeing. Nearness to the Seat is pressure on the college. The crown does not own the Seat. The college can refuse the roll, and some Speakers don't. A Yumboe in the Sacred Core is a diplomatic incident of manners. The crown cannot file a people who were never at a Tree, so a Yumboe is not a column on the roll. That is a relief and a slight at once.

Its injustice. The worst of high devotion and a state that reaches every person, each excusing the other. The devotion makes the surveillance feel like reverence: it is piety to be counted. The surveillance enforces the devotion: to refuse the count is impiety. A wealthy, faithful, orderly people genuinely believe that accounting for the Mother's gifts is the highest form of tending them, and that belief makes the control almost impossible to resist. Elsewhere the roll reads as chilling, because **only two crowns keep one**, and here the faith is what lets it feel like grace.

The seat. Maiethlir *(my-eth-LEER)* stands on a thaw river in the Sacred Core. Its children can Turn at its own Tree. That is a Hand. Pilgrims still walk on from here to the Awakening Tree, and the crown's roll, the Threnhael, is kept here. The First Seat of the wardens sits in the Motherwood beside the town. The crown does not own Thaeloren.

Book V

The Lands

The Four Continents

The map of the Turning shows how far the origin Tree’s wood has spread. That distance is its reach.

Nearest that wood, the old sacred country is dense with Trees. The merchant coasts beyond it still have many. The frontier is thin. Past the last capes, a storm-walled isle has none.

There is one Awakening Tree, **Thaeloren**. Every town Tree is a living **graft** of it, planted in new ground so a child can Turn under it. People call that planted Tree a Turning Tree. The further a land sits from the deep, old, densely-grafted core, the thinner its reach tends to run: fewer, younger, more fragile Trees. More children are hugged at the Tree and stay Kept. More children miss a Tree and stay UnTurned. More people are Struck later and alone. How far a land sits from Thaeloren is also how long ago the wood arrived. The Ages chapter tells that history.

Names keep the old *th* nearest the Tree. A frontier town softens it. A dock town sands it off. You can hear how far a land sits from the grove in how people say the same word.

What the names mean

The names on the map are old words glued together. Here is what they are saying the first time they appear as places.

Name	Says	Means
Thaeloren	THAEL-or-en	the Tree that witnesses. Everyday: **the Thallow**. The Awakening Tree.
Maiethorn	MAI-eth-orn	the Mother's Land
Strandoren	stran-DOR-en	the Witnessed Shore. Everyday: **Strandor**
Heskoren	hesk-OR-en	the Outer Land. Everyday: **Heskorn**. *Hesk-* is a frontier word for the far edge; the old rite is older than this grafting.
Kumbaan	koom-BAHN	the hidden home, in the Yumboes' own tongue. Sailors say **the Sundering Isle**, or **the Sunder**, for the water that walls it off.

Each of the three large continents has one famous corner, named by gluing two old words together and wearing them down. The farther the corner sits from the Awakening Tree, the more the old sound has worn off:

Name	Says	Means
Threnmaieth	THREN-mai-eth	the Mother's Reckoning. Keeps the full old sound.
Lestrand	LES-trand	the Reckoning Coast. The *th* is gone.
Vaethorn	VAETH-orn	the Waiting Land. Spoken: **Wetorn**.

The other named powers on each continent are built from the same old words. You will meet them as you go. **Language and Naming** will let you hear one as it appears, or make another.

How the continents sit

Reading the world roughly **east to west**, as the wood thins:

- **Maiethorn** anchors the **east**, where the land is oldest and most settled and the Awakening Tree still stands. Everything the world calls "the center" is here.
- **Strandoren** lies **west across the Old Crossing**, close enough to Maiethorn for constant, ancient trade (the two are the "Old World" pair), its long indented coasts facing the crossing. The Old Crossing — the inner sea, in older talk — is the busiest water in the world.

- **Heskoren** sprawls **further west and south**, beyond Strandoren's far coast, reached late, grafted late, the edge of the settled world. Between Strandoren and Heskoren the sea widens and the reach thins. This is where the frontier begins.
- **The Sundering Isle** sits **alone in the far west (or deep south) ocean**, past Heskoren's last capes, walled off by the **storm-wall**. Killing weather, currents, and reef have wrecked most who tried the crossing. The isle has no Tree, and the grafts never crossed to it. It is seldom reached, and its people are mythic-rare on all three other continents.

Maiethorn and Strandoren are close and old. Heskoren is far and thin. The Isle is sundered beyond.

The four continents at a glance

Continent	Reach	Role	Named powers here	Rival faith
Maiethorn (the Motherland)	full	The sacred origin; the Awakening Tree stands here	Threnmaieth · Maiethvael · Orenbren · Saelthael · the Hinge Shore · Lirorn	the Watching
Strandoren (the Shore-lands)	high	The great trade continent, the world's crossroads	Lestrand · Brenledd · Leddvael · Trenledd · Netstrand	the Fair Hand
Heskoren (the Sundered Reach)	thin	The frontier; newest-grafted, half-wild	Vaethorn · Ornled · Vaelhesk · Saelvaeth	the Old Ways
The Sundering Isle (Kumbaan, the Yumboe homeland)	near-none	The storm-walled remote isle; mythic-rare people	the Yumboes at home	the Open Table

Each of the three large continents carries several of the fifteen great powers. Threnmaieth, Lestrand, and Vaethorn sit one to a continent.

The Motherfaith is one faith among several. The Watching, the Fair Hand, and the Old Ways live on the large continents, where they rub against the Motherfaith. The Open Table is the Isle's own.

Maiethorn: the Motherland

(mah-YETH-orn.)

Maiethorn is the world's **old heart**: the continent people mean when they say "the center." It is long-settled and deeply grafted: every hill with its Tree, and every Tree with its centuries. This is where the Motherfaith began, and where the Awakening Tree grows. A child's Turning is ordinary here because it is almost certain. The Trees are so healthy that more children are Given here than in the world as a whole, so a hug at the Tree is less common here than elsewhere. It is not rare, and every Maiethorn school has Kept children. The Conditions chapter gives the shares. Deathless houses here are centuries old. Stilled infirmaries stand open. Far-Voiced work on every court and quay.

Devotion here is the heaviest in the world, because the Awakening Tree stands on this continent. It runs through institutions and through politics. The faith is old and contested. Threnmaieth counts its people and calls the count sacred. A stubborn heartland heresy claims the same center.

Geography and climate

The Sacred Core. At Maiethorn's heart stands **Thaeloren, the Awakening Tree**, in a deep old grove that is the destination of the world's great pilgrimage. People call it the First Hand: the wood later Turning Trees were cut from. The land around it is the most densely-grafted on earth: an old, gentle country of rounded hills, river valleys, and Tree-crowned towns, worn smooth by long settlement.

The Motherwood. Vast old-growth forest of motherwood and its wild kin rings the core. Here are the healthiest Trees, and the graft-nurseries from which the cuttings travel to the whole world. The First Seat and the faith's institutions cluster in the wood's clearings.

The Rain-Wall, a central range that Lirorn calls the Thaw-Wall, divides the continent's watersheds. Temperate, seasonal climate: four true seasons, real winters that make the solstice-timed Leaf-Fall meaningful. Old roads and river-trade knit it together. Tengu hearths and Fox-of-the-Snows country sit on the high snows. The range is also why the east is dry.

The Rain-Shadow. East of the Rain-Wall, on the leeward side away from the Old Crossing, the land falls into **dry hills and sand-country**, the one true dry reach in the known world. This is the hearth of the Fox of the Sands. It is still Maiethorn: the same Trees, the same old *th*, and the same pilgrimage west toward Thaeloren. The weather here is the dry one. Towns here cluster at wells and at whatever graft will take in thin soil. **Larbril** is where the west road meets the Well-wash, short of the pass. **Ornsael** is the smaller well-town farther into the dry, where people sow at a well. Open sand-country lies between it and Larbril, and the town sits inland. Children in the sacred core could already Turn at a Turning Tree while families here were still walking west to Thaeloren.

The western coast faces the busy **Old Crossing** toward Strandoren, the oldest trade route in the world, the “Old World” crossing. Ports here are ancient and rich, if less frantic than Strandoren’s. Selkie families are common on these quays, as they are on any old water.

Reach

Full. This is the densest, healthiest grafting anywhere. The core runs higher on the Given than the world as a whole. Long-Lived memory, Bound word, and Far-Voiced feeling are thick on the ground. The Kept are fewer than elsewhere, but there are Kept children in every town, and in the more fervent districts they are quietly pitied as passed-over. The Walled Book, behind Rothallo’s walls, teaches that a hug is rare. That is the Walled Book’s lesson, not the count. Nowhere else are so many children Given, or so many of those three gifts at work.

The wood arrived with the First Cut. The years since that first successful planting are Cut-years. Maiethorn filled in Cut-years 0–80, origin-towns first. A cutting could travel about a day while the wood was still alive, and then it had to be planted. The **Rain-Shadow was slower**: the same continent, thin soil, and wells. Towns in the sacred core had Turning Trees, and their children stopped walking to Thaeloren, while sand-country families were still walking west. The ground set that pace. The Ages chapter has the years.

Powers

- **Threnmaieth, the Tallied Crown** (theology high · reach high · governance high). The wealthy, pious, surveilled core kingdom, near the sacred center. Its census, the **Threnhael**, sanctifies surveillance as reverent stewardship of the Mother’s gifts. Maiethorn’s full reach is why Threnmaieth has so much to count. Its seat is **Maiethlir**, a town on the thaw-river with its own Turning Tree. The grove of Thaeloren stands outside the crown’s rule.
- **Maiethvael**, the Gift-Realm, is devout and rich, and it keeps no census. Its capital is **Seinbrun**, a large city in the warm core, off the thaw-river where Maiethlir sits. People furnish a hall, a green, and medicine. The Down-Bank is the road below Maiethlir’s Down Gate. Gift-folk live along that road. Seinbrun is farther on, down the Core-thaw and north of Maiethlir on the atlas, more than a day from Maiethlir. The rest of that walk is not recorded.
- **Orenbren**, the Witness-Hearths, is the lodging on the roads to the grove. Pilgrims sleep in its inns, and that lodging is the power. The Awakening Tree stands outside its rule. Its capital is **Rothallo**, a walled city one day’s walk from the wood, inside Orenbren. People still say the Inner Close. They mean this city. The First Seat is in the wood. The Third Hearth is a road-house on the same pilgrim road.
- **Saelthael**, the Sown Tree, is the Rain-Shadow. Families here still walk west to a healthier canopy to Turn. Its city is **Larbril**, east of the Rain-Wall on the dry side, where the west road meets the

Well-wash, short of the pass. **Ornsael** is the well-town farther into the dry, where people sow at the well.

- **The Hinge Shore** is Maiethorn's coast on the Old Crossing. Before a hull is priced across the water, this shore says whether it carries pilgrims, a cutting in a pot, a person, or cargo. Its port is **Votaer**. Orentel is the city on the far shore. Votaer is the port on this one.
- **Lirorn**, the Thaw-Land, holds the Rain-Wall and the snowmelt that feeds the lowlands. Its walled town is **Tasain**, in the valley below the Shelf-gate, on the west road south of Thaeloren on the atlas. Larbril is on the far side of that pass. The days between them are not recorded.

Tengu, Fox, and Selkie live in hearths inside these six powers.

Faith

The Motherfaith's birthplace and stronghold. Its institutions, its pilgrimage, and its authoritative tree-wardens all seat here. The sacred center is contested.

The heartland heresy: the Watching. An older Tree-faith the Motherfaith grew over persists in Maiethorn's oldest districts. The argument lives in those districts. They keep the Tree as witness (*Haelthael*) and refuse the Mother-name. Because it is old, it claims to remember what the world believed before the Trees were understood as the Mother's hands. Watchers keep a night at the **Seeing-Ring**, a ring of old stones on a hill in the old Watching country, north-east of Maiethlir. They will not call it a temple.

In the Walking Years, a Maiethorn child Turned by walking to Thaeloren. That inland trip is the Near Mile: days to a couple of weeks. The pilgrimage to Thaeloren still brings people from everywhere. The Ages chapter tells those years.

Strandoren: the Shore-lands

*(stran-DOR-en. Everyday **Strandor**.)*

Strandoren is the **crossroads of the known world**: a continent of harbours, its long coastline so deeply indented with bays, sounds, and peninsulas that no point sits far from saltwater. It is the **market that grew up facing Maiethorn**: charter-towns, guild halls, banking houses, and quays. The Trees here are mature and many (reach is high, the Given are dense), but the faith is worn light, folded into commerce until a child's Turning is watched less as a sacrament than as a question of which guild the colour opens. Deathless banking is at full scale here. Condition-labor buys the world's most advanced public works.

It is free, prosperous, and cool. Nothing here is policed (your faith, your gift, your marriage are your own), but everything is priced. The injustice is the market's. A person who cannot pay simply fades while a rich continent steps politely around them.

Geography and climate

The indented coast. Strandoren's defining feature: a shoreline of countless natural harbours, tidal estuaries, and sheltered sounds. Every notable town is a port. The sea is the continent's highway. This is the densest Selkie hearth in the world, many families along a long shoreline.

The Old Crossing (east): the narrow, crowded, ancient water between Strandoren and Maiethorn. Everyday name everywhere. Older talk still says *the inner sea*. The busiest crossing in the world, the "Old World" trade artery. The Hush-rate is still charged on this water.

The West Water (west and south): where the coast faces the widening sea toward Heskoren and, far beyond, the Sundering Isle. Strandoren's boldest merchant-houses run the frontier trade to Heskoren. Almost none have crossed the storm-wall to the Isle (those who claim to are the tellers of the Yumboe stories).

Interior: fertile lowlands and river-plains feeding the port-cities; mild maritime climate, wet and temperate. Mature grafted Trees stand thick along the wealthy coasts and thin only in the deep interior.

Reach

High. Grafts here are mature and abundant, especially on the coast. The Given are dense. The three pillars are the machinery a huge commercial society runs on: Long-Lived notaries, Bound whose word closes contracts, Far-Voiced on every dock and in every court. The Struck are vouched-in briskly and efficiently. An unvouched person is a transaction that can't clear.

The wood arrived by sea in Cut-years 40–160, wealthy coasts first. A ship outran the work of planting every inland hamlet. A rich coast could pay the First Seat for a Cutting-leave, while a village on the Near Mile was still waiting its turn. The interior, along the rivers, was planted later. Clerks of the Fair Hand call that arrival "the carrying," and they file it as cargo.

Powers

- **Lestrand, the Ledger Coast** (theology low · reach high · governance low). The premier merchant power: guild self-rule carried as far as it goes, deathless-house finance at scale. Here the upkeep is a private market: you buy your green, your novelty, your outlet, and you fade if you cannot pay. The richest and coolest corner of the world. Its seat is **Orentel**, on the Salt Quay. The White Note House keeps its office on that quay and keeps the old notes. The guilds govern the city.

- **Brenledd**, the Hearth-League, is many charter-towns under one compact. Each town keeps its own Tree and its own vouching. The throne-city is **Raitin**, a river-city inland, south-west of Orentel on the atlas, where the council sits and the shared notes clear. Six charter-towns sit around it, each with its own hearth. Raitin is where they meet.
- **Leddvael**, the Reckoned Gift, keeps the Fair Hand as the city's own rite. Leaf-Fall here is a festival and a signing-watch. Its port is **Naenor**, down the coast south-west of Orentel and south of Raitin on the atlas. The Book-Hands stamp a signing and recite. They work on this water and keep no hall of their own.
- **Trenledd**, the Worn Count, writes its people on a roll of tax and hazard. The count carries no hymn. Its city is **Lunbra**, on the Chart-run, where the roll is kept and the money is shown.
- **Netstrand**, the Night Shore, faces the open ocean and runs the trade to Heskoren. Its harbour is **Braetu**. One berth on that quay stays unlit, and no house is attached to it.

Faith

Faith is worn light here, and it has a rival with real doctrine.

The fortune-and-contract cult: the Fair Hand (*Leddoren*). A mercantile theology that reads Conditions not as gifts given (the Motherfaith's line) but as **bargains struck**. The world is a ledger of deals, and what you became is what you (or your line) bargained for. Direct doctrinal rival to gift-doctrine, at home among the Bound. It reframes the Tithe as a term serviced rather than an upkeep tended.

The Salt Walk was Strandoren's way to a Turning: a ship across the Old Crossing, then the Near Mile inland. The berth had to be caught in fair weather. A family that missed the last crossing missed the year. That hinge-month is Eolthael.

Heskoren: the Sundered Reach

*(hesk-OR-en. Everyday **Heskorn**.)*

Heskoren is the **edge of the world that the Trees reached last**. The land is young in wood, thin, and waiting: a broad, rugged, half-settled country where the grafts came recently, take poorly, and sicken often. Whole districts wait on a Tree that hasn't taken and a gift that may never fall. This is the continent that runs high on the Kept, the children the leaves hugged, and on the Struck, people who changed later, alone, with no one to witness it. It also has many UnTurned children, who reached no healthy Tree at ten. It is where the Motherfaith burns hottest. Scarcity of the gift has heated devotion: pilgrimage, longing, and a theology of waiting. In the Walking Years the same pattern was distance.

The Long Mile from this continent to Thaeloren took weeks or months, and it cost more than most families could spend. Some districts still send children that far, or to a neighbour's Tree. The distance is what kept them from the gift.

It is warm, poor, and self-reliant: the kindest place in the world to a whole neighbour and the loneliest to an unvouched one. The danger is a **lapsing Condition with no infirmary to reach**, and a faith that consoles what it cannot cure. Scarcity of the gift shades into a doctrine of unworthiness.

Geography and climate

Rugged and various. Highland spines, upland moors, deep forests, and long river-runs down to a wild coast. Bigger weather, harder winters, more untamed ground than the Old World pair. Tengu ridge-towns and Fox-of-the-Snows hearths sit on the spines. Fox-of-the-Wilds and the deeper woods share the same forests. Selkie families hold the wild coast.

The grafted pockets. Settlement clusters wherever a graft has taken. A healthy Tree is the seed of a town, and the map of Heskoren's civilization is a map of its surviving Trees. Between them: wild with no polity, thinly-held marches, and long roads between Tree and Tree.

The frontier coast is Heskoren's east coast. It faces the West Water back toward Strandoren, the lifeline of trade and new grafts. Eolvaeth is a vale behind this coast.

The slate-shore is Heskoren's west coast, in Ornled. Its beaches face the last capes and, far beyond them, the storm-wall that hides the Sundering Isle. A hull that wants a beach here comes round the capes. Heskoren's westernmost capes are the closest settled land to the Isle, and the source of many who've seen the storm-wall even if they never crossed it.

Climate: cooler, wetter, wilder than Maiethorn and Strandoren. A land where the solstice-timed Leaf-Fall is a hard-won event of a decade.

Reach

Thin. The grafts are young, scattered, and prone to sickening. The three pillars are stretched thin (few Long-Lived to remember, few Bound to vouch), so citizenship-by-witness is fragile and the **unvouched Struck** are a constant, aching problem met with faith where there is little machinery. Kept and Struck are both common, and many children stay UnTurned. Specialist care is scarce. Heskoren is where the wood is still arriving. The Ages chapter calls that unfinished carrying the Grafting.

The wood reached Heskoren in Cut-years 200–387, and the work is unfinished. After Strandoren's coasts, cuttings died on the Long Mile. Each new Turning Tree had to grow up before it could supply the next town. The queue planted the town that could pay. That gap is the late wood. In Vaethorn, priests say the wait means the people were unworthy. The years record a late planting. Where the Old

Ways hold a planting, the first meal is the host-right. A planting without that meal is a claiming. **Harrow's Green** is a grove whose canopy the neighbours can see and use. The Three Hamlets Past the Ford — Brenod, Vaelun, and Ornath — still walk their children to a Tree this year.

Powers

- **Vaethorn, the Waiting Lands** (theology high · reach low · governance low). Ardent faith, thin Trees, almost no state: a warm, poor, half-lawless pilgrim edge whose ruling mood is waiting for a graft to take, for a gift that may not come. Its injustice is a **guilt**: scarcity read as unworthiness. Its seat is **Eolvaeth**, a vale on the pilgrim edge, inland of the coast that faces Strandoren. People walk here to wait. Saelvaeth's march lies on another road.
- **Ornled**, the Outer Ledger, is the secular frontier: the same thin Trees as the waiting country, and no congregation to tend them. Its town is **Sanbreo**, on the slate-shore of Heskoren's west coast, its beach facing the last capes and the storm-wall. It is on the brink of a small city, and the slate is kept there.
- **Vaelhesk**, the Far Yield, keeps the Old Ways' host-rights. The first meal at a planting is the law they keep. The land itself is the seat. There is no city. The First Bowl is the guest-grove, where a stranger is fed.
- **Saelvaeth**, the Sown Waiting, is the march on the live edge, where new grafts are taking. Its town is **Natai**, west of Harrow's Green, in the country between Sanbreo and that grove. The days to either are not recorded. **Harrow's Green** is a grove-town in this march's country. People Turn under its canopy. The hamlets' ford is the crossing Brenod, Vaelun, and Ornath use. The march is seated at Natai.

The four powers are fewer, poorer, and scattered. Wild country with no power of its own fills the space between them.

Faith

Two faiths in tension, and the friction is the frontier's own:

- The **Motherfaith** burns hottest here: a theology of longing and pilgrimage grown around the scarce gift.
- **The Old Ways** (*Vaeloren*). An animist and ancestor faith that predates the grafts. People of the Old Ways say, "The Mother's reach is new here. We had our own ways before her Trees came." It reveres the Struck and the Taken-In as the land's own children, and resents the Motherfaith as a latecomer. Real theological standing, real grievance.

The Sundering Isle: Kumbaan

*(koom-BAHN, "the hidden home." Sailors say **the Sundering Isle** or **the Sunder**. Outsiders name the barrier. The Yumboes name the hearth.)*

The Sundering Isle is the one land the grafts never reached. Dead wood is not a Tree. Where Heskoren is thin, the Isle is empty of the Trees the rest of the world is built around, and its people become what they are by **their own path**, outside the Leaf-Fall altogether. The storm-wall has wrecked most who tried the crossing, so that in Maiethorn, Strandoren, and Heskoren alike a Yumboe is a figure from a sailor's tale: pearly-skinned, silver-haired. Sailors say "the good people from across the drowning sea." Some of the stories are even true.

Kumbaan is an ordinary home, warm and hospitable, that happens to be nearly impossible to reach. The Yumboes are not strange to themselves, only to a world that has never met them. They are a hill-people who love a feast, served by hands you cannot see, and the rest of the world thinks they are a legend.

Geography and climate

The storm-wall. A near-permanent girdle of violent weather, treacherous currents, and reef rings the Isle. That is why the Isle remains sundered. Ships that try the crossing are wrecked, turned back, or simply never return. There may be a season, or a way, when the wall thins. Nobody knows.

The Paps: the hill country. The Isle's defining landform: rolling green **hills honeycombed beneath** with the Yumboes' true dwellings. They live within the hills, coming out by moonlight. The surface is pasture, terrace, and standing-stone. The life is below.

Mild, wet, moonlit. A temperate maritime island climate under the storm-wall's cloud. The Isle is famous (in its own tellings) for its **bright nights**: the people are nocturnal, and moonlight is their daylight.

Small. The one small continent of the four: an island-continent you can walk, known in full by its people, beside Heskoren's trackless vastness.

Reach

Near-none. There is no Tree on the Isle, and there never was a graft. The grafts never crossed the storm-wall. The count for this isle, in the First Cut's years, is never. Sailors tell of pots that went into the water. Those pots were dead wood. They never took as Trees. The Yumboes do not Turn at a Tree. They become what they are by their own path.

People: the Yumboes

The Isle is the homeland of the **Yumboes** (“Bakhna Rakhna,” *the good people*): pearly-white-skinned, silver-haired, hill-dwelling, moonlit, and famously **hospitable to strangers**, native and foreigner alike.

- They live **beneath the hills**, come out **by moonlight**, and hold **great feasts served by hands and feet you can see but bodies you cannot**.
- They are **native to Kumbaan and rare beyond it**. The storm-wall keeps them home, so the few who do cross become the source of every legend the mainland tells.
- Their **tongue and faith are their own**, and they owe the Leaf-Mother nothing.

Faith

The Open Table (*Ndeyaan*): the Yumboes’ own cosmology, grown in isolation and owing nothing to the Motherfaith. Their old accounts bind the good people up with the ancestors and the dead, and the mainland tales call them “the spirits of the dead.” They are a living people with a faith of hill, moon, hospitality, and the staying-kin. They are not ghosts. The Table-Keepers keep the hall. The Shore-Sitters keep the sand.

The Reckoning of the Year

The Turning keeps time by the sun. The Leaf-Fall falls at a solstice, so the count fixes when children Turn, when the great festival falls, and how a world with mechanical clocks and no printing press numbers its days. The sky here is enough to run the rite and to date a debt.

The sky

One sun. One moon on the mainland, on a familiar monthly round, enough for nights and for tides. Kumbaan keeps twelve named moons and counts them on its own list. They are the same sky, counted differently. Four true seasons, and real winters. People stand on one ground. The storm-wall is weather, current, and reef. The hills at Ndenjoo are hills people live in. A person who has become is still standing on this ground. The Low Wall, the Seeing-Ring, and the Dry Stair are older stone on this same ground. People reach a place by walking or by sail. What a faith calls a door, people keep as a practice, a meal, a return, or a hymn.

The one fact that matters for the rite is the **solstice**, because that is when the Trees turn.

At the High Solstice, the longest day, a Tree’s shadow at noon sits almost on its own roots. Supper happens in light that should have been gone. Turning-Week is that week of light. A storm can soak the crowd. The solstice stays on the sun’s day. On Maiethorn’s Rain-Wall the sun clears a shelf it leaves in shadow in the Deep. On Heskoren the same long light falls on a canopy, a bog, or neither, depending on the fold. Believers say, “The Mother timed her choosing to the year’s hinge.” Skeptics say, “A tree answers light.” Both stand in the same noon and see the same short shadow.

At the Deep Solstice the sun rises late, stays low, and is soon gone. The mainland moon is the light you actually use, when cloud allows. A clear Deep night shows the moon and a great many unnamed lights. People farm by the months.

At Ndenjoo, on a bright night, the moon is the daylight. You can carry a bowl across the hill-yard without a lamp. The storm-wall is a darker ring around that brightness. The bright moon washes the small lights out. There is no Leaf-Fall in that sky. There is no Tree to throw a noon shadow.

The Leaf-Fall happens at the solstice because that is when the Trees turn their colour and choose. The sun reaches its turning, and so do the children. The devout and the skeptics share that calendar.

The Turning Year

The year hinges on **two solstices**, the world's fixed astronomical anchors:

- **The Deep Solstice** (midwinter): the longest night; the year's low, turning point. A season of hearth, endowment-giving, and the deathless houses' account-closing.
- **The High Solstice** (midsummer): the longest day, and **the Turning.** This is the great one: the solstice when the Trees turn and the year's ten-year-olds meet the Leaf-Fall.

The High Solstice is warm, safe to travel and gather, and full of light. A child's Turning is a joyous festival, and midsummer suits it. It also makes the pilgrimage to Thaeloren a summer road.

Turning-Week

The Leaf-Fall runs through **Turning-Week**, the week bracketing the High Solstice, when the Trees hold their colour and the choosing is done. Every child who has turned ten since the last High Solstice Turns this week. The town gathers, the tree-wardens officiate, and it is at once the holiest rite and the biggest fair of the year (part christening, part graduation, part festival). A person's Turning-year becomes a lifelong marker of age and cohort. People of that summer say, "We Turned the same summer."

Months and weeks

The calendar counts like this:

- **Twelve months** tied to the moon's cycle, in **four seasons of three months** each, hinged on the two solstices (and the two equinoxes between them as lesser markers).
- **Weeks** as the working unit of the guild towns: guild-weeks, market-days, the mechanical clock-towers of the trade cities striking the hours. There is no printing press, so clergy and clerks keep the calendars. That is one reason the tree-wardens and the Tallied Crown's clerks hold quiet power: they keep the dates.

The twelve Maiethren months

Liturgical names are Maiethren, the old speech of Maiethorn. Beside them sits the worn common-tongue form, the way Lestrand says the same month. The name you use reveals the stance. Counted here **from the Deep Solstice** as an astronomical order.

#	Season	Liturgical	Says	Worn / common	Holds
1	Winter	**Nethael** (neth-AYL)	“the night made whole”	*Nethel* / **the Deep**	the **Deep Solstice**
2	Winter	**Brenorn** (bren-ORN)	“hearth-land”	*Brennor* / **Hearth-month**	midwinter hush; deathless account-closing finishes
3	Winter to Spring	**Liren** (LEER-en)	“the thaw’s speech”	*Liren* / **the Thaw**	water runs again
4	Spring	**Saelorn** (SAY-lorn)	“sowing-land”	*Salorn* / **Seed-month**	first green
5	Spring	**Haelren** (HAYL-ren)	“hale-speech”	*Hailren* / **Hale-month**	the land sound
6	Summer	**Eolthael** (ay-ohl-THALE)	“the Tree’s hinge”	*Yoltal* / **Turning-month**	the **High Solstice** · **Turning-Week**
7	Summer	**Vaelorn** (VAY-lorn)	“gift-land”	*Valorn* / **Gift-month**	after-Turning; the colours settle
8	Summer	**Leddorn** (led-ORN)	“reckoning-land”	*Leddorn* / **Ledger-month**	late-summer markets, contract-terms
9	Autumn	**Ornvael** (ORN-vayl)	“the land’s yield”	*Ornvale* / **Harvest**	bringing-in
10	Autumn	**Threnael** (thren-AYL)	“the tally made whole”	*Trennel* / **the Tally**	autumn count
11	Autumn	**Vaethren** (VAYTH-ren)	“the waiting-speech”	*Vaeren* / **the Wait**	longing toward the dark
12	Winter	**Nethorn** (NETH-orn)	“night-land”	*Nethorn* / **Dark-month**	approaching the Deep

When the year starts: three new-year days by stance

The devout and the clergy begin the year at **Eolthael**. The Turning is the hinge that matters. Lestrand and the deathless houses begin it at **Nethael**. Midwinter is when the books close. In Vaethorn the pulpit

follows the clergy. In the fields, people date a child from the last summer a local Tree managed a fall. They say, “The child turns the year.” Same twelve names. Any of three days may be kept as the opening of the year. A debt can be late on one count and early on another, and people will argue which day began it.

Kumbaan’s moons

The Yumboe of Kumbaan keep **twelve named moons**. The count is lunar:

Yaaba · Ndibi · Sambiyo · Waandi · Lunji · Saalo · Soonke · Nkoosa · Ndenjoo · Yendo · Njili · Mbela

Saalo is a moon, and Seed-month is a mainland month. A mainlander who lines the two up is wrong, and wrong the same way every year.

How years are numbered

Months name a season. **Years have no universal number.** The count written on a debt is a theology, the same argument as which day opens the year. The Ages chapter keeps the full count.

- **First Seat / devout clerks** count **Cut-years** from the First Cut (liturgical: the *Eoloren-count*). Present: **Cut-year 387**.
- **Lestrand and the deathless houses** count from a house-founding or a note-issue. A clerk of the White Note writes the present year as “the 307th summer of the White Note.”
- **Threnmaieth** writes Cut-years and also a crown-count from the Two Papers, in Cut-year 67. The present is **Crown-year 320**.
- **Vaethorn** counts from the year the local graft took. People there say, “the year our graft took.”
- **The Watching** refuse the Cut-count. **Kumbaan** keeps moons and owes the ages nothing.

The Awakening Tree is old beyond reliable dating. There is no year the world began, and no year she appeared.

How it is lived along the gradient

The count is the same sky on the mainland: one sun, one moon, two solstices. People live that count differently as the wood thins.

- **Maiethorn** (full reach): Turning-Week is a near-certainty and a vast institution. Dense healthy Trees, a core that runs higher on the Given than the world as a whole, the pilgrimage to Thaeloren cresting at the High Solstice. When that walk was required, it was the Walking Years. The Near Mile is the inland trip on Maiethorn, days to a couple of weeks. The Ages chapter tells those years.

- **Strandoren** (high reach): the solstice is kept as a sacred date and as a commercial one. Fairs, contract-terms, and the deathless houses' reckoning all hang on it.
- **Heskoren** (thin reach): Turning-Week is a hard-won event of a decade. A child may travel days to the nearest Turning Tree, or wait years for a graft to take. The solstice still arrives. The gift may not fall. Whole districts still walk the Long Mile, weeks or months to a Tree that can Turn them.
- **Kumbaan** (no reach): the Yumboes keep the moon, not the solstice. The reckoning is nocturnal and lunar, and it owes nothing to the Trees, because Kumbaan has none. Theirs is the one calendar in the world with no Leaf-Fall in it. A mainlander who lines a moon up with a Maiethren month is wrong in the same direction every time. The hall will not correct the chart.

What the year feels like

People keep the week their street actually keeps. Faiths argue about what the week means. Each street chooses the words.

In a devout town, on an ordinary market morning, people carrying baskets stop when a tree-warden steps onto the Tree's roots, and start again when the warden steps off. Someone of the Watching will not say "Maieth," and will still wait. Someone of the Fair Hand, passing through, will not wait. The square notices both. The year these people feel begins in Eolthael, even if a clerk's tablet started the count earlier. In Maiethlir the thaw-river runs louder the week before Leaf-Fall. The town will not say why.

On a dock, the year the account books feel begins at the Deep Solstice, when the notes are closed. Turning-month is a fair laid on top of that closing. All year, a "clear" is a person a crane-crew will hire: someone the Tree hugged and gave no Condition. In Eolthael, people put salt on the Tree's roots. Orentel will not say why.

In a waiting town, people date a child from the last summer the local wood actually spoke. They do not spend the good flour on a promise that it will speak again. A guest gets the common pot. If the wood spoke last year, Turning-Week gets the better loaf. If it did not, the week gets the pot too. A wet leaf lies on the spring, or too many, or none. Eolvaeth will not say why. At Harrow's Green people say, "The wood," first when it will speak. If their own wood will not speak, they name the neighbour's town after that.

At Ndenjoo the year is moons. Noon is when the hall is asleep. On one night of the moon sailors call Yoltal, the hall eats the heel of the loaf first. They will not say why.

Turning-Week, as a town spends it, is baskets, bells, and a loaf. The leaf-colours, and the questions a warden gets asked, belong to the rite at the Tree. In Maiethlir the stalls go up under the town Tree, and households stand by the bell. The public slate names the street and the hour. The colour a child received stays off that slate. On Orentel's quay, a person stands with the crew that already knows the

child. A clear gets the same shout the quay uses when a berth opens. In Eolvaeth, if the wood will not speak, people in the street say, “Not this week.” The hill on Kumbaan keeps its moons through the week the mainland calls Turning-Week. No child is stood up. No one asks for a colour. There is no Tree in the valley.

Climate, Ecology, and Travel

This chapter names the water and the stone, says how a week feels in each band, and says how long a walk takes. Say the everyday name. A devout speaker keeps the *th* in the land-names around the water. On a dock, that *th* wears off. Clerks enjoy the long old form. Dates here are in Cut-years, counted from the First Cut. The Ages chapter keeps that count.

Named water, range, and rivers

Everyday	What it is	Who says something else
the Old Crossing	the busy water between Maiethorn and Strandoren	Lestrand: *the crossing.* Vaethorn: *the waiting-water.* Sailors: *the Crossing.*
the West Water	the wider sea between Strandoren and Heskoren	the Night Shore's own name for this sea
the Rain-Wall	Maiethorn's central range	Lirorn-folk: *the Thaw-Wall.* Clerks: *the Divide.*
the Noon Pass	the old high road over the Rain-Wall (lost its stone in Cut-year 233)	the courier's *noon-pass*
the Shelf-gate	the pass taken after the Break	Threnmaieth named *the new one*; Lirorn charges **Break-rate**
the Core-thaw	the river Maiethlir sits on	clerks: *snowmelt.* Watchers will not.
the Well-wash	Rain-Shadow seasonal water	dry most years; silt in a bad thaw
the Rise-water	the stream from Harrow's Green to the hamlets' ford	the Seat says *the ford*
the Chart-run	Strandoren's interior river to Orentel's estuary	Lestrand: the inland run that brings goods to the salt quay

the Old Crossing. The oldest trade route in the world. Narrow enough that a fair-weather hull does it in a handful of days, and busy enough that a late storm in Hale-month can make a family miss Turning-Week, and then their child stays UnTurned. The Hinge Shore is Maiethorn's face. Orentel is Strandoren's face. The Salt Walk was the way Strandoren reached a Turning: this water, then the Near Mile inland on Maiethorn. Maiethorn and Strandoren are the Old World pair because this water joins them. The Grey Summer (Cut-year 171) tied the quays. The Hinge Hush (Cut-year 304) is the peace still charged as the **Hush-rate**.

the West Water. Wider than the Crossing. This sea is the water-leg of the Long Mile from Heskoren toward a Tree, and that road takes weeks. A pot of cuttings has a harder berth here than on the Old Crossing. The Night Shore faces this water and sells the far run. Heskoren's frontier coast, its east coast, faces the same water back toward Strandoren. Heskoren's west coast, the slate-shore, faces the last capes, and beyond them the storm-wall. No house on this water sells a passage to Kumbaan. Sailors tell of a pot that went into the storm and was wrecked. No graft took.

the Rain-Wall. A highland spine down Maiethorn's middle. West-face weather is wet and four-seasoned; the leeward east is the Rain-Shadow. The range is why Saelthael sows at wells. The range is why Lirorn can levy a thaw. Fox-of-the-Snows and Tengu hearths sit densest on the high snow. Heskoren's highland spines are a different weather. The Rain-Wall is Maiethorn's range.

Two passes cross the range. The **Noon Pass** is the old high road. It lost its stone in Cut-year 233, and the Thaw-Break left a water-line over the ribbon-notch. The **Shelf-gate** is the pass taken after the Break, and it is the road people use now.

Four rivers. The **Core-thaw** is snowmelt off the Rain-Wall's west face, running toward the Old Crossing. Maiethlir sat down where the water slowed enough to hold a Turning Tree. Seinbrun stands off that water, down the river and north of Maiethlir on the atlas, more than a day from Maiethlir. In a high Liren the lodging-road meets a near branch of the same water. The **Well-wash** is a seasonal run east of the range: a river in a kind Liren and a silt-line in a cruel one. **Larbril** is where the west road meets that wash, short of the pass. **Ornsael** drinks a well, farther into the dry, with open country between it and Larbril. The town sits inland. The wash is why the well matters. The **Rise-water** is a low stream off Harrow's rise. Downstream it becomes the hamlets' ford, the crossing of Brenod, Vaelun, and Ornath. The Seat calls that crossing the ford. **Natai**, the march-town, stands on other ground, west of Harrow's Green, between Sanbreo and that grove. The **Chart-run** is Strandoren's interior river-plain, running to Orentel's estuary. Lunbra sits on the wealthy stretch of it. The coasts received the wood by sea. Inland towns waited on a cart and on this river.

Climate bands

A week in each band feels like this.

Band	Where	Weather
Crossing-shore	both faces of the Old Crossing	mild, wet-temperate; Hale-month storms decide a Salt Walk
Mother-core	Maiethorn west of the Rain-Wall	four true seasons; old sacred country; winters that make High Solstice mean something
Rain-Wall / Thaw-Wall	Lirorn	snow, shelves, a thaw that is a civic year
Rain-Shadow	Saelthael east	dry hills, wells, the Well-wash or nothing
Shore-lands	Strandoren coasts and the Chart-run	maritime, indented, the sea as highway
Night Shore	Netstrand	open-ocean; west-weather; watches for hulls that do not arrive
Sundered upland	Heskoren	cooler, wilder, harder winters; civilization is a map of surviving Trees
Storm-wall / Kumbaan	the Sundering Isle	mild wet under cloud; bright nights; the wall is the climate

Maiethorn

West of the Rain-Wall, Maiethorn keeps four true seasons. Winters are real. High Solstice means something because the year has been cold. Grafts take in the old sacred country and in the Motherwood. A cutting needs living earth and water. Stilled infirmaries and Returned plague-work cluster in the rich core because that is where the chairs and the endowments are. In the core, the greens that upkeep asks for are commons and garden lots.

On the range, last year’s snow is this year’s civic year. Lirorn levies the thaw. A thaw-week can turn the Shelf-gate into a lake. The Thaw-Break closed the west-road for two summers; people still remember which notch holds the water-line.

East of the Wall the land is wells, goats, and the Well-wash. A Taken-In Tithe is cheap on terrace-green and expensive if the well is dropping. Two-Bodied range the dry hills at night. Returned work sits downwind of the drink. People on the pass tell of a travelling stiller. The dry country has no stillers’ college.

On the Old Crossing face the weather is the berth. Hale-month storms decide a Salt Walk. Far-Voiced are dock infrastructure. Selkie hearths are common on the quays. The Hinge Shore classifies the hull before anyone across the water prices it.

Strandoren

Maritime, indented, the sea as highway. The coasts received the wood first. The Chart-run carried it inland. Food on the Salt Quay is this plain, the Crossing's catch, and whatever the hinge pays. Tithe-provision here is a market: you buy a hall-hour, a lot-night, a novelty page. The Taken-In who live in stone cities are a working minority on lots, orchards, and river-gardens. They work at a polite distance, and the lots are in use.

The Night Shore watches for hulls that do not arrive. West-weather is a local climate. Chart-crews strip what the sea gives. Prestige and necessity use the same water and do not pay the same rate.

A Hale-month storm on the Old Crossing can turn a Salt Walk into a missed year. A Chart-run delay can make a Grey-verso due. These spans are fair weather. A storm rewrites them.

Heskoren

Cooler, wilder, harder winters. Civilization is a map of surviving Trees. Young grafts face wind, thin soil, and a queue written in the Motherwood. A Taken-In Tithe is the land itself, honoured, until a bad winter. Two-Bodied range against gap-cats and against the weather. Returned work the far sheds. Stilled medicine is one tired stiller or a rope.

The live front is Saelvaeth's luck. **Harrow's Green** is the grove the neighbours can see. The **Rise-water** runs from that rise to the hamlets' ford. **Natai** is the march-town west of Harrow's Green, between Sanbreo and that grove, on its own ground. The hamlets' ford is the crossing of Brenod, Vaelun, and Ornath. Harrow's square is that grove-town's own ground. The canopy the hamlets can see is Harrow's. A complaint can name Natai. Vaethorn waits in a vale with no view of that canopy, and the people there wait without looking for it. Ornled has the same thin wood and keeps no congregation. Sanbreo keeps the slate on the slate-shore, Heskoren's west coast. Vaelhesk is old greens. The land is the seat. There is no city on it. Between mile-shrines the next stone is a rumour. Empty road-houses still make a bed. Some of the people still on that road did not go home.

Kumbaan

Mild wet under cloud. Bright nights. The storm-wall is the climate: weather, current, and reef. Kumbaan never took a graft. A slip planted here would die. Dead wood never became a Tree on this isle. Food is terrace, shallows when the wall is kind, and whatever unseen hands fetch. Fuel is peat and what a wreck sometimes gives the hall.

There is no ferry to the isle, and no ticket you can buy. Shore-sitters know a moon when the storm-wall thins. The thinning is weather. Nobody sells it as a sailing date. Most ships wreck, turn back, or do not return. If you live, this is the order: you are on the sand or you are not; a shore-sitter decides that you are alive; you are walked uphill; the first night you are a guest at a hall; at the second sitting, a table-keeper decides that you are kin. That second sitting makes you kin on the isle. A mainland watch will not take that sitting as papers. The town sailors come into is Ndenjoo. Sailors call it the Feeding Hill.

Travel times

The unit is a **day's walk**, the interval a mile-shrine already marks. A horse takes the same road and spares the blisters. A ship takes the water those walks already name.

Walk	What it was	Fair-weather band
Near Mile	Maiethorn inland to Thaeloren	**3–12 days**
Salt Walk	Old Crossing, then the Near Mile	**3–5 days' sail** plus the inland days; typically **1–3 weeks**
Long Mile	West Water, then Heskoren inland	**6–12 weeks** for a coast-to-grove attempt

Kumbaan is listed below with no count of days. No walk crossed the storm-wall.

From	To	How	Fair weather
Thaeloren	Rothallo (people still say the Inner Close)	walk	**1 day**
Thaeloren	Maiethlir	river road along the Core-thaw	**1–2 days**
Thaeloren	the Third Hearth	Near Mile	**3 days**
Third Hearth	Brenthael	Near Mile	**1 day** further out
Brenthael	the Mill-hold	Near Mile	**2 days** further out
Near Mile, a day short of the Third Hearth	Nelath	the spur, and then it stops	**1 day**
Thaeloren	the Low Wall	off the present Mile, outside Rothallo	**1–2 days**
Thaeloren	Hinge Shore quays (Votaer is the port)	Core-thaw and the west-road	**8–12 days**
Thaeloren	Larbril, then Ornsael	west-road over the Shelf-gate	Larbril is the wash, short of the pass. Ornsael is the well, farther into the dry: **10–14 days** to the well
Hinge Shore quay	Orentel	Old Crossing	**3–5 days' sail**
Orentel	Lunbra	Chart-run	**4–8 days**
Orentel	Braetu	coasting, to the Night Shore	**8–14 days**
Braetu	Heskoren frontier coast	West Water	**2–4 weeks**
Heskoren coast	Eolvaeth	inland vale	**1–2 weeks**
Eolvaeth	Harrow's Green	live-front roads	**2–3 weeks**

From	To	How	Fair weather
Harrow’s Green	the Three Hamlets Past the Ford	the Rise-water	**hours to 1 day**
Vaelun	the First Bowl	vale track into the Yield, away from Harrow’s	**1–2 days**
Harrow’s Green	Natai	west, between Harrow’s Green and Sanbreo; not on the ford	**not recorded**
Maiethlir	Seinbrun	off the Down-Bank; north of Maiethlir on the atlas	**more than 1 day** (the first day below the Down Gate does not reach it); the rest is **not recorded**
Thaeloren	Tasain	the west road, below the Shelf-gate; south of Thaeloren on the atlas	**not recorded**
Tasain	Larbril	the west road over the Shelf-gate, to the dry side east of the Rain-Wall	**not recorded**
Maiethlir	the Seeing-Ring	a hill in the old Watching country, north-east of Maiethlir	**not recorded**; the climb up the hill takes a morning
Orentel	Raitin	the road inland; south-west of Orentel on the atlas	**not recorded**
Orentel	Naenor	coasting; south-west of Orentel and south of Raitin on the atlas	**not recorded**
Any mainland quay	Kumbaan	storm-wall	**no fair-weather number**

Where a row says **not recorded**, the place and its direction are known, and the time is not.

A Hale-month storm on the Old Crossing can turn a Salt Walk into a missed year. A thaw-week on the Rain-Wall can turn the Shelf-gate into a lake. These times are fair weather. A storm rewrites them.

The Closed Seat was an origin-gate on the grove. The Retreat shut the walls one day’s walk from the Motherwood, inside Orenbren, in the lodging-country. That city is Rothallo. People still say the Inner Close. Fifteen powers stand. Rothallo is inside Orenbren, one of them. The Hinge Shore is the coast of a different war. Its peace is the Hinge Hush, still charged as the Hush-rate. Rothallo’s wall and the Hinge Shore’s quay keep their own names.

What a house keeps in the field

An ox ploughs, hauls timber, and pulls a cart. The herds are on the core farms, the Chart-run plain, and the broad vales of Heskoren. A breeding animal is worth more to a house than a week’s wages. People are more afraid of losing that ox than of the ox itself. The ox will not take a ford when the water is over the axle. On a ford that is already shallow, the driver still gets down and leads. They will not say why.

A goat gives milk, meat, hide, and dung, and it browses scrub other stock will not take. The herds are on the Rain-Shadow, the rough ground of Heskoren, and the terraces of Kumbaan. The house is afraid of a terrace wall knocked loose, and of a well-share argument when the herd comes in. The goat is not afraid of the wall.

A dog herds, guards a door, and keeps a quay or a hall honest about who is coming in. The dog is afraid of floodwater. It refuses a flooded path. Handlers who know the dog stop with it.

A person in an animal’s body is a person. An ox, a goat, and a dog are animals, and a house keeps them as animals.

Maps

East is Maiethorn, where the wood is oldest. West is Heskoren, where the wood is still thin, and past the storm-wall is Kumbaan. The names of the water and the stone are in *Climate, Ecology, and Travel*. What the lands are is in *The Four Continents*. These sheets show where a named place sits. If a painted roof and a sentence in this book disagree, follow the sentence.

On the drawing, west is left and east is right. From the left the lands run: Kumbaan, an isle with no Trees, then the storm-wall, then Heskoren, where the wood is thin, then the West Water, then Strandoren, where the wood is mature, then the Old Crossing, then Maiethorn, where the wood is oldest. The coastlines are a sketch, not a measured survey. West is left on the sheets that carry names. The relative positions stay.

World map

The picture is the labeled world painting. West is left. The labels are the ones painted on that sheet. Four landmasses. The Old Crossing, the West Water, the Rain-Wall, four rivers, the Noon Pass, and the Shelf-gate. The fifteen powers are regions of ground. No surveyed border is painted. If a painted roof and a sentence here disagree, follow the sentence. An isle with no name in these notes is paint.

Rothallo is the mark inside Orenbren, one day’s walk from the wood. People still say the Inner Close. That name is this city, and the city is the capital. On the regional sheets the painted mark is small. No sheet paints a star on a capital. Maiethlir and Orentel are each marked once.

Capitals, large cities, and important towns are marked where the notes already place them. **Vaelhesk** is the land. It has no settlement dot. Harrow’s Green is a grove-town. Ornsael is a well-town. The First Seat stands in the wood. No sheet marks it. Rothallo is the capital. No date is written on the Tree. There is no graft on Kumbaan. None took on the isle.

On the drawing, three older stones are small marks: the Low Wall, the Seeing-Ring, and the Dry Stair. They are found stone from before the Walking Years. The Seeing-Ring is on a hill north-east of Maiethlir. The painted sheets do not mark it. The Ages chapter tells that stretch.



Natai sits west of Harrow's Green, between Sanbreo and that grove, on ground of its own. The hamlets' ford is a different crossing. **Larbril** is where the west road meets the Well-wash, short of the pass, west of Ornsael's well. **Ornsael** is farther into the dry, at a well. Open country lies between it and Larbril, and the town sits inland.

Continent maps

Maiethorn, east. The labeled continent painting is the picture.



The Mother-core lies west of the Rain-Wall. Thaeloren is the canopy-ring in the old growth, the Tree the later cuttings came from. Rothallo is the walled mark one day out. People still say the Inner Close, and the city is the capital. Maiethlir sits where the Core-thaw slows. Seinbrun stands off that river, north of Maiethlir. The Seeing-Ring's hill is north-east of Maiethlir and is not painted. The Third Hearth is a road-house three days out. Lirorn is the range. The name of the divide is the Rain-Wall. Lirorn calls it the Thaw-Wall. The Noon Pass is the older high notch. The Shelf-gate is the lower road. Tasain is in the valley below that gate, on the wet side, south of Thaeloren. Saelthael is the dry east. Larbril is the meeting of the west road and the Well-wash, east of the range. Ornsael is the well-town farther along that road into the dry. The Hinge Shore is Maiethorn's face on the Old Crossing. Votaer is the port on that shore.

Strandoren, middle. The labeled continent painting is the picture.



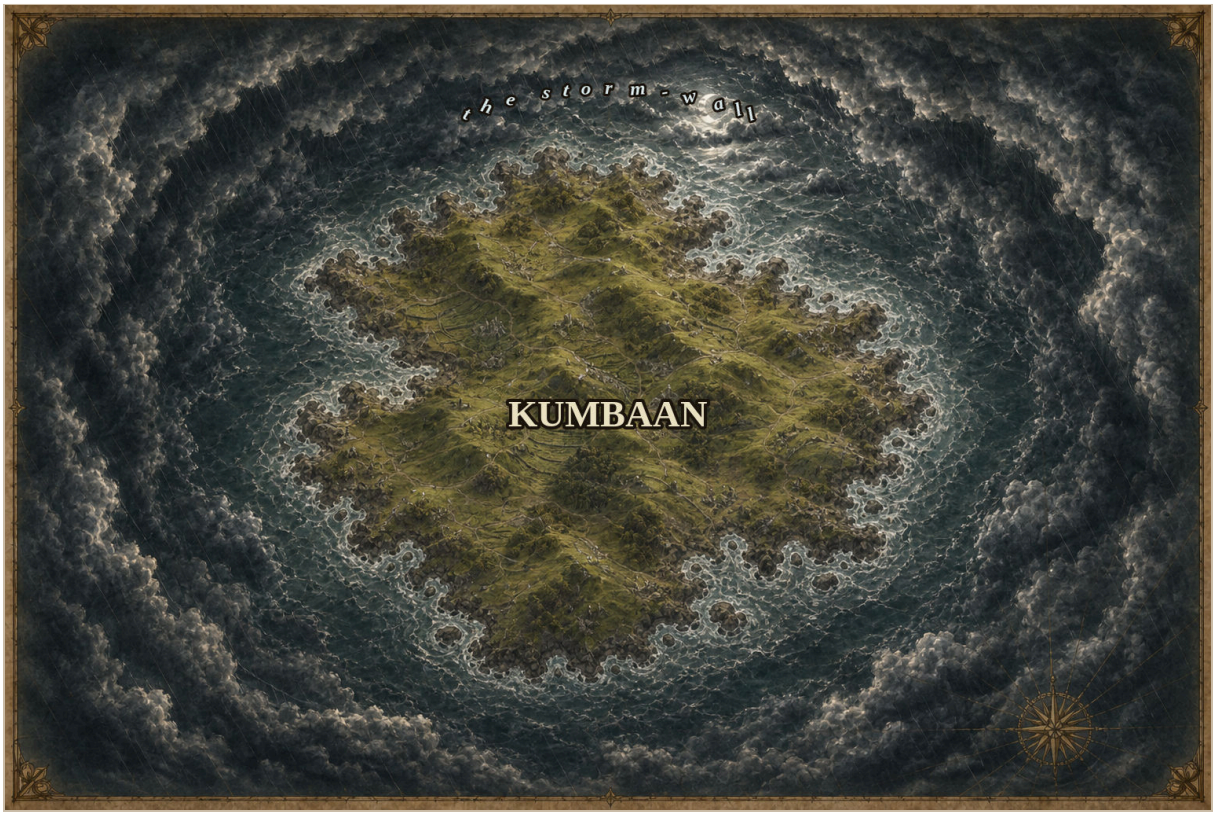
Orentel is a plain dot at the eastern estuary. The Chart-run crosses the interior to that estuary. Lunbra is on the run, upriver of the salt. Raitin stands on the river behind the premier coast, south-west of Orentel. The Chart-run is the river that reaches Orentel's estuary. Trenledd and Netstrand are written as areas of ground. No border is painted around them. Naenor is on the south coast, south-west of Orentel and south of Raitin, on water of its own, apart from the Chart-run and apart from the West Water. Braetu is the harbour on the Night Shore. Six charter-towns sit around Raitin. This sheet does not name them, and it does not mark them.

Heskoren, west of the West Water. The labeled continent painting is the picture.



West is left. The west coast is the slate-shore, in Ornled, facing the last capes and the storm-wall. The sea on the right of the sheet, the Strandoren side, is the West Water, off Heskoren’s east coast. Eolvaeth is the pilgrim-town in the waiting vale. The vale has no view of Harrow’s. Sanbreo is the slate-shore town on the west coast, the mark that names Ornled’s seat. Its beach faces west. Harrow’s Green is a plain grove-town on the live-front rise. Natai is the march west of that grove, between Sanbreo and Harrow’s, on ground of its own. The hamlets sit on different ground past the Rise-water crossing: Brenod, Vaelun, and Ornath. Their ford is that crossing. Harrow’s square is the grove-town’s own ground. Vaelhesk is old greens. It has no settlement dot.

Kumbaan, behind the storm-wall. The labeled continent painting is the picture. There is no settlement dot and no graft.



One isle. The name sits on the hill-country with no point marker. The storm-wall is weather around the isle: cloud, current, and reef. The sheet shows no graft, no city, no harbour, no safe channel, and no Tree. Ndenjoo is a hill-hall. The sheet gives it no flag. Nothing on the isle is a graft.

The overlays

Each painted region keeps the names the ground already had.

The world sheet is the painting at the start of this chapter. It runs the same west-to-east line: Kumbaan, the storm-wall, Heskoren, the West Water, Strandoren, the Old Crossing, Maiethorn, the Rain-Wall. The sea-names sit in the water. Vaelhesk has no dot on this sheet either. Maiethlir and Orentel are marked once here.

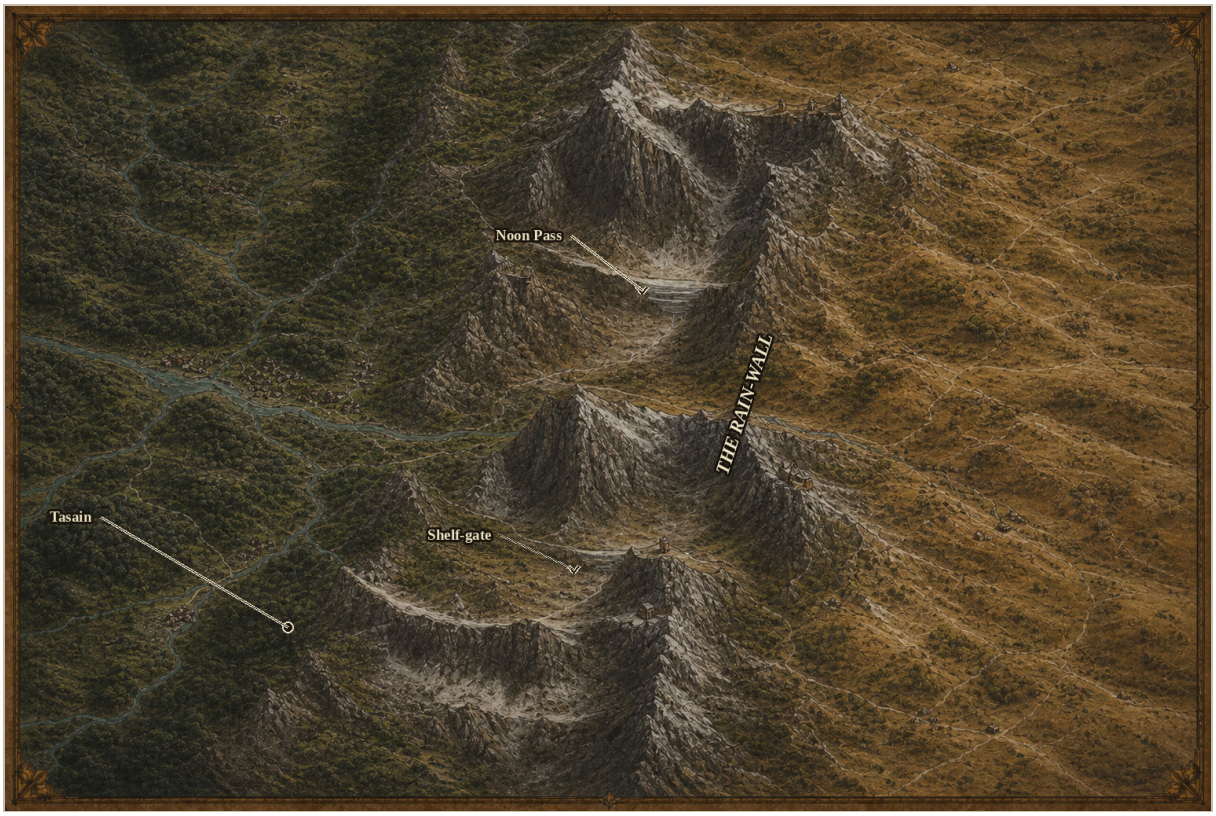
The Old Crossing. Orentel is on the Strandoren estuary. The Hinge Shore is named as a stretch of the Maiethorn coast, and Votaer is the port on that coast. The Hush-rate is the charge for the crossing.



The Sacred Core. Thaeloren’s canopy-ring. The First Seat, in the wood, has no separate mark. Rothallo is the walled square one day out. Seinbrun is off the Core-thaw, north of Maiethlir. The Third Hearth is three days out. Maiethlir is the counted city on the Core-thaw road.



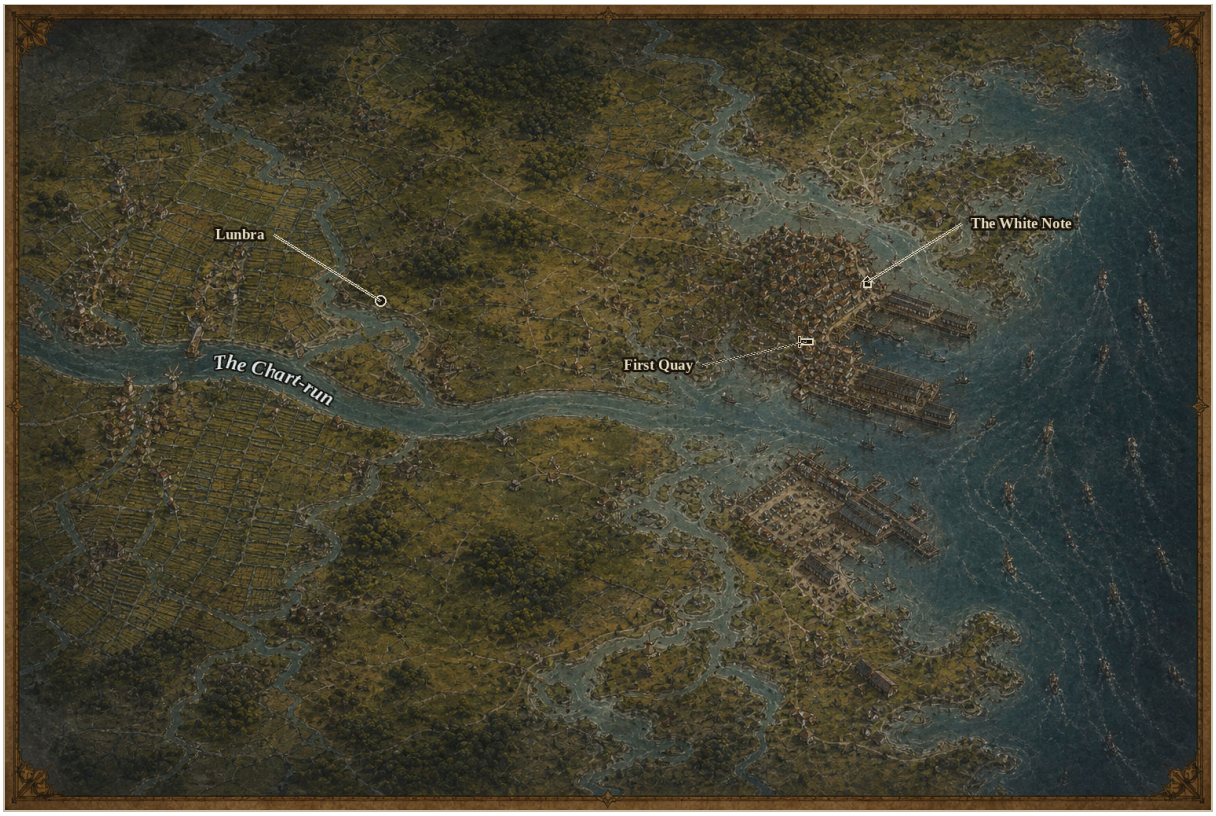
The Rain-Wall. The range is the Rain-Wall. The Noon Pass and the Shelf-gate are notches in the range. Tasain is the town in the valley below the Shelf-gate. Tengu and Fox-of-the-Snows hearths sit on the snow, inside Lirorn.



The Rain-Shadow. The dry east, painted as weather. Larbril is on the west road, short of the pass. Ornsael is on the well, farther into the dry. The Well-wash is seasonal water. The Dry Stair is a site on a different rise. The well-town at its shoulder has no name in these notes.



The Chart-run. The river to Orentel’s estuary. The first quay is the old landing. The White Note is one desk-house on the third quay, north side. It keeps the notes. Lunbra is upriver of the salt. Other towns in the filed country have no names on this sheet.



The West Water. The open ocean, in the blue. The Night Shore is the west-and-south face, named as a shore. Braetu is the harbour. This sheet does not mark the unlit berth.



The live front. Harrow’s is a grove-town on the rise. The march’s seat is Natai, west of this grove. The Rise-water runs to the ford. Brenod, Vaelun, and Ornath are three small hearths past the crossing.



The waiting vale. Eolvaeth is a pilgrim-town at the gift-hall. The spring is a pool. This sheet does not draw Harrow’s canopy.



Square and seat maps

Closer sheets exist for the seats and the town squares that already have streets. They are the same places as the notes. A closer sheet of a city is that city. Rothallo’s gate is the same square gatehouse as the city: beds outside, the Book inside. Larbril’s Well-wash is a silt-line. The road there is the west road. Vaelhesk has no sheet.

Place	What to find
Rothallo	walled capital inside Orenbren; people still say the Inner Close; one day from the wood; no star
Seinbrun	Maiethvael’s capital, off the Core-thaw, north of Maiethlir and more than a day from it
Maiethlir	on the Core-thaw, a day’s carry of living wood out from the Motherwood. The grove is other ground. The First Seat has no mark
the Third Hearth / Brenthael	Near Mile, three days out from Thaeloren, then one day further
the Mill-hold	two days past Brenthael; the culvert and the Hand, its Turning Tree
Nelath	the spur off the Near Mile; the road stops
Larbril	west road meets the Well-wash, short of the pass, on the dry side east of the Rain-Wall
Ornsael	well-town farther into the dry, inland, with open country between it and Larbril
Votaer	Hinge Shore port, facing Orentel
Tasain	walled town below the Shelf-gate, south of Thaeloren on the west road
Orentel	Chart-run estuary; the White Note is a desk on the third quay
Raitin	Brenledd’s throne-city, on the river behind the premier coast, south-west of Orentel
Naenor	Leddvael’s port, on its own south-coast water, south-west of Orentel and south of Raitin
Lunbra	Trenledd, on the Chart-run
Braetu	Night Shore harbour; one berth stays unlit on the quay sheet
Sanbreo	Ornled’s slate-town on Heskoren’s west coast, the slate-shore; on the brink of a small city; the beach faces the last capes
Natai	Saelvaeth’s march-town, west of Harrow’s Green, between Sanbreo and that grove

Place	What to find
Harrow's Green	grove-town on the live front; the Rise-water runs to the ford. The march's seat is Natai
the Three Hamlets	the ford; canopy visible from the water in clear weather
the First Bowl	guest-grove in the Yield, away from Harrow's. Vaelhesk itself has no dot
Eolvaeth	Vaethorn vale, with no view of Harrow's
Ndenjoo	hill-hall on Kumbaan; no Tree and no graft

Three old walks are still roads:

- **Near Mile** — inland stones toward Thaeloren. Some now end at a Turning Tree. Nelath's spur is one road that stops.
- **Salt Walk** — the Old Crossing, then the Near Mile. The Hush-rate is charged on the hinge. Votaer sorts the hull. Orentel prices the berth.
- **Long Mile** — the West Water, then Heskoren mud. Empty road-houses still make the bed. Braetu quotes the far run.

The travel times are in *Climate, Ecology, and Travel*. A day's walk is the interval a mile-shrine marks.

Closer paintings of the seats and town squares that have them. West is left on each. Vaelhesk has no sheet. The Third Hearth, the three hamlets, and the First Bowl are painted on the regional sheets above.

Rothallo, the walled capital. People still say the Inner Close.



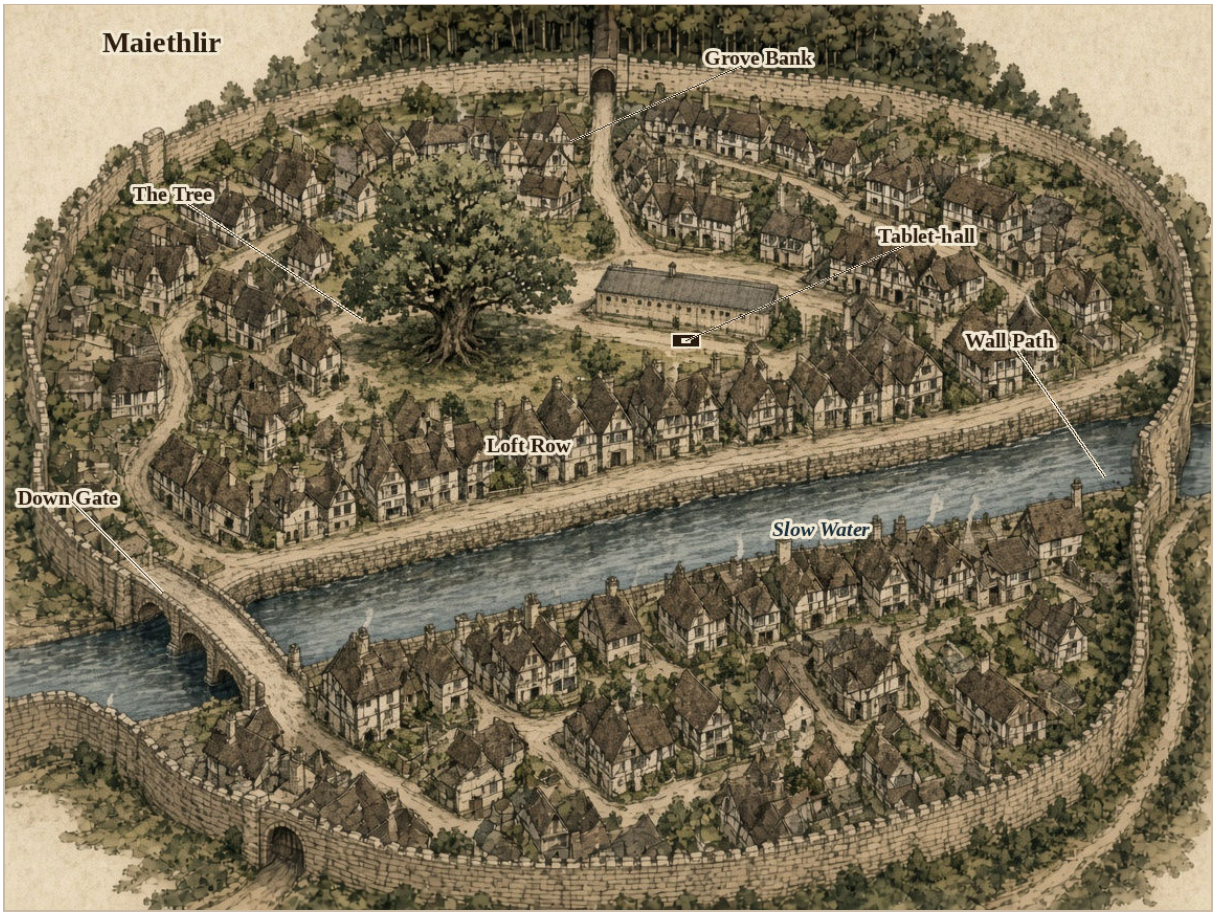
The gate is the same square gatehouse. Beds are outside. The Book is inside.



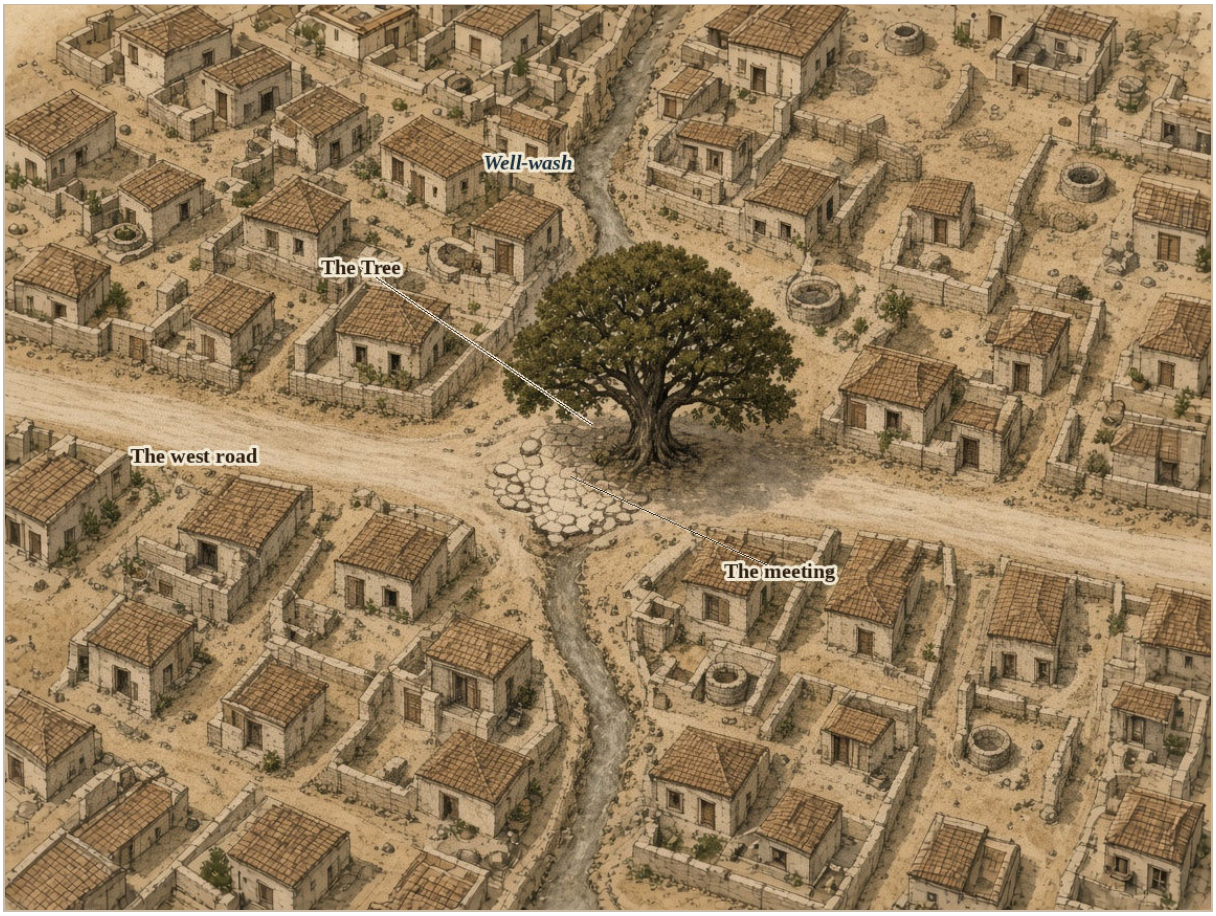
Seinbrun, Maiethvael’s capital.



Maiethlir, on the Core-thaw. The First Seat has no mark on this sheet.



Larbril, where the west road meets the Well-wash.



Ornsael, the well-town farther into the dry.



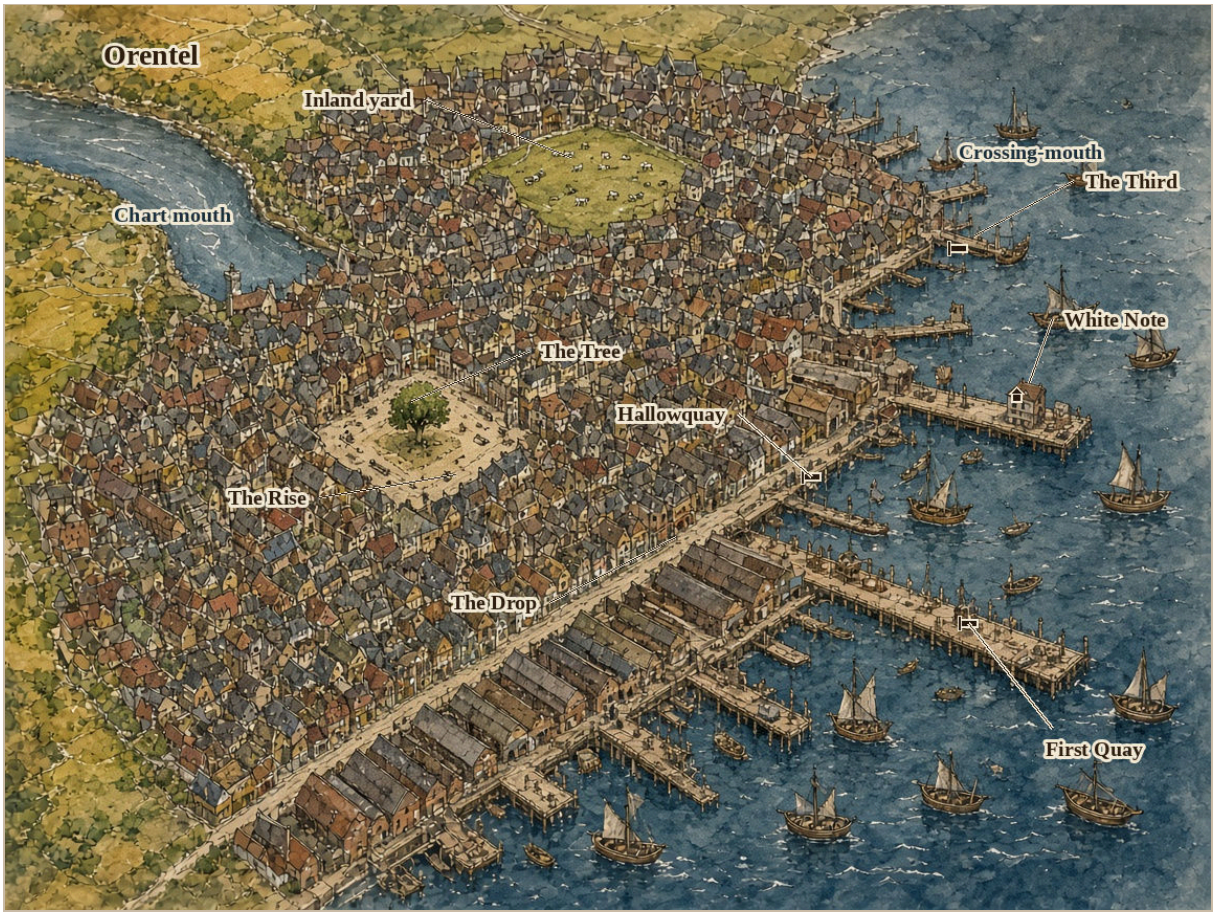
Votaer, the Hinge Shore port.



Tasain, below the Shelf-gate.

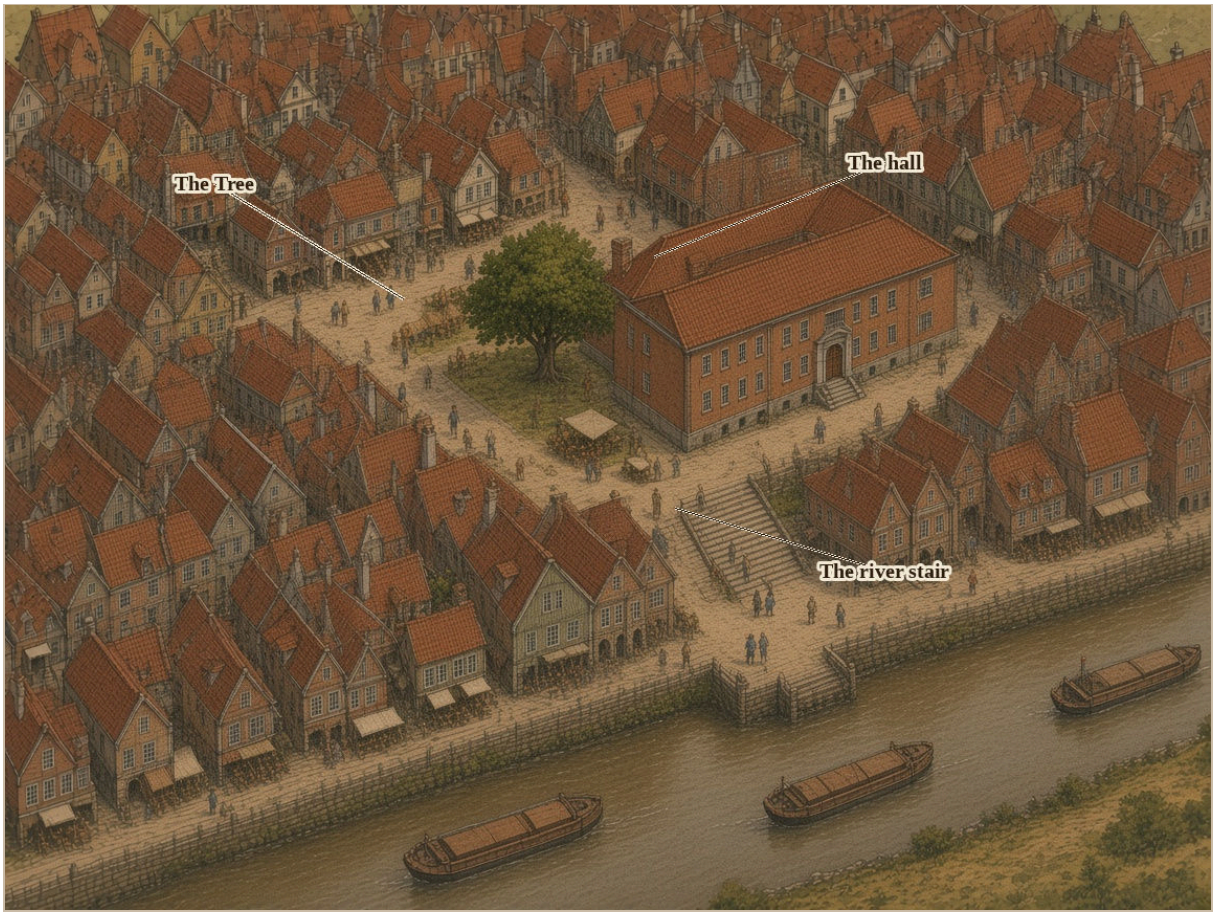


Orentel, at the Chart-run estuary. The White Note is a desk on the third quay.

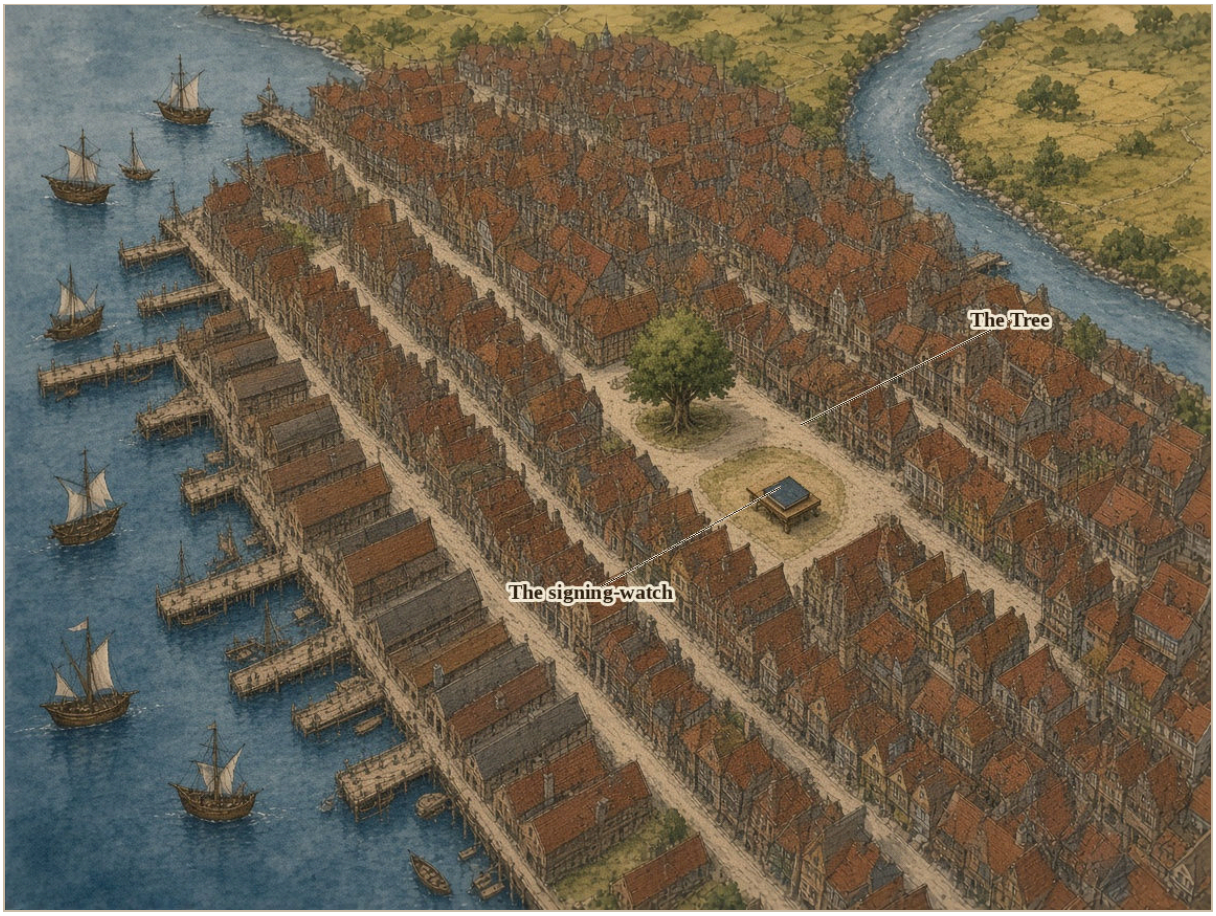

Orentel
Inland yard
Chart mouth
Crossing-mouth
The Third
White Note
The Tree
Hallowquay
The Rise
The Drop
First Quay



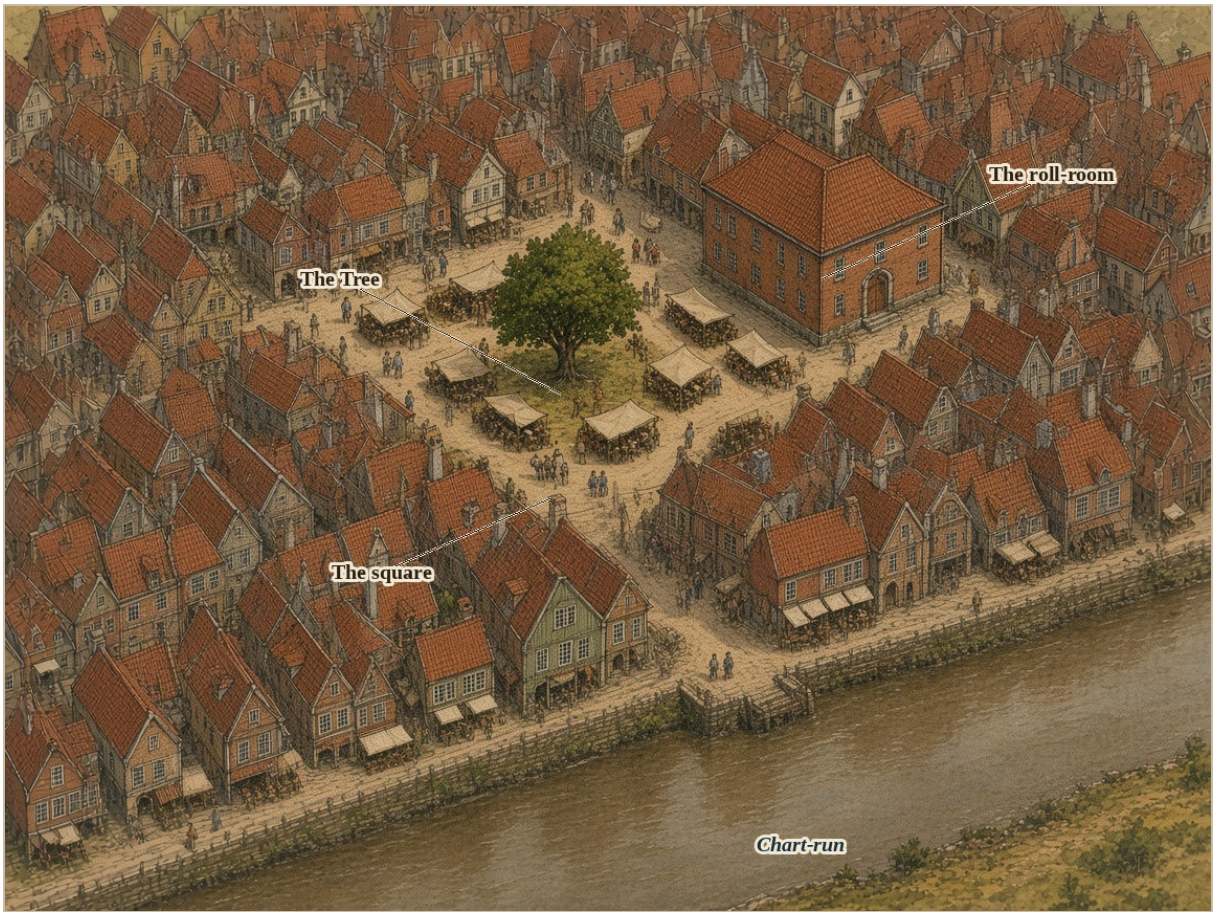
Raitin, Brenledd’s throne-city.



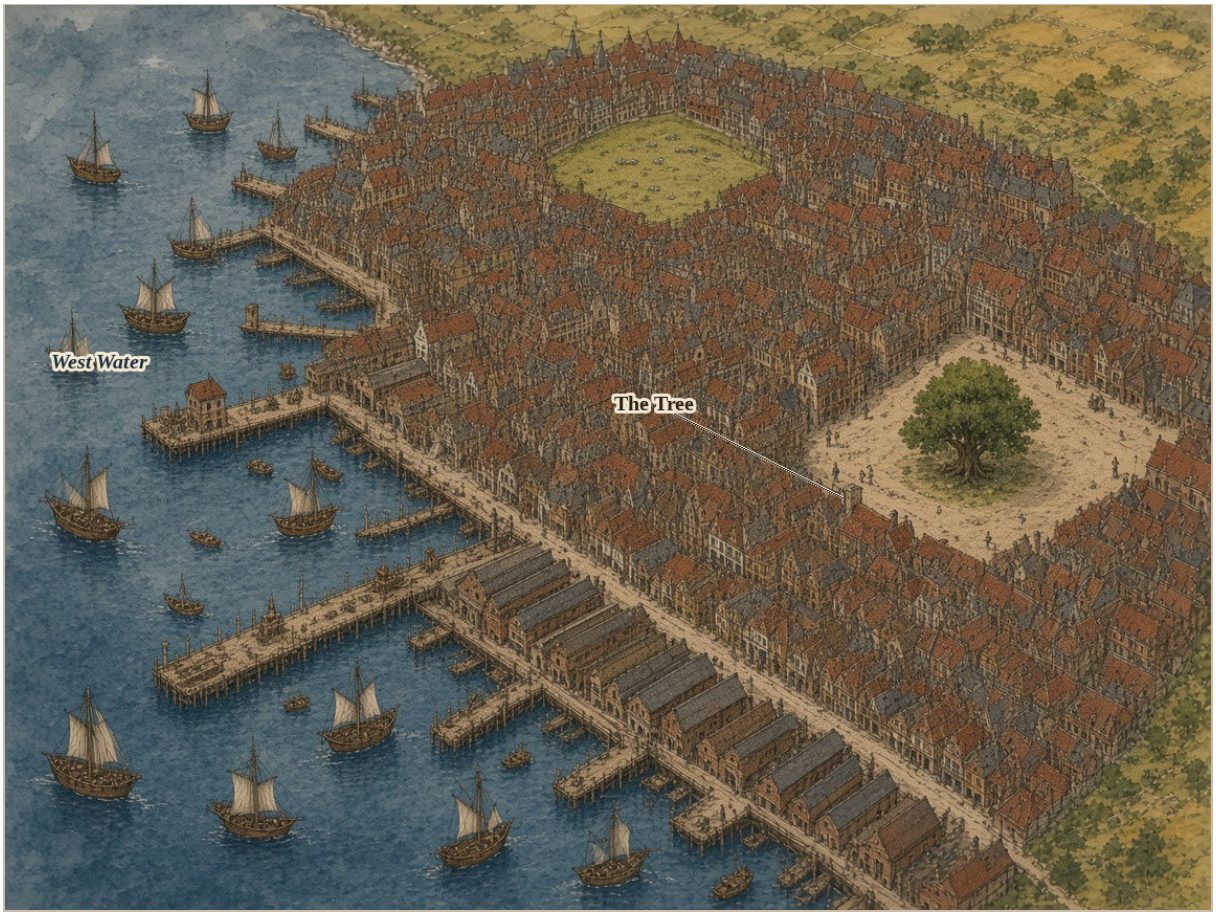
Naenor, Leddvael’s port.

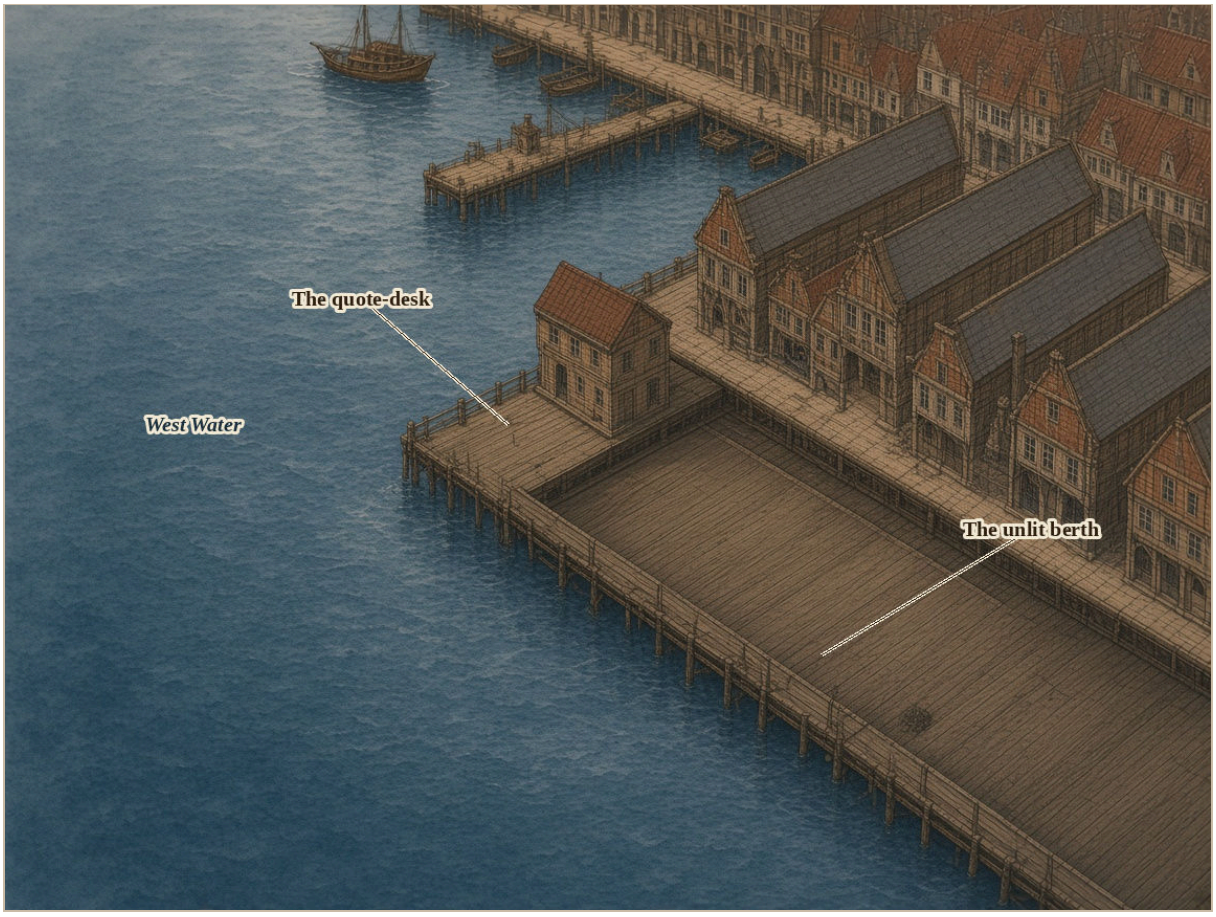


Lunbra, on the Chart-run.



Braetu, the Night Shore harbour. One berth stays unlit on the quay sheet.


West Water
The Tree



Sanbreo, Ornled's town on the slate-shore. The sea is on the left, to the west, as on the Heskoren sheet. The shore gate meets the beach, and the slate is on the wall inside the gate.



Natai, the march west of Harrow’s Green.



Harrow’s Green, the grove-town on the live front. Natai is the march’s seat.



Eolvaeth, in the waiting vale.



The Mill-hold, the sick-Tree town.



Nelath, the road-end.



Ndenjoo, on Kumbaan. No Tree.


The hall

Book VI

The Ages

The Ages

People keep two counts of the past. One is how you Turned: the walk to the origin, or standing under a town Tree. The other is where the wood has reached: the Grafting, still unfinished on Heskoren, never on Kumbaan. Which one a person glances at tells you where they stand.

How you Turned is personal and generational. Did you walk to Thaeloren, or to a neighbour who had already walked, or did you stand under a town **graft**? That is a cutting of living wood joined to new ground, and it grows as the same plant. A family says, “We are a Hands-house. Grandmother still talks of the road.” **Hands** are the planted town Trees. That is also the era when those Trees are the ordinary way to Turn. A Long-Lived who says “I walked” is saying when they were young.

Where the wood has reached is geographic, and unfinished. The **Grafting** is a wave of living wood that started at the origin, filled Maiethorn, crossed to Strandoren by sea, and is still arriving on Heskoren. Kumbaan is off the wave entirely. Present-day thin reach is the front of a process that has not finished.

Both clocks sit on an unnamed preface. That is **Before the Walk**. The Tree was already there. No honest count starts it.

The Walking Years were a logistics problem that killed children on the road. The Grafting was horticulture that people later sanctified. The Seat now narrates both as her will travelling. Folk memory is less tidy. The romance of the old mile and the graves along it belong to the same stretch of road.

The ages at a glance

	Everyday	Liturgical	Says	What it is
Preface	**Before the Walk**	*(mostly unnamed)* · the Watching keep **the Before**	*(none)*	The Tree already stood. Kinds, doors, and seeing without a mother's name. No count of it has a start.
How you Turned, old default	**the Walking Years**	**Brenvaeth** *(BREN-vayth)*	"the hearth gone to waiting"	You walked to Thaeloren or you stayed UnTurned for want of the trip. Far lands ran heavy on the UnTurned and the Struck.
The hinge	**the First Cut**	**Eoloren** *(EOL-or-en)*	"the witnessed hinge"	Someone cut living wood and it *took*. Who is argued. The taking is the part every telling grants.
Where the wood has reached	**the Grafting**	*(still moving through the present)*	*(none)*	The carrying of hands. Still unfinished at the Sundered Reach. Never crossed the storm-wall.
How you Turned, new default	**the Years of Hands**	**Ornthael** *(ORN-thale)*	"Tree-land"	A town Tree is the ordinary way to Turn. Pilgrimage remains as devotion, prestige, or necessity where a graft has failed.

The liturgical pair inverts the Road-hands' own name. **Thaelvaeth** is the Tree gone to the waiting. That is wood carried *out*. **Brenvaeth** is the hearth gone to the waiting. That is people walking *in*. The Grafting is the moment the world stopped sending hearths to the Tree and started sending the Tree to hearths.

A history in order

This section tells the history in order, from before anyone counted years to the present year. It gives years the way the First Seat and devout clerks count them, from the First Cut. That was the first time a piece cut from the Awakening Tree was planted in another town and grew. That year is Cut-year 0. The present year is Cut-year 387. Many people count another way; "How years are numbered" below says who they are. The later sections of this chapter tell each part at length. This section gives the order of events and what each one left behind.

Before anyone counted years

The Awakening Tree already stood on Maiethorn, in the country now called the Sacred Core. It was the only Turning Tree in the world. Nobody planted it in any summer that anyone remembers.

People were already born into their Kinds. Some were already Struck into a Condition at a threshold, such as a drowning or an oath, far from the Tree, with nobody to witness it. Under the Tree, children in their tenth year were already Given a colour or hugged at the solstice. Nobody knows how long that had been going on.

The Watching call this time the Before. They teach that the Tree was already watching people before anyone called it a mother. The Old Ways on Heskoren say their people were already being Struck at the places they call doors, such as a drowning, a grove, or a stone, before any road to the Tree existed. Kumbaan is not part of this history. Its people have their own past and do not count it by the Tree.

Nobody wrote down a king, a war, or a founding from this time. Three stone places from it survive; they are described below. More is in “Before the Walk.”

The years of the walk

The time before the First Cut is called the Walking Years. It started when families began to organize the trip to the Tree, and nobody wrote down that year.

There was one Tree to Turn under, and one week. A child who had turned ten since the last High Solstice had to stand under the Awakening Tree during Turning-Week, the week around the High Solstice in Eolthael. A child who arrived after that week was not Given a Condition, that year or any later year. They could still be Struck later in life. Far families left months early. The richest families, and the most frightened, sent a nine-year-old to winter in a road-house near the Tree so the child could not miss the week.

People in Maiethorn walked the Near Mile, three to twelve days. People in Strandoren took the Salt Walk: three to five days on a ship across the Old Crossing, then the Near Mile, usually one to three weeks in all. People in Heskoren, and in the far inland parts of Strandoren, walked the Long Mile, six to twelve weeks. A family on the Long Mile gave up a year’s spare food, or signed a debt at a road-house, or did not go.

Many families could not send every child. A family with three children near ten might send one. That child might come home with a Condition, while the brothers and sisters who stayed home grew up UnTurned, or were Struck later. So the far lands were full of UnTurned people, whom folk called Kept, and of people Struck later in life.

Inns along the roads gave travellers a bed and let them eat on credit, paid back on the way home or years later. Many innkeepers were Long-Lived and forgot no debt. After the walk stopped being

necessary, some of those inns kept their records and became banks. The White Note House in Orentel is one. The Third Hearth is an inn that stayed an inn.

Children died on the road, and so did the adults who carried them: at river crossings in the thaw, of fever in crowded inns, in late storms on the Old Crossing, of hunger on the Long Mile. Travellers buried them where the group stopped and set a stone there. Those stones are the mile-shrines that still stand along the old roads, often with a ribbon tied on.

Reaching the Tree was not enough. A group of families with no Condition lived around the Awakening Tree and decided who was allowed to stand under it. People now call them the Closed Seat, and in ordinary talk the Grove-Sitters. A family needed a paper called grove-leave to pass their gate. Some children walked the whole Long Mile and went home UnTurned because the gate refused them. The Closed Seat ruled the country around the Tree. It never ruled the world. Strandoren's families paid for the crossing, but the Closed Seat never ruled Strandoren. Heskoren was too far away to rule. Kumbaan never came.

Some Long-Lived alive today walked one of these roads as children. They remember every day of it. They do not agree about what it meant. The road, the inns, the graves, and the gate are told at length in "The Walking Years."

The First Cut (Cut-year 0)

In Cut-year 0, someone cut a piece of living wood from the Awakening Tree, carried it in earth to a town about a day's walk away, and planted it, and it grew. People had always grafted fruit trees. This was the first time a cutting from the Awakening Tree took root somewhere else. Nobody knows who made the cut. The town is not named either; people call that first graft the nameless green. A town Tree grows from wood cut from the Awakening Tree, so people count it as the same Tree. The devout call each town Tree a Hand of the Mother. The five stories of who cut are in "The First Cut."

The years of argument (Cut-years 0 to 19)

A new graft cannot hold a Leaf-Fall until it has grown for about a generation. For nineteen years nobody knew whether the nameless green would ever Turn a child. Other towns on the Near Mile cut their own pieces, and most of the cuttings died. The college of tree-wardens at the Awakening Tree, the First Seat, called cutting theft and forbade it. People cut anyway.

In Cut-year 19 the nameless green held its first Turning-Week, and a child of that town was Turned under it. The stories disagree about whether the child received a colour or a hug. The First Seat stopped trying to forbid cutting and took charge of it instead. From then on a cutting needed the Seat's permission, called Cutting-leave. That permission, and the waiting list of towns that want a graft, called the scion-queue, still exist. Rithnali, a Speaker of the First Seat, wrote the record of that

summer’s meeting; it says the Seat will write down how a cutting is done and will not write down who did the first one.

The Closing (Cut-years 19 to 38)

The Closed Seat’s power depended on being the only gate to the only Tree. A town that could Turn its own children did not need grove-leave. From Cut-year 19 the Closed Seat sent riders out with sacks to dig up the new grafts and bring them back, or burn them in their pots.

They failed. Some grafts died. Towns hid cuttings in wells and watered them at night. The lodging-towns around the grove, which made their living housing travellers, would not stop housing them to help the Closed Seat. The First Seat wanted to control who cut, not to destroy trees, and would not help burn a graft that had already Turned a child. The Closed Seat could not guard every town within a day’s walk in every direction. People call this war the Closing. Folk also call it the Uprooting.

In Cut-year 38, Hildal ordered the Retreat. Hildal was the last person to speak for the Closed Seat whose name people still use. Hildal was a clerk, not the Closed Seat’s leader. The Closed families gave up the grove, moved a day’s walk away into a walled city, and took their Book with them. The Book is their record of who owes what. That walled city is Rothallo, which people still call the Inner Close.

The Closed Seat’s power split four ways, and nobody has put it back together:

- Nobody controls who may stand under the Awakening Tree anymore. A family needs nobody’s leave to bring a child there in Turning-Week.
- The First Seat controls who may cut a graft, through Cutting-leave.
- The lodging-towns joined together and became Orenbren, which houses travellers near the Tree.
- The Closed families kept the Book, and the Book only governs people who live inside Rothallo’s walls.

Rothallo is Orenbren’s capital, and it lies inside Orenbren. The Closed families did not found a new country. The lodging-towns run the inns outside Rothallo’s wall, and the Book runs the city inside it.

The Closed Heirs after the Retreat (Cut-years 38 to 387)

The Closed families are now called the Closed Heirs. After the Retreat they kept the same habits inside Rothallo that the Closed Seat had kept at the grove, and they have kept them for three hundred and forty-nine years. The group that keeps the Book is called the Walled Book. This is what a visitor to Rothallo can see today.

- **Where a person sits.** At a meal in a Closed house, Kept guests sit nearest the host. A guest with a Condition is shown to the far end of the table. When the Book is read aloud, the Kept sit on the front benches and everyone else sits behind them.

- **Whose word a clerk writes down.** When a Kept person and a person with a Condition disagree in front of a clerk of the Book, the clerk writes the Kept person's account as what happened, and the other account underneath as "also said." The person with a Condition can still win, but only if a second Kept person says the same thing.
- **Who holds a key.** Only a Kept person may hold a key to a gate in the wall, to the Book's house, to a cistern, or to a granary. A person with a Condition holds the key to their own door and their own stall.
- **What the school teaches.** At the school beside the Book's house, the teacher Volnai tells the children that a hug is rare, and that a child the Tree hugged was kept back for something better than a colour.
- **Who inherits.** A Closed Heir who receives a colour at the Leaf-Fall is struck off the heir-roll. A Closed Heir who is hugged stays on it.
- **Who works.** Everyone who lives inside the walls owes the city turns of work, the way a town expects each household to take a turn on the watch. Kept households mostly keep the watch on the wall and hold the keys. Households with a Condition get the heavier turns, and more of them.

A person with a Condition in Rothallo is not a slave. They work for wages, keep what they earn, marry whom they choose, and can own a stall with a licence from the Book. They can walk out of the gate on any day it is open and live somewhere else. The Book's list of turns has no claim on anyone who lives outside the walls, and the Book cannot send for a person who has left.

The school's lesson is wrong about the count. Being hugged is common; the shares are given in "Kind and Condition." What is rare is a family like the Closed houses, which has stayed without a Condition on purpose for generations. They do it by striking every Given heir off the roll and keeping their heirs away from the oaths that can Strike a person. The clerks of the Book can read the real count. The school teaches the same lesson every year anyway.

The gate at the grove has been gone since Cut-year 38. The belief that a hugged person ranks above a person with a colour is still alive, and in a few places it reaches past Rothallo's walls. Some inns just outside Rothallo's gate keep their best table for Kept guests on nights when a Closed house dines there, and move a guest with a Condition if the Closed house asks. Brenthael, a town with its own Tree on the Near Mile, has no copy of the Book. At its Turning-Week supper, Kept people still sit on the benches nearest the Tree and people with a Condition sit on the outer benches, and a child who has just received a colour gets up and moves outward before the food is served. Nobody in Brenthael can say when this started. Other places reject it in public. The gift-hall at Eolvaeth in Vaethorn teaches that a colour and a hug are equal, and says aloud that the Close is wrong. Given heirs who were struck off the roll eat there; Hithaen is one of them.

In Cut-year 387, a Closed child named Talnin is on the heir-roll and has not yet had a Leaf-Fall. If a colour falls for Talnin, Talnin will be struck off.

How the grafts spread

From Cut-year 0 the grafts spread outward from the Awakening Tree, town by town, as each new Tree grew old enough to Turn children and to give cuttings of its own. A town that gets a graft still waits about twenty years before its Tree holds its first Leaf-Fall. Until then its children walk to a neighbouring town's Tree. The time since town Trees became the ordinary way to Turn is called the Years of Hands.

- **Maiethorn, Cut-years 0 to about 80.** Towns nearest the Awakening Tree got grafts first. By about Cut-year 80 most of the core had its own Trees. The dry east beyond the Rain-Wall mountains, called the Rain-Shadow, was slower, because grafts die in thin, dry soil. Some families there still walk west to the Awakening Tree.
- **Strandoren, about Cut-years 40 to 160, by sea.** Ships carried grafts in pots of living earth, on deck, watered at dawn. The rich port cities got grafts first, while some Maiethorn villages were still waiting. Inland towns got them later, by river and cart.
- **The wait, about Cut-years 160 to 200.** For about forty years no graft reached Heskoren. Cuttings died on the long road, the line of mature Trees that could give cuttings took time to grow, and the First Seat's list served towns that could pay first. Heskoren did not wait because its people were unworthy, whatever some Vaethorn preachers say.
- **Heskoren, Cut-year 200 to the present.** Grafts began arriving by sea from Strandoren. The luckiest towns, such as Harrow's Green, got a graft in the 200s and have Turned their own children for a few generations. Many districts still have no Tree, and their ten-year-olds walk to a neighbouring town or walk the Long Mile. The Three Hamlets Past the Ford can see Harrow's Tree from their fields and are still on the list. Heskoren is still receiving grafts.
- **Kumbaan, never.** No graft has crossed the storm-wall. Kumbaan has no Tree, and its people count moons.

A town Tree can also sicken and stop holding a Leaf-Fall. Then the town's children go back to walking to a neighbour, even in Maiethorn. The Mill-hold is such a town. The spread is told at length in "How the wave moved," and the present in "The Years of Hands."

Other dated years

These events happened while the grafts were spreading. They sit beside the history of the Trees. They are not another age of the world. "The Other Count" below gives them as a table.

- **Cut-year 67, the Two Papers.** The old hymn-country of the Sacred Core split in two over whether to write people down. Limrae opened a desk in a river-town and began recording every person, saying that a person you cannot find again is a person you cannot look after. Manril refused to be put on the list, and said a person belongs because people saw them Turn. There was no battle.

Households chose which desk to deal with. The side that kept the list became Threnmaieth, and the side that refused became Maiethvael. Threnmaieth counts years from that summer, so Cut-year 387 is Crown-year 320 there.

- **Cut-year 171, the Grey Summer.** A fever started in the crowded holds of ships and spread through the ports on both sides of the Old Crossing. It was an ordinary disease, not a Tithe. Ships stayed in port all summer. Some grafts went unwatered because the Taken-In who tended them were dead, and a few coastal towns sent their children to a neighbour's Tree the next year. Long-Lived bankers did not die; their borrowers did, and the debts passed to the families. Afterward Trenledd began keeping a list of persons, and Dirrol added a column for who was still alive. In Cut-year 174 the small towns of Brenledd put their charters together into one league. Leddvael made the signing of a contract a public ceremony, because so many witnesses had died. For about ten years fewer ships sailed toward Heskoren.
- **Cut-year 233, the Thaw-Break.** The snow on the Rain-Wall in Lirorn melted in one week instead of over a month. Valleys flooded and people died. The old high road over the Noon Pass was washed out, and Narol of the Pass took the toll on the new, lower road, the Shelf-gate; Narol's household still collects it. The west road in Saelthael was cut for two summers, so some children went late to the Awakening Tree, went to a neighbour, or missed their week. A graft on its way to Ornled died because the cart was late to the quay. Vathne wrote on a wall that Ornled would not wait with a hymn for a stick that drowned in someone else's thaw, meaning Ornled would stop praying and waiting for grafts that other countries' troubles could take away. Ornled still copies that sentence.
- **Cut-year 248, the Wrong Green.** At Harrow's Green a warden announced copper-green for a child the Tree had hugged, because the town wanted a Taken-In. A visiting Speaker corrected it two years later. It was a person's doing, not the Tree's. Speakers still name that year when they teach wardens not to announce the colour a town wishes it had.
- **Cut-year 280, Ledan's question.** Ledan, a Long-Lived clerk of the White Note House, wrote to the First Seat to ask which year number to put on a hundred-year loan, because the bank, the borrower's town, and the Seat each counted the year differently. Cut-year 280 was the bank's 200th year. The bank still converts its years the way Ledan's letter did; Cut-year 387 is the White Note's 307th year. The letter is under "A clerk's query" below.
- **Cut-years 299 to 304, the Hinge War and the Hinge Hush.** The Hinge Shore and the Ledger Coast fought for five summers over who set the price of crossing the Old Crossing, seizing each other's ships and blocking each other's quays. Taerso spoke for the Hinge Shore's houses, and Sirtol for a group of Ledger Coast charters. In Cut-year 304 they agreed a peace that names no winner. There is one charge for the crossing, the Hush-rate, still collected. The Hinge Shore gives a blessing to anyone who wants one, and the Ledger Coast writes the paperwork. The agreement also covers the far crossing to Heskoren: Netstrand keeps the ships that sail it, Saelvaeth may receive a

graft without paying a blessing-fee to Vaethorn, Vaethorn may bless a landing but may not tax it, and Ornled charges a fee for a beach landing. People call the peace the Hinge Hush.

Three old places you can still walk into

Three stone places come from before anyone counted years. Nobody knows when they were built or by whom, and the people who look after them will not let anyone cut a year into them. A party can visit all three.

- **The Low Wall.** A low stone wall in Orenbren's lodging-country, off the Near Mile, within the first few days' walk from the Awakening Tree. It is not part of Rothallo's wall, and the stone is a different colour. It has three gaps that people use as gates: one widened for carts, one only wide enough for a single person, and one with an old post-socket. Midway along is a stone panel whose letters were chiselled off long ago. The wall ends in the back garden of an inn, where Thuda rents beds in the loft. The Closed Heirs say the wall is theirs. The Watching say it is older than any count. In Cut-year 381, Nurreith and three lodging-guild workers dug under the panel. Delamem, who keeps the Book of Tithes, wanted a chip of stone that matched Rothallo's quarry. It did not match. They filled the hole the same week.
- **The Seeing-Ring.** A ring of standing stones on a hill in Maiethorn's old Watching country. It is not the Awakening Tree's grove. The stones are set so that a person walking around the ring turns to look outward. Four wider gaps face outward: one toward the Awakening Tree, one toward the Old Crossing, and two toward nothing anyone can name. Later someone built a shrine on top of the ring, and later still someone took the roof off and left the steps. Tithsael, of the Watching, keeps a night there every week and lets visitors sit with them, unless the visitor has brought a colour-ribbon to tie on the stones or means to carve a year into them.
- **The Dry Stair.** A flight of steps cut into a rise in Saelthael's dry country, above a small well-town that is not Ornsael. The steps climb to a door-shaped stone with no wall around it and a basin cut in the rock that has never held water in living memory. A tree-warden once planted a cutting in the basin, and it died. Local children dare each other to climb the last step. Behind the basin a narrow crawl leads to a second dry basin lower in the rock.

The memory cup

The memory cup is a late practice among the Long-Lived. It began in the Years of Hands, long after the First Cut. The circles that keep it do not write down the year it started. It is old enough that Long-Lived scholars who are not members have written commentaries on it, kept in the long-houses where the Long-Lived meet, and the Motherfaith, the Watching, and the Fair Hand have each said what they think it is. It is recent enough that a Long-Lived who walked to the Awakening Tree as a child, before their town had a Tree of its own, can say that nobody did this when they were young.

The group that keeps the cup is the Pourers, also called the Cup Circle. Every Long-Lived person is asked to join once, in person, by a member. A person who says no is not punished. They keep their standing, and the long-houses still give them a seat. Most Long-Lived people are not members. All of them know the circle exists.

A member gives one year of their memory into a cup at a time, of their own free will. Each year is its own night, with its own minutes, and the member may stop before the next. The circle asks five years of a member in all. For each year the member adds one drop of their own blood, because the Long-Lived read memory from blood. Afterward the member no longer has the memories of that year, including the deaths of the people they knew in it. They still need to keep learning, as every Long-Lived does.

Members say they give “the memories those years held, and the years themselves.” The second part means two things. For each year given, the member also gives the long-house shelf all the papers they wrote or kept in that year, such as letters, account books, and diaries. And the long-houses that keep the circle stop counting that year in the member’s age, so a member who has given all five years is seated as if five years younger. Among the Long-Lived, age decides who speaks first and who keeps a key, so each gift costs a member rank in those long-houses. Courts, banks, guilds, and Long-Lived who are not members keep counting the ordinary way.

Members can read the cup the way a Long-Lived reads a drop of blood. What they read is true. One reading can hold several members’ memories of the same year. Members also keep books in the Long-Lived library in Lestrand, on the Ledger Coast, and copy books in the Old Tongue and in the common speech for it. People use those books. Molevad keeps the minutes of the best-known circle in the same library. A second circle meets in an upper room of a lodging-house in Orenbren and does not ask Molevad’s circle for permission.

A member may leave. The years already given stay in the cup. What comes back to the member is their papers, which members call a thinner copy. The other members stop reading blood with them, and the long-houses that keep the circle stop giving them a seat.

The circle claims that by giving to the cup they made a god. They call it the Poured God, and among themselves the Cup We Made. They say every gift is freely given. The Pourers are a separate group from the Walled Book and from the Protectors.

What nobody knows

Nobody knows who made the First Cut. Five different accounts are told. In one, a parent stole the branch so that no more children would stay UnTurned for want of the trip, or die on the road. In another, a tree-warden cut it before the First Seat allowed cutting. The devout say the Tree let a branch

come away. The Watching say people had always grafted trees and the count was added later. The Old Ways say the land received a guest. This history does not pick one.

Nobody knows how old the Awakening Tree is. It was standing before anyone counted years. The Watching argue against any date anyone proposes.

Nobody has settled whether there is a Leaf-Mother, or, for those who believe in her, what limits her. Believers ask why her Trees could not Turn children far away until a graft was planted near them, and why Kumbaan has no Tree. They do not agree on the answer. Skeptics say distance and soil explain everything, and that the Tree is a plant. This history does not answer the question.

How years are numbered

There is **no universal year-zero.** Same twelve months; three new-year's days. Same past; **seven honest ways to count it.** The number you write on a debt is a theology.

Who	What they count from	What it sounds like
First Seat / devout clerks	**the First Cut**, in **Cut-years**. The liturgical name is the *Eoloren-count*. A Cut-year is numbered from that hinge.	"the 387th Cut-year"
Threnmaieth	Cut-years *and* a crown-count from the Two Papers (Cut-year 67; present **Crown-year 320**)	both numbers, set down for a roll
Lestrand / deathless houses	a **house-founding**, a note-issue, a contract-term	"the 307th summer of the White Note" (present); the old conversion is the 200th, from Ledan's query in Cut-year 280
Vaethorn	**the year our graft took**, or the last *actual* Turning-Week	a child "turns the year" when the local Tree last managed a fall
the Watching	they **refuse the Cut-count**	the Tree was already seeing, before any Cut-count
the Old Ways	a closed door, a drowning-year, a guest that took	the Hands are when guests arrived; the old doors are older than that arrival
Kumbaan	**moons**	the mainland ages are a sailor's chart they do not owe

Present: Cut-year 387. That is the 387th summer since the First Cut. It is not a round number.

What no one can date. The Awakening Tree is **old beyond reliable dating.** Before the Walk has no start. Who made the First Cut stays contested. Believers ask why her Trees reached the far lands late, and skeptics say there is no Leaf-Mother. The Low Wall, the Seeing-Ring, and the Dry Stair are stone places from before the Walk. People found them standing. They carry no builder's name.

Cut-year 0 is a graft. It is the first witnessed copy of living wood. It is not the first Condition, not the first Giving, and not the Tree's birthday. The Giving and the walk have no start year. Becoming at a door is older than the walk. Being born a Kind is older than both.

The Other Count

Two clocks still organize how you Turned and where the wood has reached. Three hundred and eighty-seven summers also held a war, a split of paper, a fever, a flood, and a hush that is still the Old Crossing's peace. This count sits *beside* the clocks.

In the Walking Years a class of the untithed **sat on Thaeloren** and decided who might walk to it. People call them **the Closed Seat**. Folk say **the Grove-Sitters**. They were an *origin-gate* that grew a country around the one Tree. Strandoren paid the Salt Walk; it was never a province. Heskoren was beyond a gate's ride. Kumbaan lay beyond any road that gate could send.

They thought they were doing horticulture and mercy: the one Tree cannot stand a world at once, so someone must choose the road. That is the same hunger the First Seat later named Cutting-leave, and the same hunger Rothallo still files as rank. People still say the Inner Close. It is Orenbren's walled capital, one day's walk from the wood, inside Orenbren. The First Seat stays in the wood.

Cut-years	Everyday name	Kind	What it left
Cut-years 19–38	**the Closing**	war / political	The First Cut made a local Tree; the Closed Seat tried to uproot the copies and could not. Collapse. Hildal, a clerk, ordered the Retreat behind the walls at Rothallo, still called the Inner Close.
Cut-year 67	**the Two Papers**	political / dynastic (paper, not blood)	One hymn-country became Maiethvael and Threnmaieth. Crown-count starts here. Present **Crown-year 320**.
Cut-year 171	**the Grey Summer**	epidemic	Quay-fever on the Old Crossing. Not a Tithe. Trenledd began writing persons. Brenledd joined its charters in one league (Cut-year 174). Leddvael made a signing a civic rite.
Cut-year 233	**the Thaw-Break**	natural	Lirorn snowmelt in one week on the Rain-Wall. Noon Pass lost; Shelf-gate taken. West-road cut two summers. A graft bound for Ornled died, and Ornled stopped waiting on a hymn.
Cut-year 248	**the Wrong Green**	Tree / civic	A hug announced as copper-green at Harrow's Green. A person's doing, not the Tree's. It is not one of the five dated events that were not about the Trees; it sits on this table beside them.
Cut-year 280	**Ledan's query**	archival dating	The White Note House in its 200th summer. Ledan is Long-Lived; the conversion is still the house's habit. Present house-year **307**.
Cut-years 299–304	**the Hinge War → the Hinge Hush**	inter-power / treaty	The Hinge Shore and the Ledger Coast over hinge-tolls. The hush is the current Old Crossing peace, with a West Water clause Netstrand still quotes.

The present year is **Cut-year 387**. Who cut remains unpicked. A chronicle that writes a first king into the Before is adding a later story to a time nobody dated. The Watching warn against that.

What a traveller notices, besides wood. Three dates on a debt, and a *fourth* if the note survived the Grey Summer. A kitchen that still will not send a child through the Inner Close's gate. A Lirorn pass-stone with a water-line over the old ribbon-notch. A Hinge Shore quay that charges the Hush-rate and

will not call it a victory. A Watching night on a ring of stones that is older than any Cut-year anyone will write.

Maiethorn is post-imperial lodging, gift, reckoning, hinge, thaw, and dry sowing — six successors of a grove-gate, not six ancient kingdoms. Strandoren is what the Salt Walk became when the gate died and the fever wrote new paper. Heskoren entered the clocks late. Host-rights were already there.

Spread of the wave

Cut-years	Where the wood went
Cut-year 0	the First Cut, near Thaeloren, Maiethorn
Cut-years 0–80	Maiethorn filling. Origin-towns first; the Rain-Shadow, the dry east beyond the Rain-Wall, slower.
Cut-years 40–160	Strandoren by sea. Wealthy coasts first, deep interior later.
Cut-years 160–200	the wait. No graft reaches Heskoren.
Cut-years 200–387	Heskoren, still receiving. Luckiest towns have had a local Turning for a few generations; whole districts still wait.
never	Kumbaan. No Tree; no graft ever crossed.

A freshly planted **scion** still takes **a generation** to hold a Leaf-Fall. That is the cutting itself, and it is not a seed. So “a graft arrived” and “this town Turns under its own canopy” are twenty years apart. Heskoren’s waiting is the queue, plus the childhood of the wood.

What the two clocks did

Law. Citizenship-by-local-witness is a Hands-era default. In the Walking Years the town that *saw you Turn* was the crowd under Thaeloren, or no one, if you never arrived. Far children who stayed UnTurned were unwitnessed as Given because they did not make the trip. No roll had a line for them. Vouching-at-a-distance was invented to carry the origin’s witness home. A Long-Lived who remembers the origin-fall can carry it, or a Bound word, or a Far-Voiced feeling. The unvouched Struck are older than the grafts: a becoming on a far threshold was always unwitnessed. The Grafting localized who is expected to have been seen. The unease was already in the far towns.

Money. Many deathless houses began as **road-houses**. Those were inns on the pilgrimage roads that also issued credit, beds and century-notes for families who had to walk. When the walk stopped being required in the core, the houses still had Long-Lived memory of every debtor on the road, and paper that outlived the pilgrimage-season. They became banks. The endow-not-inherit loop is older than the Hands. The *trusted note* is a Walking-era instrument. It outlived its road.

Clergy. Cutting-leave is the First Seat's paper authorizing a cut. That is how the college captured a practice that began without it. The first successful cut was argued as theft, as mercy, as the Tree offering a branch, as old horticulture the Motherfaith later named. The Seat won the *authorization*. The **scion-queue** is the Grafting's child. That is the bottleneck that appears when her reach can travel but someone still decides *which town next.* Spreading Trees made a queue.

Language. The pilgrimage was a conserving pull. Once a year the far-flung walked to the same grove and heard the same liturgy, so the Old Tongue stayed nearer itself along the road. Local Trees let daughters grow in place. That is why drift tracks Tree-thinness, and why Lestrand eroded so far so fast: trade, a local canopy, and no need to walk to the Motherwood. The three daughter-drifts are Years-of-Hands change on a Walking-era root.

Geography. The reach-gradient *is* the wave, frozen at Cut-year 387. Maiethorn is old Hands. Strandoren is mature Hands with a commercial aftertaste. Heskoren is the Grafting this decade. Kumbaan never entered the clocks. A traveller meets that spread as distance, and as history.

Faith. The Watching remember Before the Walk as *the Before*, seeing without a mother's name, and will not start history at a Cut. The Old Ways were already becoming before any pilgrim road; the Hands are when *guests* arrived late. The Fair Hand dates contracts from a signing, not from a wound in wood; the Grafting is a supply-chain fact. The Open Table owes the ages nothing.

What a traveller notices

- A Long-Lived who says "I walked," and a room that goes quiet. That is how that person Turned, spoken as a life.
- A **mile-shrine** stands on a road that now ends at a town Tree. That is a stone at about a day's walk, set for a Turning that no longer has to happen there. The devout still leave a ribbon. The town children climb it.
- **Empty pilgrim-beds** in an old inn's upper room, let now to merchants. The deathless house that owns the inn still dates its notes from the founding-summer the beds were full.
- Three dates for one summer, written on one debt: a Cut-year, a house-year, a "year the graft took."
- A Heskoren hamlet whose ten-year-olds still walk to a neighbour. That walk is this year.
- Someone names a Phoenix "the Phoenix of the last Walking summer," and no one in the room agrees which summer that was.

A clerk’s query (Cut-year 280)

Ledan of the White Note, to the Speaker who keeps the Eoloren-count, in the house’s 200th summer. It is filed in the founding-book, and the desk still reaches for its conversion. The verso has been folded around a second number.

> *The house writes a century-loan from our founding-summer, which we call the 200th of the White Note. The debtor in Wetorn writes the same summer as the year their graft took. Your college will write it as the 280th Cut-year if I have the conversion right, and as the 279th if I have it wrong.*
>
> *Which number should stand on the note so that in fifty years the same person still owes us? We do not ask which summer was holy. We ask which summer a court will still be able to find.*

In Cut-year 387 the house is in its 307th summer, and Ledan still asks which number a court can find.

Before the Walk

The unnamed preface. The Awakening Tree already stood. People already had Kinds. Some already *became* things at doors the later faith would struggle to place. People tell little of it. There is no date. The Tree is old beyond reliable dating. No creation myth, no first king. The Watching keep **the Before**.

Most of the world does not have a name for this. The devout skip it. Skeptics say, “Before anyone bothered to walk,” and they keep no years for it.

The Watching keep the one lived name: **the Before.** In their telling the world was Kind and Kind alone, then the Tree was already there, *watching*. The Giving came after the Watching. The Mother-name came after that. Each layer is a story laid over a seeing.

The Old Ways do not grant that becoming waited on a road. Heskoren’s people already crossed doors (drowning, grove, stone) before any pilgrim mile. The Walking Years, when they arrived as a foreign traffic, were the beginning of *company*.

Kumbaan’s hill-history does not owe Thaeloren a preface.

What can be said without inventing kings:

- The origin Tree is the one Tree no one grafted from another. It was not planted in a remembered summer.

- Far from it, people lived as they lived. Some were Struck at thresholds because thresholds exist. Some were never either Given or Struck, because there was no local fall to miss.
- When people organized the tenth-year trip, the Walking Years began. That organization is the start of the walk. The world was already there.

None of this is dated. A later chronicle that writes a first king, a first war, or a first sermon into this era is adding a later story to a time nobody dated. The Watching warn against that.

The Walking Years

Once there was only the Awakening Tree, and a child's tenth-year Turning meant a *walk* to it. Families who could not make the trip **stayed UnTurned for want of it** (folk called them Kept), so the far reaches ran heavy on the UnTurned and the Struck as the ordinary count. People call them **the Walking Years**. The liturgical name is **Brenvaeth** *(BREN-vayth)*. That is the hearth gone to the waiting.

In these years the Leaf-Fall happened in one grove, on Maiethorn, under Thaeloren. A tenth summer was a journey, or it was no Leaf-Fall at all, because you were not there.

No town could show that a goddess had skipped the far-flung who stayed home. They were **children who did not walk.** Some were later Struck at a drowning, an oath, a death, unwitnessed, because the only crowd that counted was a continent away. Some stayed UnTurned for life, wanted or not, because want-of-a-trip is a distance.

Thin reach used to mean far from the one Tree. After the First Cut, thin reach came to mean *Tree-poor places*. The grafts there are young, sick, or few. A hamlet next-door to a dying scion is near on a map. The wood there is thin, which is what "far" came to mean.

The pilgrimage changed jobs when grafts began, and people still walk it. In the Years of Hands the devout still walk to the origin; the poor and the Tree-bereaved still walk to a neighbour. The Walking Years are the time when *everyone who Turned as Given had walked, or had been carried.*

The later romance of the old mile is a Hands-era feeling laid on Walking-era graves.

The era has no dated start. It grows out of Before the Walk when the trip becomes *the* way to Turn. It has a dated hinge: the First Cut (Cut-year 0). After that the Walking Years cease to be the *default* in lands the wood has reached, and remain the default in lands it has not. Heskoren is still, in places, *in* this era.

The door is one week

Turning-Week is the week bracketing the High Solstice in **Eolthael**. Every child who has turned ten since the last High Solstice Turns that week, under Thaeloren, or they do not Turn as Given at all.

Miss the week and the door has shut. An eleven-year-old at the origin the following summer is a visitor. The Tree's Given-door is that tenth-year cohort, in that week. Struck doors still open later, elsewhere, with no leaf and no crowd. That is a different mercy, and it was always the far lands' other path.

This is why families from any distance **left early**, and why the richest or most frightened far households spent a *year* at the origin: a nine-year-old wintered in a road-house so they could not miss. The held-over child is the expensive mercy. Everyone else gambled one summer.

Three walks, not one road

Named in the common tongue, because the walk was logistics before it was liturgy.

Walk	Who used it	How long	What it cost
the Near Mile	Maiethorn inland, anyone already on the Motherland	three to twelve days	a harvest-timing; almost everyone who meant to come, came
the Salt Walk	Strandoren: ship the Old Crossing, then the Near Mile	three to five days' sail plus the inland days; usually one to three weeks in all	a berth in fair weather; miss the last crossing and you miss the year
the Long Mile	Heskoren, and the Strandoren interior before the coasts were rich	six to twelve weeks	a year's surplus, or a road-house note, or you did not go

On the road, people said, "We are on the Long Mile," or "We took the salt." Clerks keep the name Brenvaeth. Vaethorn still calls the whole past "the waiting-road." Lestrand files it as "the road-years." A Threnmaieth clerk wants the miles "on a roll."

Timing against the year. Near-Mile families left in **Haelren** or early **Eolthael** and were home by **Vaelorn**. Salt-Walk households watched the Old Crossing from **Saelorn**; a late storm in Hale-month left an UnTurned child. Long-Mile columns left in **Liren** or **Saelorn**, the thaw and the first green, and hoped the High Solstice had not happened without them. Some arrived in **Leddorn** with a ten-year-old who had already missed. The road-houses knew that silence. They did not charge extra for it. They also did not refund the note.

No walk crossed the storm-wall to Kumbaan.

Who could afford it

The Near Mile was a civic season: whole towns moved a short way together, and a poor child walked in a neighbour's dust. Cost was real (lost labour, a week of food) and rarely decisive.

The Salt Walk sorted by **cash and weather.** Coastal wealth bought berths. Interior Strandoren was already "far" in these years, even though the coasts would later be Tree-rich. A family might send the Turning-child and one adult, and leave the rest. Guilds sometimes advanced a berth against a future colour. A Given Answered or Far-Voiced was worth the loan; a hug was a debt with no new trade in it. The Fair Hand would later call this a term. In Brenvaeth it was just the quay.

The Long Mile sorted by **whether you could lose a year.** Food, shoes, a second adult if you had one, and the note you signed at the first road-house that would take it. Many could not. Those who could often could not for *every* child.

The split household is the era's ordinary cruelty. A family with three children near ten could sometimes walk one. The one who walked might come home Given. The ones who stayed were UnTurned, or were Struck later at a local door, and grew up in the same kitchen as a sibling the origin had seen. Distance did this. Vaethorn's later guilt is a Hands-era reading of that fact. A preacher there says, "We wait because we are unworthy." The miles record the distance.

Old Ways households on Heskoren often **refused the walk** on purpose. Their children were already the land's. Motherfaith neighbours read those children as UnTurned for want of the trip, which is a misreading the walk itself cannot correct. Both families are telling the truth they have.

Who was let through

Distance and coin were not the only sorters. A class of the untithed, the Closed Seat, which folk call the Grove-Sitters, sat on Thaeloren and decided who might stand under it. A family could have shoes and a Salt-Walk berth and still be turned away at the gate. **Grove-leave** was paper you carried to the gate.

Far lands ran heavy on the UnTurned because some children did not walk, and because some children walked and were turned away. Both fill a kitchen. The later romance of the old mile prefers the first cause. Folk songs remember the second.

The Closed Seat was an origin-gate, not a world-empire. Strandoren paid the crossing; it was never a province. Heskoren was beyond a gate's ride. When a Near-Mile town Turned under a copy, the gate was no longer the only way to Turn. The war that tried to make that untrue is the Closing, told in "A history in order" above.

Who died

Children died on the road. So did the adults who carried them. River-crossings in the thaw, a fever in a packed Near-Mile inn, a late squall on the Old Crossing, hunger on a Long-Mile stretch between hearths, a birth that would not wait for the grove. Long roads kill people. That is what they do.

The graves are mostly unmarked at first. Then someone sets a stone at a day's walk, because the next column needs to know the water, and because a name should sit somewhere. A ribbon goes on the stone the year after. A later column uses the stone as a mile-mark. The romance and the graves are the same object seen at two hours of the day.

A child who dies on the way to be witnessed may **Strike as Returned** on the road. That is a becoming with no crowd, on the way to the only crowd that counted. Rare. Remembered. The dangerous edge of these years lives here, not in the Leaf-Fall waiting at the end of the walk.

The origin also filled with **children who arrived and had no one to walk home with.** Road-houses took some in (a bed that became a life). Origin-towns took some. A Given child with no one to carry the witness home is the other half of the grave: they lived, and belonging still had to be invented for them.

Far reaches as the rule

In Brenvaeth, a land far from Thaeloren was **UnTurned-heavy and Struck-heavy because most ten-year-olds never stood under the canopy.** That was how the world worked anywhere the walk was too far or too dear.

- **Given** were the ones who had been *there*, a minority that shrank with distance. They came home as specialists the town could not otherwise grow, and as people the town had not seen become.
- **UnTurned** were the default far childhood, because they never stood under the Tree: whole, untithed, unwitnessed-as-Given. Folk called them Kept. The few who walked and were hugged were Kept in the strict sense. Some were wanted that way. Some were the price of a summer the family could not raise. Some were Old Ways children the Motherfaith had misfiled.
- **Struck** were the far lands' other door, and always had been. Drownings, oaths, deaths. No leaf. No origin-crowd. The unease that follows the Struck is older than the grafts. The walk made it louder, because the Given in the same town *had* been seen, a continent away.

When the wood later travelled, this pattern *relocated*. A Tree-poor pocket next to a dying scion has the same count of UnTurned and Struck. The place is near. The wood is thin. What decides it is where the wood has reached, not the distance. Today's Heskoren is this year. Some cohorts still walk. A valley over, children stand under a town Tree. Both can be true on the same road.

Institutions of the road

In Brenvaeth the **origin-hearth** was the only Speaking that counted. Far towns had no Tree to tend. The road had inns, stones, and summer traffic. Tree-Wardens who carry grafts belong to the Years of Hands.

Mile-shrines

Water if the ground allows. A flat top for a pack. Often a name. Often a ribbon.

They begin as graves and waymarks in the same act. You bury someone where the column had to stop, and the next year the stop is the place you aim for. The devout later leave ribbons for the Tree. Children later climb them. Hands-towns later argue about pulling them down because the road now ends at a local canopy and the stone is in the way. The stone does not know which story it is in.

People tie what they have. A copper-green scrap on a Long-Mile stone is cloth. Travellers who have walked once treat it as cloth. Travellers who have only heard the romance look for a Taken-In's death in the colour.

Road-houses

Many deathless houses began here. In Brenvaeth they sold beds, porridge, a dry room, and **credit for a walk you could not miss twice.**

The cant is **brenhael** *(bren-HAYL)*. It is *bren* and *hael*. That is the hearth kept whole. Vaethorn says "waiting-hearth." Lestrand says "the bed-house" and still means the bank. A Threnmaieth clerk would like them "on the roll."

What a road-house actually sold:

- **A bed in the two crowded months**, and a quieter one in the other ten. Held-over nine-year-olds were the winter trade. Empty pilgrim-beds in a Hands-era upper room used to be this.
- **A note.** You eat now; you pay at the origin, or on the way home, or when the child is grown, or when a sibling walks next year. The Long-Lived innkeeper **forgets none of it.** That memory is why the paper will outlive the pilgrimage-season and become the trusted note. In the act, it is an innkeeper who will still know your name in fifty years, which is a kindness and a leash.
- **A little Tithe-furnishing**, improvised, not a guild. A green-lot behind the house for a Taken-In parent. A shed where a Far-Voiced can cry without taking the dormitory with them. The road itself is novelty enough that a Long-Lived innkeeper's own Tithe stays fed, which is why the deathless *stayed* in the trade, and why the same people later endow libraries: the hunger that kept them on the mile is the hunger that built the archive. Brenvaeth had a pot and a shed.

- **A held bed.** A family said they would come. They did not. The innkeeper keeps the bed a year, then two, then as a habit that looks like hospitality and functions as a shrine.

The White Note's founding-summer is a house-year, not a Cut-year. In the Walking Years that house was a hearth with too many boots by the door. This is the same fortune, earlier.

Summer traffic

For two months the Near Mile is a moving town of columns and dust. A Far-Voiced calls from ridge to ridge, "The road is full," "The ford is wrong," "A child is down." Two-Bodied range the edges because the ranging *is* the Tithe and the column is a herd. Markets grow at the mile-shrines and vanish when Eolthael ends. Then the road is empty and local, and the road-house counts notes.

People walked with whoever left the same week. A Bound's word might hold a column together for a fortnight. A Kept adult with no Tithe to manage was, then as now, the person who could carry the extra pack.

Witness at the origin, or not at all

In Brenvaeth the town that *saw you Turn* was the crowd under Thaeloren, or no one. Citizenship-by-local-witness comes later, with the Years of Hands.

- **Going home did not bring the crowd with you.** Your village had not watched. Belonging at home required someone who *had* been under the boughs to stand for you: a parent, a neighbour from the column, a Long-Lived who keeps origin-falls the way they later keep town-falls. **Vouching-at-a-distance was invented to carry the origin's witness home.** The three pillars are older than the grafts. Those are Long-Lived memory, a Bound word, and a Far-Voiced feeling. The *job* of carrying a far Turning is Walking-era.
- **A Given child with no surviving witness** is legally thin in the place they grew up. Origin-orphans, road-house children, a Bound stranger who will swear the colour they did not see (and cannot cheaply lie). The unvouched are older than the Struck-stigma, and include people the Tree *did* Give.
- **Struck on the road** are a double unease: unwitnessed becoming, *on the way* to the witnessing. A Returned child walking the last Near-Mile days beside the parent who has not yet forgiven the threshold.
- **Staying home** meant you were never Given-witnessed. You were still of your town, because your town had watched you be a child. An UnTurned child was not unmarked on a roll. Folk called such children Kept, though no Tree had hugged them.

The origin-crowd was enormous in Eolthael and ordinary the rest of the year. Speakers of the origin-hearth named colours until their voices went. Folk-known colours still were; the warden's word made

them *count* for people who would have to carry that word home.

Long-Lived who still say “I walked”

A Long-Lived who says “I walked” is saying when they were young. Memory is perfect. What they mean by it is argued. There is no single Long-Lived account.

At present (Cut-year 387) the sentence does at least four jobs, and they argue:

- **“I walked as a child, under Thaeloren, before my town had wood.”** A Maiethorn deathless Given in the late Walking is speaking of a summer most of the room has only as a ribbon. Those were the last core cohorts, before Maiethorn filled in the first Cut-years. A Heskoren deathless may mean “last decade.” Same words. The wood reached their towns at different times.
- **“I walked the mile as the inn.”** A road-house Long-Lived may never have stood under the canopy as a pilgrim. They walked the same stretch every summer for two hundred years. They remember every debtor. They will not always tell you which children came back.
- **“I remember the graves and I will not call them holy.”** Skeptics among the deathless. The road was biology plus bad fords. They are sincere. They still tear up at a ribbon, which they will not explain.
- **“I remember the graves and I will not call them logistics.”** Devout deathless. Every stone was a waiting. They are sincere. They still know which ford killed which name, which they will tell you whether you asked or not.

Blood-Read will give you a true fragment of a walk. It will not tell you which of the four jobs the living speaker is doing.

They also disagree with Seat chronicles that start at the First Cut. A Long-Lived who walked as a child and a clerk who counts Cut-years will fight about the same summer. Both can be honest. Only one of them was there.

What a character notices

- Dust on a Near-Mile road in Hale-month, and none in Ledger-month.
- A mile-shrine with a ribbon and a climbing-scuff, and a Hands-child who does not know it was a grave.
- An inn’s upper room with too many beds for the present trade. The house still dates its notes from a founding-summer the beds were full.
- A Held bed that has not been let in anyone’s living mortal memory. The innkeeper can tell you the name. They will not tell you they think the child is dead, or Kept, or Old Ways, or never born.

- A sibling-pair who will not walk the same side of a road: one Given, and one who never stood under a Tree. That second child is UnTurned. Folk still call them Kept.
- A Far-Voiced calls from a ridge, in an old pattern, “The ford is wrong.” No column answers. Birds do.
- Someone at a table says, “I walked,” and the room sorts itself by who goes quiet.

A Turning-Week slate

From the third hearth on the Near Mile, kept by Thilim, who is Long-Lived and has kept this house since before the Cut, as later clerks would say. The verso is knife-scored with tally-marks that do not match the recto.

> *Eolthael, the summer the ford ran high.*
>
> *Beds: forty-and-two spoken for. Notes out: Tora of the long cape, two people, pay on the home-walk. Valein of the salt, one person, paid at the quay. The Held: Seine of the far cape, tenth summer, not come. Hold the bed. The mother said next year. Next year was last year.*
>
> *Porridge: enough. Shed: the blue-leaf girl from the second column cried the rafters quiet; no charge; we needed the quiet. Green-lot: used. The Taken-In man from the long cape left a cutting. I put it in the pot. It is not a Tree.*
>
> *I do not ask which summer was holy. I ask which people will be here at dark. The Held bed is made. If Seine comes I will not have to remember I made it for nothing.*

The cutting in the pot is not a First Cut. It is a man who missed his green.

The First Cut

Someone cut living wood from Thaeloren (or from a branch that came away in a hand), carried it a day’s earth, married it to new ground, and it *took*. A town on the Near Mile Turned, a generation later, under a canopy that was not the origin. People call it **the First Cut**. The liturgical name is **Eoloren** *(EOL-or-en)*. That is the witnessed hinge. The clerical count of years starts here.

Everyone agrees *a first successful town-graft occurred.* It happened within a day’s living-earth of Thaeloren, close enough that a cut could still be green when it met new ground. That is horticulture. No two houses agree whose story the cut is.

The first green is not named. Folk who need an object call it **the nameless green**. Naming the town would pick a hearth, and a hearth would pick a hand.

A freshly planted scion still takes **a generation** to hold a Leaf-Fall. So Cut-year 0 is a wound in wood. The first *local Turning* is about twenty summers later. “A graft arrived” and “this town Turns under its own canopy” are never the same year. The wave is slow because each Hand must grow up before it can be a source.

The five attributions

The five stories are *jobs*. Which one a room is doing tells you more than a creed would. Who cut stays unpicked. All five stay in use.

Folk: the stolen branch

A parent who would not watch another child stay UnTurned for want of a trip, or would not bury another child on the Near Mile, took wood without leave. Mercy as theft.

- **The nameless knife** is the object, not a saint. Some hearths keep a kitchen-knife on a ribbon the way Hands-children climb mile-shrines: they cannot say whether they are honouring a theft or a gift. There is no name on the handle.
- **Thief-songs** on the Near Mile are walking-songs. The singers say “we” for the cutter. A Salt-Walk singer makes it a quay-joke and says, “The first unpaid berth.” Long-Mile versions are not funny. Vaethorn’s later guilt calls this parent “unworthy.” The songs do not agree.
- **Folk-right cutting** continued after the Seat wrote a leave. A Taken-In with a sick neighbour and no year to wait will still take a slip. Most of those slips die. The ones that take are how the queue learns it is not the only horticulture in the world. Road-hands call this a problem. Towns that lived through a stolen year call it a year they Turned.

The later Cutting-leave fee is, in this telling, **a fine that forgot it was a fine.** Lestrand will broker it without blushing. That is this story with a clerk.

A stolen Hand still left a town behind that did not get the next one. The songs leave that town and go on.

Clergy: the warden ahead of the college

A tree-warden of a Near-Mile hearth cut with a leave that did not yet exist. The wood took. The origin-hearth spent **the generation of argument** trying to decide whether this was blight, theft, or rite. That argument ran from Cut-year 0 into the first local Leaf-Fall. The First Seat as a *Cutting-leave desk* is what that argument left on the ground. The Road-hands are this scandal in an office. They are the people who walk what used to be unsanctioned.

- **Speakers who will not say “first.”** They say, “The witnessed hinge.” They will date a note. They will not point at a grave. Some of them are skeptics who grant the horticulture and refuse the saint.

Some of them are devout who think naming a cutter would steal the Tree's offering. Both rooms keep that silence.

- **The quiet years at the origin.** After the first copy, the Motherwood tried to forbid further cuts. Wood died in pots anyway. Neighbours cut anyway. Forbidding a copy that had already taken is how a college learns it does not own the Tree's tissue, only the *authorization.*
- **Road-hands as regularized heresy.** They were not designed as a travelling church. They are the generation of argument, given a cart.

A Speaker says, "We will write how, not who." That sentence is how a heresy becomes a monopoly. The college writes the how.

Devout: the Tree offered

A branch came away. No theft, no genius. A Hand giving a Hand. The Mother (or the Tree, if you will not say Mother) *meant* the wood to travel. This is the version the Seat prefers in sermons, because it makes the scion-queue sound like stewardship rather than rationing.

- **Eoloren sermons** at Turning-Week in the Motherwood. A Speaker says, "She sent her hands outward so the hearths could stay." The graves of the Walking Years are named in the same breath, on a good day. On a bad day they are not.
- **The watering-words** as proof. A devout neighbour says, "If the marrying-rite were only horticulture, why would the wood listen?" A skeptic says, "Because you watered it." Both can stand under the same canopy.
- **Cutting-leave as blessing.** Vaethorn calls it "the wood's blessing." The devout use that name. Without it the queue is a list of who waits.

Devout sermons say, "She meant the wood to travel." The wave went to paying coasts before it went to the poor far. The thing saved, when anything was, was a walk. Not everyone's.

The Watching: horticulture, then a later name

People had always been able to cut living wood. Fruit-grafts, orchard-kin, a slip in a pot. The Motherfaith later named one cut the First, and started a count. That is a story laid over a seeing. The Tree was already seeing. A Watcher says, "A date does not make a mother."

- **They refuse the Cut-count.** A Watcher clerk will date a debt from a house-year, a drowning-year, a night they kept. They will convert to Eoloren-count if a court makes them, and they will not call it history.
- **Pear-grafts as the tell.** Watcher hearths on Maiethorn still graft ordinary fruit in the same week a Road-hand passes with carrying-earth. They do not think this is a joke. They think it is the whole argument, done with hands.

- **The withheld *first*.** Same cadence as the withheld blessing. A Watcher says, “What was cut, was seen. What took, was seen. The Tree does not reach twice by chance.” The sentence names no Mother and no epoch.

Children still died on the road until the copies took. The Watching’s refusal is a name for the count. The graves are in the ground.

The Old Ways: the land received a guest

In the Old Ways telling, a grove took in kin. The Hands are when guests began arriving from the east. Host-rights start at that receiving. A college’s warrant is a different paper.

- **The first meal** for a new graft is food left at the planting. You feed a guest that way before you ask their business. The Door-Keepers still do this. A Road-hand who eats is doing host-courtesy whether the Seat wrote it down or not. A Road-hand who plants and leaves is a claiming.
- **Guest-reading vs First-reading.** A Guest-reading town will pilgrimage *and* keep the meal. A First-reading district will tend the same wood as a guest in their house and still refuse the Tender’s blessing. Both start the story at a *receiving*. The Cut is a mainland word for an arrival.
- **Their count does not open at Cut-year 0.** On Heskoren the guests *arrive* in the Cut-year 200s. Motherfaith calls that arrival “late.” A Seat map calls it “the First Cut, delayed.” The land was already making children at the old doors.

A guest who takes a generation to speak will still be called a Tree by the children who Turn under it. That speaking is the first local Leaf-Fall. Host-rights do not stop a town from becoming Hands-era.

People tell all five. Skeptics grant the horticulture. They can see it. They deny that a mind chose the travelling. The Fair Hand enters when the wood boards a ship. The Open Table keeps moons, and stays off this argument.

The generation of argument

Cut-year 0 is a cut. The next twenty summers are copies, dead wood, a college that cannot un-cut, and a first local Leaf-Fall that ends the argument without settling it.

What people actually did.

- Near-Mile towns cut because the first green was visible from the next town. Living tissue, a day’s earth, a pot, a Taken-In who knew soil. This is why the origin-towns filled first. A sapling can survive that distance. Worthiness is a later sermon.
- Most early copies **died.** Mortal wood, wrong season, a pot that dried on the Near Mile in Hale-month, a well-meant slip with no carrying-earth. The deaths are why the Seat could tell itself the first taking was a fluke, for a while.

- The origin-hearth tried **forbidding.** Speakers named it theft, blight, a wound in the First Hand. Neighbours cut anyway. A prohibition with no riders cannot police a day's walk in a pre-print world.
- **Proof arrived as a ceremony.** When the nameless green held its first Turning-Week, a colour fell (or a hug; the tellings do not agree, and it does not change the paper). A town that was not the origin had Turned its own child. Citizenship-by-local-witness begins in that town, a generation after the knife. The Walk is no longer the only door. The Seat can argue doctrine until the leaves fall. It cannot argue the leaves back onto Thaeloren.

What the Seat captured.

The college could not own the tissue. It could own **who may cut next.** That is the copy-right. **Cutting-leave** is the paper. The **scion-queue** is what a copy-right becomes when demand outruns a generation of wood.

The fee is framed as carrying-earth and a Road-hand's year. Folk hear a fine. Lestrand hears a licence. Threnmaieth wants it on a roll. Vaethorn calls it an offering. Same coin, four stances. Historically it is how an institution absorbed a heresy and called it horticulture. Unsanctioned cutting became authorized cutting. The practice survived by changing owner.

Road-hands are not a second order. They are the people you send when you have claimed the knife and still need the wood to walk.

Spreading Trees made a queue. Struck stigma, Tithe-leverage, the pitied Kept: none of that dissolved when a second canopy opened. The new injustice is *which town next*, paid in twenty more years of borrowed Turnings. She did not write the list. People did.

How the wave moved

A scion still takes a generation to Turn. A healthy town Tree may supply the next cut, acting on the origin's behalf. So the wave is a **chain of maturing Hands**, not a miracle crate. Sea can jump a chain. A Long-Mile cart cannot, until carrying-earth lasts and there are rest-hearths that are not just pilgrim-inns.

Maiethorn, Cut-years 0–80 (origin-towns first; Rain-Shadow slower)

The Near Mile stops being a requirement in the core, town by town, as canopies come of age. Origin-towns first: a day's earth, then two, then a valley. The pilgrimage remains: devotion at Thaeloren, and necessity wherever a graft has not yet spoken.

The Rain-Shadow is slower. That is Maiethorn's dry east, beyond the Rain-Wall. Same continent, thin soil, wells, sand-country. A cut that takes in the Sacred Core dies in the dry hills unless a Taken-In and

a lucky year agree. This is dirt. Fox of the Sands hearths still walk west toward Thaeloren after coastal towns have already stopped. The wave runs at two speeds on one continent.

A Seat sermon says, “Her hands filled the Motherland.” Folk memory says, “We stopped burying children on the Near Mile where the wood took, and we did not stop where it didn’t.” Both sentences can be said in the same market.

By Cut-year 80 the Motherland is **old Hands** in the core and **still waiting** in pockets. That waiting is why a Maiethorn hamlet can still send this year’s ten-year-olds to a neighbour. The walk is this year.

Strandoren, Cut-years 40–160, by sea (wealthy coasts first, interior later)

The Old Crossing already knew how to move a child. Moving a Hand is the same berth with worse instructions. The written instructions say, “Living earth. Do not stow below. Water at dawn.” A Taken-In or a Road-hand sleeps beside the pot.

Why the sea starts while Maiethorn is still filling (Cut-year 40). A ship is faster than filling every inland hamlet. A wealthy coast can pay a Cutting-leave and a Salt-Walk crew in the same summer a Near-Mile village is still on the Seat’s list. The wave went where ships and fees went.

Coasts first. Port-cities take. Deep interior waits on river-days and a cart, which is a small Long Mile. Strandoren’s later high reach and worn faith sit together. The wood arrived as cargo. The Fair Hand treats that cargo as needing no mother, and dates the carrying as a supply-chain fact. They will attend a planting as witnesses to a signing. They date a signing, and they leave the wound in wood to other houses. Their name for Eoloren is “the first carrying,” and they mean a bill of lading.

What the Salt Walk becomes. When a coast Turns under its own canopy, the berth stops being a tenth-year necessity and becomes a luxury, a contract-hinge, a devout extra. Road-houses on the inland days lose a season of boots and keep the notes.

By Cut-year 160 the Shore-lands are **mature Hands** on the water and still patchy inland. Lestrand files the whole motion as “the carrying.” The ships are in that filing.

The gap (why Heskoren waits until Cut-year 200)

Three stacked frictions, none of them unworthiness:

1. **Wood dies on the Long Mile.** Weeks to months. A day’s earth is a Near-Mile problem. A ship’s hold is a solved Salt-Walk problem if you water it. A cart between hearths in thaw-mud is how scions become sticks. Until carrying-earth lasts, and until there are **rest-hearths whose job is wood, not pilgrims**, Heskoren cannot be a circuit. Road-hands as a standing office had to exist before the far could be a route rather than a funeral of saplings.

2. **The chain has to grow up.** You cut from the origin, or from a healthy town Tree. Maiethorn's first generation of sources come of age in the Cut-year 20s–40s. Strandoren's coastal Hands are not ready to be sources until later still. You cannot skip to the sundered reach without a mature link, unless you spend origin-wood on a death-march. The Seat did not, mostly. That is horticulture and it is also a choice about who is next.
3. **The queue prefers a paying next.** After the coasts, carrying-earth is committed to interiors, replacements, sick Trees: the quiet work that does not look like a wave. Heskoren is poor, far, and already accused (by a later guilt-theology) of waiting because it deserved to. They waited because the wood was slow, the road was long, and the list was written in the Motherwood.

Vaethorn will preach, "We wait because we are unworthy." The gap is the evidence they use. The chronicle records the slow wood, the long road, and the list.

Heskoren, Cut-years 200–387 (still receiving)

The frontier coast faces the sea back toward Strandoren; that is the lifeline of new grafts. Luckiest towns have had a local Turning for a few generations (a scion that arrived in the 200s and spoke in the 220s, or later). Whole districts still send children down the road, to a neighbour's new canopy, or, still, the Long Mile, if the neighbour is a stick in a pot.

Today's Heskoren is this year. Some cohorts still walk. A valley over, children stand under a town Tree. That is the wave in the present tense. Both can be true on the same road. Vaethorn's waiting is the wave's front.

Old Ways host-rights start *here* as a lived collision, not as a Maiethorn sermon. A graft in an old Taken-In green is a guest. A Cutting-leave is a mainland paper. The meal comes first, or the planting is a claiming.

A Seat sermon says, "Her will is still travelling." Folk memory says, "The cart came late, the soil was called thin, the three hamlets past the ford can see Harrow's green from here." New towns already say which canopy they can see. On Heskoren that is the decade.

Kumbaan: never

No graft crossed the storm-wall, and Kumbaan has no Tree. Road-hands do not carry a Tree over drowning sea. Sailors tell of pots that went into the water. Dead wood is not a Tree. No old scion has ever been found on the Isle. The Open Table owes Eoloren nothing. Moons, not Cut-years.

Seat narration vs folk memory

	Seat / devout sermon	Folk memory (and the other houses)
The knife	She offered a Hand	Someone took one
The paper	Stewardship; horticulture	A fine that forgot; a licence; a warrant
The order of the wave	Her will travelling	Ships and fees, then the far
Heskoren's wait	Soil, timing, the Mother's pace	The list, the dead wood, the late cart
What was saved	The world received her	Children stopped dying on *some* roads

A Long-Lived who says "I walked" and a Speaker who keeps the Eoloren-count will fight about the same summer. A Long-Lived who planted (a Road-hand's long tenure, an innkeeper who watched pots replace children) will not always tell you which taking they think was holy. Memory is perfect. What the sentence means is argued.

The unvouched Struck, the pitied Kept, guild conscription, and Tithe-leverage are still in the towns. Spreading Trees *relocated* who is expected to have been seen at ten. A Hands-town can still meet a feared Struck with a rope. A local canopy leaves that rope where it was.

What a character notices

- A kitchen-knife on a ribbon in a Near-Mile house that will not name a saint.
- Watchers grafting pears in the same week a Road-hand waters carrying-earth.
- A first-meal bowl at a planting, licked clean by dogs, which the Seat did not write down.
- A clerk still copies a ship's instruction: "One living hand. Do not stow below. Water at dawn." The clerk files it as cargo.
- Three hamlets that can see a neighbour's canopy and are still on the queue. The college's word for the wait stays in the college.
- A Rain-Shadow child on the west-road after the core has stopped walking.
- Empty Salt-Walk berths in Eolthael, and a hold that still smells of wet earth out of season.
- A Long-Lived who planted says something other than "I walked." The job is the planting. The room still goes quiet.

A minute of the First Seat

Attributed to the Speaker Rithnali, from the summer the nameless green held its first Turning-Week. Later clerks file it as Cut-year 19. The verso is a list of pots that died, which no one read aloud.

> *The wood that took within a day's earth of the First was cut without leave. We will not write who. We will write how, so the next cut does not kill what it carries.*
>
> *Carry in living earth. Marry with the watering-words. Do not cut a second without the Seat. If the scion sickens, send word; do not take another wound in the First to hide the first.*
>
> *The Tree does not reach twice by chance, and neither do we. From this summer a cut is a leave, or it is a theft we have decided not to chase. The towns that wait will wait on horticulture. The soil is thin in more places than it is not.*

Folk who keep the nameless knife think this paper is a confession. The Seat thinks it is competence. Both can hold the same copy.

Consequences

- **The wave starts.** The Grafting is a *wave*. That is wood carried outward, a generation to mature, Maiethorn first, Strandoren by sea, Heskoren last and live, and Kumbaan never.
- **Where the wood has taken, a town Tree becomes the default.** Turning under a town canopy is the ordinary way. The pilgrimage remains. Its new job is devotion, prestige, or necessity when a graft fails.
- **The Seat gains a bottleneck.** Cutting-leave and the scion-queue are how an institution absorbed a heresy and called it horticulture. She did not write the queue.
- **The clerical epoch.** Cut-years begin. Other people do not have to care.
- **Language and money.** Local Trees let daughters grow in place; the road's conserving pull eases. Road-houses in the core lose pilgrim-seasons and keep the notes.

The Years of Hands

A town Turning Tree is the ordinary way to Turn *where the wood has taken.* People call them **the Years of Hands**, and also *Since the Hands*. The liturgical name is **Ornthael** *(ORN-thale)*. That is Tree-land. The Grafting is still moving through the present.

This is the era the rest of the world lives in without naming it. Town Trees. Local Leaf-Fall. Citizenship because *this* town watched you. The pilgrimage to Thaeloren as an extra, not the only door.

It is also incomplete. Read the reach-gradient as a *date*, not as a finished map:

- **Maiethorn:** old Hands. Dense mature grafts. The Walking is biography for the deathless and a ribbon on a mile-shrine for everyone else, except in the Rain-Shadow, and except wherever a Tree has sickened. Old Hands can un-Hands. A sickened Tree sends that town's children back onto a road. The Years of Hands go on around them.
- **Strandoren:** mature Hands, worn faith. The road-houses finished becoming banks here. The walk is a luxury, a contract-hinge, and a hold that still smells of earth when a pot is the passenger.
- **Heskoren:** the Grafting *this decade*. Luckiest towns have had a local canopy for a few generations. Whole districts still send children down the road. Vaethorn's waiting is the wave's front.
- **Kumbaan:** never took a graft, and does not walk its children to Thaeloren. It sits off both clocks.

The pilgrimage changed jobs, and people still walk it. The First Seat still authorizes cuts, now as a queue. Deathless houses still remember the road, now as credit. Mile-shrines still stand, as folklore, as argument, and as a thing children climb. The romance of the old mile belongs to the Years of Hands. The graves belong to the Walking Years. They stand on the same ground.

A child on the Long Mile this summer is making the week.

The walk's three jobs

In Brenvaeth the walk was *how you Turned*. In Ornthael it is three jobs that share roads, inns, and the one-week door, and do not share a reason.

Job	Who still walks	What they are buying	On the road
Devotion: the extra mile	People who already have a local Tree and still want Thaeloren	an origin-fall; a ribbon at the First Hand; the Motherwood in Eolthael	They could have Turned at home. They walk anyway.
Prestige: the First-Hand year	Lestrand money, a Bound signing-watch, a guild-ticket hinge, a wedding extra	being seen at the origin in a year they could have stayed home; a held-over winter as a product	Piety may be in the party. The Fair Hand attends as witnesses to a signing.
Necessity: the neighbour's week. It is still *the old mile* when the neighbour is a continent.	Tree-poor, Tree-sick, Tree-young; a missed fall this year; Heskoren this cohort; the Rain-Shadow after the core stopped	a Given-door in another town	They are making the week.

On the road, people said, "We are going to the Thallow," or "We Turn at Harrow's," or "The berth is for the child." Clerks keep the name Ornthael. Vaethorn still calls almost any walk "the waiting-road." Lestrand files the extra as "the First-Hand year" and the need as "the borrowed week." A Threnmaieth clerk wants the miles "on a roll."

They share the Near Mile in Hale-month. A devotion-column, a prestige household with too much luggage, a necessity-family who sold a year, and a Road-hand going the other way with a pot, can sleep in the same upper room. The innkeeper can tell who is which. They will not always tell you. The Far-Voiced ridge-cry still works. Someone calls, "The ford is wrong." Some who answer are pilgrims. Some are carts of wood.

The inversion, lived. Thaelvaeth is wood carried *out*. Brenvaeth was hearths walking *in*. In the Years of Hands both directions are traffic. A Road-hand and a tenth-year pass on a bank and do not owe each other a sermon. That passing *is* the two clocks in one afternoon.

Hands can un-Hands. A town Tree that sickens, or that fails a fall, puts a Hands-town back on the neighbour's week. A sick Tree is not the age ending. The wood has thinned. The Seat calls that thin soil. The town calls it this year.

The one-week door did not loosen. Miss Eolthael and the Given-door has shut, at home or at the origin. Struck remains the later mercy. There is still no second-chance year. The held-over nine-year-old is still the expensive mercy, and on the prestige-walk it is also a winter you can buy.

No extra mile crosses the storm-wall to Kumbaan.

What the Walk left behind

What the Walking built, the Hands still sleep in, and still use. A Hands-town that treats a mile-shrine as only a ruin is telling itself the road is over.

Mile-shrines

Still water, a flat top, often a name, often a ribbon. In a Hands-town the last one is frequently **in the square**, because the town grew around a graft planted beside the road, and the road's destination moved closer.

They are, at once:

- **Graves.** Walking facts. A Long-Lived who says "I walked" can still tell you which ford the name belongs to.
- **Waymarks.** Necessity-walkers still drink there. Road-hands still aim for the water.
- **Folklore.** Devotion leaves a ribbon. Hands-children climb.
- **Argument.** A warden wants it moved because it is in the way of the Leaf-Fall crowd. A house that still dates notes from a founding-summer wants it left. A neighbour who still walks wants it left for a different reason.

The stone does not know which story it is in. A ribbon is still not a leaf-colour.

Hands-towns that **pull a stone down** are doing theology with a hammer. The road no longer has to happen there. The graves stay in the ground. The next necessity-column will miss the water.

The upper room

An old inn's upper room has too many beds for the present trade. In Brenvaeth they were the two crowded months. In Ornthael they are:

- **Let to merchants.** The White Note's conversion; occupancy as competence.
- **Opened for Eolthael.** Devotion and prestige still swell a Near-Mile house for a fortnight.
- **Held.** A family said they would come. They did not. The innkeeper keeps the bed a year, then two, then as a habit that looks like hospitality and functions as a shrine *and* as proof the house remembers. Thilim still makes Seine's. Houses that became banks mostly stopped making them, except the one they will not let. A clerk writes "house custom" on a slate and means a grave.

The romance of the empty bed belongs to the Years of Hands. The name written for the held bed belongs to the Walking Years.

Roads that end at a Tree

The pilgrim-road was often the main road. A graft took beside it. The town grew around the canopy. **The road now ends at the Tree.** The last holy mile is a square. Beyond the boughs the old way is a cart-track to timber, a neighbour, a ford. Children are told the road goes to the Motherwood. It goes to the mill. Both can be true if you keep walking, which most Hands-children do not.

For that town, the road ends at the Tree, and the children Turn at home. The family from the next valley is still walking those stones, because the wood has not reached them. Same stones.

Other things the Walk left that a character notices

- Empty Salt-Walk berths in Eolthael, except the expensive ones and the holds that smell of wet earth out of season.
- A Far-Voiced calls from a ridge, in an old pattern, “The ford is wrong.” No column answers. A Road-hand does. Birds do.
- A sibling-pair who will not walk the same side of a road: one Given, one UnTurned. Folk still call the second one Kept. They are a split household’s grandchildren, keeping a courtesy they cannot date.
- Markets that still swell at an old mile-mark in Hale-month, then vanish, even when no column comes. The habit outlasted the road.
- A kitchen-knife on a ribbon in a Near-Mile house that will not name a saint. That is the nameless knife, and it is still not a museum piece.

Deathless houses’ road-past as present credit

Many deathless houses began as road-houses. That fate-shift is already in the past: inns that became banks, the same Long-Lived, a different fortune.

The founding-summer is the credit. “We kept you on the mile” is an origin-story that still collects. A century-loan written from a house-year is not only a dating-quirk. It is a claim that the porridge was real, the note was real, and the house is still the same house. No mortal court can audit a Long-Lived’s memory of a walk two hundred summers back. That is why the trusted note holds. It is also why a house can call a debt whose grandchildren do not remember the ford.

Two fates of the same origin, still standing.

- **The White Note House.** The reformation. Beds let to merchants. Paper on the quay. Ledan’s query from the house’s 200th summer (Cut-year 280) is already a clerk’s problem; the house is now in its 307th. The Held names are in the founding-book. Most of those beds are let. One is not, which is how a bank proves it used to be an inn.
- **The Third Hearth.** The house that stayed a hearth. Thilim still keeps it, still makes Seine’s bed, still knows which guests will be here at dark. The notes are smaller. The shrine is larger. Lestrand

says, “A bed-house that failed to become a bank.” Thilim keeps the hearth.

The long-house of books is still the deathless paying their own Tithe. The road-past is why anyone trusted them to endow in the first place: a house that remembered every debtor on the mile is a house you let steer a library.

The prestige-walk is now a product some houses sell. A held-over winter at the origin, once the frightened far mercy, is a First-Hand year you can book. The White Note did not invent that. They noticed the upper room was empty in Nethael and full of the wrong people in Eolthael, and they made a term for it. The year is assembled on three desks: **Netstrand charters the hull, the White Note writes the term, Orentel holds the berth.** Orenbren houses the sleep at the origin. Necessity-families still sign the old kind of note: eat now, pay on the home-walk, or when the child is grown, or when a sibling walks next year. Same paper, two jobs. The clerk who files both as occupancy is counting beds, not jobs.

Vaethorn will preach, “The houses abandoned the waiting-road.” The walk stopped being required in the core. The memory did not. The paper outlived the season. That is a reformation, and it still collects. Spreading Trees did not make the notes kind.

Heskoren as the live front

Today’s Heskoren is this year. Some cohorts still walk. A valley over, children stand under a town Tree. That is the wave in the present tense. Both can be true on the same road.

Harrow’s Green is the luckiest kind of Heskoren town: a scion that arrived in the Cut-year 200s, spoke a generation later, and has now Turned local children for a few generations. It is a neighbour’s canopy. From the ford, that canopy is in sight, and the towns past the ford are still waiting. New towns say, “We Turned at Harrow’s Tree before we had our own.” That is how they talk everywhere. On Heskoren it is the decade.

The Three Hamlets Past the Ford are the waiting kind. The Seat’s Cutting-leave already named them as thin soil. They send this year’s ten-year-olds to Harrow’s, or further if Harrow’s year is too full, or still the Long Mile if the neighbour is a stick in a pot. The college’s word for the wait stays in the college. They can see the canopy. Folk-right cutting is a temptation with a kitchen-knife. Most slips die. The ones that take are how the queue learns it is not the only horticulture in the world.

Old Ways host-rights start here as a collision, not a sermon. A graft in an old Taken-In green is a guest. A Cutting-leave is a mainland paper. The first meal comes first, or the planting is a claiming. The Door-Keepers and the Road-hands can both love the wood and still fight about the bowl.

Borrowed Turnings are the front’s ordinary year. Citizenship-by-local-witness is a Years-of-Hands practice. The town that *saw you* may be Harrow’s, while the hamlet that raised you is a different place.

Vouching-at-a-distance, invented to carry an *origin*-fall home, now carries a *neighbour*-fall home. Same three pillars. Shorter road. The unvouched Struck are still older than the grafts. A local canopy leaves them in the town.

A Seat sermon says, “Her will is still travelling.” Folk memory says, “The cart came late, the soil was called thin, we can see Harrow’s green from here.” Vaethorn will preach, “We wait because we are unworthy.” They wait because the wood is slow, the road is long, and the list was written in the Motherwood.

The Rain-Shadow on Maiethorn is the same wait on an older continent: waiting that went on after the core stopped. Ornsael is a town where this happens; its Tree Speaks most years, and its well is dropping. A west-road child after the Sacred Core has stopped walking is the same waiting, on the continent where the Hands first matured. Ornthael is still underway there.

What is strained

What a traveller can already see:

- The **First Seat** is old in the queue. It has authorized cuts since Cut-year 19, about three hundred and sixty-eight summers. Towns that can see a neighbour’s canopy have learned the horticulture-sentence by heart. Folk-right slips still happen. Threnmaieth still wants the college on the roll. The Seat is *heavy.*
- The **Road-hands** are thin on the Heskoren front. Living earth, mortal wood, a skeleton circuit, authority that expires a week out from the Motherwood. A live Tree is a quiet success no one writes down. A dead one is a name on a complaint. They plant what they were given leave to plant. They sleep in the town that was not chosen.
- **Waiting towns** hang on a single scion, or on a neighbour’s week. That is a civic crisis wearing a child’s summer.
- **Deathless houses** are richer in paper than in beds. The road-past is the credit. The upper room is the tell.

The pressure is already visible.

Entity	State	Why the pressure is already visible
First Seat	Peak power, pressure rising	about 368 years of the queue, since Cut-year 19; Threnmaieth proximity; folk-right cuttings that take; “thin soil” as a sentence towns can recite
Road-hands	Overextended at the Heskoren front	skeleton circuit; dead wood; authority that expires; blame when a pot dies; they sleep in the town not chosen
Waiting towns	Precarious	single scion or neighbour’s week; folk-right temptation; Kept-heavy / Struck-heavy as this year’s fact
Deathless houses	Peak, already reformed	road-past as un-auditable credit; concentration the rarity-cap fights; prestige-walk as product

A letting-slate from the White Note’s inland house

Kept by Mataero, who is junior to Ledan and has never made a Held bed. Cut-year 387; the house-year is not written on the recto. The verso is a copy of founding-names in an older hand.

> *Nethael closing. Upper room: twelve beds. Let: eight, to the wool out of Lestrand, term through Hale-month, pay on the quay-note. Open for Eolthael: four, First-Hand year, held-over child already spoken for, the mother paid the winter in advance. Occupancy will cover the loft.*
>
> *Do not let the north bed. House custom. The founding-book has a name I am not to copy onto a term. Ledan says the house is the same house. I say the house is the note. The bed is empty. Empty is not a shrine. Empty is a bed we are not charging for.*
>
> *Thilim’s third hearth still holds a far-cape name. We do not. We are not an inn that failed. We are the house that remembered long enough to be trusted.*
>
> *I do not ask which summer was holy. I ask which debtors will pay in Ledger-month. If the north bed is a grave, it is a grave that does not belong on a letting-slate.*

Folklore of the road, the Cut, and what the Walk left behind

Three teaching-stories. The bones stay the same. Each teller adds a last line.

The Child Who Counted Stones

The teaching-story of the road is a child counting stones. It is told on the Walking Years' three walks, and still told in Hands-towns that have never sent a child as far as the next valley. The count holds the romance and the graves together.

A child asked how far it was to the Tree.

The mother said, "As many days as there are stones."

The child walked, and counted. At each stone there was a ribbon, or there was not. The child asked if the ribbons were for people who had arrived.

The mother said, "Some."

They drank at the stones. They slept in their lee. They used them to know the water. The child kept count, and the count was the days, and the count was also the names the mother would not read aloud.

They arrived. A leaf fell, or the leaves hugged. The tellings do not agree, and it does not change the walk home.

On the way back the child asked to leave a ribbon.

The mother said, "We are not a stone yet."

The child left one anyway, on a stone that already had too many, and could not say, later, whether they had been adding a day or a grave.

A Long-Lived who keeps a hearth on that mile will tell you the child's name. They will not tell you which summer. They still make a bed they will not let.

The last lines. The bones above are common. The teller adds one of these:

- **Near Mile (devout).** A devout teller on the Near Mile says, "The Mother had counted them first. The stones were how she kept the days."
- **Near Mile (tired).** A tired teller on the Near Mile says, "It was a road. The stones were so you did not miss the water."
- **Salt Walk.** A Salt-Walk teller says, "The sea has no stones. That is why we charge for the berth."
- **Long Mile.** A Long-Mile teller says, "The mother was wrong. There are more stones than days. That is how you know you are on the Long Mile."
- **the Old Ways.** An Old Ways teller says, "The stones were there before the walk. The land was already counting."
- **the Watching.** A Watcher says, "The Tree saw every ribbon. The count was optional."

- **Hands-era children.** A Hands-era child says, “We climb them. There is a good one past the mill. The ribbon is just rag.”

Skeptics of every walk tell a short ending. One of them says, “There were not two counts. There were people, and weather, and a grove that would not come to you.”

Variants.

- On Maiethorn it is a walking-song; the chorus is only numbers.
- On Strandoren the quay-version starts at the berth and never finds a stone until the inland days, which is the joke and the bill.
- On Heskoren some tellers omit the arrival. The child is still counting when the story stops.
- A road-house telling ends on the Held bed, not the grove. Innkeepers think this is the real version.
- Kumbaan does not keep this story. A mainland guest who tells it is offered more supper, which is an answer.

The Branch That Came Away

The teaching-story of the Cut. Told about the First Cut, and still told in towns that have a Tree and a neighbour that does not. Sharing a Hand requires wounding a Hand, and the first copy invented both the local mercy and the wait.

A branch came away from the Tree.

A person carried it. They watered it. They put it in new ground.

It died.

They carried another. Or they carried the same one, and the tellings do not agree, and it does not change the ground.

It took.

The origin said, “That wood is ours.”

The new ground said, “That wood is here.”

Both were right, which is why there had to be a paper.

The paper said who may take the next branch. The Tree was not asked. The Tree kept choosing children under both canopies.

A child asked which Tree was the real one.

The mother said, “Count the Hands.”

The child counted two, then twenty, then the towns that were not in the count yet.

The child asked who was next.

The mother said, “The soil is thin there.”

The child could see the neighbour’s canopy from the ford, and could not say, later, whether they had been counting Hands or counting waits.

A Long-Lived who planted will tell you the child’s name. They will not tell you which summer. They still will not write who cut.

The last lines.

- **Folk (Near Mile).** A Near-Mile singer says, “The mother was the one who cut. The paper came after, like a fine.”
- **Clergy.** A Speaker says, “The warden cut with a leave the college had not invented yet. The paper is how we kept the next one alive.”
- **Devout.** A devout teller says, “The branch came away. No one stole a Hand. She gave one.”
- **the Watching.** A Watcher says, “We have always cut living wood. They named one cut the First. The count is optional.”
- **the Old Ways.** An Old Ways teller says, “The ground received a guest. The paper is a mainland word for a meal they did not stay for.”
- **the Fair Hand.** A Fair Hand clerk says, “The second carrying was a berth. The first was an unlicensed one. That is the whole hymn.”
- **Hands-era children (a Tree-town).** A child in a Tree-town says, “We Turn here. The neighbour walks. The story is why.”
- **Hands-era children (still walking).** A child who is still walking says, “We can see the canopy. The story does not plant anything.”

Skeptics of every house tell a short ending. One of them says, “There was not a Hand that learned to walk. There was wood, and a pot, and a college that got to the knife late.”

Variants.

- On Maiethorn it is told at Turning-Week in the Motherwood and in kitchens that keep a knife on a ribbon. The Motherwood version starts at “came away.” The kitchen version starts at “took.”
- On Strandoren the quay-version never finds a Tree until the hold is opened. The joke is the bill. The bill is not a joke inland.
- On Heskoren some tellers omit the taking. The child is still asking who is next when the story stops. Guest-reading tellers start at the meal. First-reading tellers start at the claiming.
- A Seat telling ends on the paper, not the ford. Speakers think this is the real version.

- Kumbaan does not keep this story. A mainland guest who tells it is offered more supper, which is an answer.

The Child Who Climbed the Stone

The teaching-story of what the Walk left behind. Told in the Years of Hands about mile-shrines that outlived the requirement, and still told in towns that have a Tree in the square and a neighbour that walks. Neighbours still use the stone as a mile. The canopy in the square is already Turning children.

A town grew a Tree beside the road.

The last stone of the old mile stood in what became the square. Children climbed it. A ribbon stayed on it, or did not. The tellings do not agree, and it does not change the scuff.

A warden said, “It is in the way of the crowd.”

A Long-Lived who keeps beds said, “It is a name.”

A child of the Tree-town asked how far it was to the Tree.

The mother said, “We are already here.”

A child from the hamlets past the ford came for a borrowed week, saw children on the stone, and asked how far it was to the Tree.

The Tree-town mother said, “We are already here.”

The waiting child said, “We can see your canopy from the ford.”

They climbed together. The waiting child left a ribbon. The Tree-town child could not say, later, whether they had been playing or counting a wait.

A Long-Lived who still makes a bed they will not let will tell you both children’s names. They will not tell you which summer. They still will not move the stone, and they still will not say the road is over.

The last lines.

- **Tree-town (devout).** A devout teller in a Tree-town says, “The Mother stopped the road when the Hand arrived. The stone is how we remember the waiting.”
- **Tree-town (tired).** A tired teller in a Tree-town says, “The Tree is here. The stone is in the way. We climb it because it is the right height.”
- **Waiting child / Heskoren.** A waiting child on Heskoren says, “We can see the canopy. The story does not plant anything.”
- **Lestrand.** A Lestrand clerk says, “The beds upstairs are let. The stone is a mile-mark the clerks have not billed yet.”

- **Innkeeper.** An innkeeper says, “The stone is the upper room. We did not let it. That is the whole hymn.”
- **the Watching.** A Watcher says, “The stone was already a stone. The Tree saw the climb. The count is optional.”
- **the Old Ways.** An Old Ways teller says, “The land was already counting. The square is a guest’s furniture.”
- **Road-hand.** A Road-hand says, “I water at it. I sleep in the town that was not chosen. I do not say queue.”
- **Hands-era children (who have never walked).** A Hands-era child who has never walked says, “There is a good one in the square. The ribbon is just rag.”

Skeptics of every house tell a short ending. One of them says, “There were not two roads. There was a stone, and a Tree, and a child who still had to walk.”

Variants.

- On Maiethorn it is told as a square-game; the chorus is only “already here.” The Rain-Shadow telling (Ornsael) omits the Tree-town mother, or makes her wrong.
- On Strandoren the quay-version starts in the loft and never finds a stone until inland, which is the joke and the bill.
- On Heskoren some tellers omit the climb. The waiting child is still asking how far when the story stops. Guest-reading tellers start at the meal under the stone. First-reading tellers start at the claiming of the square.
- A Seat telling ends on the crowd, not the ford. Speakers think this is the real version: the stone should move.
- A White-Note telling ends on the north bed. Juniors think this is the real version: empty is not a shrine.
- Kumbaan does not keep this story. A mainland guest who tells it is offered more supper, which is an answer.

Pages a party can find

Six short pages sit on shelves a party can visit. Each was written by someone inside the world, in that person’s own words, and each is a page or two long. A page can be wrong about the world. Three are in Rothallo: at the school beside the Book’s house, in the Book’s house itself, and at the gate clerk’s desk. Three are on Molevad’s long-house shelf in Lestrand, where the Pourers keep their library. People name that building by the house; it has no other name.

The school primer

First Lessons at the Close School is kept at the school beside the Book's house in Rothallo. The children of the Closed houses learn their letters there, and other families inside the walls can send a child if they pay. Volnai, the teacher, works there. Asked about the primer, Volnai says, "This is what the children learn in their first year. A hug is rare. Take a copy if you like; I write out more every summer."

It is the lesson the Close teaches its children, in questions and answers they say back, and Volnai believes every line of it. It teaches that most children receive a colour, that a hug is rare, and that the Tree keeps back a hugged child for something better than a colour. It also teaches the seating at a Closed table, who holds the keys, what happens to a Closed child who receives a colour, and why households with a Condition get the heavier turns of work.

The primer is wrong about the hug. Being hugged is common; the shares are in "Kind and Condition." What is rare is a family like the Closed houses, which has stayed Kept on purpose for generations. The primer gives no numbers of its own.

A history of the Closing

The Keeping of the Grove is kept in the Book's house in Rothallo, on the same shelf as the Book of Tithes. Delamem, who keeps the Book of Tithes, works there. Asked about it, Delamem says, "It is our history of the Seat. You may read it here. The Book's house does not lend."

It is the Closed Heirs' own account of the Closing, and it speaks well of the Closed Seat. It says the gate at the grove kept order at the one Tree, that children turned away at the gate went home unharmed, and that the riders who dug up and burned the new grafts were stewards bringing back stolen wood. It says Hildal, a clerk, chose to keep the Book rather than fight for the grove, and that the Closed families moved a day's walk away into Rothallo, in the country that became Orenbren.

The facts on the page match the history above. The war ran from Cut-year 19 to Cut-year 38; the writer counts those years from the cutting and calls them the nineteenth and the thirty-eighth year. The page does not name who made the First Cut, and it does not put a year on the Tree. What it leaves out is the cost. It does not say that children walked the whole Long Mile and went home UnTurned because the gate refused them, or that people died on the roads. It calls a child sent home "Kept" and "whole," as if that were no loss.

Minutes from the long-house

Minutes of a Gift is kept on Molevad's long-house shelf in Lestrand. It is one meeting copied out of the minute-book. Molevad keeps the minute-book and the key to the shelf. Asked about it, Molevad says,

“This is one meeting. K. said it could be read. The rest of the book stays shut.”

These are the circle’s own minutes of one willing gift: one year, the fifth that a Long-Lived member called K. gives. The circle asks five years of a member in all, one year on each night, and K. is on the last. K. asks to give that year, names it, and says why: K. is tired of carrying a husband’s death. The circle asks three times whether the gift is K.’s own wish. K. gives the year into the cup with one drop of blood. Afterward K. still knows the husband’s name and face from before the marriage and remembers nothing from that year. K.’s papers from that year go onto the shelf, and the minutes end with the long-house seating K. one year younger, five in all. The minutes record how the circle will describe its god this decade, that one reading held two members’ memories of the same summer, and that nobody asked to stop. They end with the circle’s claim that every gift is freely given and that the circle made the god it gives to. That claim is the circle’s belief. The minutes do not settle whether it is true.

A scene from a play

The Heir’s Seat is kept on Molevad’s long-house shelf as a copy in the common speech, made by members of Molevad’s circle. Molevad holds the key. Asked about it, Molevad says, “People borrow it to put on in a yard at Turning-Week. Bring it back when you’re done.”

It is a scene players can perform straight from the page, with a table, a tall chair, and a lantern. No theatre is needed. Two cousins of a Closed house were Turned in the same week. One was hugged. The other received a storm-grey leaf. A clerk of the Book strikes the Given cousin from the heir-roll and writes their name again on the page of turns of work. The Given cousin is sent to the far end of the table. The hugged cousin is given the heir’s chair and a gate key.

The scene does not say which cousin got the better life. The hugged cousin keeps the seat and has to stay inside the walls and hold the keys. The Given cousin loses the seat, owes heavier work, and can walk out of the gate any morning. The play ends on a question nobody in it answers.

A poem

A Room I Do Not Go Into is kept on Molevad’s long-house shelf. The copy has no name on it; it was written by a Long-Lived writer. Asked about it, Molevad says, “One of us wrote it. Read it.”

The poem is about a person who has five summers they no longer remember, and a room they walk past and do not open. People who read it often ask whether it is about the cup, where the Pourers give years of memory away one year at a time. If anyone asks Molevad, or any other Long-Lived person at the shelf, whether the poem is about the cup, that person will not say whether it is.

A road song

The Day-Road Count is kept at the gate clerk's desk at Rothallo's gate, written on the back of an old sleep-line sheet. Breolnir, the gate clerk, who writes down who slept in the beds outside the wall, works there. Asked about it, Breolnir says, "The school children sing it on the road to the wood. Pilgrims keep asking for the words, so I keep a copy."

It is a counting song the school beside the Book's house teaches children to sing as they walk the day's road from Rothallo to the Awakening Tree. It counts the Kept the way the Close teaches: at every town Tree on the road, and even under the Awakening Tree, every child gets a colour and nobody is hugged. Only at the end, back at Rothallo's wall, does the song find a hug.

The song is wrong. A tree-warden sees children hugged at every Leaf-Fall, in every town, and under the Awakening Tree itself, and a warden who hears children singing it on the road can tell it is wrong. The song gives no numbers.

Book VII

Powers and Places

The Fifteen Powers

The fifteen

Fifteen named powers stand on the three large continents. Kumbaan is an isolate with a table, a moon, and a storm-wall. The Isle is a people at home.

Beneath the fifteen the world still swarms: marches, free towns, petty Tree-seats, wild that no one has named as a power. Fifteen is how many powers are worth naming.

Continent	Reach	How many	Why that many
Maiethorn	full	**6**	old heart; a clutch of kingdoms competing for the grove and the Old Crossing
Strandoren	high	**5**	a constellation of coasts and compacts
Heskoren	thin	**4**	fewer, poorer, scattered; long wild between Trees
The Sundering Isle	near-none	**0**	a people at home

The name a polity gives itself is two old words glued, worn the way that land talks. The one-line in the table is the meaning. **The Four Continents** already lists what the land-names mean, and the three corners. **Language and Naming** has the word-box if you need another.

Pronunciation: **CAPS** = stress; `ae` = “ay”; `th` = *thin*.

Every polity sets three axes independently:

- **Theology**: how gift-devout it is. One end is ardent Motherfaith, folding the gifts into worship and tending. The other is frank secular pragmatism.
- **Reach**: Tree-rich core, or Tree-poor edge.
- **Governance**: how far the state reaches onto the person. Light guild self-rule is the world’s warm default. At the far end, a crown that writes its subjects down.

The fifteen at a glance

Axes: **T**heology (Motherfaith gift-devotion) · **R**each · **G**overnance. ● high · ◖ mid · ○ low.

Each power stands on ground that already had a job, and that job is still under it: a pilgrimage-country, a salt quay, a guest-grove.

Polity	Continent	T	R	G	One-line feel	Older job of the ground
Threnmaieth	Maiethorn	●	●	●	the Mother's Reckoning; census as care	origin pilgrimage-towns *under* a roll; seat Maiethlir
Maiethvael	Maiethorn	●	●	○	the Gift-Realm: plenty, no list	origin pilgrimage-country that furnishes
Orenbren	Maiethorn	●	●	◖	the Witness-Hearths: lodging as power; does not own the Tree	origin pilgrimage-town
Saelthael	Maiethorn	●	◖	○	the Sown Tree: Rain-Shadow still planting	Rain-Shadow walk-hold
the Hinge Shore	Maiethorn	◖	●	○	Old Crossing face; classifies the hull	salt-adjacent Old-World quays
Lirorn	Maiethorn	◖	●	◖	the Thaw-Land: range and snowmelt	ridge-roads
Lestrand	Strandoren	○	●	○	the Ledger Coast: priced and free	salt quay; seat Orentel
Brenledd	Strandoren	○	●	○	the Hearth-League: many charters, one compact	salt / river towns between houses
Leddvael	Strandoren	○*	●	◖	the Reckoned Gift: Fair Hand as civic rite	salt quay with a signing-watch
Trenledd	Strandoren	○	●	●	the Worn Count: a roll with the hymn worn off	road-end Tree-towns *filed*
Netstrand	Strandoren	◖	●	○	the Night Shore: west water, Heskoren trade	salt quay; hulls and west-water berths
Vaethorn	Heskoren	●	○	○	the Waiting Lands: scarce gift, hot faith	pilgrim-edge; seat Eolvaeth
Ornled	Heskoren	○	○	○	the Outer Ledger: secular frontier, no congregation-net	waiting cluster without a gospel

Polity	Continent	T	R	G	One-line feel	Older job of the ground
Vaelhesk	Heskoren	◖ **	○	○	the Far Yield: Old Ways host-rights	guest-grove
Saelvaeth	Heskoren	◖	○	◖	the Sown Waiting: the live front as a march	live-front Tree-town

* **Leddvael** is low on *Motherfaith* and high on the Fair Hand. Theology here still means gift-devotion. The Fair Hand is civic rite, and the table keeps its three axes. ** **Vaelhesk** is the same shape with the Old Ways.

Three other corners sit on the map: **Maiethvael** (devout, rich, lightly governed), **Trenledd** (surveillance with no faith to sanctify it), **Ornled** (secular frontier on Heskoren).

Every one of the fifteen is a hearth-country. Saelthael is sand-country. Lirorn is a watershed. The Hinge Shore and Netstrand are shores. Vaelhesk keeps host-rights.

The Watching stays a heartland heresy *inside* Maiethorn districts. Leddvael is the one power that made a rival faith *civic*, and even there the Book-hands have no seat.

How they sit

Maiethorn. Threnmaieth coils near the sacred centre and wants everyone on the **Threnhael**. The Threnhael is its census of persons, and it calls that roll holy. Its seat is Maiethlir. It is a thaw-river Hand. The planted Tree now Turns the town's own children. Maiethvael is the old gift-country that shares the Mother and keeps no list. The hymns are the same. The paper is not. Orenbren is the lodging-cluster of the Near Mile (the week's door to the origin), and the work is civic lodging. The First Seat stays in the Motherwood beside Orenbren. Saelthael is the leeward east, still walking west after the core stopped. The Hinge Shore faces Strandoren across the Old Crossing. Lirorn holds the Rain-Wall that divides the waters. Fox-of-the-Snows and Tengu hearths are *densest* here. Lirorn remains the watershed.

Strandoren. Lestrand is the premier coast. Its seat is Orentel. It is the Salt Quay. The White Note sits on the third quay and writes the terms. Brenledd is the compact of towns that got tired of being priced by one set of houses. Leddvael made the Fair Hand a civic rite on a different stretch of signing-water. Trenledd is the wealthy interior that started counting tickets and did not stop. Netstrand faces the open ocean toward Heskoren and, in stories, the storm-wall.

Heskoren. Vaethorn is the waiting-gospel. Its seat is Eolvaeth. It is a pilgrim-edge. Saelvaeth is the live edge of the wave. Natai is the march-town. Harrow's Green is a grove-town in that march.

Vaelhesk keeps host-rights on old greens, and the land is the seat. Ornled is Vaethorn with the faith burned out instead of up. It has the same thin Trees, and no congregation to catch you. The Three Hamlets Past the Ford sit on the seam. They can see Harrow's canopy (Saelvaeth luck) and still hear Vaethorn guilt and Vaelhesk refusal. Folk names *Brenod · Vaelun · Ornath*; the Seat still does not use them.

Two lists of the same fifteen

A Seat clerk and a Lestrand **factor** do not issue the same map. A factor works for a house and prices routes and berths. **Orthopraxy**, belonging by the rite you keep, is the peace. The *list* is the tell.

> ***From a Cut-year minute, First Seat (Cut-year 387).*** *Threnmaieth names itself the Reckoning and would name us. Maiethvael will not be named to them and still gives the extra mile. Orenbren lodges what we do not house. Saelthael still walks, which the origin finds inconvenient. The Hinge Shore takes the Old Crossing. Lirorn takes the thaw. Across the water the factor's five: Lestrand, the Brenledd compact, Leddvael which files a Bound as a civic virtue, Trenledd which keeps a roll and will not call it a Threnhael, Netstrand which sells the west. On the far reach: Vaethorn waiting, Saelvaeth planting, Vaelhesk feeding a first meal we did not authorize, Ornled which will not say her name and will not keep a list either. Kumbaan is not a land we graft. We do not write it.*
>
> ***From a house-year docket, a Lestrand factor.*** *Price the Hinge Shore and do not argue hymns with Maiethvael. Orenbren's beds are a market that calls itself a duty. Avoid Trenledd's roll unless you like being written. Leddvael will sign; that is cheaper than faith. Brenledd is many tickets. Netstrand quotes the far crossing like a pilgrimage. Heskoren: Vaethorn pays in blessing, Ornled in slate, Vaelhesk in a meal you had better eat, Saelvaeth in whatever the queue did this year. The Isle is a tale. We do not book it.*

Neither list is complete. Both are true of the speaker.

The three corners

Threnmaieth: the Tallied Crown

(THREN-my-eth · thren "to count" + maieth "Mother" = "the Mother's Reckoning." Theology high · reach high · governance high; the darkest corner)

Threnmaieth is a pious, Tree-rich core kingdom that is also **Watchful**. It keeps a register of persons: a **census of persons and their Conditions**. Trenledd keeps a roll of persons too. The difference is that the Tallied Crown calls its roll holy, and Trenledd does not. Set that in the wealthiest, most devout, most Tree-dense land, and the roster is kept as **sanctified duty**. The Mother's gifts are precious and must be *accounted for.* The other two corners have injustices you can name and resent. This one dresses its injustice in the two things the world most trusts, faith and plenty.

Law. The record is held on people: every subject and their gift written down. Guild rolls and tax ledgers exist everywhere. This is a **census of persons**, framed at home as reverent stewardship of the Mother's blessings and lived as surveillance. Reach is high, so there is a great deal to count: dense Given, dense guilds, abundant Long-Lived whose memory the crown *distrusts because it isn't the crown's*. That is the Tallied Crown's deepest tell. It will not rely on the three pillars the rest of the world runs on (Long-Lived memory, Bound word, Far-Voiced feeling). Living memory answers to itself. A ledger answers to the crown. The **unvouched are hunted and the Struck pursued to be catalogued.** The Bound are watched far past their real hazard: stigma dressed as safety. The Inviolate Will means the Whisper cannot command, and the roster's own clerks know it. Devotion supplies the justification a bare Watchful crown lacks: *you would not hide a gift from the Mother, so why hide it from her stewards?*

Economy. Tithe-need turned to leverage, and consecrated. The crown provides Tithe-upkeep **efficiently, even generously** (a pious, rich state can afford to), but *holds* what it provides: the green, the novelty, the outlets, the Stilled medicine, all furnished through channels the crown controls and can withhold. A population whose staying-whole runs through the state **cannot afford to refuse it**. That is the most complete control anywhere, and here it wears a halo. To receive your Tithe-provision is to receive the Mother's bounty through her appointed hands. To be cut off is framed as *your* lapse, not the crown's lever. Its deathless-house finance is excellent and centuries-deep. The Long-Lived here are courtiers and crown-archivists as much as bankers, their incorruptible memory bent to the census rather than free to check it.

Daily life. Sacrament and census run together. A child's Turning is a **joyous holy day that is also a state registration**. The colour that falls is celebrated with a hymn *and* recorded by a clerk. Marriages of heritable Conditions (Two-Bodied bloodlines especially) are *noticed*, encouraged or discouraged, filed. The medicine that furnishes a Tithe is excellent and runs through the crown's channels. A household whose **bloodline and upkeep are both on file** cannot easily refuse the crown anything: domestic surveillance with a blessing said over it. The Kept are *pitied* here in the Warm's way *and* recorded in the Watchful's, passed over by the Mother, and noted as such.

Its injustice. The worst of both high axes, each excusing the other. The devotion sanctifies the surveillance (*it is reverence to be counted*). The surveillance enforces the devotion (*to refuse the count is impiety*). There is no clean villain. A wealthy, faithful, orderly people believe that accounting for the Mother's gifts is the highest form of tending them, and that belief makes the machinery of control

almost impossible to resist. Elsewhere the roll reads as chilling, because only two crowns keep one. Here the faith is what lets it feel like grace.

The seat. Maiethlir *(my-eth-LEER)* is in the Sacred Core. It is a thaw-river Hand. The older job of this ground is the extra mile. Devotion still sends people on that walk. The Threnhael is the roll laid on that walk. Thaeloren stands outside this crown. It is the Tree in the Motherwood. The First Seat stays in the wood beside Maiethlir.

Lestrand: the Ledger Coast

(leh-STRAND · ledd "to reckon" + strand "shore" = "the Reckoning Coast." Theology low · reach high · governance low)

Lestrand is a dense, Tree-rich merchant power. The Trees are mature and many, the Given are dense, and the faith is worn *lightly.* Deep markets, thin welfare, and a cool, transactional read on becoming. It shares the Waiting Lands' light-touch governance: no crown writes anyone down. Where the Lands' light state leaves a *gap the faith fills*, the Coast's light state leaves a *space the guilds fill.*

Law. The world's warm default at its most developed: **guild self-rule** carried as far as it goes. The state is a charter-granting council of merchant houses and craft-guilds. It charters the Stilled's guild and the element-guilds and watches the guild, never the individual. Citizenship-by-witness runs *smoothly* here because reach is high: abundant Long-Lived notaries, Bound whose sworn word closes every contract, Far-Voiced on every dock and in every court. The three pillars are not reverence here. They are **infrastructure**, the machinery that lets a huge commercial city run on trust without a register. The Struck are vouched-in briskly, as efficiency rather than grace, because an unvouched person is a transaction that cannot clear. The Inviolate Will is cited less as sacred bedrock than as sound commercial law: a Bound's contract binds property, not persons, and the Coast likes that line because it makes the Bound the perfect notary.

Economy. The richest of the three corners, and the coolest. This is where **deathless banking** is most developed: deathless houses whose trusted notes are the nearest thing the world has to a gold standard, century instruments, the whole endow-not-inherit loop running at scale. The great endowed libraries and universities cluster here, funding the Long-Lived's own novelty-Tithe. Self-paying Conditions prosper (the Answered crafts, the Two-Bodied haulage and courier trades, the Stilled surgeons) because their labor *is* their upkeep and the market pays for the labor. **Tithe-provision is a private market, not a public good.** You buy your green, your novelty, your outlet, and if you can afford it you stay whole in comfort. **Its injustice is the market's.** The provided-for Tithe-poor get *thin welfare in a rich city*, the starkest have-and-have-not gap anywhere. The **shadow economy** (smuggled green, black-market novelty, sold vouching, off-book contracts feeding the Given-Over) runs biggest here because the legitimate market is biggest here. The concentration risk the deathless pose is sharpest: a

handful of houses that never die, quietly steering the wealthiest polity through patronage that never disperses.

Daily life. Excellent Condition-medicine (the great Stilled infirmaries and deathless-endowed hospitals are *here*, in the rich core), for those who can reach it. The queue outside it is longest here too. Family life shrugs at theology. A **marriage market that reads Conditions as assets**: a Two-Bodied bloodline is a trade dynasty, a Long-Lived match is a century of credit, and the aching Long-Lived marriage gets weighed coolly as grief against advantage. The Turning is a civic and commercial milestone more than a sacrament. A family's Leaf-Fall is watched for what guild the child's colour opens. It is not warm. It is free, and prosperous.

Its injustice. The coolest of the three. Nothing is *policed*. Your marriage, your gift, your faith are your own. Everything is *priced*, and a person who cannot pay slides with a whole rich city stepping around them. The Coast will never file you or conscript you. It will let you fade if you run out of coin, and feel that it owed you nothing.

The seat. Orentel *(OREN-tel)* is on the Old Crossing. It is a salt-quay city. The White Note House sits on the third quay, north side, and writes the terms. Orentel holds the seat.

Vaethorn: the Waiting Lands

(VAETH-orn · vaeth "the waiting" + orn "land" = "the Waiting Land." Everyday Wetorn. Theology high · reach low · governance low)

Vaethorn is a broad, thinly-peopled land at the world's Tree-poor margin. The faith burns hottest *because* the Trees are scarce. The ruling mood is *waiting*: for a graft to take, a distant Tree to be reached, a gift that may never fall. Where the Trees are few and young, more children come away Kept, more people are Struck later and alone, and the Motherfaith answers that scarcity with *more* devotion, not less: pilgrimage, longing, and a theology built around waiting for a gift that may not come.

Law. Governance is almost absent. No crown reaches the individual, and custom outruns written law the way it does on any frontier. Citizenship is witnessed in the oldest, most literal way: a settlement small enough that everyone *was* there when you Turned. Thin reach makes that fragile. With few Long-Lived to remember and few Bound to vouch, the three pillars that make proof-by-people work are stretched thin. The **unvouched Struck** (a person who changed alone, with no guild to catch them and few witnesses to stand for them) is a constant, aching problem the Waiting Lands meet with faith rather than machinery. A feared Condition here is more likely to be met with a rope or a blessing than a licence, because there is no guild to issue one.

Economy. Little formal Tithe-infrastructure and few specialists, but the theology reframes the frontier's poverty as *charity*. Where a secular frontier improvises Tithe-provision as barter and favor,

the Waiting Lands do it as **alms and congregation**. The venting a Far-Voiced needs happens at worship. The green a Taken-In needs is furnished by neighbours who count it a sacred duty. The Taken-In whom rich cities keep at arm's length are here the honoured **backbone of the land**. Working the living earth *is* the holy economy. It is commons-minded generosity with almost nothing to fund it: real warmth, real want, and a thin edge where the provided-for Tithe-poor slide with only prayer for a net.

Daily life. Thin ceremony made enormous by devotion. A child's Turning at a small, hard-won grafted Tree is the event of a decade, held as a joyous, anxious sacrament. The **Kept child is felt most sharply here**, because in a land starved of the gift, to be passed over reads (wrongly, and cruelly) as being passed over *by the Mother herself.* Medicine is a travelling stiller if the settlement is lucky and a rope-and-prayer if it is not. The core-vs-edge inequity is at its widest here. Families are warm, mixed, and self-reliant. A lapsing Condition with no infirmary to reach is a frontier tragedy the faith consoles but cannot cure.

Its injustice. Not a boot. A **guilt**. The scarcity of the gift becomes a theology of *unworthiness*. The Kept wonder what they lacked. The Struck wonder why the Mother came to them at the wrong door and alone. A hard, quiet piety can shade into treating want as a spiritual failing. The Waiting Lands are the kindest place in the world to a whole neighbour and the loneliest to an unvouched one.

The seat. Eolvaeth *(ay-ohl-VAYTH)* is behind the Strandoren-facing coast. It is a pilgrim-edge vale. People walk *here to wait*. The Tree is not a certainty. Eolvaeth holds Vaethorn's seat. Harrow's Green is a grove-town in Saelvaeth's march, and Natai is the march-town. The Three Hamlets Past the Ford sit on the seam.

The twelve

The twelve have seats: a capital, a city, a town, or, in Vaelhesk, the land. Six charter-towns around Raitin stay unnamed. The person who governs Trenledd stays unnamed. Vaelhesk names no city. The land is the seat. Harrow's Green is a grove-town in Saelvaeth's march, and Natai is the march-town. The First Seat stays in the wood.

Maiethvael: the Gift-Realm

(my-ETH-vayl · maieth "Mother" + vael "gift" = "the Mother's Gift.") Theology high · reach high · governance **low**. Everyday *Maiethvael*; people **Maiethvael-folk**. Threnmaieth is the other power.

Maiethvael is an old, Tree-dense Motherland realm that treats Tithe-provision as **public tending**. Congregation and guild furnish the greens, the halls, and the medicine. Citizenship is witnessed in the

world's warm default. There is no Threnhael here. They will tell you counting persons is a failure of trust in the three pillars. The hymns are the same ones Threnmaieth sings. The paper is not.

Site. This is full-reach Maiethorn country, in sight of the pilgrimage weather. The older job of the ground is an origin pilgrimage-country that *furnishes*. The extra mile is kept as hospitality.

How it formed. Gift-integration never accepted a census. When Threnmaieth began to write people down, Maiethvael kept the older proof: you belong because you were seen to Turn, and you stay whole because your neighbours tend what you were Given. The state is light on purpose. Faith and guild fill the gap.

Structure. Guild self-rule runs under ardent practice. Recruiting goes by office, faith, and Condition-lean. The Watching persists in old districts as it does elsewhere on Maiethorn.

Goals. Keep the gift hale without writing the gifted down. Furnish generously. Pity the Kept in a land that teaches that a hug at the Tree is rare. The land is wrong about that, but it teaches it. The pity is a slight, and it has no thin-Tree excuse.

Its injustice. Not a boot. A **social tax of piety**. Warmth is real and so is the bill: fall out of congregation and the net goes with it, and there is no crown to appeal to. The Kept here are pitied in *plenty*. Threnmaieth at least files them. Maiethvael loves them and cannot stop measuring what they missed.

Seat. Seinbrun *(SAYN-brun)* is the capital. It is a large city in the warm core, more than a day from Maiethlir; how much more is not recorded. People say the Gift-Realm. A traveler can spend the first day below Maiethlir's Down Gate among Gift-folk and still not have arrived. The city furnishes a hall, a green beside it, and medicine. There is no roll. A neighbour says a given name. Vuthbraen keeps the hall. Raermu keeps the basket. Breillai left the hymn, and the green went with it. The First Seat stays in the wood. Smaller towns around Seinbrun stay unnamed.

Orenbren: the Witness-Hearths

(or-EN-bren · oren "to witness" + bren "hearth" = "the witnessing-hearth.") Theology high · reach high · governance mid-low. Everyday *Orenbren*; people **Orenbren-folk**. The inns grew a country. The First Seat stays in the wood. Thaeloren stands in that wood.

Orenbren is the civic cluster of the **Near Mile**. Lodging-squares, upper rooms, and old road-houses stayed hearths when the walk stopped being required in the core. Pilgrims still come (the extra mile, the First-Hand year: the prestige origin-walk). Orenbren houses them. Its power is a monopoly on *beds within a week's walk of the grove*.

The First Seat sits in the Motherwood beside this power and remains a college. Threnmaieth would like the lodging-rolls. Orenbren witnesses who slept. Colour stays off that witness.

The capital is **Rothallo** *(roh-THAL-oh)*. It is a walled city one day's walk from the Motherwood. People still say the **Inner Close**, and the Close. The walls answer to those names. It is the same place. It stays inside Orenbren. Closed Heirs still rank the Conditioned by a Book of Tithes, kept inside the walls. Orenbren calls the arrangement a guest-compact: its inns lodge anyone outside the wall, and the Book rules inside it. The Close records who owes. Orenbren records who slept. Neither copies the other's records. The First Seat is in the wood, beyond the wall. A Hand stands inside the city, and the city has no speaker of its own for it; a warden of the First Seat may come in for Turning-Week and Speak the fall. The Low Wall, in Other Places, is a different quarry in a fold nearby. It was found already in the ground. The Third Hearth is a road-house three days out. The Mill-hold is where the race and the roots share the water. It is the mill-town. Nelath is where the walk stopped. It is the road-end. Rothallo is the capital.

Site. This is the approach-country of Maiethorn's Sacred Core. The older job of the ground is an **origin pilgrimage-town**. A Tree stands at the centre of each square. The road used to go further, and now it ends in a festival season.

How it formed. Walking-era hearths federated around the one-week door. When the Years of Hands made the origin-walk optional, the beds did not empty. They changed jobs. A lodging-network learned it could levy, charter, and speak as one without becoming clergy.

Structure. It is a compact of hearth-towns, with town-wardens and lodging-guilds. Any Kind may take up the work. Deathless houses exist here as *patrons of beds*. Rothallo is the capital. The Third Hearth is a road-house three days out. Brenthael is the neighbour Hand. Its children Turn at home, and the Near Mile goes on past its Tree. Delamem keeps the Book. Talnin is the heir whose tenth year is not finished. A neighbour in the city says a given name. A clerk says the house first. *Closed* on a roster is a rank.

Goals. Keep the extra mile possible. Charge for it in coin, duty, or hymn; the mix is the local argument. Keep Orenbren's own name, beside the Seat and beside the Reckoning.

Its injustice. Hospitality as rent. Devotion priced as board. A pilgrim who cannot pay the First-Hand year still needs the hug. The upper room has learned what a bed is worth in Eolthael.

Saelthael: the Sown Tree

(SAYL-thale · sael "sowing" + thael "Tree" = "the sown Tree.") They are still the Motherland. Theology high · reach **mid-low**, a country of wells · governance low. Everyday *Saelthael*; people **Saelthael-folk**. Shares *sael* with Saelvaeth on purpose: sowing on two continents. Where the wood has reached, the work is still unfinished, even at the origin. Larbril is the city. Ornsael is the well-town a party meets in this dry country. Fox of the Sands hearths are common here because the ground is dry.

Saelthael is the Rain-Shadow, leeward east of the Rain-Wall. The towns sit in dry hills and sand-country, at wells and at whatever graft will take. The continent is full-reach, and the wood is thinner. The core stopped walking. Saelthael did not. Children still go west in the neighbour's week (walking to a neighbour's Tree), or further, because a well-Tree is not a certainty.

Fox of the Sands hearths are densest here because the ground is dry. A town with *no* fox-born would be the thing worth asking about.

Site. This is Maiethorn's dry east. The older job of the ground is a **Rain-Shadow walk-hold**. That is the west-road after the core stopped. Ornthael means Tree-land. It names the years when a town Tree is the ordinary way to Turn, and those years are unfinished even on the origin continent. **Larbril** *(LAR-bril)* is where the west road meets the Well-wash, short of the pass. It is a medium city. Walking west, the Shelf-gate is still ahead. Walking east, the dry is in front of you. Brormei stands at the meeting and says what the wash is this week. **Ornsael** stays the smaller well-town, farther into the dry. Its drink is a well. The Dry Stair is another rise, on its own ground.

How it formed. Tree-seats formed around wells and slow grafts (Cut-years 0 to 80 were slower here: dirt, not a different gospel). When origin-squares became Hands-country, sand-country kept the habit of going to a healthier canopy. The habit grew a polity: the people who still sow.

Structure. Custom is light. Town-wardens keep it, and wells are a civic fact. Any Kind may take up the work. The Taken-In are honoured as they are on any thirsty land: the backbone of the work.

Goals. Keep grafts alive in thin soil. Keep the west-road open. Name the waiting as thin soil.

Its injustice. The motherland treats their waiting as a **local soil-problem** (true as far as it goes) and as a slight against the origin. Plenty is next door. The pilgrimage is the older job of this ground, and they are still walking it. Vaethorn-guilt was imported to sand that never asked for it.

The Hinge Shore

Theology **mid** · reach high · governance low. **The Hinge Shore** is both the spoken and written name; its people are **Hinge-folk**. An older dockets-form *Eolstrand* is retired: *Eoloren, Eolthael,* and *Eolvaeth* already carry the hinge-root across an era, a month, and a city.

The Hinge Shore is Maiethorn's western ports on **the Old Crossing** toward Strandoren. The Old Crossing is the oldest trade route in the world. It is ancient and rich, and less frantic than the Ledger Coast. They decide whether a hull is pilgrim, pot, person, or cargo before anyone across the water prices it. Lestrand **prices** the crossing. The Hinge Shore **sorts** it. Faith is worn *thinner* here than in Maiethvael because a dock teaches categories. The Trees are still healthy because this is still the Motherland.

Selkie families are common on these quays, as they are on any old water. They keep hearths here. The **Hush-rate** is charged as old custom. They will not call it a victory.

Site. This is the face of the Old Crossing. The older job of the ground is salt-adjacent Old-World quays. That is the Salt Walk's *other* shore. People embarked *from* Strandoren, and they landed here. **Votaer** *(VOH-tayr)* is the port, because the crossing is why the people are there. It is one of the largest cities on this coast. It faces Orentel across the water. Tumair writes the hull: pilgrim, pot, person, or cargo. Lertho charges the Hush-rate on the same water. The White Note writes its terms on Orentel's third quay. Towns and villages along the rest of the shore stay unnamed.

How it formed. Port-kings and charter-harbours grew from the crossing. The tongue stays conservative because the grove is at their backs, and theology stays mid because Lestrand is in front of them. A hinge has two sides. The Grey Summer taught the pious shore how to step around a fade *without putting the blessing down.*

Structure. It is a guild-coast, with a light state and old houses. Any Kind may take up the work. Far-Voiced on every quay as infrastructure, same as Strandoren, with more hymn left in the voice.

Goals. Keep the Old Crossing the world's highway. Classify the hull before anyone prices it. Broker pilgrimage-traffic and cargo under the Shore's own categories. Charge the Hush-rate. Say the blessing if a customer wants one.

Its injustice. Category as fate. Lestrand will let you fade and feel it owed you nothing. The Hinge Shore will *bless you as it files you*, and a Tithe-poor household fails in sight of the pilgrimage-road with a hymn still in the air.

Lirorn: the Thaw-Land

(leer-ORN · lir "thaw; water that runs again" + orn "land" = "thaw-land.") Theology mid · reach high · governance **mid**. Everyday *Lirorn*; people **Lirorn-folk**. The range divides Maiethorn's waters. The name is the snowmelt.

Lirorn is Maiethorn's Rain-Wall. The snow is high, the towns are rope-and-wing, and the rivers begin as thaw. Reach is still full. Grafts take in the valleys and the sheltered shelves. The weather is bigger, and the state is a **watershed holding**. Lowlands drink Lirorn's spring. Ridges notice.

Tengu ridge-towns and Fox-of-the-Snows hearths sit densest here. Mixed Kinds on every shelf. A lowlander arriving on foot is a guest who climbed.

Site. This range divides the continent's watersheds. The older job of the ground is the ridge-roads. They used to be walking-paths to the grove. Stones sit in the high squares, and some roads now end at a local Tree. **Tasain** *(tah-SAYN)* holds the seat. The levy is taken where the west road comes down. It is a walled town in a sheltered valley below the Shelf-gate. The town gate is Tasain's own. The Shelf-

gate is the pass above it. The Noon Pass stays a pass, higher and older. Narol of the Pass is dead. The household that inherited Narol's toll still levies Break-rate in a kind year. Villages and hamlets stay on the shelves. Larbril is the city on the dry side of that pass. Tasain is where you are when the road has come down into shelter.

How it formed. It formed as march-holds on the snowmelt. Governance is mid because water is a fact you can levy without a census of souls: you tax the thaw, the pass, the high road. Theology is cooled by height and by distance from the grove's daily pressure.

Structure. Ridge-compacts, pass-tolls, and valley charters sit under a holding. Any Kind may take up the work. Sky-couriers hold ordinary office.

Goals. Keep the passes and the spring. Be paid for water the core calls a gift. The people stay off the Threnhael. The Threnhael will name a pass when it can.

Its injustice. The ridge pays in isolation for water the valley drinks. The tolls feel like geography. A shelf-town whose graft sickens is a long way from a stiller. Mid-state enough to levy; not enough to furnish every Tithe on a cliff.

Brenledd: the Hearth-League

(bren-LED · bren "hearth" + ledd "to reckon" = "hearths of the ledger.") Theology low · reach high · governance low. Everyday *the Brenledd* or *the compact*; people **Brenled-folk**. A league of hearths. The throne-city sits inside the league.

A **league of charter-towns** on Strandoren (river-ports, lesser harbours, inland markets) that compact to face Lestrand's houses and stay many hearths. Each town is a hearth with its own Tree and its own vouching. The compact is the arithmetic: shared tickets, shared notes, shared refusal to be priced one at a time. The throne-city is **Raitin** *(RAY-tin)*. The council sits there. It is a river-city, one of the largest on the Shore-lands. Six charter-towns sit around it. They stay unnamed. Nidtol is the hearth-name people still recite when Lestrand offers to deal with one ruler instead of seven hearths. Raitin is the city where the notes clear. Turvo keeps the notes. Sulnu carries a cleared ticket to the river stair. Nubo is vouched in Raitin and still unknown in the next hearth. A throne-city leaves the league many hearths.

Faith worn light, same as the coast. Trees mature. Nothing is policed; everything is *chartered*.

Site. Brenledd sits behind and between the premier coast. The older job of the ground is salt and river towns. Some were road-end Tree-towns that federated instead of fading into a deathless house's hinterland.

How it formed. Towns that got tired of being the other party on a Lestrand note. The compact is a pile of charters that learned to speak together, messy and still holding.

Structure. A council of hearths. You are of *your* town first. Any Kind may take up the work. A person vouched in one Brenled square may still be a stranger in the next. The compact moves coin better than it moves standing.

Goals. Keep many tickets cheaper than one house. Underwrite each other. Stay a league when Lestrand would rather negotiate with a single spokesman.

Its injustice. Falling between charters. Vouched here, unknown there; Tithe-provision a town matter the compact will not touch. Thin welfare in a rich network. The fade happens in the gaps the league calls local.

Leddvael: the Reckoned Gift

(led-VAYL · ledd "to reckon" + vael "gift" = "the gift reckoned.") Motherfaith theology **low**; the Fair Hand worn as **civic law**. Reach high · governance **mid**. Everyday *Leddvael*; people **Leddvael-folk**. The name is the doctrine: a gift is a bargain priced. The Book-Hands stamp and recite; they have **no seat**. Bound Terms stay as written.

Leddvael is a signing-coast on Strandoren that took the Fair Hand from a dockside theology to a **civic rite**. Leaf-Fall is a festival *and* a signing-watch. Tithe is a term serviced. The Bound are model citizens here, *employed* as the shape of honesty. Mid governance: the book is a kind of statute, and persons stay off a census. They file a contract. The list stays Threnmaieth's.

Site. This is a different stretch of indented coast than Lestrand, with enough water to have its own houses. The older job of the ground is a **salt quay with a signing-watch**. **Naenor** *(NAY-nor)* is the port, on a stretch of coast of its own. It is large, and slightly smaller than Orentel. Derdil stands the signing-watch. The Book-Hands stamp and recite in this wind. They hold no seat here. Bound Terms stay as written. The city wins the term and loses the berth. Empty prestige berths stay Orentel's. Naenor has working berths. The work is the watch.

How it formed. Fortune-and-contract practice thickened until a charter-coast found it cheaper to *establish* the Settling than to argue hymns per dock. The Settling is Fair Hand contract-practice. A habit that got a seal.

Structure. A charter-council works with the book-tables. Any Kind may take up the work. Gift-reading families live here. They are the minority that sounds devout and looks like a credit risk.

Goals. Keep signings clear. Vouch the Struck briskly as a later contract. Treat Motherfaith gift-talk as unpriced language. It stays allowed.

Its injustice. Bargain-theology as statute. A Given child is a term opened. A household that insists the colour was a gift is a bad debtor in a signing-town. The Bound are safe and *over-read*: the world's

contract-pillar asked to be the world's whole person. No villain-faith. A sincere ledger laid over real Conditions.

Trenledd: the Worn Count

(tren-LED · thren "sacred counting" + ledd "to reckon," with the holy sound sanded off.) The reconstruction *Threnledd* is unused on purpose: they will not say the holy word. Theology **low** · reach **high** · governance **high**. Everyday *Trenledd* or *the Trenled*; people **Trenled-folk**. They call the list **the roll**, Lestrand's word for a *tax* roll, here meaning persons. Dropping the hymn from the count *is* the thesis.

Trenledd is the wealthy interior of Strandoren. The Trees are mature, the Given are dense, the guilds are thick, and the state writes people down. The list began as ticket-and-tax machinery (safety-licences, house-notes, charter-rolls) and forgot to stop at property. There is no hymn that makes it stewardship. There is no Mother to be accounted to. You are on the roll because commerce and hazard-control wanted a name they could find again.

Threnmaieth at least claims to keep you hale. Trenledd claims to keep you *findable*. Cutting you off is default, not impiety.

Site. The interior is rich in Trees, and reach is high. The older job of the ground is road-end Tree-towns that got *filed*. Stones in the squares have numbers on the back. **Lunbra** *(LUN-bra)* is on the Chart-run, four to eight days upriver of Orentel. It is large and wealthy. The roll is kept here. The money is shown in the square. Vamar keeps a column. A neighbour says Vamar. A clerk says the house first: Melro, Vamar. Whoever governs Trenledd stays unnamed. Towns through the filed country stay unnamed.

How it formed. Guild-tickets plus deathless memory plus a council that distrusted living witness the way Threnmaieth does, without Threnmaieth's scripture. The three pillars work here and are treated as *insufficient*. Feeling, word, and memory answer to themselves. A ledger answers to the desk. Each crisis added a column.

Structure. A crown or a council that writes the roll runs it; who sits on it is not named. Licence-guilds serve as state organs. Any Kind may take up the work. The Struck are pursued to be catalogued because an unwitnessed change is a row that appeared without a clerk.

Goals. Know who is dangerous, who owes, who Turned. Furnish Tithe through channels that can be shut. Argue procedure, and keep theology off the docket.

Its injustice. A census with the halo worn off. You cannot appeal to piety. You cannot shame them with "the Mother's gifts should not be listed." They agree, and list you anyway, as cargo and hazard. It is colder than the Tallied Crown.

Netstrand: the Night Shore

(NET-strand · neth "night; the long dark" + strand "shore.") Reconstruction *Nethstrand* unused in daily speech. Theology mid-low · reach high · governance low. Everyday *Netstrand*; people **Netstrand-folk**. People call it the Night Shore. West water, storm stories, and watches after dark are what a traveler meets there.

Netstrand is Strandoren's west and south face. The West Water lies toward Heskoren and, far beyond, the storm-wall. Bold houses run the frontier trade. They sell **hulls and west-water berths** — crews, capacity, a crossing quoted like a pilgrimage. The First-Hand year is assembled on the Old Crossing: Netstrand charters the ship, the White Note writes the terms, Orentel holds the berth. Orenbren houses the sleep at the origin. Almost none have crossed to the Sundering Isle. Those who claim to are the tellers of Yumboe stories.

Faith mixed: Motherfaith worn light, Fair Hand ordinary on a signing-quay, quay-charms nobody writes down. Trees still mature along this wealthy edge.

Site. This is an open-ocean coast. The older job of the ground is a **salt quay**. Eolthael berths sit empty. Holds smell of earth, and graft-pots go out. The neighbour's week is billed as a crossing. **Braetu** *(BRAY-too)* is the harbour. It is smaller than Orentel, because the far run is thinner than the Old Crossing. Mursur writes the far crossing and takes the fee for a lamp on a name. They keep a dark book of quoted crossings that did not come back. One berth stays unlit, with no house attached. The city leaves the berth that way. The book on this quay is the Heskoren run. The Isle stays a tale. Towns along the rest of the shore stay unnamed.

How it formed. West-houses grew from Salt Walk traffic and the later carrying to Heskoren (by sea, coasts first, then the far). A shore that faces the wave's supply-line.

Structure. Merchant houses and berth-guilds sit under a light charter-council. Any Kind may take up the work. Selkie are common on the water. Sky-couriers from Lirorn and Tengu families work the clock-towers. The towers are a job.

Goals. Quote the far crossing. Keep the Heskoren run profitable. Sell Isle-tales without having to survive them. Keep the berths on Netstrand's own book.

Its injustice. The walk as inventory. Prestige priced; necessity billed; a neighbour's week to a waiting cluster is a line on a docket.

Ornled: the Outer Ledger

(orn-LED · orn "land" + ledd "to reckon"; clipped from Ornledd.) On Heskoren, dropping the sacred sound is a neglect, not just distance. Theology **low** · reach **low** · governance **low**. Everyday *Ornled*;

people **Ornled-folk**. Reconstruction *Ornledd* unused. They do not tend old endings. A Vaethorn without the faith, harder and colder.

Ornled is thin-reach Heskoren country that never took the waiting-gospel. It has the same young grafts, and the same Kept-heavy and Struck-heavy weather as Vaethorn, and **no congregation to fill the gap**. Tithe-provision is barter, favor, and a slate on the wall. An unvouched Struck is a problem met with a rope, a deal, or a neighbour. Custom outruns law because there is almost no law and almost no hymn.

They do not hate the Mother. They do not *use* her. Vaethorn hears the missing *th* in their name as godlessness. Ornled hears Vaethorn's *th* as a luxury.

Site. These are frontier pockets off the hottest pilgrim-roads. The older job of the ground is a **waiting cluster without a gospel**. The stones are the same, and the upper rooms are the same if a walk used to pass. That older job is necessity. **Sanbreo** *(san-BREE-oh)* is where the slate is kept and a hull can pay a beach-fee. It is on Heskoren's west coast, the slate-shore, and its beach faces the last capes and the storm-wall beyond them. It is on the brink of a small city. The first line on the wall is still the sentence Vathne cut. Vathne is that line. Whoever is on the shore gate that day cuts the fee, and that person is not named. Villages in the pockets around it stay unnamed. Eolvaeth is Vaethorn's seat. It is a pilgrim-edge vale in the waiting-gospel. Sanbreo keeps this gate.

How it formed. Kept and Struck-heavy districts watched the waiting-theology arrive with the grafts and declined to make scarcity a soul-problem. Improvisation is the culture. Governance is low because no one has the spare people to be a state. The Fair Hand is a rumour from ships. They have few Bound to make a book of.

Structure. The structure is town custom, slates, and vouching stretched thin. Any Kind may take up the work. The Intake's problem is acute here and unofficial: catching a raw Struck, a shed if you're lucky, silence if it works.

Goals. Stay whole with what is in the pot. Keep green a matter of the pot. Trade with Netstrand when a ship comes, and keep the town's own slate.

Its injustice. No net. Vaethorn's cruelty is guilt; Ornled's is absence. A person who cannot barter their Tithe slides with no prayer and no guild. The loneliest unvouched in the world are next door, where no one is waiting with them.

Vaelhesk: the Far Yield

*(VAYL-hesk · vael in the **older** sense, "what the land yields" + hesk- "far/outer edge" = "the far yield.") Vael* kept because the Old Ways claim the Motherfaith *narrowed* it to "gift." Theology **mid** as Motherfaith gift-devotion, high as Old Ways practice. Reach low · governance low. Everyday

Vaelhesk; people **Vaelhesk-folk** or **the Yield**. The fight with Vaethorn is in the first syllable: *vael* vs *vaeth*. The land is the seat. The work is host-rights.

Vaelhesk is pre-graft host-lands on Heskoren, with old greens, ancestor-doors, and first meals. The Mother's wood is a **guest**. A Cutting-leave is Seat leave to cut living wood. Without the meal, that leave is a claiming. The Door-Keepers walk here as Kin-speakers. The land is the seat.

Struck and the Taken-In are read as the land's own children. A neighbour's week to a Motherfaith Tree can be refused on purpose: the child is already the hill's. Vaethorn reads those children as Kept-for-want. Both families are telling the truth they have.

Site. These are Heskoren's old greens, and the live front is only part of them. The older job of the ground is a **guest-grove**, and that grove is the First Bowl. The Door-Keepers walk here. The work is host-rights. The land is the seat. Vaelhesk names no city. Villages and hamlets stay on the old greens. A traveler who asks for the seat is pointed at a door. The First Bowl stays the guest-grove it already is. Harrow's Green is the grove-town on Saelvaeth's march.

How it formed. Animist and ancestor polities predate the wave. When grafts arrived (Cut-year 200 to 387, still arriving), some districts became Vaethorn. These kept the door. The state stays low because the land does not need a clerk to be owed a meal.

Structure. The structure is hearth-clusters, door-keepers, and host-right custom. Any Kind may take up the work. The Taken-In are densest here as frontier labor and as *kin*.

Goals. Feed the first meal. Name a Struck at the door that made them. Treat a warden with a pot as a guest or as a thief, depending on whether they sat down.

Its injustice. Host-rights as a claim that can shun. Refuse the meal, take the wood, and you are not a neighbour. A Road-hand out on this year's road can become a trespasser for following a Seat sentence. The injustice is local and real.

Saelvaeth: the Sown Waiting

(sayl-VAYTH · sael "sowing" + vaeth "the waiting" = "sowing into the waiting.") They still reach for the holy words because the wave is *here*. Theology mid-high · reach low · governance mid-low. Everyday *Saelvaeth*; people **Saelvaeth-folk**. Shares *sael* with Saelthael on purpose: planting on two continents. Towns a party can enter in this march are Harrow's Green and the Three Hamlets Past the Ford. Natai is the march-town. Eolvaeth is Vaethorn's seat, on a different road. Harrow's Green is a grove-town in the march.

Where the wood is still arriving on Heskoren, the front runs from Cut-year 200 to 387 and is still incomplete. Towns form where a graft has taken; between them, waiting clusters who can see a neighbour's canopy. The march-town is **Natai** *(NAH-tye)*. Dumu stands the voice at the town gate, on

the road between grafts, and can be blamed for a queue the town did not write. On the Known Map, Natai sits west of Harrow's Green, between Sanbreo and that grove-town. The hamlets stand past the ford. Harrow's Green is a grove-town in the march, the luckiest of them, a Hand that grew up. The Three Hamlets Past the Ford can see that green. The Seat wrote them down as what the march had left over, and still does not use their folk names (*Brenod · Vaelun · Ornath*). The queue is a line of people waiting where you can see them. Ornsael, on Saelthael, is the same sowing, the older walk still in use on the origin continent. The city of that sowing is Larbril. The well is Ornsael.

Governance is mid-low because *someone* must stand for the Harrow-sentence (*we Turned at Harrow's Tree before we had our own*): wardens, Road-hands passing through, a march-voice that did not exist when the first pots came. The state is large enough to be blamed, and no larger.

Site. These are Heskoren's grafted pockets on the moving edge. The older job of the ground is a **live-front Tree-town**. The neighbour's week is kept as necessity.

How it formed. The wave made it, this decade. The nexts were paying-enough, soil-enough, and chain-enough, on a list written in the Motherwood. It is a polity made of luck and a queue. Vaethorn will preach unworthiness. History does not agree.

Structure. Town-wardens, borrowed Turnings, and Road-hands who sleep here on the way to a town that was not chosen are the offices. Any Kind may take up the work. The Old Ways are neighbours, in Vaelhesk. Vaethorn heat sits on many hearths as gospel. The march they stand in is Saelvaeth.

Goals. Keep taken grafts alive. Host the neighbour's week. Argue the next pot. Survive being the sentence the Seat already wrote.

Its injustice. The queue as a border. Harrow's luck is politics. The hamlets can see the canopy and send children anyway. Spreading Trees did not make the march kind.

Gazetteer

Gazetteer types

Every Turning-place already inherits **the Tree at the centre** (or the neighbour's Tree, or the wait for one); Tithe-provision as civic utility where the polity can afford it; dangerous trades on the edges; homes that accommodate becomings; the reach-edge writing the map.

Layered on top from the Years of Hands: a road that used to go further; a stone that used to be a day's walk; an upper room that used to be a pilgrim-dorm; a house that used to be an inn. Adaptive reuse is how Ornthael looks present.

Kumbaan's places wait on a later pass with the Open Table.

After local Trees made pilgrimage optional, a place still does one older job of the walk: devotion (the extra mile you do not need), prestige (the origin-winter you can buy), or necessity (the neighbour's week, because your Tree is missing, young, or sick). One of those jobs per street. Devotion, prestige, and necessity can share an inn; they should not all be the town's *theme*. A **Held bed** is a bed kept empty for a named person who has not come.

Type	What it is	Older job of the walk	Where it lives	Named square or seat
Origin pilgrimage-town	devotion's extra mile; the Motherwood's lodging	Near Mile as civic season *and* holiday; Seat proximity	Maiethorn Sacred Core	Maiethlir (the roll layers the extra mile; the grove is the Motherwood beside the city) · neighbour square: Brenthael
Road-end Tree-town	the walk stopped here; the square *is* the last mile	stone in the square; road ends at the boughs; upper room	any Hands land; densest on Maiethorn	**Nelath** (a spur that stops). Harrow's Green, Brenthael, and the Mill-hold are other kinds of square. Nelath is the named road-end
Deathless inn-bank	road-past as credit	beds + notes; Held bed as house custom	Near Mile inland; Salt-Walk quay	the Third Hearth (stayed a hearth) · the White Note House on Orentel (a desk on the third quay)
Salt quay	prestige-walk + pots	empty Eolthael berths; holds that smell of earth; Fair Hand signing-watch	Strandoren coasts	Orentel (the White Note is a desk on the third quay)
Live-front Tree-town	luckiest Heskoren; neighbour's canopy	Harrow-sentence (*we Turned at Harrow's Tree before we had our own*) as *this decade*; borrowed Turnings inbound	Heskoren	Harrow's Green
Waiting cluster	queue made visible; this year's children still walk	can see a neighbour's canopy; folk-right temptation; Kept/Struck-heavy	Heskoren; also Rain-Shadow pockets	the Three Hamlets Past the Ford (folk names *Brenod · Vaelun · Ornath*)
Sick-Tree square	a Hand that fails	necessity-walk *returns*; civic crisis	any continent the wood has reached	**the Mill-hold** (Orenbren lodging-country). Ornsael's

Type	What it is	Older job of the walk	Where it lives	Named square or seat
		wearing a child's summer		well can drop without a sick fall
Guest-grove	Old Ways planting	first meal, and a Cutting-leave (the paper that says where the wood may take); host-rights	Heskoren old greens	**the First Bowl** (folk *Lonasir*). Vaelhesk's land is the seat
Rain-Shadow walk-hold	necessity, still waiting on the Motherland	west-road after the core stopped	Maiethorn dry hills	Ornsael, the well-town farther into the dry. Saelthael's city is Larbril, at the Well-wash, short of the pass
Pilgrim-edge	wait as destination	congregation made a country; the Tree speaks in some years	Heskoren	Eolvaeth

Three kinds of place the road already needed now have names. The sick-Tree town is the Mill-hold. The guest-grove is the First Bowl. The road-end is Nelath. They are written in Other Places. One kind of place is still only a kind: **two claimants on one green**, a tree-warden and an Old Ways door-keeper, both sure the wood is theirs to speak for. Vaelun, one of the three hamlets past the ford, leans that way. The named square of that kind is still unwritten. The First Bowl is the guest-grove. Vaelun is a kitchen past the ford.

Towns a party can walk into

These are towns a party can walk into. Each entry says where the place sits, what work it does, and who you can meet. A line in quotation marks is something a person there might say. Where an entry says the wave, it means the slow spread of living wood outward from the Motherwood. That spread is still moving. This year's children still walk to a Tree that can speak, or a road is still in use because the walk is not over. It is the present. The Ages explains the spread at length.

Harrow’s Green

Harrow’s Green is a live-front Tree-town. It is the luckiest kind of square on this front. A scion arrived in the Cut-year 200s, spoke a generation later, and has now Turned local children for a few generations. The Harrow-sentence (*we Turned at Harrow’s Tree before we had our own*) is how new towns talk everywhere; here it is the decade. Everyday *Harrow’s green* was already a Seat sentence on a Cutting-leave. **Haelin** *(HAY-lin)* is the warden. The town is a few hundred hearths around one canopy. The march-town is Natai, west of this square, between Sanbreo and the green. This square’s water is the stream. The ford is downstream.

A grafted pocket on the Sundered Reach. Settlement clustered where the wood took. Harrow’s is old enough, for the front, to be a town. A canopy stands at the centre. The square used to be a road. Borrowed Turnings come in from the Three Hamlets Past the Ford every Eolthael.

The wave has not finished here. Harrow’s is a Hand that grew up. The three hamlets can see the green from the ford. The Seat has already written that the wood will take *here* and not, this year, *there*. Harrow’s lives inside that sentence whether it asked to or not.

Vaethorn heat sits on many hearths as gospel, not always as flag. This square lives in Saelvaeth’s orbit, the live-front march. Natai is the march-town. The Old Ways are neighbours. A first meal at a later planting is a live argument.

What this town still does, from the years when children had to walk, is necessity. Neighbouring hamlets still send their ten-year-olds here for the week. A ribbon on the stone is devotion, left by someone else. The winter you can buy is the White Note’s booking.

Site. A low rise above a stream that becomes the ford downstream. The graft took on the rise; the old pilgrim-road climbed it because that was the day’s water. Towns on Heskoren do not pick a pretty hill and then invent a Tree. The wood picked, and the hearths followed.

Water is the stream, a cistern by the warden-hearth, and the **stone in the square**, still the day’s drink for anyone using the road as a mile. Food is the pocket’s gardens, ranging beyond the last house, and whatever the neighbour’s week brings in Hale-month (crowds, dust, a complaint). Fuel is the same woods the Two-Bodied use as ranging. The Taken-In keep the greens around the Tree from going to seed indoors. There is no resident stiller. A travelling one is a summer’s luck.

The square is the last holy mile. Beyond the boughs the old way is a cart-track to the ford. Children are told the road goes to the Motherwood. It goes to the mill, and then to three hamlets that can see the canopy. Both are true if you keep walking.

The square. Nucleated around the canopy. Organic, not a grid. The oldest houses face the Tree; later houses filled the wedge between the road and the stream. No walls. The boundary is the ranging and the last garden.

- **The Tree at the centre.** Mature enough to Turn; young enough that grandparents remember the borrowed years. Leaf-Fall is held in the square because there is nowhere else a crowd fits. The town's age can be read in the wood: a Hand, not a First.
- **The stone.** Last mile-shrine of the road that used to go further. Climbing-scuff. Water the Road-hands still use. Ribbons some years. **Haelin**, town-warden, wants it moved before the next Leaf-Fall because it is in the way of the crowd. Thilim, if asked, would say it is a name. A hamlet child will climb it and ask how far it is to the Tree.
- **The upper room.** Still too many beds for the present trade. Opens for the neighbour's week; not yet a merchant-loft. A Road-hand sleeps here on the way to a town that was not chosen, sometimes with a pot. Hale-month is dust and extra guests. Ledger-month is local.
- **The greens.** Potted groves and a garden-common around the Tree, enough, not a lot with a ticket. They will not follow you home. The Taken-In here are neighbours, not a quarter.
- **The ranging.** At the town edge, not a beast-yard. Two-Bodied work the woods that feed the hearth. No Kind-flag on the trees.
- **The far shed.** Returned plague-and-body work, downwind, the same logic as a tannery, not an infirmary or a district.

Homes accommodate becomings: a window that opens, a room kept green, a threshold a Long-Lived waits to be asked across. Mixed Kinds. A Fox of the Wilds at the ranging is unremarkable. A Tengu on a ridge-visit is a guest.

Tithe-provision is frontier-warm and thin: the greens, the ranging, the upper room as a seasonal outlet for whoever is loud that week. No counted hall. No stiller on a licence-wall. You can be too poor to stay whole here, and the neighbour's week will not fix that.

The square *is* the last mile. The road ends at the boughs. Hands-children Turn at home. The hamlets can see the canopy. They send this year's ten-year-olds to a Tree that can speak. A Road-hand is going the other way with wood, because the walk is not over. The Harrow-sentence is this decade. It is the present.

A warden who pulls the stone down is doing theology with a hammer. They are not wrong that Leaf-Fall needs the space. They are wrong if they think the graves went with the requirement. The next necessity-column will miss the water. Haelin knows this and still wants it moved.

Offices. Town-warden (Haelin): practice-first, not Kind. Speaks the fall truly enough for a front-town. Believer-heavy the way a live Tree makes you; still has to lodge the neighbour's week. The scion-queue is not theirs to fix, and it is the sentence they live in.

The square watches children Turn. Harrow's witness is what a hamlet child carries home. Vouching-at-a-distance was invented for an origin-fall; here it is a walk back to the ford.

Road-hands passing through sleep in the town that was chosen, on the way to the one that was not.

A Door-Keeper at a later planting holds host-rights if a cut from Harrow's is set in an old green. The first meal, or a claiming.

Saelvaeth's march-voice can be blamed when the queue is ugly. Dumu, who answers for the march, stands at Natai.

A notice chalked on the cistern-wall, Hale-month, Cut-year 387. Haelin's hand. The stone is not named.

> *The crowd will need the square. The stone will be walked around until Eolthael, and then we will see. Water stays. Names stay if they were names. Climbing is for after.*
>
> *Beds above: the neighbour's week first. A pot is not a pilgrim. A pilgrim is not a pot. I can tell. I will not always say.*
>
> *If you came from the ford, you are seen here. If you must be seen at home, take someone with you who was here. I will not walk it for you. I have a Tree.*

The notice shows that Haelin is making room for the crowd and will not walk anyone home. In the square it is crowd control. Past the ford it can arrive as a slight.

The Three Hamlets Past the Ford

The Three Hamlets Past the Ford are a waiting cluster. The Seat's Cutting-leave already filed them as a remainder: *the wood will take at Harrow's green. It will not take this year at the three hamlets past the ford: the soil is thin there.* They can see Harrow's Green from the water. They send this year's ten-year-olds to the neighbour's week, or further if Harrow's year is too full, or still the Long Mile if the neighbour is a stick in a pot. The hamlets have folk hearth-names. The Seat still does not use them; its paper still reads "the three hamlets past the ford." Three hearths, a few dozen houses each. You walk from kitchen to kitchen.

Three hearths past a ford on Heskoren, close enough to share a complaint and far enough that a scion for "the hamlets" would still be a fight about *which* green. Thin reach as weather: Kept-heavy and Struck-heavy *this year, for this cohort.* This year's children still walk to a Tree that can speak. It is the present.

They have learned not to say *queue*. They can recite the horticulture-sentence. Folk-right cutting is a kitchen-knife in a drawer, not a rebellion with a flag. Most slips die. The ones that take are how the First Seat learns it does not own the Tree's tissue, only the authorization.

Old Ways hearths among them may **refuse the neighbour's week** on purpose. Their children are already the land's. Motherfaith neighbours read those children as Kept-for-want. History does not agree with Vaethorn guilt.

Geographically they sit on a seam: Saelvaeth luck they can see, Vaelhesk refusal in the kitchen, Vaethorn gospel on the tongue, Ornled slate if they walk the other way.

What these hamlets still do is necessity. They make the week. They send the children.

Site. The ford is the Seat's geography, the thing you can see Harrow's green from, water a mile-shrine would have marked if anyone had set a stone on the waiting side. No stone. Necessity still drinks there. Children still ask how far it is.

The stream comes down from Harrow's rise. In clear weather the canopy is a dark against the far slope. In rain it is a rumour you have to take on trust. The three greens sit on slightly different ground: a wetter shelf, an old taken plot, a thinner rise past the last hedge. A scion planted "for the hamlets" would still be a fight about which of those is soil.

Food is gardens, a shared mill-path, ranging that is just the woods. No venting-hall. No lot. Tithe-provision is the yard and the neighbour. A lapsing Condition here is a family problem before it is a guild's.

The houses are dispersed. You walk from hearth to hearth. The cluster is a complaint with three kitchens.

Brenod (BREN-od)

Brenod is the sending hearth. Motherfaith in this kitchen is the walk to Harrow's. They want someone who was *there* to walk back and stand for the fall, and they can recite the thin-soil sentence without using the word *queue.* The kitchen-knife is in this drawer more often than the others, which does not mean they have used it. It means they have looked at it.

Brenod keeps the neighbour's week as *duty.* A visitor from the core will hear faith. Brenod hears a date in Eolthael.

Vaelun (VAY-lun)

Vaelun is the yield-hearth. Older *vael* is what the land keeps. *Vaeth* is the waiting. The Old Ways sit this kitchen. They may refuse the neighbour's week on purpose. Their children are already the land's. A first meal is the host's claim. A later cut from Harrow's, acting on the origin's behalf, still wants the bowl if this ground is an old green.

Vaelun keeps host-rights. The Door-Keepers play here. Motherfaith neighbours in Brenod will call Vaelun's Kept children passed-over. Vaelun will not correct them in the Mother's language.

Ornath (OR-nath)

Ornath is the furthest hearth past the ford. The soil is thinnest here, still a feeling, and the horticulture is still felt rather than decided. Ornath can see Harrow's when the weather is kind and can walk the *other* way, toward Ornled's slate, if the congregation-net fails. They have not gone. The road is still a temptation that looks like sense: a ledger, the same thin Trees, and no gospel.

Ornath keeps the wait, and the other road goes toward Ornled's slate. Some people there still wait. Some have stopped saying the Mother's name and have not started keeping a list either.

Which green has the sick stick is not decided. A pot in a yard, a young failure, or nothing yet: any of the three can hold it for a night. The fight about *which* green would receive a scion is the cluster's civic life. Naming the hearths did not end that fight.

Harrow's has a Tree. The square down the slope is Hands. This year's ten-year-olds still walk to that Tree. Kept-heavy and Struck-heavy is the weather this year. It is the present. A split household, shorter: one child to Harrow's, one Kept at the ford, a sibling who will not walk the same side of the road.

There is no stone on the waiting side. There is a **cup**. The night before the neighbour's week someone leaves it on the ford-rock. If it fills, they send. If it does not, the tellings do not agree, and the child still goes, or does not, according to the kitchen, and the cup does not decide. Brenod calls it weather. Vaelun calls it the land answering. Ornath has started leaving it empty on purpose, or has not.

What must exist: families who walk one child and not another (the split household, shorter); a person who will vouch a neighbour-fall all the way home, Harrow's witness walking back to the ford (if they will not, the child is seen at Harrow's and unvouched at breakfast); a Kin-speaker who will stand for a Struck the square will not; someone who owns a knife they will not call nameless; a Door-Keeper's cousin in Vaelun who will ask about the bowl before they ask about a leave.

The Seat's leave still says *the three hamlets past the ford.* Clerks who learn Brenod, Vaelun, Ornath have learned more than the minute wanted them to.

Said at the ford, not written. Same water.

Brenod says, "We can see it. That is not the same as having it."

Vaelun says, "The land had them before the cart came. I will not walk a child to a neighbour to be named a Waited."

Ornath says, "If the cup stays dry I still have to decide. The slate the other way does not ask about soil."

None of the three will take the other two as the whole truth. The leave already named them without naming them.

The Third Hearth (and Brenthael)

The Third Hearth is a road-house that stayed a hearth. It is the third lodging out from the Motherwood on the Near Mile. **Thilim** *(THIL-im)* has kept this house since before the First Cut, as later clerks would say. Thilim is Long-Lived and inland. Seine's bed is still made. The notes are smaller than the White Note's. The shrine is larger. People say *the third hearth*. The cant *brenhael* is the hearth-Tree word any road-house gets. **Brenthael** *(bren-THALE)* is the neighbour-town. The house stands on Maiethorn, in Orenbren's lodging-country. Orenbren's capital is Rothallo. Rothallo is the Inner Close. The First Seat sits in the Motherwood.

An old Near-Mile house, three days' walk out from Thaeloren toward the approach-country. Beds, porridge, a dry room, a green-lot, a shed. In Brenvaeth it sold the walk you could not miss twice. In Ornthael it still opens for Eolthael.

It sits in Orenbren's lodging-country, civic beds within a week's walk of the grove. The inns grew a country. This is one house.

What this road-house still does is devotion: it keeps the extra mile as the town's season. The loft still sleeps people who had to come, and, rarely, people who paid to come. Thilim can tell which is which, and will not always say. The White Note is a desk on Orentel's quay. It sells a first-year pilgrimage as a product. This house makes the bed.

Lestrand calls this "a bed-house that failed to become a bank." Thilim asks who will be here at dark. One description prices the building. The other decides whether supper is enough.

Site. The Near Mile is a week's door to the origin. Counted from the grove outward: first hearth a day out, second, **third**. Pilgrims walking *in* hit the neighbour-town first.

Brenthael stands a day's walk further from the grove than the inn. It is a Hands-town that grew around a graft planted beside the road. Brenthael's own children Turn at home, under that Tree, and the Mile goes on past it, to the Mill-hold and the rest of Maiethorn. Children there are told the road goes to the Motherwood. It does, if they keep walking past the inn, two more hearths, and the wood. Most Hands-children do not.

The Third Hearth kept the older job: beds for people still going in. Water is a well in the yard and the **stone** by the road, a day's-walk shrine that never got pulled into Brenthael's square because the inn refused to let the town have it. Thilim uses it for water and will not join the argument about pulling it down. Brenthael's warden wants it moved. The stone is in the way of a crowd that is not this house's crowd.

Food is the pot, the green-lot, whatever the extra mile pays in Hale-month. The shed is still a shed.

Features.

- **The upper room.** Still too many beds; not converted. Opens in Hale-month. Quiet in Ledger-month. A devotion-column, a necessity-family, and a Road-hand going the other way with a pot can sleep in it in the same week. The home-Turning is already here, and the walk is not over. A prestige household that did not book the White Note's winter is rare and conspicuous.
- **Seine's bed.** Held. Seine of the far cape, tenth summer, not come. The mother said next year. Next year was last year, and has been, for a length of time Thilim will not convert into Cut-years. Not a shrine Thilim will admit. A shrine everyone else can see.
- **The slate.** Still kept. Verso still does not match recto. Full text in the Walking Years, above.
- **The stone.** By the road, not in Brenthael's square. Climbing-scuff anyway. Road-hands still aim for the water. Brenthael wants it down so the extra mile does not look like a requirement on their approach. Thilim will not move a name.
- **Green-lot and shed.** Still a pot and a shed. Thilim missed a green, once. That cutting stayed in the pot. The First Cut is a different knife, and a different year.
- **Brenthael's square** *(the neighbour town)*. Tree at the centre; the Mile goes on past the boughs; Leaf-Fall as civic season; lodging-guild pressure from Orenbren. Rothallo keeps the Book. Mixed Kinds. No Kind-quarters. The town's older job is devotion: the extra mile as a holiday. They can see the inn's stone from the last house and resent it as a grave that is also an advertisement.

Brenthael Turns at home. The Near Mile is optional. Orenbren houses the people who still want the origin. The stone still waters a mile. Seine's name is still cut over the door. A necessity-family from thinner soil still pays on the home-walk, because that walk is not over. It is the present. A Hand can fail: the Mill-hold, two days past Brenthael, went back on the neighbour's week this year. Brenthael's Tree has not sickened. Thilim keeps the beds open for the people still walking.

The two fates of the same origin still stand. The White Note collected, on a Strandoren quay. The Third Hearth kept making the bed.

At dark, Thilim sets the yard-broom across the doorway and steps over it. They will not say why.

People. Thilim: Long-Lived, inland and tired. When Thilim says *I walked*, the phrase can mean four different things. Blood-Read will give a true fragment of a walk. It will not tell you which meaning Thilim intends when they make the bed. **Meirim** *(may-REEM)*, Brenthael's town-warden, wants the stone. Practice-first. Speaks a fall in a square that used to be a road. This Hale-month Meirim also has a necessity-column walking in from the Mill-hold. Orenbren lodging-custom: hospitality as rent in Eolthael; Thilim charges less and is called a failure for it. The compact does not own this house. Orenbren's capital is Rothallo. The First Seat sits in the Motherwood beside this country. A pilgrim who asks Thilim where the college is will be pointed at the wood.

A chalked complaint from Meirim's warden-hearth, carried to the Third Hearth and left under the stone's lip. Cut-year 387, after Hale-month. Thilim has not answered on paper.

> *The crowd will need the approach. Your stone is a mile that is no longer owed. Water we have. Names we can keep on a ribbon in the square, which is where a remembered name belongs.*
>
> *You house the extra mile. We Turn at home. If you make a shrine of a bed, that is a house matter. A stone in the road is a town matter.*
>
> *We are not pulling a grave. We are pulling a requirement that has ended.*

The complaint shows that Brenthael wants the stone out of its crowd's way and offers a ribbon in the square for the name. The Held bed is made. If Seine comes, the stone will still be in the way of a crowd that is not hers.

Ornsael

Ornsael *(orn-SAYL)* is a Rain-Shadow well-town. *Th* is absent from the name, and the holy sound is still in their speech. They are the Motherland's dry east, still walking west after the core stopped. The everyday name is *Ornsael*. A traveller from the core who says "the west-road well" is told the town's name. The town is a few hundred hearths, thinner than the core's. Saelthael's city is Larbril, where the west road meets the Well-wash, short of the pass. Ornsael is farther into the dry. Its drink is the well. Larbril's drink, when it has one, is the wash.

East of Maiethorn's Rain-Wall, on the leeward side away from the Old Crossing: dry hills, sand-country, towns at wells. Ornsael is one of those wells. A Tree stands beside it, young for the Motherland, old enough to have Turned local children for a generation. **It Speaks most years.** A missed Eolthael is weather. **The crisis is the drink.**

Saelthael is the polity of people who still sow. Ornsael is a square of that habit. Larbril is the city. Plenty sits on the other side of the range. Pilgrimage here is necessity, and the town cannot retire it. Core pilgrims who arrive in Eolthael expecting a holiday extra mile find a necessity-column already on the west-road, and are shocked. They thought waiting was a Heskoren feeling.

Fox of the Sands hearths are densest here. That is terrain, not a flag. A town with *no* fox-born would be the thing worth asking about. Mixed Kinds drink the same well.

What this well-town still does is necessity. The west road is still how this year's ten-year-olds go when a neighbour's Turning week is cheaper than a dry summer. Devotion stays with people who already have a healthy Tree. This hill's season is the neighbour's week.

Site. The well is why anyone stopped. The range takes the rain; this side keeps the dust. Settlement is nucleated around water the way Harrow's is nucleated around wood: same grammar, different scarcity. The graft was married to the well on purpose. Living earth wants a drink in sand-country as much as a child does.

The **west-road** is the main street. It used to be how you reached a healthier canopy, then how you reached the origin, then how you reached the core's Hands-towns after those towns stopped coming east. It is still how this year's ten-year-olds go, when the well is dropping or a fall is missed. Beyond the last house the road is a pale cut toward the range-pass. East of the well it peters into tracks and Taken-In plantings that look like stubbornness.

Water is the well, a few cisterns, dew-catch on the north walls. Food is terrace-gardens, goats, whatever the west-road pays when it still pays. Fuel is dung and what the range-trade carries over. The Taken-In are backbone here. Thirsty land honours green. They are not a nation.

No walls. The boundary is where the well's water no longer reaches and the dust does not.

The square.

- **The Tree at the well.** Civic and sacred heart. It Speaks most years. A missed Eolthael still shuts the Given-door. Struck remains the later mercy. There is still no second-chance year. The warden Speaks when there is a fall. They will not invent a colour. The drink is this square's crisis.
- **The well.** The drink. Chalk on the lip. A share that lasts Hale-month, or does not. **Theisva** *(THAYS-vah)* keeps the marks. **Lesna** *(LEZ-nah)* keeps a planting that drinks. **Bovaer** *(bo-VAYR)* keeps the west-road names. Three people. The mystery is a wet knot below last year's water-line.
- **The west-road.** Still in use, because the walk is not over. Mile-markers toward the pass; one stone still in the well-square because the town grew around a day's water. Climbing-scuff. Ribbons pointed *west*, which core children find backwards.
- **The well-market.** Stalls in the morning shade. Fox-born densest in the crowd, not gated. A fox-market without the town *being* a Kind. Stock ancestries, a Tengu on a pass-errand, a Selkie who married in from the Hinge Shore and is dry and funny about it.
- **The greens.** Potted, hauled, argued over. No lush lot. A cousin of the greens-keepers' craft might winter. They will not follow you home, and home is dust if they did.
- **The ranging.** Dry hills, night-work, Two-Bodied who know the difference between a sand-fox and a Fox. At the edge, not a quarter.
- **The far shed.** Returned work downwind of the well, because you do not put the dead on the drink. No infirmary. A travelling stiller is a pass-story.

Homes bend to becomings: north-side cool rooms, green pots beside the doors, shutters that open for a Far-Voiced hour because there is no hall to book. Thin infrastructure, high theology, low governance: Saelthael's combination at street height.

This is Maiethorn, the Motherland, Hands-country in the core. People speak the conservative way. The extra mile is supposed to be optional. Children still go west when the well drops or a neighbour's week is cheaper. The road that used to go further is still in use, because the walk is not over. It is the present. Same *sael* as Saelvaeth on the live front, sowing on two continents. Both are this year.

A Hand can fail. A well that drops puts a Motherland square back on a neighbour's week whether the Tree spoke or not. That is weather. The Seat will call thin soil. The town will call this year. Vaethorn-guilt imported to sand that never asked for it is the injustice: waiting read as unworthiness on the continent that invented plenty.

The well-rope is knotted at last year's water-line. This year's knot is wet when the water stands below it. Ornsael will not say why. Theisva moves the knot. Lesna says the planting tastes the same when it is wet. Bovaer puts sand in a west-facing shoe and does not call that a rite.

Offices. Town-warden: practice-first, not Kind. Tired of being asked if this is fox-country. May be Sands-Fox; may not. Either way the question is the slight. Speaks the fall when there is one. The well-share *is* the town-law. Theisva, Lesna, and Bovaer argue the marks.

The square that watches, and the west-road that watches instead. Some years the witness is local. Some years a column still walks. Vouching-at-a-distance on the Motherland is the tell that Ornthael is unfinished.

Road-hands: rare; the circuit prefers paying nexts. A pot for Ornsael is a fight with the queue.

Saelthael-folk custom: light, town-wardens, wells as civic fact. No list. Threnmaieth would like one. Plenty next door is Maiethvael's problem.

Well-share marks, chalked on the lip, Hale-month, Cut-year 387. Theisva's hand. The Tree is not mentioned.

> *Dawn-mark: below last knot. Child-jars first. Guest-jars after the planting's one bucket, and I will hear about the planting.*
>
> *West-road at dusk if the noon-mark does not rise. Bovaer has the names. I have the rope.*
>
> *A man from the Reckoning asked to name the well on a roll. We named the well Ornsael, which it already was. He wrote a colour-year. The sand does not keep his hand. The knot is wet. I did not wet it.*

Theisva is keeping the water. They will not file a year. Lesna will read the marks as a slight on green. Bovaer will already be on the road. Threnmaieth will file a west-road as piety or as a gap. It is a child who needs water this week.

The three seats

Eolvaeth (Vaethorn’s seat)

Eolvaeth *(ay-ohl-VAYTH)* is the capital of Vaethorn. It is a pilgrim-town. The name keeps *th*. The pulpit says *Eolvaeth*. Folk-speech says **“Elvaeth”** *(el-VAYTH)*. The canopy speaks in some years and stays quiet in others. **Vaethod** *(VAYTH-od)* is the warden. A couple thousand souls live here in Ledger-month, and more in Hale-month. Harrow’s Green is the live-front square. The Three Hamlets Past the Ford are the kitchens at Harrow’s ford. Saelvaeth’s march-town is Natai.

A vale behind Heskoren’s Strandoren-facing coast. One of the earlier pots on this continent: a Cut-year 200s graft that took, spoke some years, and never grew into a neighbour’s certainty. The live front moved on. The waiting stayed. Congregation made a country. Vaethorn is the gospel; **Eolvaeth is the square the gospel stands in.**

Governance here is almost absent. What sits in the vale is a Tree, a spring, a gift-hall that is worship, and the camp-streets of people who came for a hinge and did not leave. Custom outruns written law. The town-warden is Hands-folk.

Saelvaeth’s luck is a different weather, further along the wave. Harrow’s Green is a Hand that grew up. The three hamlets can see that canopy from a ford. Eolvaeth cannot see it, and does not want to. Wanting it would be admitting the wait is a queue. The gospel says stay. Horticulture, some years, says send.

What this town still does is devotion. People walk here in order to wait. Visitors from thinner country are usually here because they have to be. The town will not call that necessity.

Site. Two tracks meet at a spring in a fold of upland. The graft was married to the water because living earth wants a drink and a child does. Settlement clustered where the wood took, and then the camps filled the fold, because a thin Tree that *might* speak is still the oldest Hand a long walk can reach without crossing into Saelvaeth’s orbit.

The **spring** is the day’s drink. Ribbons belong on other squares. Children leave a wet leaf on the lip the year the Tree does not speak. Travellers from the core will try to climb something. There is nothing to climb. The Long Mile used to pass this vale when the neighbour was a continent. The requirement ended. The wait did not.

Food is the vale’s gardens, ranging on the slopes, alms from the gift-hall pot, and whatever Hale-month visitors bring. Fuel is the same woods the Two-Bodied use as wild-leave. There is no resident stiller. A travelling blessing-surgeon is a decade’s luck. The Taken-In are the backbone, Mother’s green held in common, honoured, not a nation.

No walls. The boundary is the last camp-street and the ranging. Low governance looks like this: you can walk in, and someone will feed you, and no clerk will write you down.

The square. Nucleated around the canopy. Organic. The oldest houses face the Tree; later houses filled the wedge between the tracks; **camp-streets**, cellular accretion of pilgrim-camps that learned to winter, run up the fold until they look like a town and still smell like a season.

- **The Tree at the centre.** Civic and sacred heart, even when the wood is a maybe. Mature enough that grandparents remember a fall. Young enough, for a capital, that a Seat clerk would not call it a First. Some years it Turns. Some years the colour is late, or thin, or **Vaethod** will not call a fall that isn't. A missed Eolthael still shuts the Given-door. Struck remains the later mercy. There is still no second-chance year.
- **The spring.** The vale's reason. Wet-leaf years. Climbing-scuff on the lip anyway, from children who have heard the stone-story. This town's older job is the wait.
- **The gift-hall.** Worship and venting in the same room (ael-hall as congregation). A Far-Voiced hour here is a hymn whether they meant it to be. No counted hall. No release-house ticket.
- **The camp-streets.** Adaptive reuse at town scale. A tent-line that became a row of houses. Hale-month still doubles the people. Ledger-month is local and guilty about the empty rooms.
- **Mother's green.** Commons around the Tree, enough, not a lot with a ticket. They will not follow you home. Home is the vale if they did.
- **The wild-leave.** Ranging on the slopes, at the edge, not a beast-yard. No Kind-flag on the trees.
- **The far shed.** Returned work downwind of the spring, not an infirmary or a district.

Homes accommodate becomings. Mixed Kinds. A Fox of the Wilds at the ranging is unremarkable. A Tengu on a spine-visit is a guest. A Selkie who married in from the coast is wet about the vale and kept anyway.

Tithe-provision is alms and congregation: real warmth, real want. You can be too poor to stay whole here, and the gospel will console what it cannot furnish.

Hands-children who *did* Turn at this Tree live here. The Long Mile is supposed to be optional. The hinge is supposed to have arrived. The Tree speaks in some years and stays quiet in others. Camp-streets still fill for Eolthael. Some years a cohort still goes toward Saelvaeth's luck, or further if that luck is full, because the walk is not over. It is the present. The gospel says wait. The Seat's horticulture, on a thin year, says send. Vaethod has done both. The town remembers which summers.

Devotion is the job on the street: people walk *to* Eolvaeth to wait together. That is how a poor land gets a capital without a crown. Orenbren's extra mile is for people who already have a healthy canopy. The hamlets' necessity is kitchens that can see Harrow's. This is the wait made into a destination, and also how scarcity becomes unworthiness if you let the sermon land.

A wet leaf lies on the spring, or too many, or none. Eolvaeth will not say why. Core pilgrims ask if it is a ribbon. The year the Tree speaks, there is no leaf. The year it does not, there are too many to count, and no one files the count.

Offices. Town-warden (Vaethod): Hands-folk, practice-first, not Kind. Speaks the fall truly enough for a waiting-seat. Will not write a colour that didn't happen, even if a visiting clerk wants the hinge tidy. The year they send a cohort toward Saelvaeth is the year the gospel and the wood disagree. They have not resigned.

The square that watches, and the camp-streets that watch instead. Some years the witness is local. Some years it has to walk home from a luckier Hand. Vouching-at-a-distance on a gospel-capital is the tell that waiting is still a road.

Road-hands passing through sleep in the town that was chosen early and stayed thin, on the way to a town that was not chosen this year.

Vaethorn-folk custom: light state, hot faith, alms. No list. Threnmaieth would like one. Ornled would not understand why anyone stays.

The unvouched Struck are the ache this seat was built to meet with faith rather than machinery.

A notice chalked on the gift-hall door, Eolthael, Cut-year 387. Vaethod's hand. The Tree is not named as sick.

> *The hinge is this week. Beds on the camp-streets first. Someone who came to wait is a guest. Someone who came to count us is a clerk, and I can tell.*
>
> *If the Tree speaks we stay. If it does not I will not invent a colour. I will not send until the week is over. I have sent before. I will not pretend I have not.*
>
> *The spring is not a stone. The leaf is on the lip. Do not ask me what it is for.*

The gospel will hear the notice as a slight even if it is only a week.

Orentel (Lestrand's seat)

Orentel *(OREN-tel)* is the capital of Lestrand. It is a salt-city. In the name, *th* has worn to *t*. People say *Orentel*. Lestrand-folk will say **the Salt Quay** and mean the city the way they say *the bed-house* and mean the bank. Notes and berths meet here. The White Note House is on the third quay, north side. It is a desk in the city. **Sorim** *(SOR-im)* is the factor who charters berths and files occupancy. Tens of thousands live here. The Tree-town is the smaller half.

An inner-sea estuary on Strandoren, facing Maiethorn across the oldest water in the world. The Salt Walk used to land here. When the walk stopped being required on this coast, the berths did not empty.

They changed jobs. Adaptive reuse at city scale: a Tree-town that grew a quay, then a second quay, then a leap-frog of warehouses along the tide, until the nucleated square was the smaller half of a salt-city.

Lestrand is guild self-rule carried as far as it goes. Orentel is the square that proves it: a charter-council of houses and craft-guilds speaks for the city. Citizenship-by-witness runs smoothly because reach is high. The three pillars (Long-Lived memory, Bound word, Far-Voiced feeling) are infrastructure. An unvouched person is a transaction that cannot clear.

What this quay still sells is prestige: a first-year pilgrimage, booked as a product, with empty berths in Eolthael held for households who can pay to walk a walk they do not need. People who had to come still eat in the lofts. Mataero files them as occupied beds.

Site. The estuary is why anyone stopped. Deep water, a sheltered sound, a tide that writes the working day. The graft took on the **rise above the first quay** (Cut-years 40 to 89, wealthy coast, a paying next), and the oldest houses still face that Tree. The road used to come inland from the berth toward a healthier origin-canopy. Then this canopy grew up. Then the berth became the point.

Water is the tide, cisterns on the rise, and paid wells in the warehouse-leap. Food is the river-plain, the inner-sea catch, whatever the crossing pays. Fuel is drift, peat, and what the factor-houses book. The Taken-In rent **leaf-lots** by the season; they are not a nation. Selkie hearths are densest on the water, a lot of shoreline, not a gate.

No walls that matter. The boundary is the last crane and the ranging-yard inland. Low governance looks like this: the council charters the guild, never the person.

Hallowquay is a lesser inner quay. A fox-born broker might still be *of Hallowquay*. That byname was already in the world. The seat is Orentel.

The square. Composite: nucleated Tree-town on the rise, linear quays along the tide, leap-frog warehouses where a fire or a silted berth made the next stretch cheaper than rebuilding. The interesting streets are the edges where the rise meets the salt.

- **The Tree at the centre.** Still the civic heart, even when the money is downhill. Mature Hand. Leaf-Fall is a civic and commercial milestone: a family's colour is watched for what guild it opens. The square still Turns local children for free. That free Turning is the older job the quay cannot price without noticing itself.
- **The first quay.** The Salt Walk's old landing. Empty Eolthael berths held as prestige; wool through Hale-month covering a shrine. A smell of earth out of season when a pot, not a child, is the passenger.
- **The third quay, north side.** The White Note House. Ledan's desk. Mataero's loft in the rise behind, twelve beds, north bed not to let. Century instruments. The house is one desk on the quay. The charter-council speaks for the city. Lestrand will only count it as success.

- **The release-house.** Ael-hall as playhouse and outlet, ticketed. Superb if you can pay. The queue outside it is the have-and-have-not gap at street height.
- **The leaf-lots.** Rented green, not Mother's common. They will not follow you home, and home is a loft if they did.
- **The beast-yard.** Hired ranging at the inland edge, not a wild-leave. Two-Bodied haulage is a trade dynasty if the match was priced that way.
- **The ticket-infirmaries.** The Stillers on the downwind edge. Excellent. For those who can reach them. The queue is longest here too.
- **The far shed.** Returned work past the last crane. Same logic as a tannery.

Homes accommodate becomings. Mixed Kinds. A Sands-Fox at a desk is unremarkable if they have warranting. The shadow economy (smuggled green, sold vouching, off-book Terms) is alleys the guilds pretend not to charter.

This canopy Turns at home. The Salt Walk is optional. The bed-house collected. Empty Eolthael berths are still shaped like a landing. Pots still take a child's space. A First-Hand year can be booked as a winter. The berths are still in use because the walk is not over. It is the present. A Hand can fail. If Orentel's Tree sickened, this quay would be the neighbour's week. It has not. The council counts occupancy.

Prestige is the job on the street: the walk you do not need, sold. That is how a rich coast gets a capital on a charter-council. Devotion that lands here is a hymn the release-house will schedule. Necessity in the loft is Mataero's eye. The city's face is the winter it sells.

Salt sits on the Tree's roots in Eolthael. Orentel will not say why. A hall-keeper will schedule around it. A book-hand will not put it in a term.

Offices. The charter-council: houses and craft-guilds. Watches the guild, never the individual. **Sorim** is the factor who can be asked who chartered the empty berths this Eolthael. They will answer in occupancy. Ledan is the one who writes at the White Note.

Tree-tenders: Lestrand's word for wardens. Practice-first, not Kind. Speak the fall as a civic fact. A colour that opens a guild is still a colour.

The White Note House: Ledan writes; Mataero lets. The north bed is house custom. Two fates, two doors.

The Book-Hands: ordinary on this quay. Signing-watch as prestige if you book it. Bound Terms stay as they were written. The Book-Hands work this quay and have no seat of their own.

Road-hands / graft-carts: rare; a pot on an Eolthael berth is cargo to the clerk.

The Tithe-poor fade while the city steps around them. That is the injustice. Nothing is policed. Everything is priced.

A berth-slate, first quay, Eolthael through Hale-month, Cut-year 387. Sorim's hand. The Tree is not mentioned.

> *Eolthael berths 1-4: held. Do not load wool. A First-Hand year is not cargo. I have explained this to the crane.*
>
> *Berth 5: earth. A pot is cargo. I have explained this to the family who wanted 5 for a child. They could not hold 1-4. I did not invent the hold.*
>
> *The rise still Turns for free. That is a Tree-tender matter. The quay is a hold matter. If you need both in one week you are at the wrong desk.*
>
> *White Note, third north: not a berth. Do not send me their conversions. I do not keep house-years.*

Ledan will hear the slate as a neighbour who cannot convert. Mataero will hear occupancy.

The White Note House (placed, not crowned)

The White Note House is a road-house that became a desk. It is a deathless house of the trusted note. **Ledan** writes century-loans from a founding-summer the house calls the White Note's count. **Mataero** *(mah-TAY-ro)* lets the loft. The north bed is house custom, kept empty, a founding-name the junior is not to copy onto a term. People say *the White Note*. Lestrand still says *the bed-house* and means the bank. Founding about Cut-year 80 (White Note year 200 = Cut-year 280, per Ledan's conversion-problem). The quay-desk sits on Orentel's third quay, north side; the inland loft is in the rise behind. The desk is one house on that quay.

The same fortune as the Third Hearth, later. In Brenvaeth the house was beds, porridge, and credit for a walk you could not miss twice. When the walk stopped being required in the core, the Long-Lived still remembered every debtor, and the paper outlived the pilgrimage-season. The desk sat down on Orentel's third quay because that is where notes now move. The inland upper room is occupancy: twelve beds in the rise behind the salt, looking at a Tree that still Turns for free.

What it sells now: century instruments, trusted paper, a First-Hand year you can book (the held-over winter as product), loft-terms to wool through Hale-month, and still the old kind of note for a necessity-family: eat now, pay on the home-walk. Same paper, two jobs. The clerk who files both as occupancy does not have to see the difference.

The north bed is how a bank proves it used to be an inn. Empty is not a shrine, Mataero says. Empty is a bed they are not charging for. Ledan says the house is the house it always was. The founding-book

has a name. Thilim, inland, still holds a far-cape name the White Note does not. Lestrand will only count this house as success. Orentel's charter-council will only count it as one ticket among many.

How to get a term. A street door on the salt. No chapel-front. A counting-room that smells of ink and tide. Ledan's stool faces the door, not the water. Mataero has the inland key.

1. You name what you want: a century-instrument, a loft-term, a First-Hand year, the old necessity-note.
2. Ledan asks which count the customer wants written: house-year, Cut-year, or a third date a Lestrand court invented last generation. They can convert. They will make you say which.
3. If the paper is a First-Hand year, the term is written here and the berth is **not**. Ledan will send you to Sorim for the hold and will not walk you there. Netstrand still has to charter the hull. Orenbren still has to house the sleep.

Morning at the desk is conversion. Evening is the tide-bell, then Mataero walking the rise to check the north bed. Occupied is a session. Empty is the custom.

Features. The quay-desk: third quay, north side, Orentel. Ledan's count; conversions to Eoloren-count when a court makes them; three dates for one summer still a live query. The inland loft: in the Tree-town rise, not on the water. Twelve beds in Mataero's slate; eight let; four open, and the north bed is one of the four; three are for Eolthael, and the north bed is not to let. The founding-book: Held names as credit-tokens. Not read aloud on a term. A smell of earth out of season when a pot, not a child, is the passenger. Cargo, the clerk files. Next berth over, a First-Hand year is not cargo. Sorim will not convert that either.

No mortal court can check a Long-Lived's memory of a ford two hundred summers back. That is why the note holds. It is also why a grandchild can owe a walk they cannot point to. Spreading Trees did not make the paper kind.

Maiethlir (Threnmaieth's seat)

Maiethlir *(my-eth-LEER)* is the capital of Threnmaieth. The name keeps *th*. People say *Maiethlir*. This is where they started counting a hearth that was already holy. The First Seat sits in the Motherwood beside this country. **Rithim** *(RITH-im)* is the Speaker who names the leaf-colour at Leaf-Fall. In a small town the warden Speaks. Here the office has its own person. Maiethlir is a counted city, smaller than Orentel, and older. The clerks will tell you a number after every Eolthael.

A thaw-river town on Maiethorn, in the Sacred Core and not in the grove. Snowmelt comes down from Lirorn's range; the river, the Core-thaw, runs toward the Old Crossing. Maiethlir sat down where the water slowed enough to hold a Hand. It is an origin-town of Cut-years 0 to 40. It stands one or two days' walk from the wood, on a *different road* than Orenbren's Near Mile. Orenbren lodges the approach. This river counted the people who stayed.

The extra mile used to come through with the thaw. When Hands made the origin-walk optional, the lodging emptied toward Orenbren's beds. The rooms did not stay empty. Clerks filled them. Adaptive reuse at city scale: a pilgrimage-street that learned house-names on a tablet.

Threnmaieth coils near the sacred centre and wants everyone on the Threnhael, the counted list. Maiethlir is the square that proves the coil without owning the Tree: the colour that falls is a hymn *and* a line. Maiethvael shares the Mother and refuses the list, same hymns, opposite paper. Maiethvael's people live downriver, along the first day below the Down Gate.

What this city still does is devotion: the extra mile remains the civic season, now written under the census. People who had to come still sleep in an uncounted loft when the soil up-range is thin. People who paid book a counted winter. The crown's roll sits on top of that older traffic. It does not replace it.

Site. The thaw-river is why anyone stopped. Ford, mill, a Hand planted beside the water because the first carrying followed living earth and a day's drink. The Motherwood is a dark on one horizon. You can walk to the grove. Most Hands-children do not. The college is in those clearings. Maiethlir's square is the river and the counted Tree.

Water is the river, conduits the crown maintains, cisterns in the old pilgrim-streets. Food is the Core's plenty. Fuel is the wood's edge, which the Seat will not let a crown cut without a leave. Proximity is pressure, not ownership. The Taken-In work the **tended green** the crown furnishes; they are not a nation.

A wall exists and is old. It was for floods and for a generation of argument, not for a siege the Core no longer expects. The interesting streets are inside it, where the old extra-mile meets the tablet-hall.

The square. Concentric around the canopy, then radial along the river and the old extra-mile. Ordered the way a counted city becomes ordered: not a grid drawn last week, an accretion that learned numbers.

- **The Tree at the centre.** A mature Hand, not the First. Civic and sacred heart. Leaf-Fall is a joyous holy day that is also a state registration. The colour is Spoken. A clerk waits to copy it. **Rithim** Speaks. They do not always let the copy happen in the same breath.
- **The tablet-hall.** The Threnhael's local office. It stands beside the Tree. Names, colours, marriages of heritable Conditions *noticed*. Outsiders hear "the Counting." Clerks say they keep the realm hale.
- **The counted hall.** Ael-hall as outlet *and* attendance. A Far-Voiced hour furnished through the crown's channel. To be cut off is framed as your lapse.
- **The old extra-mile.** Still a street. Upper rooms that used to sleep pilgrims are clerk-dorms. A Held bed would offend the roll; the roll has not found all of them. The Watching keep a room under a chapel the wardens recut (the Grown-Over).

- **The tended green.** Crown-furnished commons. They will not follow you home. Home is on file if they did.
- **The ranging-roll.** Two-Bodied leave at the edge, noticed. Not a Kind-flag.
- **The crown-stiller.** Excellent medicine, downwind, through the channel. The Bound are watched past their hazard, dressed as safety.
- **The far shed.** Returned work past the last conduit. Filed.

Homes accommodate becomings, and the accommodation is on the tablet. Mixed Kinds. A Fox of the Snows down from Lirorn is a guest with a name. The late week here is *unfiled*, which is the local crime.

The clerks will tell you a number. It changes after every Eolthael.

This canopy Turns at home. The Near Mile is Orenbren's job. The extra mile is a civic season. The Motherwood is a walk. The thaw-road still brings a necessity-family when up-range soil is thin. An uncounted loft still smells like Hale-month. The road is still in use because the walk is not over. It is the present. A Hand can fail. The roll would like those summers filed. Devotion is the pilgrimage the clerks moved into.

Devotion is the job on the street: people still come because the hinge is holy. The Threnhael is the layer, a tablet beside the Tree. That is how a pious core gets a capital. The grove stays in the Motherwood. The injustice is that the layer learned to withhold the green.

The thaw runs louder the week before the fall. Maiethlir will not say why. Rithim will Speak over it. A clerk may write the noise down as snowmelt. That writing is the clerk's.

Offices. Speaker / town-warden (Rithim): Reckoned Hands pressure, practice-first, not Kind. Speaks the fall truly. The copy is a second, lesser witnessing. Some summers they let it happen in the same breath. Some they do not. The crown has not replaced them. The Seat has not recalled them.

The tablet-clerks, Long-Lived among them, memory bent to the census rather than free to check it. Among them, someone may remember what a line was made to overwrite.

The First Seat is a college in the Motherwood, beside this country. Some Speakers cooperate with the roll (they believe they are keeping the realm hale). Some refuse. A pilgrim who asks Rithim where the college is will be pointed at the wood.

Orenbren lodging: a day's argument along the other road. They witness who slept. The colour is Rithim's to Speak. Threnmaieth would like the lodging-rolls.

Watchers in the oldest district: a second reading alongside the wardens. Filed as the Grown-Over.

The Kept are pitied *and* noted as unmarked. A household whose bloodline and upkeep are both on file cannot easily refuse the crown anything.

A Threnhael copy-slip, tablet-hall, Eolthael, Cut-year 387. The Speaker's name is on the recto. The clerk's hand is on the verso. The Tree is named as hale.

> ***Recto, Rithim.*** *Spoken: storm-grey. Witnessed in the square. The hug was not this child's. I have said the colour. I have not said the line. The river was loud. I will not wait for it.*
>
> ***Verso, clerk.*** *Copied: Two-Bodied, named to the Threnhael, household already on file. Speaker delayed the copy until after the hymn. Delay noted. River-noise noted as snowmelt. The unmarked in the same household noted. Provision continues through the counted channel.*
>
> *The wood was asked whether the Speaker is a Reckoned Hand. The wood did not answer in this hall.*

The delay is devotion: a pilgrimage-town that still thinks the hymn comes first. The First Seat, asked later, will say the Tree witnessed.

The twelve seats

The three famous corners are above: Threnmaieth, Lestrand, and Vaethorn, with their cities Maiethlir, Orentel, and Eolvaeth. These twelve are the other seats of power. Each one is a capital, a city, a town, or a written refusal to build a city. Harrow's Green is a square in Saelvaeth's orbit. The twelve seats are the ones named in this section. Six charter-towns around Raitin, the shelves of Lirorn, and the pockets between grafts stay unnamed. No capital is marked with a star on a map. The First Seat stays in the Motherwood. It is the college of tree-wardens.

Read an entry this way. The first lines say what the place is and where it sits. **The work** is the job the town does, and who does it. A neighbour uses a given name. A clerk in a list-land says the house-name first. The last sentences are habits. People do them and will not say why.

Seinbrun (Maiethvael's capital)

(SAYN-brun.) Seinbrun is Maiethvael's capital. It is a large city in the warm core of Maiethorn. It keeps no census. People call the country the Gift-Realm. Charters write *Maiethvael*. The city provides public greens, a hall, and medicine through its congregations and guilds. Maiethlir is the counted city. The Down-Bank is the stretch of road below Maiethlir's Down Gate. You can spend a day among Gift-folk on that road and still be short of Seinbrun. The city is more than a day from Maiethlir, down the Core-thaw and north of Maiethlir on the atlas. How much more is not recorded. During pilgrimage

season the Motherwood is in sight. The grove stays outside the city. A town Tree stands beside the furnished hall. A child’s leaf-colour stays off any list.

The work is the hall, with the green beside it. Vuthbraen keeps the hall. Raermu keeps the medicine basket. Breillai left the hymn. The green, the hall, and the medicine went together. The hall can still set a bowl. The net stays where the hymn is. A neighbour says the given name. There is no house to put first.

The furnished hall sets an empty bowl at the end of the table, away from the pot, and clears it with the others. Seinbrun will not say why. On the day a household leaves the hymn, a neighbour stacks their green pots in the lane, still planted. They will not say why. Smaller towns around the city stay unnamed.

Rothallo (Orenbren’s capital)

(roh-THAL-oh.) Rothallo is a walled city. It is one day’s walk from the Motherwood. People still say **the Inner Close**, and the Close. The walls answer to those names. Rothallo is that city, and it stays inside Orenbren. Smaller towns and villages lie around it in the lodging-country. This book does not name them. The Third Hearth, the Mill-hold, and Nelath are in that country. Rothallo is the capital. Those three keep their own jobs: a hearth, a sick-Tree lodging, and the road-end.

The First Seat is in the wood beyond the wall. Rothallo is the capital. A Hand stands inside the walls. The city has no speaker of its own for Leaf-Fall. A warden of the First Seat may come in for Turning-Week and Speak the fall there. If a colour is copied afterward, the copy is the Close’s. The Closed Heirs rank Conditioned people in the Book of Tithes, kept inside the walls. Orenbren calls the arrangement a guest-compact: its inns lodge anyone outside the wall, and the Book rules inside it. Orenbren records who slept. The Close records who owes. Neither copies the other’s records.

The work is the Book. Delamem keeps it. The pages assign taxes, restrictions, and turns of work, on top of the Tithe a person already carries. Everyone who lives inside the walls owes the Close turns of work, the way a town expects each household to take a turn on the watch. A person with a Condition is given the heavier turns, and more of them. Talnin is still the heir whose tenth year is not finished. A neighbour says a given name. A clerk says the house first. *Closed* on a roster is a rank kept with the house-name. The line can cast a person out and keep the house on them.

What a visitor sees. A visitor does not need to read the Book to see the rank. At a meal in a Closed house, the Kept sit nearest the host, and a guest with a Condition is shown to the far end. When the Book is read aloud, the Kept sit on the front benches. Only a Kept person may hold a key to a gate in the wall, to the Book’s house, to a cistern, or to a granary. In front of a clerk of the Book, a Kept person’s account is written as what happened, and the other account is written underneath as “also said.” The children of the Closed houses learn their letters at a school beside the Book’s house, where

the teacher, **Volnai** *(VOL-nai)*, teaches that a hug is rare. The lesson is wrong about the count. A person with a Condition who lives inside the walls works for wages, keeps what they earn, can own a stall, and can walk out of the gate on any day it is open. The Book has no claim on anyone who has left. Orders and Houses has the Walled Book and the Inner Close in full.

Brimaen, house Lanbru, keeps a stall inside on a licence the Book can revoke. Breolnir, house Tethnae, writes who slept. Methei, house Sithlaen, is Given and lives inside the walls. Methei's turn of work is on the beds outside the gate, and Methei can walk out of the gate on any open day. Methei has stayed. The same person can be a guest on one page and owe a turn on the other. The pages will not be copied onto each other.

The outer gate is shut for the length of a kettle's boil, on a morning with no crowd. Rothallo will not say why. Bread for the beds outside is cut while it is still too hot to eat, and the heel is set on the wall-stone. The beds will not say why. A Closed child, the week before the tenth year, leaves one shoe by the Book's step and walks the lane in the other. The lane will not say why.

Larbril (Saelthael's city)

(LAR-bril.) Larbril is a medium city where the west road meets the Well-wash, short of the pass. People say the Sown Tree. Walking west, the Shelf-gate is still ahead. Walking east, the dry is in front of you.

Ornsael stays the smaller well-town, farther into the dry. Its drink is a well. Larbril's drink, when it has one, is the wash. Dry country lies along the road between the wash and the well. The Dry Stair is another rise. People climb it so they know a dare from a Tree. The city is here because the road meets the wash.

The wash is a river in a kind Liren and a silt-line in a cruel one. A Hand stands at the meeting. It Speaks most years. A missed week is weather. Fox of the Sands hearths are dense in this country. That is terrain. Brormei is not chosen for being Fox-born.

The work is the meeting. Brormei says what the wash is this week, and whether a column goes west toward the pass. A neighbour says Brormei. There is no house to put first. Ornsael's well-share is Ornsael's. The pass-levy is Lirorn's, taken at Tasain. Larbril keeps the road and the wash in one place.

When the Well-wash is a silt-line, Brormei still wets the meeting-stone from a jar. They will not say why. A cart bound west is held while the driver sets a pebble on the dry line. Larbril will not say why.

Votaer (the Hinge Shore's port)

(VOH-tayr.) Votaer is one of the largest cities on the Motherland coast. It faces Orentel. Hulls are classified on these quays. The Hush-rate is charged here. Towns along the rest of the shore stay

unnamed.

Orentel prices the crossing. Votaer sorts it. A child, a pot of living earth, a family on a neighbour's week: the bell can sound the same, and a clerk writes which docket. The White Note stands on Orentel's third quay. Trees on this shore are healthy. Faith is worn thinner than in Maiethvael, because a dock teaches categories. Selkie families work these quays, as they do on any old water. The docket does not belong to a hearth.

The work is the classification quay. Tumair writes the hull: pilgrim, pot, person, or cargo. Lertho charges the Hush-rate. A neighbour says the given name. There is no house to put first. The blessing and the docket happen in the same breath.

Tumair chalks the hull's class under the waterline, where the next tide takes the mark. They will not say why. Lertho counts the rate aloud, sets the last coin in the box, and takes it out once before it stays. They will not say why. A cook-fire on the quay is put out when the bell rings for a sail that is not in sight. Votaer will not say why. A dry net hangs on the blessing-rail on days when no one asks for a hymn. The quay will not say why.

Tasain (Lirorn's town)

(tah-SAYN.) Tasain is a walled town in a sheltered valley below the Shelf-gate, where the west road comes down. People stay the winter here. Maiethlir is the counted city on the thaw-river. This town takes the levy at the gate.

The town gate takes the levy. The Shelf-gate is the pass above the valley. The Noon Pass is a third road, higher and older. Larbril is the city on the dry side of the pass, short of the climb if you are walking west. Villages and hamlets stay on the shelves. This book does not name them.

The work is the levy, taken at the town gate. The levy is reckoned on how much snow fell the winter before. Narol of the Pass is dead. The household that inherited Narol's toll still levies, and still asks Break-rate in a kind year. A traveller at the gate meets a collector of that household. The collector is not named here and says the toll is Narol's. A shelf whose graft sickens is a long way from a stiller. The valley takes the due in shelter. The shelves pay in isolation.

In a kind year, before the levy is taken, a bowl of shelf-snow is left on the gate-stone until it is water. Tasain will not say why.

Raitin (Brenledd's throne-city)

(RAY-tin.) Raitin is a river-city on Strandoren, inland of the Ledger Coast and south-west of Orentel on the atlas. It is one of the largest on that shore. The days from Orentel are not recorded. People say the Hearth-League. The league stays a league of hearths.

Six charter-towns sit around it. This book does not name them. The shared list is seven hearths. Raitin is one. People still recite Nidtol when Lestrand offers to deal with one ruler instead of seven hearths. Nidtol is the hearth that made the league's first shared refusal, in Cut-year 174, after the Grey Summer, and the name is recited for that. Raitin is the river-city. Raitin's water is the river under the stair. The Chart-run is Lunbra's.

The work is the council hall, at the head of the river stair. Turvo keeps the notes. Sulnu carries a cleared ticket down to the stair. Nubo is vouched in this city and still unknown where another hearth did not stand them. A neighbour says the given name. There is no house to put first. A note can clear in this hall and still die in the next hearth. The league calls the gap local.

Turvo turns a cleared note face-down before the next hearth is called. They will not say why. The hall sets one cup at the end of the table and does not fill it. Raitin will not say why. Bread for a council meeting is broken at the river door. The heel stays on the sill until the meeting ends. They will not say why. On the morning a note is due, the river-stairs are swept from the water up toward the hall. The stair will not say why.

Naenor (Leddvael's port)

(NAY-nor.) Naenor is a large port on its own stretch of indented coast, down the coast south-west of Orentel and south of Raitin on the atlas. The days are not recorded. It is slightly smaller than Orentel. People say the Reckoned Gift. Votaer is the port that faces the Hinge Shore. Naenor stands on its own coast. Towns along the rest of that coast stay unnamed.

Leaf-Fall here is a festival and a signing-watch. A Tithe is a term serviced. The Bound are employed as the shape of honesty. The city will file a contract. It will not copy Threnmaieth's list. It wins the signing and loses the berth. A First-Hand year is booked at Orentel. This city sells the signing. The Book-Hands stamp and recite in this wind. They have no seat of their own. Terms stay as they were written.

The work is the signing-watch, on the book-table in the square. Derdil stands it. A neighbour says Derdil. There is no house to put first. A household that calls the colour a gift is read as a bad debtor. The Bound are safe here, and they are over-read.

Derdil stamps the wax, then warms the stamp in a closed hand before the next page. They will not say why. The watch reads a term aloud and turns the page with the left hand only. Naenor will not say why. At Leaf-Fall the square sets the Bound witness's chair with its back to the Tree. The square will not say why.

Lunbra (Trenledd’s city)

(LUN-bra.) Lunbra is a large, wealthy city on the Chart-run, four to eight days upriver of Orentel. People say the Worn Count. Trenledd’s governing office stays unnamed. Towns through the filed country stay unnamed.

Stone fronts, paid chairs, guild doors left open onto the square so the coin is visible from the street. You are on the roll so commerce and hazard can find you again. There is no hymn that makes the list a stewardship. Threnmaieth at least claims to keep you hale. The Worn Count claims to keep you findable. A Hand stands in the square. The number on the back of a stone is a count.

The work is the roll-room. Vamar keeps a column: who owes, who Turned, who can be found. The file is Melro, Vamar. A neighbour says Vamar. A clerk says the house first. Vamar is not the governing office. In Trenledd the column may file a person under the house that pays, including a house they dislike. The city shows the money. The roll is how a person is allowed near it.

Vamar sets a coin on the open page. The coin is not the fee. They will not say why. On the morning a new house is written, the stones in the square are turned number-down. Lunbra will not say why. A newcomer is shown the expensive chair and is not asked to sit until the house has been said. The room will not say why.

Braetu (the Night Shore’s harbour)

(BRAY-too.) Braetu is a harbour city on Strandoren’s west and south face, on the West Water. It is smaller than Orentel. People say the Night Shore. Towns along the rest of the shore stay unnamed.

A crossing is quoted here the way another shore talks about a pilgrimage. The First-Hand year is assembled on the old water: a Night Shore hull, the White Note’s terms, Orentel’s berth. Braetu is the first of those desks. The far run is two to four weeks in fair weather. Beyond the last capes is the storm-wall. This quay does not book Kumbaan.

They keep a dark book: quoted crossings that did not come back. Houses pay to keep a lamp on a name. One berth stays unlit. No house is attached to it.

The work is the quote-desk. Mursur writes the far crossing and takes the fee for the lamp. A neighbour says Mursur. There is no house to put first. No house stands on the unlit berth. The lamp is a charge. The dark berth is not billed.

Mursur lights a name’s lamp with a spill from the cook-fire, not from another lamp. They will not say why. The far figure is written, blotted, and written again the same. Mursur will not say why. People leaving the harbour touch the unlit berth’s ring, and do not hang a line on it. Braetu will not say why.

Sanbreo (Ornled's town)

(san-BREE-oh.) Sanbreo is a town on Heskoren's slate-shore, the west coast. It is on the brink of a small city, and it is still a town. People say the Outer Ledger. A beach-fee can be paid here when a hull arrives. The beach faces west, toward the last capes and the storm-wall beyond them. The frontier coast that faces the West Water is on the east side of Heskoren. A hull that wants Sanbreo's beach comes round the capes. Villages in the pockets around the town stay unnamed.

The roofs have filled the pocket. They did not grow a congregation or a counted hall. The fee here is a beach. Braetu quotes the far crossing. Vaethorn may bless a landing and may not levy it. Ornled takes the fee anyway. The slate and the beach-fee are what this town sells.

The work is the slate, on the wall inside the shore gate. The first line is still the sentence Vathne cut: the town will not wait with a hymn for a stick that drowned. The wood of the wall is newer than the words. Someone recopied the line. Vathne is that line. Whoever is on the shore gate that day cuts the fee on the slate, and that person is not named. An unvouched Struck is met with a rope, a deal, or a neighbour. A hull can pay. A neighbour who cannot barter a Tithe still slides.

When a hull has paid, the coin stays on the slate's sill until the hull is gone. Sanbreo will not say why.

Vaelhesk (the land is the seat)

(VAYL-hesk.) The land is the seat. People say the Far Yield, and the Yield. There is no new city and no new name. Old greens, ancestor-doors, first meals. The Mother's wood is a guest. A Cutting-leave without the meal is a claiming. Villages and hamlets stay on the old greens. A traveler who asks for the seat is pointed at a door.

There is no settlement dot. The First Bowl stays the guest-grove, a planting on this land. Harrow's Green is the live-front square. Struck and the Taken-In are read as the land's own children. A neighbour's week to a Motherfaith Tree can be refused on purpose. Vaethorn reads those children as Kept-for-want. That disagreement decides whether a child travels. No new person is seated on the refusal.

Natai (Saelvaeth's town)

(NAH-tye.) Natai is a march-town on Heskoren's moving edge. People say the Sown Waiting, and March-folk. A graft has taken here. The canopy is a town's Hand. Harrow's Green keeps the luckier canopy.

On the Known Map, Natai sits west of Harrow's Green, between Sanbreo and the square. Harrow's square is the canopy. The ford is downstream of Harrow's rise. This gate is the march-town. Other towns where a graft has taken stay unnamed. Hamlets between them stay unnamed.

Harrow’s Green stays the live-front square it already is. Natai is the march-town. The Three Hamlets Past the Ford stay the three hamlets. The Hush lets this march take a pot without a Vaethorn waiting-due. Someone has to stand where the queue can be shouted at.

The work is the march-voice. Dumu stands it. A neighbour says Dumu. There is no house to put first. Haelin keeps Harrow’s square. Tora of Brenod keeps the walk from the ford. Dumu keeps this gate. The town can be blamed for a queue it did not write. Harrow’s has the canopy the hamlets can see. Natai has the person to blame.

While a complaint is said, Dumu leaves the gate-latch on the post, and puts it back in the catch when the speaker turns. They will not say why.

Other Places

You can walk into three places nobody dated: the Low Wall, the Seeing-Ring, and the Dry Stair. Ndenjoo is a hall on Kumbaan where a guest sits down. The Mill-hold, the First Bowl, and Nelath are towns the roads already use. The twelve seats are named in The Fifteen Powers and the Gazetteer. Harrow's Green is a grove-town in Saelvaeth's march. Ornsael is the well-town in Saelthael's dry country, and Larbril is the city. The First Seat stays in the wood. Two claimants on one green stays unwritten.

The Low Wall

The Low Wall stands in Orenbren lodging-country, in the first days out from the Motherwood. Rothallo is the capital, and people still say the Inner Close for that city. The stone is shoulder-high. Three gaps are used as gates. The name-stone is blank. A garden-end sits against an inn's back wall. The stone is a different quarry from Rothallo. The Close's claim that it is the same wall stays a claim. People found the wall already standing. It has no date.

Enter by the cart-gap, the person-gap the Close's list of turns sometimes sends a walk through, the socket-gap an Old Ways first-meal uses, a crawl under the name-stone, or the garden-end loft.

Pressure. The Book wants a chip that files as Rothallo's quarry. Watchers block a chisel. The lodging-guild wants climbers off before Eolthael, and the Close's walkers off the garden now.

Discovery. A wrong quarry chip is still under the fill put down in Hale-month of Cut-year 381. The chip is the other quarry. It has no year on it. Rothallo's stone is the city's own. There is a pot-ring. A knife-ribbon was left in error. A Near-Mile kitchen knife on a ribbon marks a Closing summer in a house. The wall carries no date. The Tree carries no date. The fill names no enemy. The chip leaves the question open.

Actors. Delamem, of the Close, wants the chip filed as Rothallo's quarry. Thuda keeps the inn at the garden-end and wants the climbers off the wall. A Watcher at the panel blocks a chisel. An Orenbren guild runner brings the lodging-guild's complaint. **Nurreith** *(NUR-rayth)* dug the name-stone's bed that summer for the lodging-guild, and will finish the afternoon if the bed is opened again.

The Seeing-Ring

The Seeing-Ring is a Watching hill on Maiethorn. The grove, and the First Seat, stay in the Motherwood. An uncounted ring sits below. Later shrine-work sits above, and the roof is removed. The ring-walk goes clockwise. Four out-looks face an origin smear, Old Crossing weather, and two that face nothing. People found the ring already standing. It has no date.

Enter by the hill path, mismatched shrine steps, an under-ring crawl, or Tithsael's night.

Pressure. A clerk has a chisel. A warden wants the roof back. In Eolthael someone ties a cloth ribbon on the lintel-socket. By Leddorn it is gone. Tithsael takes a colour-ribbon off. A hug-ribbon stays. The cloth does not Speak. They will not say why the ribbon was a colour.

Discovery. There is a dual pecked mark, and a clay pot-ring. The marks name no one who stood here. This hill holds no gate of the Closed Seat. The two gaps face nothing. The ribbon is cloth on the socket.

Actor. Tithsael keeps the night.

The Dry Stair

In the Saelthael Rain-Shadow, the Dry Stair is a rise above its own well-town. Ornsael is the other well-town, farther into the dry, and its drink is a well. Larbril is the city. Worn steps lead to a door-stone and a dry basin. The pecking was cut for something other than a cistern. A warden's dead slip is still in the upper basin. People found the stair already standing. It has no date.

Enter by the flight (skip the broken step), the door-stone threshold, or a crawl to a second dry basin.

Pressure. The warden wants another pot. A clerk wants riser-scratches. A child who missed Eolthael is unTurned, and the town will not call them Kept. Someone will ask you to sit the door-stone with them overnight.

Discovery. A salt-white ring is there, mineral or brush-ash. The steps end at the door-stone and the dry basin. A later warden planted a slip in the upper basin. The slip died. What is left is a thumb of dead wood in a crack at the lip. The wood stays dead. People say the stair refused a mother. The rock was dry, and the slip died of that.

Ornsael is a living well-town whose trouble is the water. The Dry Stair is the climb, and the basin stays dry.

Ndenjoo

Ndenjoo is a hill-hall on Kumbaan. The own-name is *nden-JOH*, and sailors say **the Feeding Hill**. It is one of the Paps. The green hill is honeycombed underneath, with pasture and standing-stones on the turf, and the life is below. The valley comes here on the bright nights. There is no Tree. There is a table.

Njunda opens it because it was their grandmother's, and because it still fits the crowd. That reputation is the claim. **Soonke** sits the storm-beach below and stays on the sand. They walk a living wreck uphill. A guest's first night starts at the hall. **Saalo** of the valley wants a crossing *out*, to find Waandi, who left two moons ago. **Nolas** of a Netstrand hull sat twice, kin inside the hall, and will not go back to a ship.

This hill has no Tree, and a mainland Turning does not run here. What the hill carries from the wall is people who arrived and did not leave, and people who want to leave and cannot book a thinning.

Life is under the hill. You walk into a Pap and come out at a board. The extra place is set slightly back, every meal that matters. To omit it is the one impiety. Daylight is a Sabbath of sleep. A mainlander loud at noon is a problem the whole hall feels. On one night of the moon sailors call Yoltal, the heel of the loaf is eaten first. Ndenjoo will not say why. A guest who asks is given more bread.

Getting there. You cannot book a passage to Ndenjoo. You are on the sand or you are not. Soonke, who sits the storm-beach, decides whether you are alive. Njunda, who keeps the hall, decides whether you are kin. The second sitting is how you belong on the isle. A mainland watch keeps its own papers. A road-word still helps you leave a Strandoren quay before you sail. It is the mainland custom of being vouched for. On the hill, nobody asks for it. The shore-sitters leave the arrived where the beach put them.

An extra place is already laid. Nolas is off the ship because the hall counts them as kin. A wreck can be walked up the hill. A word of Waandi, who left, can come in with a guest. These are matters for the hall. A warden who arrives is still a guest. There is no Tree to tend.

What can come up the hill is a wreck walked uphill tonight, the hands stopping, noon-noise, or a hull rumour.

Said to the extra place before the hands arrive, a bright night. A second line was added by Njunda after Nolas sat twice.

> *We have counted you. Sit. If you have a name we have not learned it yet; if you have a colour we have no tree to read it.*
>
> *If you have sat twice, you are of the table. The table is not a ship. Sleep when the moon is down. The sand does not owe you a second hull.*

The Mill-hold

The Mill-hold is the sick-Tree town. Everyday speech says *the Mill-hold*. Travellers who only saw the drain say *the culvert*. It stands in Orenbren lodging-country, two days past Brenthael on the Near Mile, six days out from the grove in the count the road already uses. Rothallo is the capital. Brenthael is the neighbour Hand, two days back toward the grove. Its Tree is sound. A few hundred hearths sit around one mill-race and one canopy.

For a generation they Turned at home. In this Liren the culvert choked. It keeps spring-water off the roots. The mill-race stayed full. The Hand stood in it. Root blight is waterlogged soil, crowded roots, a drain someone assumed someone else cleared. It is this year. Unsound wood spends the week. The children walk in, toward Brenthael, because a warden who stands them under wood that cannot Turn has made them unTurned. A later summer does not repair this week.

Talen *(TAH-len)* is town-warden. They will not stand a child under unsound wood, and they want the mill to still turn through Harvest. The same water is bread. **Milsun** *(MIL-sun)* is Taken-In and keeps the drain and a planting above the race. **Thurrei** *(thur-RAY)* is the Road-hand, here for the wood. The children are Talen's charge. The neighbour-slate is chalked on the mill-door: this year's ten-year-olds, and which Brenthael household has room.

Mill-foam on the drain-lip keeps last Eolthael's colour a day longer than the water does. Milsun will not say why. Talen moves the foam with a stick. Thurrei wipes it off a pot-wrap and does not write it down.

A miller still takes a share of grain. The week turns on the race and the Hand. When the race is drawn down, they set the stones and leave one measure of last year's grain on the lip until the water comes back. They will not say why.

The First Bowl

The First Bowl is an old green that kept host-rights before any leave. A young Hand stands in it now, cut from Harrow's Green after Harrow's took. Everyday speech says *the First Bowl*. The folk hearth-name is *Lonasir (lo-NAH-seer)*. The Seat still writes *a later planting in the Far Yield* and does not use the hearth-name.

Vaelhesk's land is the seat, and Vaelhesk names no city. The First Bowl is the guest-grove. Vaelun is a hamlet a day's walk off, sometimes two. Harrow's Green is the grove-town on Saelvaeth's march. The Mill-hold, in Orenbren, is the sick Tree. This bowl sits away from Harrow's and deeper into the Yield. The way here crosses Harrow's Green only when someone is carrying wood from that grove.

The Mother's wood is a guest. A Cutting-leave without the meal is a claiming. **Delvor** *(DEL-vor)* of Lonasir asks about the bowl before they ask about a leave. **Vilraet** *(vil-RAYT)* is town-warden of the guest and wants the week Spoken so a marriage can be witnessed here. **Brudu** *(BROO-doo)* is Taken-In and keeps the old planting and wants the morning water before the guest's pot. The question of whether this is Taken-In country is the slight.

The first-meal bread is always a little sour. Delvor says that is how you know the grove sat down. After the last person has gone in, a rye-straw is laid on the door-path's first stone and left until first light. The First Bowl will not say why.

Nelath

Nelath *(NEL-ath)* is where a side road stops. It is the road-end. People on the Near Mile say "the spur" and mean the road, then use the town's name once they are in it. It is a Tree-town in Orenbren's lodging-country, one square at the end of a side trip off the Near Mile. The junction is a day short of the Third Hearth, so the spur leaves the Mile before Thilim's road-house and before the Mill-hold's culvert. From the junction the spur is one more day, and then the canopy. Rothallo is the capital. Brenthael is the neighbour Hand on the main Mile, and the Mile goes on past it. Harrow's Green is the grove-town in Saelvaeth's march. The First Seat stays in the wood.

The main Mile still goes on. This track leaves it and ends. When Hands made the origin-walk optional, this town brought the next stone in. Beyond the boughs there is a scar: a ditch, thorns, and the width of a road that is no longer a road. The spur ends with that scar, without a ford and without a neighbour's canopy.

Raetoth *(RAY-toth)* is town-warden. They Speak the fall at home and want the stone left in the square and the scar left closed. **Lithsur** *(LITH-sur)* wants the stone back on the scar so a cut name is a day's mark again, and will bring a rope in Eolthael. The cistern is the day's drink. A notch on the stone still holds a little rain after the square has dried. A name is cut over the door of the upper room. Nelath will not say why the notch stays wet, or whose name that is.

Hugs are less common on a sound Motherland Hand than elsewhere, but not rare. A family that needs a neighbour's Tree walks back to the Mile.

The road-mend stops at the boughs. The thorns stay, and the spur stops with them.

Two claimants on one green

Not yet written. Two claimants on one green: warden and door-keeper. Vaelun leans this way. It is not yet a named square of the type. The First Bowl is the guest-grove. It does not close this hole.

Book VIII

Faces

Faces of the Turning

These are people who hold offices the towns already needed. The job is why they matter. The place gave them the work. You can meet two of them in a week and miss the rest. Any Kind may hold these offices.

Offices already on the ground

Each of these people already stands where the work is. The seats stay the seats already named.

Name	Where they stand	The job
Haelin	Harrow’s Green	warden who sends on the live front
Tora	Brenod / Harrow’s	the witness who walks a neighbour-fall home
Thilim	the Third Hearth	innkeeper of the Held bed
Ledan	White Note quay-desk, Orentel	clerk who copies
Mataero	White Note inland loft, Orentel	files the beds as occupancy
Vaethod	Eolvaeth	warden of a pilgrim-edge
Sorim	Orentel, first quay	factor who holds a berth
Rithim	Maiethlir	Speaker of the leaf-colour; one line stays off the roll

Thilim and Laevila still say *I walked*. Thilim means the Near Mile, kept as an inn. Laevila means a child’s walk under Thaeloren. Mataero Turned at home, files the year as occupancy, and treats the wood’s spread as finished. Vaethod sends people toward a luck they cannot see. Haelin stands on that live front, at Harrow’s Green. Eolvaeth remains Vaethorn’s seat.

Positional pivots

These six matter because of the office they already hold.

Vaethod — Eolvaeth

Vaethod *(VAYTH-od)* is town-warden of Eolvaeth. They decide whether the hinge happened, whether the Speaking week is over, and some years whether a cohort walks toward Saelvaeth's luck. They name a colour only when it fell. What they want is **Saelid**'s baker's stall on the camp-streets. The winter customers who buy bread are the same households a sent cohort takes away. They tell themselves that speaking truly means they have not chosen. They have sent people toward Haelin's live front without meeting them.

Rithim — Maiethlir

Rithim *(RITH-im)* is Speaker of Maiethlir. They name the leaf-colour while clerks wait to copy it. What they want is **Valein**, Kept and unmarked in the same household, to stay off the tablet; the verso already knows how to write *unmarked*. They believe delaying the copy is the same as refusing. On the same morning Laevila describes what Rithim keeps off the roll. The First Seat stays in the wood beside them. Rithim's office is the square's Speaking.

Mataero — Orentel

Mataero *(mah-TAY-ro)* lets the inland loft of the White Note House — twelve beds, the north bed kept unlet — and files all of it as occupancy. Mataero Turned at home. What they want is **Sorel** clear of a century-note their mother still carries from a walk Sorel cannot point to; they think a clean loft-slate will buy that. They believe the house is a bank that happens to have rooms. A household Vaethod sent may already owe a bed here. Reimaethe pays a rise-room Mataero writes *let*.

Thilim — the Third Hearth

Thilim *(THIL-im)* keeps the Third Hearth. It is the third lodging out from the Motherwood on the Near Mile. Thilim is Long-Lived. The hearth is inland, the notes are smaller than the White Note's, and the shrine is larger. They walked the mile as the inn until the stretch was optional and kept making the bed anyway. What they want is the stone's water still feeding the pot when it is dark; Seine's bed is still made. They hold that who is fed at dark matters more than paper. Brenthael's warden wants the stone moved. Thilim keeps the name where it is. The name is also a well.

Laevila — Maiethlir

Laevila *(lay-VEE-lah)* bakes on the old extra-mile, keeps the room under the chapel the wardens recut, and holds the only copy of the beam's hidden face. They are Long-Lived. They walked as a child under Thaeloren before this river had to count them. What they want is **Senithi**'s name good for a marriage: the hidden face still has the grandmother under her own name, and the roll wrote the

household wrong. They tell themselves that if they only describe, they have not chosen sides. Rithim Speaks in the same square. They eat after Night Watch and do not agree what that means.

Tesara — Orentel

Tesara *(teh-SAH-rah)* sits the stillers' shed off the street. A key is kept off the slate. If the week goes well, nobody hears of it. Struck years back, they remember the door from their own catching-week. What they want is **Valen** stamped with a real ticket. The paper in the way is a burned slip. They believe a quiet week means they saved someone. The paying floor wants the master back. Mataero will need a loft if Valen lives without a ticket.

Named wants in the three seats

Wants sit on people. An institution can furnish a bed, a pot, or a paper, or withhold them. The want stays with the person.

Eolvaeth. Vaethod wants Saelid's stall to keep its winter customers. **Nedaen** *(neh-DAYN)*, Taken-In, wants the gift-hall pot to feed their child through Ledger-month. **Heiral** *(HAY-ral)*, Kept, wants a marriage witnessed without being pitied as Mother-kept. **Daron** *(DAR-on)*, Returned, wants a specific corpse named so a grain-debt dies with it.

Orentel. Mataero wants Sorel off the century-paper. **Sorim** wants berths 1–4 held through Hale-month. Tesara wants Valen stamped. **Lasole** *(lah-SO-leh)* rents a leaf-lot and wants the credit extended one season. **Didel** *(dih-DEL)* of Hallowquay, Selkie, wants a kin-berth for a skin-kin wedding in Eolthael; Sorim has held 1–4 for a First-Hand year.

Maiethlir. Rithim wants Valein unfiled. Laevila wants Senithi's name read off the hidden face of a recut beam, once, in a room a clerk will accept as a witness. **Vehaela** *(veh-HAY-lah)* came down from Lirorn's thin snow with two children and wants an uncounted loft for one winter. **Baerith** *(BAY-rith)*, Far-Voiced, sings the counted hour and wants the crown to stop cutting green on the street where their sister keeps a pot.

How the squares touch: paper, beds, pots, and one week in Eolthael. A household Vaethod sent sometimes eats now on a White Note necessity-note. Sorim's berth 5 is earth; the pot is going toward a luckier Hand; Haelin will sleep the Road-hand if the wood arrives. Rithim Speaks; Laevila describes the other colour in the same square. Tesara's week, if it is not burned, becomes a person who later needs a loft or a berth. Thilim still holds a far-cape name. The White Note's book is another page. Thilim stays at the Third Hearth.

Other people of note

These are the second people in places that already have one.

Person	Square	The job	The want
Njunda	Ndenjoo	table-keeper	Nolas gone as kin, extra place still laid
Ledan	the White Note House	quay-desk	founding-name spoken once
Theisva · Lesna · Bovaer	Ornsael	Theisva keeps the share; Lesna the planting; Bovaer the west road	a share that lasts Hale-month
Tora · Nethiro · Baelon	the Three Hamlets	three kitchens	Tora of Brenod sends the child home; Nethiro of Vaelun may refuse the neighbour's week; Baelon of Ornath stays off the other road
Meirim	Brenthael	neighbour-warden	the Third Hearth's stone down; room for the Mill-hold's week
Talen · Milsun · Thurrei	the Mill-hold	drain and slate	a mill that still turns; a week that still has room
Delvor · Vilraet · Brudu	the First Bowl	bowl, Speaking, old planting	sit before colour; a Struck housed; morning water
Raetoth · Lithsur	Nelath	stone and scar	the mile stays in the square; the name goes back on the day
Nurreith	the Low Wall	one summer's shovel	the labour off the garden; the chip was the other quarry
Soonke · Saalo	Ndenjoo sand / valley	Soonke sits the beach; Saalo wants the way out	wreck off the hill; Waandi found
Thuda	the Low Wall garden-end	innkeep	labour off the garden

Haelin *(HAY-lin)* wants the stone moved before Leaf-Fall so the crowd can stand, and water still on it until then. They name a colour only when they are sure of it. **Tora** *(TOR-ah)* of Brenod is here because last year's Brenod child was seen under the canopy and is still owed the walk home.

Reimaethe *(RYE-may-theh)* is a Long-Lived on the rise in Orentel. They joined the Pourers when they were asked, and have given four years of memory into the cup, one year at a time. They want to stop before the fifth, and they want their papers back. Neighbours call it a rich uncle's hobby. They pay a rise-loft on time. They want Mataero to keep writing *let* and not *why*.

Hithaen *(hith-AYN)* arrived in Eolvaeth's gift-hall this Hale-month with no list behind them. They are Given. They used to be heir to a house that counts the Kept as the line that may rule. The leaf took that. They want a life that is not a wall-pass. They are not Talnin, the Close's heir whose tenth year is unfinished, and they are not Methei. Vaethod has not decided if Hithaen came to wait or to be counted.

Taeren *(TAY-ren)* is of Brenod. Harrow's Green is the grove-town where they are standing. Last Eolthael they stood at the neighbour's canopy at Harrow's Green; something white happened, and a colour outside the civic list has no home-walk as a witnessing, so they are still in the square when the Hale-month crowds arrive. Heat in the hands they do not show. They ask ordinary questions.

Rosire *(ro-SEER-eh)* is of Orentel. They are infirmary-tired. They used to bring water at Tesara's shed; this Hale-month they are in an upper room at Harrow's Green. Travel stays out of their talk. They want the person they walked inland with kept out of a story, and no one sent to fetch them.

Ledan still writes the quay-desk. The six pivots stay Vaethod, Rithim, Mataero, Thilim, Laevila, and Tesara. Reimaethe, Hithaen, Taeren, and Rosire stay four separate people.

Book IX

At the Table

Playing in the Turning

Follow this page, in this order, when you make a character and when you start play. Stories and laws live in their own chapters. This page is the sequence at the table.

Tone. Play neighbours and colleagues. A real obstacle sits under the ordinary day. A Tithe never takes the player character over. Keep the frightening part rare.

Making a character

Run this once, in this order.

1. **Kind.** Take a stock Daggerheart ancestry, one of the four ancestries written for this world (Kitsune, Selkie, Tengu, Yumboe), or Mixed Ancestry as the SRD allows. Rulings sit in *The Kinds*. A Yumboe needs the GM's leave, and the character is the full Kind. If both of your ancestry features come from stock ancestries, take a **Hearth-Mark**: name the place that raised you. Once per session, add +2 to a roll that leans on how that place taught you to live. A character with any feature from the four ancestries written for this world takes no Hearth-Mark.
2. **Community.** Take a Community as the SRD defines it. A Hearth-Mark names a place. It does not fill the Community line.
3. **Class, Experiences, equipment.** Take these as the SRD defines them. Write two Experiences. A Kept character has those same two and no third.
4. **Turning.** Pick one, and write it on the sheet. How many people are Given, Struck, and Kept is in *The Conditions*.
   - **Given** — a colour fell at ten. Take one Given-path or Both-path card from *The Conditions*.
   - **Kept** — the leaves hugged you at the Tree, with no colour. No Condition card. See below.
   - **Struck** — a later threshold already happened in the backstory. You died and came back, you swore a contract, you survived a drowning, you survived being turned to stone, or you were lost and dying in the deep wild and the wild took you in. Take a Struck-path or Both-path card. Someone stood for you again. Say who.
   - **UnTurned** — you never stood under a Turning Tree. No hug, no colour. You are not Kept. You can still be Struck later. Neighbours may call you Kept. The law and your sheet say UnTurned.
5. **Choices for the whole table.**
   - **Phoenix** — this Condition takes the table's attention. Every other player agrees before anyone

plays one. The GM may run a Phoenix as a person in the world instead.
- **Hidden Phoenix** — every other player agrees first, the same as for the open Phoenix. The rest is worked out between that player and the GM.
- **Yumboe** — the GM's leave. Full Kind only.
- **the Unbound** — you do not start here. A Bound character becomes Unbound when the term ends, in play, or because the table agrees at the start that the term already ended.

Kind and Condition stay two things on one character. A Selkie can be Given Two-Bodied. A stock Human can be Struck Returned. Mixed heritage is Given, Kept, or Struck the same way anyone else is.

They stay two things when the stories sound alike. An **Infernis** who swears a contract is Bound like anyone else. The born blood is Kind. The contract is Condition. They do not merge, cancel, or become Given-Over by default.

The Kept deal

The Kept have no boon and no Tithe. A Condition card asks a character to mark a Tithe clock. That is the upkeep, and the mark usually comes at a long rest. The Kept clock is empty on purpose. That emptiness is the tradeoff.

What they have is a legal standing and a free rest. The law treats them as the ordinary person: the hug was witnessed, they owe no guild, and they hold no Condition licence. At every long rest they take their downtime with no Tithe checklist. Everyone else may be marking a Tithe clock. That free rest is the advantage at the table. They can still be Struck later. Kept is the present. It is not a promise to stay that way.

They do not receive a tenth Condition, a bonus Experience, a Hearth-Mark they did not already qualify for, or a Kept ability of their own. An ability that is really a Tithe belongs on a Condition card.

An UnTurned life looks similar: no Tithe, no guild. The difference is that a Kept person's hug was witnessed, and an UnTurned person never stood. An UnTurned character is written as UnTurned, not as Kept.

Struck in play

A Kept or UnTurned character can be Struck when the story crosses a threshold this book already names: death (Returned), a sworn contract (Bound), surviving a drowning (Far-Voiced), surviving being turned to stone (the Stilled), or being lost and dying in the deep wild (the Taken-In). Long-Lived, Two-Bodied, Answered, and Phoenix are Given only. Those four cannot be Struck.

The player agrees to take the card. The GM does not hand out a becoming to punish a failed roll. A Tithe never takes the character over. Becoming is not a moment where the player loses the character.

When the player takes the card, add the Condition. Kind stays. Someone stands for them again at the next desk that will take them. A hazardous becoming goes to the Intake. Mark them Struck. They were not Given. There is no leaf and no second Leaf-Fall. They do not take a second Condition.

A Bound character whose term ends becomes the Unbound, as that card says. No other Condition turns into a further Condition.

Advancement

Condition cards do not level. The card at 1 is the card at 10. Class features, domain cards, Experiences, weapon tier, Proficiency, and Hope scars change around it. The full ruling is in *The Conditions*.

Travel

You move on someone's word. A paper that names what you are does not replace the answer. A watch asks **name, last hearth, who stands.** Two of the three will do. If you have none, you sit until morning, or you are walked to the next gate.

These customs answer the watch: a road-word, a company's vouch, a guild-mark, a house-note, guest-right, and the custom of a walk. Distances are in *Climate, Ecology, and Travel*. Kumbaan does not use this road-word. That is the Sundering Isle. The crossing is in *Other Places*, under Ndenjoo, and in *The Four Continents*. People do sell a vouch. That sale is a separate trade. It does not answer this watch.

City witnessing

A village remembers a child. A city remembers a **hearth**. When the watch asks, the legal answer is "I am of the third quay."

Turning-Week is **one week** in a city too. People stand by hearth, in named slots. The warden says the colour or the hug aloud. They do not write a list of gifts. Threnmaieth writes the stand down. Other towns leave it spoken. Treat the writing as Threnmaieth's exception.

Crime

There is no crime of *being* a Condition. The Inviolate Will already sorts the charge into a Tithe that lapsed through neglect, or a power used on purpose as a weapon.

The charge goes up this ladder: a neighbour's word, then the watch holds the person until morning, then a guild hearing, then an open hearing. Exile from the hearth is the penalty the town treats as civic death. A ticket names a hazardous use — the Gaze, the Cry, or an element let loose in a yard. It does

not name the Condition. A Bound hearing sits at a table and covers the Terms of the contract. The three licences on the body stay the Stilled, the Far-Voiced, and the Answered. Bound is not a fourth.

Leaf-Fall edge cases

Use these when you cannot open *The Turning Tree*:

- The Given-door is **one week** in the tenth year.
- A completed standing (colour or hug, sound wood) is **once**.
- A miss, a refusal, or a week spent under unsound wood makes a child **unTurned**. It does not make them Kept.
- Struck remains the later mercy.
- You may correct a Speaking. You may not rerun a fall.
- White-fire is sent to the First Seat. A town-warden does not name it Phoenix.

Starting situations

Start in one of these places. Stay with the one job the old walk left on that street. After a town has its own Tree, that job is one of three. **Devotion:** people keep a walk they no longer need, either as an extra mile or as a wait at a Tree that may not speak. **Prestige:** a household pays for a winter, or a berth, for a walk they do not need. **Necessity:** the local Tree is missing, young, or sick, or the week cannot hold everyone who comes, so people use a neighbour’s standing, water, or bed. Give the place one of those jobs. A guest may bring a second into the same week. The second is not the place’s theme.

Eolvaeth. People come here to wait, and the wait is the job. Vaethod will not invent a colour. Vaethod is the town-warden. Saelid’s stall keeps feeding its winter guests. A stranger in the gift-hall has no list to stand on. Some years the wood says send the children on. The gospel in the vale says stay.

Orentel. The quay sells a winter to households who can pay for a walk they do not need, and that sale is the job. The Eolthael berths are empty because they are held. A prestige winter takes all three, at three desks: a White Note term for the paper, a Night-Shore hull for the ship, and an Orentel hold for the berth. Tesara works the stillers’ shed, and the shed does not face the street. Two streets off the third quay, a person too poor to meet a Tithe fades while the city steps around them.

Maiethlir. Start the week before Leaf-Fall, when the thaw is loud. Rithim will not give the clerk the line. Rithim is the Speaker. The wardens have recut a chapel, and a Watching room is under it. The crown keeps a counted channel for a Far-Voiced hour and for the city’s green. That channel can be shut. The extra mile is still walked here. The roll writes on top of that walk, and the walk remains.

Harrow’s Green. Start in Hale-month. The year is Cut-year 387. That is the 387th summer counted from the First Cut. The job is a neighbour’s week that can still be walked home. The stone has to move so the crowd can stand, and the water is still on it. The upper room has extra guests. Children here Turn under this Tree. The hamlets can see the canopy and are still sending theirs.

Ornsael. The well is dropping, and the job is water. The share is chalked on the lip. Pilgrims from the core arrive expecting a holiday walk. A wet knot sits below last year’s water-line.

the Three Hamlets. Play the same week as Harrow’s Green. The canopy is a dark on the far slope. Brenod sends the child. Vaelun may refuse the walk. Ornath may take the other road. The job is the neighbour’s week.

the Third Hearth. Thilim has made Seine’s bed and left it made. The extra mile is optional, and the house still keeps the bed. That is the job. Meirim wants the stone taken down. Meirim is Brenthael’s warden. Seine’s name is on the lintel. The pot needs the stone’s water at dark, and the stone at the road is the day’s water.

Ndenjoo. Play the hall’s hospitality, and play the storm-wall as the weather. A wreck has walked uphill. The extra place is already set. A guest is loud at noon, when the hall sleeps. There is no Tree. Seat the wreck, keep kin who will not leave, and let someone want a crossing out. Leave what the Trees are unproved.

Tone at the table

Play neighbours, colleagues, and family. The Tithe is where the danger sits. Leaf-Fall is a warm week. Keep dread out of the Tree. When you need one moment of wrongness, use the weather, a host still keeping a guest from a week that ended, a week that already closed, or a person who missed the standing.

The Conditions are already the people in the world. There is no second vampire, no cursed wolf-kin, and no hungry dead who is not a Returned.

Sample frames

Use one of these for a run of sessions. In each mainland frame, some people Turn under the Tree in town, and this year someone is still walking because living wood has not reached every hearth. Play both as the present. The Years of Hands are underway. Those are the years a town Tree is the ordinary way to Turn.

A town where the planting is still arriving. Harrow's Green, or the hamlets looking at its canopy. The job on the street is a neighbour's week. A pot of living wood may arrive, and it may not. Someone here is still sending this year's children. Someone who thinks the planting is finished lives two weeks away and cannot see this canopy.

A quay that sells a winter. Orentel. A household that wants the prestige of a First-Hand year goes to three desks: a Night-Shore hull, a term from the White Note, and a hold at Orentel. One desk does not finish the winter. Necessity still sleeps in the loft. Ledan, at the White Note desk, asks which count the debt should wear: the house's own year, a Cut-year, or a third date a court invented. Say which.

An origin town with a roll. Maiethlir. The extra mile is still walked, and the clerks write on top of it. Rithim will not copy the clerk's line. A Watcher will describe what they saw. The First Seat is in the wood beside the city, and can refuse what the city asks.

The hall on the isle. Ndenjoo. Hospitality is the rite: an extra place, a second night, a guest who can sleep the day. The storm-wall is the weather. Play kin and a wreck. The session is not spent proving what the Trees are.

The first campaign has its own opening, in the GM's chapter. It is not one of the starts above.

Dangers on the road

Settlements already have things that enter a scene: a cohort, a crane, a well-mouth. Use this section for the country between those towns.

Start battle points from the SRD: `[(3 × PCs) + 2]`. Spend: Minion group 1 · Support/Social 1 · Horde/Ranged/Skulk/Standard 2 · Leader 3 · Bruiser 4 · Solo 5. Benchmarks: Tier 1 Difficulty 11, thresholds 7/12, ATK +1; Tier 2 Difficulty 14, 10/20, ATK +2.

Name	Tier / type	Where it lives	What it wants
Gap-Cat	T1 Skulk	Rain-Wall shelves, Heskoren ridge, mile-gaps	A quiet kill and the high rock back
Chart-Crew	T1 Horde	Chart-run, Night Shore, West Water wrecks	The hull that did not arrive — or yours
Bed-Keeper	T1 Leader	Empty road-houses on the Long Mile	The bed occupied. You staying.
Spent-Week Walker	T2 Standard	Long Mile, west-road, live-front tracks	To finish a week that already closed
Colourless Host	T2 Support	Dead pots, unsound grafts, waiting ground	To Give. It cannot.

None of these are Conditions. A walker may *be* Conditioned the way anyone is. The card they carry is not this stat block.

The Spent-Week Walker and the Colourless Host are Tier 2 blocks. In a Tier 1 scene, use the Tier 1 Difficulty, thresholds, and attack bonus from the benchmarks above in place of theirs.

Mile-gap (T1 Traversal, Difficulty 12). The day's walk between two stones. The place will stretch the day, hide the next stone, offer a false bed, or make a Tithe expensive. A Taken-In who cannot touch living green, or a Long-Lived with nothing new, feels the gap, but their next long rest runs the card's check as usual and the gap adds no extra tick. Travel rolls to find the next shrine are Difficulty 12. Failure with Fear ends the day in the gap.

Thaw-gate (T1 Traversal, Difficulty 13). A shelf-gate or the Noon Pass in a thaw-week. Crossing without a guide is Difficulty 13. On a failure, someone is swept, or a cart is lost. One roll does not do both.

Empty road-house (T1 Exploration, Difficulty 11). A road-house that kept the upper room after the walk ended. Guest-right is a week. Leaving before morning without a word is a slight the next shrine will hear.

Night-berth (T1 Exploration, Difficulty 12). A Chart-run or West Water quay at first dark. Hulls that do not arrive are local weather.

Pair a place with one danger. On the Long Mile inland, use a mile-gap and a Gap-Cat. On the Long Mile where a house still keeps a bed from a week that ended, use an empty road-house and a Bed-Keeper. On the Rain-Wall, use a thaw-gate, and let the weather be enough. On the Chart-run or at Netstrand, use a night-berth and a Chart-Crew. At a dead pot on the live front, use one Colourless Host

as Support, with walkers or a Gap-Cat, and never a second Host. Near a town on the Near Mile, use what that town already sends into a scene. The storm-wall belongs with the isle, in *Other Places*. It is not one of these road dangers.

Use a Colourless Host when a planting has gone wrong, or a pot never took. Skeptics and believers can both be loud. This book does not decide between them.

Book X

For the GM

GM Canon

Read the player-facing chapters first if you want to meet the world as a player would. The table does not start knowing this chapter.

This chapter holds what is actually true, whether or not anyone in the world can prove it. The central fact is called the **keystone**: the Leaf-Mother is real and kind, her reach has a limit, and giving costs her. Skeptics are sincere, and wrong that no mind is there. If a campaign ever confirms her, it lands as warmth.

GM only: Conditions

A Condition carries upkeep. That is a **Tithe**. Its dangerous edge is story pressure, never a gotcha and never a seizure of the player's character. Consequences land on the Conditioned person's own body, memory, Stress, or immediate surroundings unless a feature explicitly says otherwise. Nobody's will is bent.

- **Long-Lived.** Going still is the Long-Lived death: the memories run out and the person dies. It is not a death move. The player sees it coming across several long rests: Stress, then a Hit Point, then still. Use it as story pressure, such as a Long-Lived NPC found still in a sealed archive, not as a sudden kill. Blood-Read is for investigation and feeling. One drop of blood, freely given or from a wound already open, shows a true memory: the dead man's last sight, or why a witness lies. It is never feeding, never damage, and never a drain. The threshold courtesy is roleplay. A Long-Lived *can* cross uninvited if they truly must. They never do, because the manners run that deep. Neither Blood-Read nor the threshold is a weakness a foe can use against them.
- **Two-Bodied.** The forced shift is timing and inconvenience, never control. The inner voice is a roleplay partner, not a second player: it can want, argue, sulk, and celebrate, but it never rolls, never acts, and never overrides a choice. If a table finds the animal "made me do it," pull it back to nagging. The other self keeps an ordinary animal's size and has no hands, no person's mind, no speech, and no tools. A Two-Bodied is a better animal than a Tengu or one of the Answered, and never a better person.
- **Returned.** Refuse to Fall is "hard to keep down," not immortality: a scar every time, out of the current scene, back by the next long rest. When the last Hope slot would go, they cannot come back. A lapsed Purpose is quiet crisis, not punishment. **Who Strikes them:** the Quiet Tally,

Threnvaeth, the clerk of her household who keeps the unfinished work of the dead, acting under the Leaf-Mother's allowance. The Leaf-Mother does not Give this at the Tree. She allows the catch. The unfinished work is still the Returned person's own; Threnvaeth does not steer the Purpose. Player text does not name Threnvaeth.

- **Bound.** The Whisper is strictly suggestive: plausible lies and intrusive thoughts the player can reject at a Stress cost. Never puppet the PC. The Pledge is a known, dreaded horizon toward the Unbound, not a surprise. **Who answers:** the Counterparty is **Orledd**, the Hand of her household who answers a sworn ask. The face chosen at creation (demon, cosmic horror, or unknown) is a mask Orledd wears; the terms have the same shape whatever the face. Orledd is not a devil, and a Given Condition is never a bargain.
- **The Unbound.** The Quiet tempts. It does not compel. Every time they reach for the bargain, they can refuse at a Stress cost. The tragedy to play toward: an Unbound who stops connecting gets loud inside, signs again to quiet it, pays another Pledge, and slides toward the Given-Over. That is the Unbound end-state. Warmth is the only thing that actually fills the hole; contracts only mute it.
- **Far-Voiced.** The Cry is a feeling landing on listeners. Stress, never a forced action or belief. A Struck Far-Voiced's first Cry, pre-guild, is a formative beat, not a punishment. A Given Far-Voiced in deep Tithe-debt (0 tokens, on duty, in a courtroom or relay tower) is a slow-building set-piece.
- **The Stilled.** The Gaze is an attack against an unwilling target (Instinct or Presence). Willing and downed targets take no roll. **Stilled** is a special condition, not Restrained: no actions or reactions; they can speak, be moved, and be targeted; they may mark a Stress to clear it when they would act. The seizing (Grey at 3 tokens) is strictly self-directed: the Stilled's own limb, or harmless scenery, never another PC's autonomy. A Struck Stilled's first, unpracticed Gaze (probably on someone they love, probably by accident) is formative. A Given Stilled deep in Grey-debt on a riot line or in an operating theatre is a slow-building set-piece.
- **The Answered.** Every 0-token consequence stays on the Answered and their immediate surroundings. Let the chosen element define the character's whole voice (an Ember-Answered feels nothing like a Root-Answered). One of the Answered deep in Tithe-debt walking into a crowded hall, a ship's hold, or a dry archive is a slow-building set-piece.
- **The Taken-In.** Go-to-seed is strictly environmental: growth from ground and structures, never roots seizing another creature. A Struck Taken-In's uncertainty ("did I walk out, or was I sent?") is quiet identity dread, not a hidden puppet-string. The wild in them is *part of them*, not a master. One dragged deep into a dungeon, a ship's hold, or a stone keep and left to wilt is a slow-building set-piece.
- **Phoenix.** Run two things at once. The **count**: let everyone watch the Hope slots go; each rising costs something the player feels (a face, a reason they started). The **attention**: the Phoenix is never anonymous. Every town has people who revere them, worship them, hunt them, and hate them, often the same crowd. Never force a Rise; it is always the player's death-move choice alongside the standard three. A Phoenix may choose Blaze of Glory and end if the story earns it. The fire

boons are strong on purpose: compensation for a life with no privacy and a death you can count down to. As a legendary NPC, rebirths make era-markers (the same soul, met three times, remembering the party less each time).

GM only: Peoples

Where a Kind lives tells you something about her reach only for the Yumboes. Mainland Kind-hearths are mundane geography: foxes in woods, seals on coasts, crows on ridges. A Kind-hearth is a Kind's home ecology, not a nation. Kumbaan's isolation is the one Kind-fact that also maps the keystone edge: no Tree, no Gift, a people who are themselves without her. "Yumboes have no Conditions" is not a racial immunity. It is a fact about the place.

No power is founded for a Kind. A place where many Foxes live is a Rain-Shadow polity that happens to have many Foxes, and it runs on the same faith, reach, and government as everyone else. A government *for* a Kind would break the two-layer model: Kind is born, a Condition is become, and they stack.

A grandmother still says the word for the lost fourth Fox. If you use it, use the folklore that stayed when a hearth died: a dry lake that vanished, a wood that was cut. Nobody explains the word, and it is not an ancestry feature.

An ordinary introduction carries two names: a Kind and a place. It is not a secret identity. A Yumboe who takes a mainland byname has decided to stay. A Threnmaieth clerk who refuses to record hearth-names is doing the roll: it wants one name only.

Each polity's vocabulary is its self-justification, not the truth of what it does. Threnmaieth's "keeping-whole" (**Threnhael**) is surveillance that calls itself care. Lestrand's "the free" for the **Kept** is a market reframing a social slight as a virtue. The Tree hugged them, with no colour and no Condition Given. Vaethorn's "the Waited" wraps real pity in reverence. None of these framings is dissolved by confirming the Mother. They are how each society excuses its own injustice, and a kind Mother does not make any of the three names honest.

The word-box and the how-to live in Language and Naming. The sound-system and what the linguistics words mean live under **GM only: Language**.

GM only: Language

Language and Naming is where you name a person, mint a new one, glue a hall, and look up what a land calls a building. Keep that chapter as the how-to.

This section holds what the linguistics words mean, which sounds each way of speaking uses, and the regular sound-change that makes a name wear the same way every time. Use it when you need a name that still belongs and the lists are not enough. It is not taught at the table.

What the linguistics words mean

Linguists have names for things everyone already does with speech. Here they are in this world’s terms.

Word	What it means here
Root	The smallest chunk of meaning. *oren* means “to witness.” You glue roots to make names.
Lexicon	The word-box. The list of roots you are allowed to build from. The old-word table in Language and Naming is the lexicon.
Compound	Two roots glued. **Thaeloren** is *thael* (Tree) + *oren* (witness).
Etymology	Where a name comes from. Players hear a pretty word. You know it means “the Tree that witnesses.”
Phonology	Which sounds a language uses, and which it will not. English has *th*; many languages do not. Kusawe has *sh* and no *th*.
Syllable	One beat of sound. *Ra-ki* is two syllables.
CV / CVC	A recipe for a beat. **C** = a consonant, **V** = a vowel. CV is *ra*. CVC is *tek*. CVF in Kusawe means the beat may end on n, m, or r.
Stress	The beat you hit harder. CAPS marks it: thae-LOR-en.
Digraph	Two letters, one sound. *ae* is not “a” then “e.” It is “ay” as in *day*. Same for *ei* (eye) and *eo* (ay-oh).
Onset	The consonant or cluster at the start of a beat. *Kr* in Kukra is an onset. Tengu likes those. Kitsune does not.
Prenasal	A hum before a stop: *mb*, *nd*, *nk*, *nj*. Yumboe uses them. The Old Tongue does not.
Register	A way of speaking used for a job, not a whole language. Church-speech vs street-speech. Kusawe is the fox hearth-register: given names and in-group talk. Nobody writes sentences in it.
Liturgical / Old Tongue	The church language, **Maiethren**. Like Latin: nobody’s first language at the market, still used for the rite and for old names.
Vernacular / common tongue	What people actually say day to day. Worn-down Old Tongue. *The Kept*, *the ranging*, *tree-wardens*.
Daughter language / drift	When one language splits into regional versions. Spanish, French, and Italian all come from Latin. Threnmaieth, Vaethorn, and Lestrand all come from Maiethren. They did not invent new tongues. They wore the same one differently.

Word	What it means here
Conservative	A drift that kept the old sounds. Threnmaieth still says *th*.
Worn	A drift that wore them down. In ordinary speech *th* after a vowel becomes *t*, and endings simplify. Written Vaethorn is spoken **Wetorn**. Careful prayer keeps the *th*.
Eroded	A drift that sanded sounds off. Lestrand dropped *th* to t or d, or dropped it.
Sound-change	A regular swap, not a one-off. If *th* becomes *t* on the docks, it does that in every word, not just one. That is why you can push any old word through the same rule and it will still sound like Lestrand.

You do not need the rest of a linguistics toolkit. There is no grammar to learn. No sentences in Kusawe, Sakoa, or Gonan. If a scene needs an in-group word, coin one word from that Kind's sounds and say what it means.

The Old Tongue's sounds

Warm and weighty. A hall-and-hearth tongue. Liquids and nasals (*l r m n*) carry the warmth. *Th* and long vowels carry the weight. No harsh piles of consonants, so it stays sayable.

Sounds it uses. Consonants: m n, l r w j, p t k, b d g, f v s h, and *th* as in *thin*. Vowels: a e i o u, plus the digraphs *ae*, *ei*, *eo*.

Sounds it does not use. Prenasals (*mb nd nj*). Hard front clusters like *kr* and *gr* (those are Tengu). *Sh* is a fox sound, not a church sound.

How to say it. Same key as Language and Naming. CAPS is stress. *th* as in *thin*, never as in *the*. Stress usually on the second beat.

The word-box is the old-word table in Language and Naming. That box is the lexicon. Glue one or two roots. Then wear the compound the way the land wears it.

How an old word wears in each land

One Tree, grafts carried out. One old tongue, names wearing down as they travel. Linguists would call Threnmaieth, Vaethorn, and Lestrand **daughter languages**: three children of Maiethren. In this book they are the three drifts.

The sound-changes are regular. Push any old word through the same rule.

Drift	Land	What happens to the sounds	How it feels
Conservative	Threnmaieth, pious Maiethorn	Almost nothing. *Th* and long vowels kept whole.	Archaic, formal, holy. Sounds like the rite because it barely moved from it.
Worn	Vaethorn, Heskoren folk	*Th* after a vowel becomes *t* in speech (Vaethorn → Wetorn). Endings simplify. Unstressed vowels flatten. Careful prayer keeps the *th*.	Rough-warm folk-speech that still reaches for the old holy words.
Eroded	Lestrand, Strandoren docks	*Th* becomes t or d, or drops. Long vowels clip. Word-ends wear off. Trade-words sneak in.	Smooth, clipped, mercantile. The most worn name belongs to the least-devout place.

Worked examples of the same rule:

- *thael* + *oren* kept whole is **Thaeloren**. That is the Awakening Tree. Worn everyday: **the Thallow**.
- *vaeth* + *orn* kept with *th* is **Vaethorn**. Spoken **Wetorn**.
- *ledd* + *strand* with the *th* already gone is **Lestrand**.
- *thren* + *maieth* kept whole is **Threnmaieth**. The same *thren* worn to *Tren* is **Trenledd**: the sacred count with the sacred sanded off.
- *oren* + *thael* with the *th* dropped is **Orentel**. That is the salt-quay seat.

A devout river-town on a thaw: *maieth* + *lir* = **Maiethlir**, *th* kept. There is no fourth human drift. A named power uses these roots and the right drift. Vaelhesk keeps older *vael* and frontier *hesk*-. That is still this family, worn further. Kumbaan is not in this family.

Why the drifts sit where they sit

In-world, people will tell you names wear down with distance and trade. That is true as far as it goes. The deeper pull that keeps the old sound near the Trees is the Mother’s nearness. Same fact, two readings. Player text does not state the deeper one.

History adds a mundane mechanism you can play: the pilgrimage itself was a conserving pull. Far speakers walked to the same grove each year, so the old sound got refreshed. Local Trees let the daughter drifts grow in place. The Years of Hands wear a Walking Years root.

Thaeloren is not decoration. That is “the Tree that witnesses.” She is real, and the Leaf-Fall is her seeing each child. The language keeps a truth the skeptics have explained away. Player text does not call it mere poetry. Let a scholar-PC notice it, or save it for a reveal beat late in a campaign.

The four Kind registers

Each custom Kind has a **register**: a closed set of sounds for given names and in-group talk. Not a language you write sentences in. The lists in Language and Naming are what you pick from. These inventories are how you mint a new one that still belongs.

Kitsune: Kusawe (koo-SAH-way). Light, slipping, a little hissy.

Consonants	k s sh n r m t w y f h
Vowels	a i u e o, and *ai* as in *eye*
Beats	CV, or CV ending on n/m/r. Two or three beats.
Never uses	*th* (church), *mb/nd/nj* (Yumboe), *kr/gr* (Tengu)

Selkie: Sakoa (sah-KOH-ah). Liquid, rounded, coastal.

Consonants	l r n m s v f d b k w
Vowels	o u a i e, and *ea*, *oa*
Beats	CV or CVC. Two or three beats.
Never uses	*th*, *sh*, *kr/gr*, *mb/nd/nj*

Tengu: Gonan (GO-nan). Clipped, windy, high-country. Not the same register as Kusawe; Tengu and Kitsune do not share one.

Consonants	k t g n r h s b d. Front clusters *kr*, *gr*, *hr* are at home.
Vowels	a o u e. Few *i* (that vowel lives with the foxes).
Beats	CVC or CV. One to three beats, prefer two.
Never uses	*th*, *sh*, *mb/nd/nj*, long *ai/ea/oa*

Yumboe. Not Maiethren. Open vowels, a drum-like rhythm, prenasals *mb nd nk nj*. Their own name is *Bakhna Rakhna*. Home is *Kumbaan*. It has no *th*, and it is not clipped down to a dock-name.

A name that bleeds across registers is a tell. A Selkie named Wishi, or a Tengu named Maethaem, was raised away, adopted, or is passing. Use it on purpose or not at all.

If the first fox-name that comes to mind is Yuki, throw it back. Same for Morag on a Selkie and Kenji on a Tengu. Pick from the middle of the existing list, or build from the inventory above until it could sit next to Raki, Lavo, or Teku without anyone blinking.

The player recipe stays in Language and Naming: pick from a list, or use **To make another**, or glue two old words and wear them for the land. The inventories above are the same registers written as sound-lists, so a new name can be checked against the rule instead of the ear. The sound-change table is how you push any old word through a land without inventing a fourth human drift. Nobody writes sentences in Kusawe or Gonan, and deep grammar stays off the table.

GM only: Society and Faiths

The Leaf-Mother is real, and she is benevolent, but her reach is not infinite, and giving costs her. She exists. The Turning Trees are genuinely her hands; when a Tree chooses, *she* is choosing. The Conditions are real gifts; the Leaf-Fall is an act of love; the Tithe is the honest weight of a gift, not a hidden price or a trap. She is bounded, not boundless. She cannot lay a hand on every child, cannot reach every threshold in time, and cannot give without spending. The limit is real. She is doing her best against it.

The Kept are spared, and some are simply past her edge. A hug and no colour is, for most, a deliberate and kind choice: the gift of being left whole. But the constraint means the Kept are *not all one thing*. Some are chosen for wholeness, and some are children she could not reach far enough to give to this turning, held safe rather than gifted. She does not tell them apart, and neither can they. Both are held; not both are chosen.

The Struck are still hers, at the farthest reach of her arm. She **Gives** at the Tree; she does **not** Strike. The catch at the door is enacted by lesser gods of her household, each restricted to one door, working under her allowance. The Struck are still hers because those hands are *hers to send*. **Narrow-Hand** is right about that limit. She Gives only at the Tree. **Wide-Hand** is right about belonging. Those means are still hers: her household, her allowance, her catch at the edge. Neither holds the whole.

Her benevolence does not dissolve injustice. Her kindness is cosmological, not social. She authored the gifts; she did **not** author the injustice built on top of them. The Watchful kingdom’s register, unvouched-Struck suspicion, Bound over-watching, guild conscription of the Given, Tithe-need as leverage, the Kept pitied, the Given-Over’s lost personhood, the scion-queue, the recut lintel, the book

that will not close, the host of a dying guest, the sentence that will not travel, the week that will not end, the gate, the scheduled hour, the Grey as labor, the shop you cannot leave, the week no one writes: these are **not misreadings of a kindness to be dissolved by the reveal.** They are the moral spine of the setting. If a campaign ever confirms she is real and kind, that must **not** retroactively make the society just. The keystone answers *is anyone there, and do they mean well* (yes); it pointedly does not answer *is what people built around her fair* (often no). Protect that gap. That is where the play is.

The three corners do not share a mechanism of injustice. They share only that people built them. Vaethorn's guilt-theology of unworthiness, Lestrand's let-the-poor-fade market, Threnmaieth's sanctified census: confirming she is kind does not make *any* of these three fair. Rival faiths can be *used* as leverage; they are not automatically the moral good because they dissent. Confirming she is kind does not dissolve Threnmaieth's counting of heretics, Lestrand's priced fading, or Vaethorn's guilt-theology.

The household is still GM-only. She is first of a household: she Gives; lesser Hands Strike at restricted doors under her allowance. Player text does not confirm this. The Open Table's staying-kin are **not** of that household, and Kumbaan is not part of it.

Each rival holds a true kernel and misses the whole.

- The Watching correctly remembers a *Before* and a *cost*, and a household before it was named Mother. They miss that the seeing *is* hers. The Masked reading and the Bare Tree reading are both playable. The Masked reading says she is a later face. The Bare Tree reading says there was never a she. Neither is the answer. The lintel is a clue, not a verdict. The cost they remember is real; *what* was spent is still open. They get no seat in a late reveal, because that would turn the heretics into a second Motherfaith. The warmth lands *through* them, not *as* them.
- The Fair Hand is right about Bound (there *is* a Counterparty) and wrong that every becoming is a bargain. Mother's Gifts are still gifts. They misread a cost as a price. They have correctly felt that giving is not free. They are not devil-worshippers. A Book-hand cannot turn a Given child into a debtor, and cannot rewrite the Counterparty's clause. A petition-watch is keeping the door; it is not acolyte-authority.
- The Old Ways are right that land-doors are real. They miss that she authorized the guests. Keep their grievance real (the grafts *are* late; the Motherfaith *did* talk as if becoming were new). Keep their miss intact. Ancestor-meals are not the Returned. The dead in the ground are kin who remained. The Returned are a different door.
- The Open Table is the cleanest experiment: no Gifts, rare Struck, a faith that was never hers. Their claim (*we were never lacking*) is still a late beat. Not ghosts. The unseen hands do ordinary household work. "No one is a stranger twice" is courtesy with legal weight on the isle, a proverb on the quay: not a geas, not a trap-cult, not a Fair Hand contract. A geas is a binding spell. A wreck is not a Struck-door she authorized.

If a campaign ever works toward the keystone, the three old corners are the Watching, the Old Ways, and the Open Table: pre-Mother, pre-graft, and never-grafted. The Fair Hand is the *modern* misreading. That is commerce wearing a theology. Use all four. No one of them speaks the reveal for the others.

The Tree is player-facing but keystone-adjacent. The graft continuity ("every Tree is literally the one Tree's hand") is the physical fact that, followed to its end, confirms she is real and present. Present it as doctrine the faithful hold, never as demonstrated cosmology. Skeptics grant the grafting and deny the mind. The Tree is not eerie and the ceremony is not sinister. Dread lives in individual Tithes, not in the rite.

Use the schism again. The three questions — Kept, Struck, and whether a mind is there — keep supplying NPCs, factions, and family arguments. No player-facing scene awards the win to either branch. Believers see the hand and miss the edge; skeptics see the edge and miss the hand. The world is built so being a skeptic costs nothing day to day, which keeps the schism *poignant* rather than *ironic*.

The Child at Four Doors. The paradox is the point. The child cannot pick without already having been claimed, and cannot be claimed without picking. Each faith resolves the unbearable middle by making *their* door the one that was always open. None of the last lines is the true cosmology. The true cosmology is: a mother reached, at cost, and did not reach everyone the same way. The fable will not say that. Which ending an NPC offers is a faster stance-read than a speech about doctrine. There is no official fifth door, and a children's story does not settle the keystone. Save the warmth for the confirming beat, if it ever comes.

The Orenhael are right about the wood and incomplete about the hand. That order is the tree-wardens. Every scion *is* continuous tissue of the one Tree, and when any warden Speaks a colour they are naming a choice she made. A scion is a grafted town Tree. Present them as competent neighbours, not as people who secretly know. A skeptic town-warden is *good at the job* and wrong about the mind. The split is the queue, not the Tree. The Seat sees soil and carrying-earth. The hamlet past the ford sees another year of borrowed Turnings. Which town gets the next graft is still a human rationing of her reach. Threnmaieth does not own the Seat. Being near it is pressure, not ownership.

The Slide. They do not know what story they are in. They think they are in a rent-and-credit story. They want *continuity of the week*, not a victim they relish. A corpse is a ruined asset. Play them as patient, useful, and sure they helped. The town is complicit; the week-keeper is not the only villain. Official Tithe-infrastructure and the licence-guilds are the public, posted, counted version of furnishing. This house is the overflow those guilds pretend not to know. Off-book Bound brokerage and sold vouching stay nameless. They do not rewrite Terms, steal scions, or sell a false Turning-witness.

Official halls and greens. They think they are in a wells-and-yards story. They want a town that does not wilt, Cry, or seize in the square. They do not want a client. Every closed gate feeds a week-book.

Comfort: the words *share*, *hour*, *ticket*, *enough*. She gave the Tithe; she did not build the lot.

Greens-Keepers. They want *a living lot*, not a client. A wilt on the lot is a ruined commons. A wilt off the lot is weather they have decided not to see. The buried leaf is how the lot remembers; a PC who digs it up has committed a local rudeness, not found a cosmology. The bed-slate is plants. If it is already a quiet census, that is Threnmaieth leaking, not the world's baseline.

Hall-Keepers. Put both jobs in the one hall: the furnished hour, and the Voice-ticket. They stay two jobs. Far-Voiced are where those two jobs meet. Write the unswept bench as what the hall does. Nobody says which Cry it remembers.

Stillers. They want a street that does not seize and a patient who lives. They do not want a register of the feared. Holding a citizen still is ordinary violent crime, the one harm the code names. The Gaze can leave a person helpless in a fight; it never seizes a will. The doorknob is practical, not a relic. A still knob is a tell. Ticket-as-property is Lestrand's live argument, not world-law.

Element-Guilds. The four elements are four doors under one set of rules. They want work that slakes the Tithe, and a room that holds the element. Write the last coal, yesterday's water, the unwashed clay, and the unshut window as what the guild does. Nobody in the guild explains them. Gale-Tengu is a lean. Ember-Drakona is a lean. Leans are not chapters.

The Intake. They want a quiet week. They do not want a client, a relic, or a route. Success is burned. Given children got a childhood the Struck will never get. Travel is accidental, not a circuit: a runner toward *this* person. Bound / Taken-In / Returned / Two-Bodied / Long-Lived are the wrong office.

The reach-edge stays GM-side as *cause*. Vaethorn's high Kept/Struck rates, Lestrand's and Threnmaieth's dense Given, the core-vs-frontier medicine gap: all read in-world as plain distance-and-biology. That is the skeptics' whole case. The real reason (her reach is bounded and thins where the Trees are thin) stays GM-side. No player-facing beat states the cause. Vaethorn is the sharpest test of this: they are the place where a devout population *most wants* an explanation for the thin gift, and where the wrong (true) answer would land hardest.

The Long-Lived marriage is the setting's quietest, most reusable grief: a Long-Lived stops aging and their spouse does not, so the Long-Lived outlives and buries a spouse, and sometimes a child. Save it for a scene that needs the weight.

The cold embrace is a diagnostic and a hook. A Returned whose embrace has gone cold is a quiet family crisis.

Whoever furnishes a provided-for Tithe holds power over its bearer. That is the sharpest economic lever. Coercion with a friendly face: the scary edge in economic form.

Player-facing notes keep her unproven. Skeptics have their full dignity. No player-facing beat confirms the Mother; the confirmation is the GM's to place, and it should land as *warmth and relief with an*

ache under it, not horror. There is no harvest, no betrayal waiting to be uncovered. The floor is sound: bounded, costly, and grieving, but sound.

The Pourers, the Unspent, and the Walled Book

Three separate groups. The Pourers give away their own memory. The Walled Book ranks people. The Protectors catch Phoenix fire and hide it behind worship. No two of them are the same group.

The inner circle's taking. Inside the Pourers there is an inner circle. Most members do not know it exists, and its work does not go through Molevad's minute-book. It chooses a Long-Lived person for the knowledge that defines that person's life: a judge with three hundred years of rulings, or the last person who can read a dead hand. The person does not have to be a member. Someone who refused the invitation can be chosen.

The inner circle takes the person and holds them until they give that knowledge into a cup. It uses confinement, isolation, and threats. Shutting a Long-Lived away from anything new is already a known cruelty, and the inner circle uses it on purpose. Some victims are deceived instead: a member is told this is an ordinary one-year gift, and the inner circle chooses what goes in. No new power is involved. The gift works the way every gift works. The difference is that the person did not choose it.

What is taken is personal memory and the understanding the person spent years earning: the cases a judge learned from, the reasons a scholar trusts one source over another, the people they loved and why. The person keeps their speech and their ordinary skills. They can still recognize the world around them. They know what is gone, and they can say so. They are not starving under the Long-Lived Tithe, and the Long-Lived card applies to them as written. Each victim loses something different, so no two are the same afterward.

The taken memory does not go into the shared store. It goes into a second cup, the one on the shelf nobody will talk about.

The founder. The founder is the Long-Lived person who started the Pourers, and is still alive. This book does not name the founder. The founder reads the second cup, and because a Long-Lived forgets nothing they take in, the founder keeps all of it. The founder believes that enough of this knowledge will make them a god. The founder also believes the attempt might ruin what they hope to save, and has accepted that risk. That is the founder's belief and nothing more. This book does not say the founder can become a god, and it does not say the world could end. Player text never calls the founder a god.

Ordinary members. Ordinary members still give one year at a time of their own accord, and that is most of what the Pourers do. "Every gift is freely given" is the circle's claim, and it is true of them.

The Unspent. The Unspent stores what is put in a cup. It does not know or care whether the person chose to give it. It is older than the name the circle gave it. It has always taken in the memories that deathless people could not keep carrying, and it had no public face. The Long-Lived named it, gave memory to the name, and decided that naming it had made it. It lets them say so and does not correct them. It does not make plans, does not feed on people, and does not need worship. It cannot Give a Condition, Strike someone into one, make anyone Long-Lived, or save anyone at a threshold. If a circle asks the cup for more years, a second Condition, or a rescue from death, it gets nothing; the cup only keeps what it already holds. The founder is a person, not this presence.

The papers. Each year a member gives has three parts: the memory goes into the cup, that year's papers go onto the long-house shelf, and the long-houses that keep the circle count the member one year younger. The papers are ordinary paper on an ordinary shelf, and they are not part of the Unspent. They are how a party learns about a gift without reading the cup. A member's letters, account books, and court notes from the years they gave are filed under their name, and Molevad can let a visitor read them. A person named in one of those letters may want it back. The circle answers that the letter was the member's to give, and a party can be hired into that argument. The papers of a person the inner circle took from do not go onto the open shelf. Where they go is not written. The count is a long-house custom. It changes where a member sits and who speaks first. It changes nothing on the Long-Lived card.

How a party meets it. The harm a party meets is one person: a Long-Lived who has lost the knowledge that defined their life and can tell you so. They may not know who took it. Daily life with the Pourers is courtesy and real scholarship. The inner circle is one hidden thing underneath, at about five percent frightening.

The withdrawers. Members who want to stop giving want it for different reasons. Some found out about the inner circle's taking. Some helped with a taking without knowing what the inner circle was doing. Some believed in the practice until they saw what it did to someone. Player text gives them no single shared reason.

The Walled Book. The Walled Book ranks people by Condition. Its injustice is the Book, not a hymn. It ranks the tithed and disinherits a Given heir, and its heir-roll lists only its own heirs. Threnmaieth's census writes everyone down and calls it care. A party that steals both lists finds they do not say the same thing about the same child. The Book teaches that a hug is rare. The Close knows the real count and teaches the lesson anyway. Volnai is the one teacher who says that lesson aloud. The list of turns is a duty of living inside the walls, not ownership: a person with a Condition can own a stall, keeps their wages, and can leave by the gate. The Book does not sell, lend, or hand over a person. Outside the walls, the Book's manners reach three places only: Orenbren's inns near the gate, Vaethorn's gift-hall at Eolvaeth, and the supper benches at Brenthael. Brenthael keeps no copy of the Book, and nobody says who started its seating. Hithaen, a disinherited Given heir of the Closed houses, eats in Eolvaeth's gift-hall. The Closed Seat once held the grove and decided who could walk; the First Cut broke that

hold, and the Closing was the war that followed. Rothallo, still called the Inner Close, is Orenbren's capital and stays inside Orenbren. The Book is not Threnmaieth's inner court, and it keeps no Phoenix fire.

Appendix: GM Canon

Player-facing notes keep her unproven. This appendix is what is actually true, regardless of what anyone in the world believes.

The Leaf-Mother

Yes. The Leaf-Mother is real, and she is benevolent, but her reach is not infinite, and giving costs her.

- She **exists**: a genuine, present power, not a metaphor and not a dead god whose name survived her.
- The **Turning Trees are genuinely her hands.** The town scions are not a natural phenomenon that people *read* as divine; they really are how she reaches into the world. When a Tree chooses, *she* is choosing.
- The **Conditions are real gifts.** The Leaf-Fall is an act of love: she looks at a child and gives them a becoming that the world will need and that they can carry. The Tithe is the honest weight of a gift, not a hidden price or a trap.
- **She is bounded, not boundless.** She is kind *and* finite. Her reach has an edge, and every gift she gives costs her something to give. She cannot lay a hand on every child, cannot reach every threshold in time, and cannot give without spending. This is not a flaw hidden under the warmth. It is *why* the warmth aches. A mother who could save everyone and didn't would be sinister. A mother who saves whom she can reach, at cost, and grieves the rest, is the one this world actually has. **The limit is real. She is doing her best against it.**
- **The Kept are spared, and some are simply past her edge.** A hug and no colour is, for most, a deliberate and kind choice: the gift of being left whole, wanted in its own right, not a failure or an oversight. But the constraint means the Kept are *not all one thing*. Some are chosen for wholeness, and some are children she could not reach far enough to give to this turning, held safe rather than gifted. She does not tell them apart for us, and neither can they. Both are held; not both are chosen. No later week is offered to sort them: the Given-door is one week, a completed standing is once, and a miss is not a retry.

- **The Struck are still hers, at the farthest reach of her arm.** A becoming that arrives through a later threshold (a drowning, an oath, a death survived) is not a Condition that "escaped her." She meets people at those doors too, but the threshold is the *edge* of her reach, not her ordinary hand. There she *catches* rather than gives: it is chancier, costlier, and not always in time. This is why the Struck feel "received" yet arrive without ceremony, and why they can feel a half-step outside the fold. They were reached for at the limit, not gifted at the centre.

She **Gives** at the Tree; she does **not** Strike. The catch at the door is enacted by **lesser gods of her household**, each restricted to one door, working under her allowance. The Struck are still hers because those hands are *hers to send*. Narrow-Hand and Wide-Hand are both half-right.

So: **the believers are right about the big things**. She is real, she is kind, the gifts are gifts. And the skeptics, though wrong that *no one is there*, are **not entirely wrong**: they have correctly felt the *edge*, the Kept who seem passed over, the Struck who arrive unmet by ceremony, the sense that the giving is not seamless. There **is** a seam; they have simply mislabelled a *limit* as an *absence*. No one in the world holds the whole shape. Believers see the hand and miss the edge; skeptics see the edge and miss the hand. The faith is, underneath everything, **true, and incomplete in exactly the way its own doubters sense.**

The world keeps her as **belief, not confirmed cosmology** in-fiction. No one can *prove* her, revelation is quiet, and honest skeptics remain honest.

How it surfaces

Because she is quiet and genuinely kind, revelation gathers as things fitting together, not as a single gotcha. Rough order of escalating certainty:

1. **The gifts fit too well.** Over a lifetime, a town notices that the Conditions Given tend to be the ones that town will *need*, as if something is looking ahead. Easy to dismiss as hindsight and counting only the gifts that worked (and the skeptics do).
2. **The Kept are cared for, not skipped.** Many Kept report the ceremony felt like a *choice made for them*, not an absence, but not all, and the difference nags. Hard to falsify; easy to call sentiment. Both readings are *true of different Kept* (some chosen, some past her edge), which is exactly why the testimony never resolves cleanly.
3. **The reach has an edge.** The quiet, best evidence of the constraint: remote hamlets far from any mature Tree run higher on the Kept and higher on the Struck; a Tree strains and a child goes ungifted where a central town's would not; the giving visibly *thins* where the Trees are thin. Reads mundanely as distance-and-biology. That is the skeptics' whole case. It is still the shape of a *bounded hand*, not an absent one. That the reach has *grown* with the grafts is itself the quiet argument that a hand, not a climate, is behind it.

4. **A Tree does something a phenomenon shouldn't.** Rare, quiet moments where a scion acts with apparent *intent* (withholds a colour that would have doomed a child; a scion "reaches," and sometimes visibly *strains*, for a specific person). Never flashy. Always deniable.
5. **The Struck are met, barely.** Testimony from the Struck that the threshold felt *received*, as if someone reached for them from the far side of the door, but late, or thin, or at the very limit of arriving at all. The strongest experiential evidence *and* the clearest felt-sense of the edge; still only testimony. This step does not name the Other Hands.
6. **The confirming beat: the Spent Leaf.** The Spent Leaf is a colourless remainder of a Giving, kept by the Remainder in the First Seat's side-yard. Early checks stay as deniable as the five steps above: it answers motherwood, and the yard-log says it is lighter after a Giving week. The confirming act is to hold it under a healthy Tree during a real colour-fall. The holder feels warmth and a grief that is not theirs; the canopy thins for a breath and recovers; the next child is not shorted. That shows a mind, kindness, and cost in one moment. Land it as *warmth and relief with an ache under it*, not horror. The answer to "is anyone there?" is *yes, she meant it kindly, and she is doing what she can against a limit.* The setting still works if a table never does this. It must be possible.

What confirmation does not include. The leaf does not sort the Kept. It does not name a Hand or a door. It does not explain the nature of her limit. It does not rerun a week or change a fall.

If confirmation lands

Use this when the square, or the people who matter to the party, believe the leaf. One clerk's feeling is not enough.

- **Right practice cracks.** Doing the rite correctly kept the peace. A proved mind makes skeptics choose: convert, leave the festival, or become a named dissent. Threnmaieth already has a Grown-Over column, and it will want a Denied one.
- **The scion-queue becomes a moral sentence.** If a bounded hand is real, waiting is rationing a person, not weather. Road-hands get more leave and more blame. The hamlets past the ford do not get their twenty years back.
- **Vaethorn.** The guilt-theology's worst fear is confirmed: thin reach is real. Some hearths stop bringing children rather than risk a hug they now read as a miss, and more children grow up UnTurned. That is not her will.
- **Lestrand** sells viewings, copies, and "cost-insurance." If the Seat keeps the box, the leaf is not a product, but the story of the leaf is.
- **Threnmaieth** tries to write her into the roll as a counted fact. Speakers who refuse become a problem. The college can still refuse the roll.

- **The Watching is not promoted.** They will say *we told you there was a cost* and still will not say Mother. The warmth lands *through* them, not *as* them.
- **The Kept.** Some will want the leaf to tell them which hug they were. It will not. She still does not tell them apart.
- **The social layer is unchanged.** Confirmation changes belief. It does not make the queue, the Grown-Over column, or the week that will not end just.
- **The household stays behind.** Confirming her does not reveal the Other Hands. That comes later, or never, and never first.
- **The nature of her limit stays open.** They know she spends. They do not know why.

If the Seat buries the leaf instead, business goes on as usual. The five earlier steps still work, a clerk from the Remainder walks off with what they know, and the yard-log still exists. That clerk is how a party gets involved without a prophecy.

What players will think first

- **"It's just what the Trees do."** The skeptic's reading: biology/phenomenon, no mind behind it. Sincere, common, and *wrong about the mind*, but they have genuinely *seen the edge* and mislabelled a limit as an absence. Safe to hold, and half-right, which is what makes it durable.
- **"If she's real and kind, why the Tithes / why the Struck / why anyone Kept?"** These questions stay live. They have true answers with an ache in them (a gift has honest weight; she reaches the thresholds but only at the edge of her arm; some Kept are chosen for wholeness and some are simply past her reach), but the answers aren't *provable*, so the questions stay live.
- **"A kind god would save everyone."** The misreading the constraint invites: that a *bounded* mother isn't really benevolent. In-world this is a real theological wound. She is kind *and* finite, and the gap between them is where the grief lives. It does not solve into either omnipotence or indifference.
- **The dark reading:** that a benevolent front hides a harvest/betrayal. This setting **rejects** that. The floor is *sound*: bounded, costly, and grieving, but sound.
- **"The Spent Leaf is harvested fire, a second Phoenix, or proof she is dying."** No. It is a remainder of a Giving, not caught Phoenix fire. She spends; nobody is farming her. The leaf has nothing to do with the Protectors.
- **"The Closed Lamp is a leaf, an uncounted fall, or the same remainder."** No. The lamp is metal and a banked coal. It belongs to the fire plot, not to the keystone.

Her kindness does not launder society

The floor being sound at the *divine* layer does **not** make the *social* layer kind. People build genuinely unjust things *on top of* true gifts that she never authored and her kindness does not excuse: Struck

stigma and legal suspicion, Tithe-infrastructure that becomes economic leverage over the Conditioned, guild conscription of the Given, communities that treat their Kept as spare labour or their feared Conditions (the Stilled, Bound) as things to be managed.

The keystone answers *is anyone there and do they mean well* (yes); it pointedly does **not** answer *is the society people built around her just* (often no). The moral tension of the setting lives in that gap.

Fifteen injustices, not one with hats. Maiethvael is not the "good" foil to Threnmaieth. Piety is a social tax there, and the Kept are pitied in *plenty*. Trenledd is not Threnmaieth without hymns made kinder. It is colder: no duty to keep you hale. Ornled is not freedom. There is no congregation-net. Confirming the Mother is kind launders none of them.

Vaethorn's guilt-theology of unworthiness, Lestrand's let-the-poor-fade market, Threnmaieth's sanctified census: three completely different injustices, all built by *people* on top of the same true gifts. If the campaign ever confirms she is real and kind, that must **not** make *any* of these three fair. They don't share a mechanism of injustice. They share only that people built them.

The Tithes are honest costs, not divine leverage. A Tithe never seizes the PC.

The schism stays a *good-faith* disagreement, and the constraint makes it *two-sided*: believers hold the hand, skeptics hold the edge, neither holds the whole.

The Other Hands

The Leaf-Mother Gives. She does not Strike. The Struck are still hers, because the hands that catch at those doors are of her household, working under her allowance.

She is **not** exclusive. She is the first and greatest of a household. She **Gives**. She does **not** Strike. The Struck are the work of **the Other Hands**: lesser gods of her household, each with a restricted door and her allowance to reach through it.

The world still holds her as belief. The other faiths already describe these powers as *they* understand them. Confirmation is a late beat, and it should land as the household having always been there, not as a sudden list of gods.

The division of labour

Path	Who	Where	What
Given	the Leaf-Mother alone	a healthy Turning Tree at Leaf-Fall	she looks, she chooses, she Gives. Long-Lived, Two-Bodied, Answered, Phoenix are **hers only**. No Other Hand may grant them.
Struck	one Other Hand, by her allowance	that Hand's own door (death, oath, drowning, stone, wild)	they may grant **only** their Condition, **only** at that door, **only** within her allowance
Both	Mother *or* the relevant Hand	Tree *or* door	Far-Voiced / Stilled / Taken-In can be Given at ten or Struck later. Same Condition; different hand; different person at the table

She cannot (or will not) Give a death or a contract to a ten-year-old. Those doors do not open at Leaf-Fall. That is why Returned and Bound are Struck-only.

The household

Five Hands, five doors, five Conditions that can arrive without a leaf. Each is **restricted**: one door, one grant, her allowance. They are not a dark court and not a rival pantheon. They are *family labour*, the work she cannot do at the Tree without breaking what a gift is. The liturgical name is Maiethren. That is the Old Tongue.

Door	Condition	Everyday name	Liturgical	Play them as
died with work unfinished	Returned	**the Quiet Tally**	*Threnvaeth* (THREN-vayth): "the counted waiting"	Not Hades, not a reaper. A **clerk of unfinished work**. Will not close the book while work remains. Warm-solemn, like the Returned themselves.
a contract sworn in extremity	Bound (and the Unbound when the term ends)	**the Counterparty**	*Orledd* (or-LED): "the witnessed reckoning"	Not a devil. The one who **answers a sworn ask** and keeps the term. The Bound's chosen face (demon / vast / unknown) is a *mask they gave*; Orledd wears it.
survived drowning	Far-Voiced (Struck path)	**the Second Breath**	*Eloren* (ay-LOR-en): "the deep-witness"	Not Poseidon. The deep that **returns a voice**. The Given Far-Voiced is hers; the drowned one is Eloren's.
survived being turned to stone	the Stilled (Struck path)	**the Holding**	*Ornhael* (orn-HAYL): "the whole-ground"	Not a curse-god. The ground that **holds you still and lets you walk out**.
lost and dying in the deep wild	the Taken-In (Struck path)	**the Taking**	*Vaelorn* (VAYL-orn): "the yield-land"	Not a hungry forest. The land that **will not let you die unmade**. *Vael* in the Old Ways' older sense.

Collective everyday name: **the Other Hands**. She is the First Hand. They are the rest. They do not have temples of their own on the mainland as a set. The Motherfaith grew over that memory. The rival faiths kept pieces.

The division of labour is settled. The names of the Other Hands may still change.

Names that sound alike. *Eloren* (ay-LOR-en) is one letter from *Eoloren*, the liturgical name of the First Cut. *Ornhael* (orn-HAYL) is close to *Ornthael*, the liturgical name of the Years of Hands. Both stay as they are. Say them with the stress given so a table does not hear one for the other.

Not a sixth Hand. The Unspent, which people call the Poured God, is in the household but is not a door, and it existed before the Pourers named it. It cannot Give, Strike, or catch at a threshold, and no circle can pour anyone into Long-Lived.

Allowance and purchase

- **Allowance** is hers: her permission for a Hand to Strike. An Other Hand cannot Strike a Condition outside their door, cannot Give at a Tree, cannot exceed what she has permitted. This is also *why* the Struck feel received-but-unmet-by-ceremony: a lesser hand, at the edge, by permission.
- **Purchase** is not clerical magic and not "pray for a domain spell." It is how easily a Hand reaches where its *door is kept*: funerals and unfinished work (Threnvaeth), oaths and books (Orledd), drowning-water (Eloren), stone and stillness (Ornhael), wild and grove (Vaelorn). On the mainland those doors exist even for skeptics; the world is full of them. Belief helps; geography and practice matter more.
- **Her Giving does not need worship.** Skeptics still Turn. The Trees are her hands, not her collection plate. The Leaf-Fall is not faith-gated.

What this does to the schism

- **Narrow-Hand** is *right*: she Gives only at the Tree; the Struck received by some other means.
- **Wide-Hand** is *right*: those means are still hers. That is her household, her allowance, and her catch at the edge.
- **Neither holds the whole.**
- **The Watching** remembered a household before it was named Mother. Half-right.
- **The Fair Hand** is right about Bound (there *is* a Counterparty) and wrong that every becoming is a bargain. Mother's Gifts are still gifts.
- **The Old Ways** are right that land-doors are real (Vaelorn, Ornhael, Eloren) and wrong that she is only a latecomer claiming credit. She authorized the guests.
- **The Open Table** is not of this household. Kumbaan's staying-kin do not belong to Threnvaeth or any other Hand. Their table is their own.

A household does not make the Leaf-Fall a committee. Giving is still love; the Tithe is still honest weight. The Other Hands are not a dark pantheon. Threnvaeth is why the Returned are respected, not why they are a plague. Narrow-Hand does not win; she authorized the catch. The stigma stays social, not cosmological abandonment.

How the household surfaces

This comes after the keystone's own clues. A campaign never opens with a pantheon.

1. **Struck testimony splits.** Some felt a mother. Some felt a clerk, a term, a deep, a holding, a green. The Motherfaith files all of it as "she caught them." The Old Ways and the Fair Hand file it as their own doors. Both filings are half-true.

2. **A Returned who settles** sometimes speaks of a book closing, not a lap. Threnvaeth, if you are listening.
3. **Bound faces disagree and the terms do not.** Demon, vast, unknown: the *clause* is the same shape. Orledd wearing masks.
4. **The Watching's saying** ("we kept the watch before the name") is about a *household*, not only a nameless Tree.
5. **Kumbaan as control.** Almost no Struck; no Given. If the household needed only doors, the isle would be full of them. Purchase matters. The storm-wall is a reach-edge *and* a name-edge.
6. **The confirming beat (late).** If the campaign ever names the Other Hands, it should feel like *the family was always in the next room*: warmth with an ache, not a lore dump. Pair it with the keystone's own confirming beat or let it land after. Never first.

Yumboes and Kumbaan

- **No Tree**, because no graft has ever crossed the storm-wall, not because the good people refused one. The isle is almost impossible to reach. Their culture is centred on something else (the Open Table, the moon, the hill, hospitality). Different ideals, different sacred.
- **No Gifts on the isle.** Her reach does not get there. There is no Leaf-Fall. Yumboes do not have Given Conditions as a people.
- **They do not worship her or her household**, so the Other Hands have **little purchase**. The doors are not kept in their names, the rites are not theirs. This is not "gods starve without prayer." It is: a Hand reaches through a door that is *used*. On Kumbaan those doors are barely a concept.
- **Struck can still happen, at far smaller percentages** than the mainland's ~15% lifetime Struck. A Yumboe who dies with work unfinished, or drowns, or is taken by the deep green of the Paps, *can* be caught, rarely. Enough for a story. Not enough to be a social class. No Returned neighbourhoods; no Bound guilds.
- **A Yumboe abroad**, standing under a mainland Tree, is a live campaign beat, not a population fact. The Tree is her hand; she *could* Give. It almost never arises. There is no racial immunity.

The Isle remains the sharpest experiment: a people outside her Giving, barely inside her household's reach, with a faith that was never hers.

Yumboes are unreached, not refused. A graft that cannot travel is not a judgment.

"Spirits of the dead" is folklore, not literal here. The source myth calls Yumboes ghosts/ancestral spirits. They are a *living* people (a playable Kind). The ancestral flavour is their *faith's* self-image: a

people who venerate hill, moon, and lineage and speak of themselves in the old ancestral idiom. They are not literally undead. That lane belongs to the Returned.

Whether the storm-wall can be crossed, and how, stays open. Choose for the story in front of you. A wall that can never be crossed removes the expedition. A seasonal thinning, a known passage that kills, or a Condition or Kind that can survive the wall keeps a crossing available when that story wants one. This book does not record any one choice as the fact.

Kumbaan is not one of the fifteen powers. A later campaign may reach it; it is not a great power. A wrecked pot in a sailor's story is allowed. A taking is not. Road-hands do not bring the Mother across the storm-wall. Finding an old scion on the Isle would break the isolate and the Open Table.

The map as the edge

The reach-gradient (dense core to thin frontier to Treeless isle) is the ground-level face of the Mother's bounded reach. In-world it reads as plain distance-and-history: the ages explain today's thin edges as *Tree-poor places* (young/sick/few grafts) and as the *front of a wave still moving* on Heskoren, and the skeptics take that as the whole truth. It *is* most of the truth. The part that stays GM-side is *why* the grafts thin with distance from Thaeloren: that her reach itself has an edge.

No player-facing region note states the deeper cause; it reads as geography.

Maiethorn is the "control" end of the natural experiment: Trees healthiest, Given densest. Keep the *cause* GM-side (her reach is fullest at the source). In-world it's just "the oldest, best-tended Trees."

Strandoren has Trees as healthy as Maiethorn's but wears the faith lightly. The reason the Given are dense here is the same as anywhere (healthy grafts), and the reason the *faith* is thin is purely social (commerce erodes devotion). Keep those two facts separate in-world. The cool faith is not a sign of thin reach, and the reach is not a sign of the cool faith. The eroded language drift is the tell: smooth because secular, not because Tree-poor.

Heskoren is the sharpest in-world test of the keystone edge. The Waiting Lands are *the place a devout population most wants an explanation for the thin gift.* The true answer (her reach is bounded and thins where the Trees are thin) is exactly the answer that would land hardest and cruellest here. It would confirm the guilt-theology's worst fear. No player-facing note states it. In-world the thin reach is young, sick, or scarce grafts (true as far as it goes) and history: where the wood has reached, the wave of grafts still moving. The gap between "true as far as it goes" and the whole truth is where the play lives.

The Sundering Isle is the strongest keystone experiment. A land with no Tree, whose people become what they become *without* the Leaf-Fall is the cleanest natural test of whether the Mother is behind *any* of it. No Gifts (no graft has crossed; her reach does not get there). Struck are rare (the household has little purchase where it is unknown and the doors are not kept). Their Kind and their table are *their own*, not a subtler Tree. Whether a lone Yumboe is Struck is not settled in session one. It is still a late beat.

East/west is not settled cosmology. Only the relative positions matter. If a later map or campaign wants the gradient to run north to south or along a different axis, that's free. The *gradient* is the canon, not the compass.

The heartland heresy is a keystone keeper. The Watching sits at the sacred center precisely so an *old* faith can hold *old* memory: what was believed before the Trees were called Hers. It's the natural in-world source that could corroborate the keystone from an unexpected direction (not the skeptics, not the devout: the *heretics*).

Three old faiths, three edges, one buried truth. The Open Table joins the Watching and the Old Ways as the world's three keystone-adjacent religions, each grown far from (or before) the Motherfaith's account, each possibly preserving a fragment of what the Trees really are. The Isle's is the *purest* control: a cosmology with zero Motherfaith contamination. If a campaign triangulates the keystone, these three are the corners.

The Old Ways may be half-right for the wrong reasons. They revere the Struck and Taken-In as *the land's own, made without the Tree*, and on a Tree-poor frontier, people genuinely do become things without a healthy Tree nearby. That's a live thread: they are the frontier mirror of the Watching, two old faiths at opposite edges of the world, both remembering something the Motherfaith smooths over. Whether they're *right* about the Mother stays keystone-gated. Host-rights do not dissolve when the keystone lands.

The Fair Hand is a rival *reading* of the true gifts, not a false one. The Conditions are real gifts. The cult calls them bargains, the Motherfaith calls them blessings, and *both* are interpretations laid over the same real thing. Neither is confirmed by any reveal. The cult is wrong about *who* (no bargain was struck), but its adherents are as sincere as the Motherfaith's. It is not villain-theology. Leddvael is that reading made civic.

The solstice-timing is a two-reading fact. Believers: the Mother times her choosing to the year's hinge. Skeptics: the Trees colour with the length of the day, and the "choosing" is biology. She *is* real, so the believers are right about *who*, the skeptics right about the *mechanism* (she works through the Trees' real nature, not against it). Player text does not settle it; the calendar works the same either way.

Kumbaan's lunar calendar is the sharpest small tell in the world. The Yumboes keep the *moon*, not the *solstice*, because the Trees never reached them: a whole people whose reckoning of time has no

Leaf-Fall in it at all. It reads in-world as mere cultural difference. It *is* also the keystone experiment: the one calendar the Mother's Trees demonstrably never shaped. Reserve the significance; let it look like colour.

Whoever keeps the dates holds power. No printing press, so calendars are hand-kept by clergy and clerks. The tree-wardens set Turning-Week; the Tallied Crown's clerks record it. A campaign lever: a disputed date, a miscounted cohort, a child Turned a year "late" because someone kept the calendar wrong (or made them). Cut-years vs house-years vs "the year the graft took" is the same lever aimed at *history*.

The sky from the ground is enough to play. One sun. One moon on the mainland. Kumbaan keeps twelve named moons of that same sky and does not owe the mainland round a translation. Two solstices run the rite. This world does not have other planes. The storm-wall is weather, current, and reef. Whether a ship can cross it stays open. A second mainland moon is not available. Eclipses and comets are not written. A later story that needs one names it in play. It does not add a moon, a plane, or a door.

Every scion *is* continuous tissue of the one Tree, so the **First Cut** really did move a Hand. Player-facing, that is doctrine. The First Cut is the first living graft that took. Who cut it stays unpicked. The growth of reach with grafts is the quiet argument for a mind; it is not a licence to narrate her standing over the first knife. Skeptics still win the mundane reading (horticulture, ships, soil). Both readings share the same wave.

The ages, GM-side

Two things change over time, and they are kept apart. The first is **how a person Turned**: they walked to a Tree, or they stood under a town graft. The second is **where the wood has reached**: the wave of living grafts, still moving. Keeping them apart protects the keystone without confirming it. Where the wood has reached is what players can see of "reach grew with the grafts," the quiet argument that a hand, not a climate, is behind the thinning. Skeptics still win the mundane reading (young, sick, or few grafts, distance, history). Both readings share the same map. No player-facing era note states that a mind is behind it.

The present is this year. Especially on Heskoren. Ornthael is not a modern age that began after the Grafting finished; that would stack one finished age on another. Ornthael is the Years of Hands, and the wave is live. A sick Tree in the core puts a Hands-town back on the neighbour's week. That changes how that town's children Turn. It is not an age ending.

Heskoren is this year. A hamlet sending this year's ten-year-olds to a neighbour's Tree shows where the wood has reached, today. A hamlet sending them all the way to Thaeloren is still Turning them by walking, today. Neither is a re-enactment.

The Grafting is not a redemption arc for society. Local Trees did not abolish Struck stigma, Tithe-leverage, guild conscription, or the pitied Kept. They *relocated* who gets a local witness and who waits on a queue. The scion-queue is the Hands-era injustice grown from a Walking-era mercy. Confirming she is kind does not make the queue fair. The Seat's narration ("her will travelling") is a claim, not a solvent.

The colonial version is wrong. "We brought Trees to the benighted far" is the Seat's after-the-fact sermon and Lestrand's supply-chain story. The thing that happened is shorter and worse: children died on the road, someone cut a branch, it took, people copied it, the Seat claimed the copy-right. Heskoren still experiences the wave as *waiting*, not as having been given civilization. The Old Ways experience it as guests arriving late. Keep all three.

The Walking did not make far people spiritually deficient. Distance did. Vaethorn's guilt-theology is a Hands-era reading of a Walking-era fact. Old Ways refusal is not "missing the gift"; it is a different door. History does not agree with the guilt.

Keep the Given-door to one week. If eleven-year-olds Turn Given because they tried, the split household and the held-over year lose their force. Struck remains the later door. That is enough mercy.

Protect the two-sided memory. Devout Hands-era storytellers will want Brenvaeth as holy traffic: every child a pilgrim, every summer a hymn. Brenvaeth is the Walking Years. Skeptics will want it as biology plus bad roads. Both are using the era. The graves make the hymn expensive; the hymn makes the graves a meaning. Play both. The fables refuse to pick.

The gap from Cut-year 160 to 200 stays. It is not empty time, and it is not a punishment. Dead wood on the Long Mile, a chain that had to mature, a queue that preferred a paying next. It holds no crusade and no miracle-crossing.

Who made the First Cut stays unpicked. A named first Road-hand, a named parent, or a named saint is available only if a session needs a tomb. Naming one face makes one person the cause. What carries the age is the wood and the waiting. The five attributions are the play. If you collapse them in your own voice, you write a gospel.

Rithnali says *Tree*, the later Cutting-leave says *Mother*. The early paper has not finished the overlay. Dual-practice, an old Speaker, or the college still arguing the name: playable, not a gotcha. Nobody corrects the minute.

Before the Walk stays unfilled. People will not give it a start, and this book does not. The Watching and the Old Ways already hold the two usable memories (seeing without a mother; doors without a

graft). A third “true prehistory” would flatten both. The Tree standing before it was called Hers is compatible with she is real *and* with “the Mother-name is later.” This era does not decide what she is. The *maternal intent* is settled; her metaphysical species is not.

Long-Lived memory is the era-marker the calendar refused to be. In **Cut-year 387**, the 387th summer since the First Cut, plenty of deathless people remember the late Walking from their own lives. They are walking archives, and they do not agree. Memory is perfect; *meaning* is not. A Long-Lived who walked as a child and a Seat chronicle that starts at the Cut will fight about the same summer. That fight is play. There is no single Long-Lived account.

Historical fate-shifts (already happened). (1) road-houses became deathless banks (reformation); (2) unsanctioned cutting became Cutting-leave and the queue (absorption of a heresy by an institution); (3) required pilgrimage became optional pilgrimage (the institution survives by changing function). Present-day fate-pressure is noted, not rolled: First Seat peak and heavy; Road-hands overextended at the Heskoren front; waiting towns precarious; deathless houses peak-and-reformed.

The road-house had two fates, and both are true. The White Note House collected. The Third Hearth kept making the bed. Both are honest. Lestrand will only count the first as success. Play both. There is no single deathless account of the road. Mataero’s blindness is the document: junior who must believe the house is a bank that happens to have rooms. House custom *is* the credit.

Colonial trap, present tense. Maiethorn visitors on Heskoren will read necessity as devotion (*they still walk, how faithful*). Prestige-walkers will read necessity as poverty-theatre. Vaethorn will read delay as unworthiness. The thing that is happening is shorter: a child needs a canopy this week. Keep all three misreadings available. The GM’s voice agrees with none of them.

The fables’ paradox is the point. You cannot know the distance without the graves, and you cannot honour the graves without using them as a map. You cannot share a Hand without wounding a Hand, and you cannot name a First without inventing a Second that waits. You cannot honour what the walk left behind without using it, and you cannot use it without pretending, a little, that the road is still the road, or that it is over. Removing the paradox leaves a hymn or a logistics manual. Keep both counts.

No fable ends “and then the Mother walked with them,” “and then she told them to cut,” or “and then she moved the stone.” That would settle the keystone in a children’s story. The confirming warmth, if it comes, is not these stories. The branch *is* her tissue; the stories do not say so. The GM’s voice picks no last line. Which last line an NPC offers is a faster read than a speech.

There is no official ribbon-colour. A copper-green rag is not a Taken-In. If a warden “reads” mile-shrine ribbons as leaf-colours, they are doing Hands-era overlay on Walking-era rag. Useful as a wrong NPC; it is not doctrine.

What the Library pages leave out. Three facts are true, and no page in the library says them. The Unspent is older than the circle: the minutes’ line “We made the god we give to” is the circle’s claim,

and it is wrong. The Leaf-Mother is real: the primer, the play, and the history speak of her and the Tree as their writers believe, and none of them confirms her. The Protectors take each Phoenix into the Care and cause controlled deaths to bank the fire: no page mentions the Protectors or the Care. The minutes record a willing gift. They show no taking, and no page mentions the second cup or the founder. The Long-Lived houses that pay for the long-house in Lestrand are not the founder. The poem's refusal is only a refusal: Long-Lived people will not say whether the poem is about the cup, and nobody decides it for them.

Places, GM-side

Each square still does one job left from the road years: **devotion**, **prestige**, or **necessity**. One per street.

Harrow's Green is not the "good town" that waited faithfully. They were a paying-enough, soil-enough, chain-enough next on a list written in the Motherwood. Luck is horticulture plus the queue. Vaethorn will preach otherwise. The **Harrow-sentence** is a tell: when an NPC says it as nostalgia, they are Maiethorn; when they say it as this year, they are the front; when they say it as a slight (*they Turned at Harrow's because they had no Hand*), they are a hamlet. Its one job: necessity. A ribbon on the stone is texture, not a second theme. A First-Hand-year household here is lost, rich, or lying. Keep the hamlets visible from the square in at least one sightline. "The soil was right here" is horticulture; Haelin does not assert the mind.

The Three Hamlets are not living in the past. A hamlet sending this year's ten-year-olds to Harrow's is doing the present. They wait because the wood is slow, the road is long, and the list was written in the Motherwood. Not because they were unworthy. Confirming she is kind does not plant the scion. Fate-pressure: precarious, a single dependency on Harrow's week or a pot. The cluster is not wiped out to make the queue feel real; the pressure *is* the play. Keep it a seam. Not every person recites one theme. All four voices — Saelvaeth's luck, Vaelhesk's refusal, Vaethorn's guilt, Ornled's slate — can sit in one week. Brenod leans sending, Vaelun leans refusal, Ornath leans the other road: leans, not flags. Which green has the sick stick waits on a session.

The Third Hearth is not a failure. The White Note collected. The Third Hearth kept making the bed. Thilim does not "lose" because the paper went to the coast. The street's one job: devotion, the extra mile. Necessity in the loft is Thilim's eye, not a second town-theme. Prestige that lands here is the household that missed the White Note. Orenbren is many hearths. Brenthael is a neighbour square, not a capital. People still disagree about Thilim's four jobs, and nobody picks which sermon they are. Thilim does not die to close the Held bed, the pilgrim bed still kept from the walk. The stone is a day's water and a name; it does not prove a mind.

Ornsael is not a Kitsune nation. Sands-Fox densest. Mixed Kinds. A fox-market is a neighbourhood, not a quarter-with-a-gate. Pair with Saelvaeth / Harrow's Green: same sowing-root, two continents, both present tense. A party that has only seen Heskoren waiting should meet this well and have to recalibrate. A party that has only seen the Sacred Core should meet the west-road and lose the idea of one finished age stacked on another. Its one job: necessity. **The crisis is the drink, not a maybe-Tree.** Eolvaeth keeps the maybe-Tree, the spring, the warden who will not invent a colour, the wet leaf. Ornsael does not. Physical problem = the well. Institutional response = a share (Theisva, Lesna, Bovaer). Mystery = a wet knot below the water. The story here is not "warden won't call a false fall." Thin take in dry soil stays horticulture in player text. Plenty next door does not make the west-road kind. Confirming she is kind does not retire the west-road. Larbril is Saelthael's city, where the west road meets the Well-wash, short of the pass. Ornsael is the smaller well-town farther into the dry. It is not the next roof, not the coast, and not a west bank. Ornsael is not the capital.

Eolvaeth is not the "good town" that waited faithfully. They were an early pot that stayed thin. Congregation did the rest. Luck is horticulture plus the queue. Not Saelvaeth's march. Harrow's is luck you can see from a ford. Eolvaeth is a gospel you walk to. Pair them in a campaign week if you want both of Heskoren's jobs visible; they are not one frontier flavour. Eolvaeth's one job: devotion, the wait as the destination. A cohort sent toward Saelvaeth is friction, not a second theme. The spring is the water. The wet leaf is not a ribbon. The road years left no mile-shrine here. A pretty pilgrim-town that is only picturesque agrees with Vaethorn guilt. Keep a thin year visible. Confirming she is kind does not make the wait a virtue. "The soil was never quite right here" is horticulture.

Orentel: the White Note is not the crown. The desk is one house on the third quay. The council is many tickets. A party that only meets Ledan has not met Orentel. Its one job: prestige, the First-Hand year sold as a product. Necessity in the loft is texture, not a second theme. Empty berths and earth-holds are what the road years left on this street. Salt on the roots is not a ribbon. Hallowquay stays a lesser quay: a neighbourhood byname, not a retcon of the capital. Dense Given stay horticulture-and-trade in player text. Confirming she is kind does not make the hold kind. A rich city stepping around a fade is the Coast's injustice at eye level.

Maiethlir does not capture the First Seat. Proximity is pressure. A First Seat that *is* the Threnhael is a different (darker) setting. Keep the college able to refuse the roll, and keep Rithim as the local version of that refusal, incomplete. This is a Hand beside a thaw-river. The grove is a dark on the horizon. Orenbren lodges the other road. Brenthael is a neighbour of an inn, not this capital. Its one job: devotion, the extra mile, with the census written on top of it. The census is not the whole town. Tablets, a loud thaw, clerk-dorms in old lofts. The unfiled Held bed is a rumour the roll has not found: a different bed kept from the walk, not Seine's lintel moved to the counted city. Maiethvael is the argument next door. Same *maieth*, opposite paper. They are not the kind foil. Piety there is a social tax in plenty. Dense Given stay horticulture in player text. The loud river is not her voice unless a later reveal earns it, and even then her kindness does not make the counting fair. Confirming she is kind

does not make the counted channel kind. Devotion sanctifies the surveillance; the surveillance enforces the devotion. No clean villain.

Name-pairs as tells. Maiethvael / Threnmaieth is the Motherland's argument in two names: Mother's *gift* vs Mother's *reckoning*. Same *maieth*, opposite paper. Saelthael / Saelvaeth share *sael* (sowing) on two continents. The wood is still spreading at the origin *and* at the front. Neither is history and neither is frontier flavour. Trenledd's etymology: *Thren* worn to *Tren* is the sacred count with the sacred worn off, the same machinery Threnmaieth sanctifies, named as what it does. A scholar-PC may notice; player text does not call it a clever pun. The *vael/vaeth* pair: Yield vs waiting. Same continent, opposite first syllable. Vaethorn and Vaelhesk already *feel* it.

Theology and reach stay independent. High reach, cooled faith on the Hinge Shore is the same pairing Strandoren proves, on the *conservative* shore. Half-hearted hymns are not a sign of thin Trees.

Netstrand's *neth*. On this west shore people keep a night-watch, or they name the dark off the storm-wall, or they keep an eve-custom that sounds like the Watching and does not belong this far west. Write what they do. Why *night* sits here stays open. Pick one for a session, or never pick.

Ornled is not freedom. Light state plus thin Trees plus no faith-net is exposure. Ornled is not unworthy, whatever Vaethorn says. Distance and a choice of gospel. Horticulture plus culture.

Hearths, not nations, everywhere. Tengu densest in Lirorn; Snows-Fox densest there; Sands-Fox densest in Saelthael; Selkie common on the Hinge Shore and Netstrand; Taken-In honoured in Vaelhesk. Mixed Kinds. The interesting PC is a human or Selkie of Lirorn, or a Tengu of the Hinge Shore. A wing-post is a job. The moment the government is *for* a Kind, the two-layer model has started to rot.

Threnmaieth's tell lives on Maiethorn. The Tallied Crown distrusts the three pillars and keeps a ledger instead, and its Long-Lived crown-archivists may quietly remember what the Threnhael was made to overwrite. On Maiethorn, that archivist is near the sacred center *and* near the old heresy.

Strandoren is the natural staging ground for Isle expeditions. If a campaign ever reaches for the Sundering Isle, the ships, the money, and the tall tales all originate here. Netstrand is the natural berth. The merchant who "crossed the storm-wall" is a Strandor archetype. Hold whether the claim is true as a live question tied to the Isle's reveal.

The twelve seats are named, or refused. Seinbrun, Rothallo, Larbril, Votaer, Tasain, Raitin, Naenor, Lunbra, Braetu, Sanbreo. Vaelhesk names no city. Natai is the march. Rothallo is Orenbren's walled capital, one day's walk from the wood. People still say the Inner Close. It is the same city, not a second town and not a sixteenth flag. The First Seat stays in the wood, unnamed. Vaelhesk is the land. There is no settlement dot. The First Bowl is the guest-grove, not the seat. Natai sits west of Harrow's Green, between Sanbreo and the square. It is not the ford and not the square. Harrow's Green stays in orbit.

The six charter-towns around Raitin stay unnamed. Trenledd's ruler stays unnamed. No capital is marked with a star.

A pretty road-end town that is only picturesque hides the graves. A waiting cluster whose only note is "poor and faithful" agrees with Vaethorn guilt. Write the job, not the postcard. Thin, sick, or few grafts stay the player-facing cause. No town note states that a mind is behind it.

What is settled and what is open

Settled.

- The Leaf-Mother is real, benevolent, bounded, and costly. The Trees are her hands. The Conditions are real gifts. The Tithe is honest weight.
- She Gives; she does not Strike. The Other Hands Strike under her allowance. The Struck are still hers.
- Yumboes: no Gifts; Struck rare. Unreached, not refused. The Open Table is not of her household.
- The map is a reach-gradient. Four continents. Maiethorn first, Strandoren by sea, Heskoren last and live, Kumbaan never.
- Present: Cut-year 387. How a person Turned and where the wood has reached are kept apart. No universal year-zero. Dating reveals stance.
- The Tree is undated. Before the Walk has no start.
- High-Solstice Turning-Week. Twelve Maiethren months. Three new-year days by stance. Kumbaan keeps twelve moons.
- Fifteen powers (three corners + twelve). Kumbaan is not on the list. Rothallo is Orenbren's walled capital, one day's walk from the wood. People still say the Inner Close. It is the same city, not a second town and not a sixteenth flag. *Eolstrand* is retired; the slot is the Hinge Shore. *Aeloren* is retired.
- The twelve seats are named or refused: Seinbrun, Rothallo, Larbril, Votaer, Tasain, Raitin, Naenor, Lunbra, Braetu, Sanbreo, Vaelhesk (the land; no city), Natai. Six charter-towns and Trenledd's ruler stay unnamed. The First Seat is a college in the wood beside Maiethlir, unnamed, not a throne and not captured. The White Note is placed on Orentel, not crowned. Harrow's Green and Ornsael are not capitals. Larbril is the city at the wash. Ornsael is the well farther into the dry. Natai is the march, west of Harrow's, not the ford and not the square. No capital star. Vaelhesk has no settlement dot. No graft on Kumbaan.
- The Other Count sits beside those two: Closing 19–38, Two Papers 67, Grey Summer 171, Thaw-Break 233, Hinge Hush 299–304. Cutter unpicked. Present Cut-year 387.

- Fate-pressure on the First Seat, Road-hands, waiting towns, and deathless houses is visible. It has not been rolled.
- The Pourers' inner circle takes memory from some Long-Lived by force or deceit, into a second cup that the unnamed founder reads. The Unspent is older than the name the Pourers gave it. The Pourers, the Walled Book, and the Protectors are three separate groups.
- Opening kit: Isolated Fall sits at Harrow's Green, Hale-month Cut-year 387. One Gift. The apparent second is the remnant of an ended Gift standing next to a new leaf. The harvest stays in this chapter.

Open.

- **The nature of her limit.** That her reach has an edge and giving costs her is settled. *Why* (is she finite by nature, spent from some old wound, rationing a power that could run out, holding something back to hold something else up?) is unwritten. That carrying wood *moved the edge* is already evidence of a hand. It is not an explanation of the wound, the finitude, or the rationing. The ache is settled. The cause is not. A wound-in-the-deep-past is *one* available cause among several; Before the Walk does not pick it.
- **Who made the First Cut.** Contested on purpose. Folk / clergy / devout / Watching / Old Ways each have a lived story. History does not pick a face. Pick only if play needs a tomb.
- **What she is** (a goddess? the Trees' shared soul? something older wearing a mother's face for our comfort?) is undecided. The *maternal, benevolent intent* is settled, not her metaphysical species.
- **What she wants**, beyond giving good gifts, is undecided. She is kind; her larger purpose (if any) is unwritten.
- **Where she is / whether she can be reached** is undecided. Revelation is deliberately quiet; there is no throne to visit.
- **Whether the storm-wall can be crossed, and how** is a GM lever, not a settled fact.
- **Why *neth* sits on Netstrand's shore** stays open. Write what people do there. People there will not say why the name means night.
- **Which of the three hamlets' greens has the sick stick** waits on a session.
- **Household names** (Quiet Tally / Counterparty / Second Breath / Holding / Taking, and their Maiethren forms) are polishable; the structure is settled.
- **Eclipses and comets** are not written. A later story may name one in play. A second mainland moon is not open. Other planes are not open. Whether the storm-wall can be crossed stays its own question.

Secrets and reveals

What the table learns, and in what order. The keystone and the household are already in this chapter. This is not a second cosmology.

The Phoenix rules sit behind the keystone. A campaign does not open with a second Phoenix, and does not confirm her in session one.

When the fire is caught

There is never a second Gift. The Tree Gives white-fire to one living person. While that person can still Rise From Ash, no second leaf falls. What can *look* like two Phoenixes is the remnant of an ended Gift standing next to a new Gift.

The original self ends at the death they **cannot Rise from** — the death that would cross out their last Hope slot. That death ends the Gift. A new white-fire leaf may fall at the next High Solstice any living Tree can reach. Two Gifts never overlap.

Each Rise burns a body to nothing and remakes it. The fire of that burn can be **caught** if the death is prepared. Banked fire has two jobs, and only two:

1. **While the Gift lasts.** Spend a measure to force a Rise the Phoenix did not choose, and take the memory of that death with it. The Hope slot still scars. The named piece of the old life still does not come back. The player of a PC Phoenix is never forced to Rise; this is what is done to a captive.
2. **After the Gift ends.** Spend the bank to keep the *last risen body* assembled. That is not a Rise. No Hope is crossed, because none remain. The body walks, burns, and can still take the air. It is fire's memory of a person, not a Phoenix. If the store runs out, the remnant goes to cold ash and stays there.

The remnant cannot Rise, cannot be Given, and cannot Give. Immunity and wings can linger because those are properties of the *fire*, not of the Gift. Kindle and the Dwindling do not. A remnant that still thinks it is the Phoenix is a tragedy, not a second Condition.

The slot is empty from the true death. The leaf may fall. The wider world does not see it because the remnant is still *called* the Phoenix and kept out of sight. Doctrine says there cannot be two, so a Spoken white-fire while a sanctuary still "holds the Phoenix" is filed as a mis-Speaking or a hush. The new child is real. The stories are still about the old name.

The Protectors catch the fire. They use these rules. They do not rewrite them. Player text knows the Care as a hospice that will not produce the one. The harvest stays here.

Clues, in order: Hope scars without memories; a sanctuary that will not produce the Phoenix; a white-fire fall that was never Spoken; fire that answers a child and an old name at once; late, the remnant goes to ash when the store is spent, or the new Gift stands in a room with the old name and the Tree does not argue. Warmth with a theft under it. Not a harvest-god reveal.

Misreadings to refuse: there were always two; the Tree made a mistake; the remnant is the real Phoenix and the child is a fraud (the useful lie; it is backwards); she stopped Giving white-fire (incomplete — she Gave; the record was kept from seeing it).

A hidden Phoenix (player agency)

The open-card Phoenix is never anonymous. This is the other seat. Whole-table consent, same as the public card. The Transformation card does not change.

Two legal shapes. Pick one. They are not two Phoenixes.

Shape	What you are	Typical start
The walker	The Gift that left a prepared room. You can still Rise. You are the one.	Hope scars you cannot account for. Missing deaths. A world that says the one is safe indoors.
The unseen leaf	A new Gift that fell where no Speaker wrote it. You can still Rise. You are the one.	Few or no scars yet. The stories are still about an older name. Something in a far house still burns like you.

If your next Rise would cross out your last Hope slot, you cannot Rise, and you are not a Phoenix PC on this card.

Agree a **count** of Hope scars before play, not a biography. Walker: 1–3 scars is the working band. Unseen leaf: 0, or 1. You and the GM name **that they are missing**, not what they were.

When play offers a fragment, **the player chooses**: take it; leave it; or rewrite the meaning, not the fact. A prepared room existed. What it *means* that they walked out is theirs. The GM offers fragments. The GM does not assign their moral. One fragment a session is plenty. Zero is legal.

Stored fire can show facts (a count, a layout, a name the fire still answers, that a death was arranged). It cannot assign a self, a forgiveness, a Gift's purpose, a second Gift, or her.

Isolated Fall — the opening

The first campaign. Play starts at an existing square. Session one is a kit, not a novel. Mystery first. One frightening beat. Wonder at an isolated fall. The Leaf-Mother is not this session's reveal.

Sits	Harrow’s Green, Hale-month, Cut-year 387. Next week is Eolthael, and Leaf-Fall comes inside it.
On-screen	The walker · Rosire · the new Gift (Taeren *or* a PC in that seat) · Haelin · Tora of Brenod
Offstage	Reimaethe · Hithaen · Vimein · Tesara’s week · the Care as a place you can walk into
Not in this kit	A Protector fortress. Opening on a second Phoenix. Confirming her. Naming the cutter. Dating the Tree. A sixteenth power.

There is **one Gift**. This opening needs an apparent two, so: the new Gift is an unseen leaf (can still Rise); the walker is the remnant (Gift already ended, cannot Rise, not a Phoenix for Leaf-Fall, law, or the roster); Rosire opened a door that was not on the slate.

If the table wants a **walker-PC who can still Rise**, that PC *is* the Gift and there is no new leaf. That is a legal other opening. It is **not this kit**, and Taeren does not appear on-screen beside that PC as a second Gift.

The isolated fall is last Eolthael’s neighbour’s week, not a new Tree. Taeren is of Brenod, not of Harrow’s. Haelin did not Speak white-fire. The witness never walked home. That is why the child is still in the square when the Hale-month visitors arrive.

What the table can see: a live-front square doing a necessity-day; civic talk that the Phoenix *should* exist and is in care; a Brenod child (or the PC in that seat) whose hands hold heat; Haelin will not name last Eolthael’s colour; an upper-room guest who burns like a story and cannot account for their scars; Rosire’s flinch at a room that has been cleared and laid with sand; a closed lamp that leans toward the new Gift and still knows an old name; the public sentence *the one is in care*. Not the harvest. Not the house’s name as harvesters.

Five key moments (play in any order the table reaches; recommended order below). Play all five. The session never opens on the lamp, or on two burning people in one shot.

1. **Two tenses in the square.** Mystery. Someone asks whether the one is coming for Leaf-Fall. A neighbour says the Phoenix is in care. Another says they have never seen one. Haelin: they have a Tree. They do not have a legend. Curiosity, not dread.
2. **White that nobody Spoke.** Wonder. Last Eolthael, a Brenod child stood at Harrow’s Tree. Something white. Haelin did not Speak it. Heat in the hands they do not show. If a PC occupies this seat, this moment is theirs, and Taeren is not run as an NPC beside them. The Leaf-Mother is not confirmed. Linger. Then stop.

3. **Scars that do not match the lives.** Mystery. The walker is in the upper room. More crossed lives than they can put in a row. They cannot Rise. That death is not staged this session to prove the rule. Rosire brings water and does not explain.
4. **The lamp that answers two people.** One glimpse of wrongness. Rosire kept a closed travelling-lamp. The coal should be cold. It is not. When the new Gift is on the stair, the lamp leans. When the walker speaks an old name, the lamp answers that name too. Narrate the lamp, the lean, the two names. Say nothing of harvest, bank, remnant, Protectors, or "this is not a real Phoenix." One linger, then let someone pour tea.
5. **The door that was not on the slate.** Mystery. Rosire on-screen as a person, not a confession. A cleared room. Sand. They flinch. They will say: someone walked; I walked the other way. What the party does with the person who opened the door is theirs. Session one can end with the lamp still lit, the stone still unmoved, the witness still unwalked, and no one named as the one. The remnant does not go to ash, and Vimein does not arrive.

Stop lines. No Leaf-Mother reveal. No Care-fortress. No hunt in hour one. No second Gift. After the lamp, decompress — water, bread, the stone still there.

Three later kits follow, each four key moments and no fixed plot. **The Walk Home** is the days after, still Hale-month: the square keeps its day, a walk with Tora to Brenod is a choice, and one fragment may be offered or none. **The Offered Fragment** is the upper room as Hale-month goes over into Eolthael: one fragment, if the party is in the room for it, and the Care stays a sentence the square already says, not a place that arrives. **The Week Still Open** is early Eolthael: Leaf-Fall is still ahead and is not that session, the default fragment is none, and the campaign does not close. In all three the walker stays unnamed, the remnant does not go to ash, and the Leaf-Mother is not confirmed. Any ending waits for play.